

# The Japanese Guide

Fun. Comprehensive. Yours.

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## The Japanese Guide

Fun. Comprehensive. Yours. Whether you just want to order ramen without pointing at the menu, binge anime without subtitles, crush the JLPT N1, or close deals in Tokyo boardrooms — this guide has a path for you.

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### Welcome

Japanese is one of the most rewarding languages you can learn. It's also famously intimidating — three writing systems, a grammar structure unlike English, and a politeness system that shifts depending on who's in the room. But here's the secret: none of it is as hard as it looks once you have a good map.

This guide is that map.

---

### How to Use This Guide

This isn't a textbook. You don't read it cover to cover (unless you want to — we won't stop you). Instead, start with the Foundations, then pick the Track that matches your goals and let it guide you deeper.

#### Step 1 — Learn the basics (everyone starts here)

| Section                          | What you'll learn                                                     |
|----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Hiragana                         | The 46 core sounds of Japanese — your first writing system            |
| Katakana                         | The script for foreign words, emphasis, and cool robot names          |
| Kanji                            | The deep end of the pool — we'll hand you a floatie                   |
| Grammar Basics                   | How Japanese sentences actually work                                  |
| Core Vocabulary                  | The 500 words that cover ~80% of daily conversation                   |
| Phrases & Idioms                 | Sound natural from day one                                            |
| Spoken vs. Written               | Why the Japanese you hear doesn't match the Japanese you read         |
| Internet & Slang                 | www and other mysteries explained                                     |
| Contemporary & Emerging Japanese | This year's slang, buzzwords, and the words that just flipped meaning |
| Role Language (役割語)              | Why anime characters don't talk like anyone you'll ever meet          |

## Step 2 — Understand politeness (it's unavoidable)

| Section                 | What you'll learn                                                 |
|-------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Levels Overview         | The full spectrum from lazy casual to bowing-at-90-degrees formal |
| Casual Japanese         | How to talk with friends without sounding like a textbook         |
| Polite Japanese         | The everyday standard — shops, strangers, most situations         |
| Honorific Japanese      | 敬語 — the system that determines your career in Japan              |
| Modern & "Manual" Keigo | バイト敬語 — the evolving politeness you'll hear at every konbini      |

## Step 3 — Absorb the culture

| Section             | What you'll learn                                                                |
|---------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Culture & Norms     | Uchi/soto, silence, bowing, shoes — the unspoken rules                           |
| Food                | Because you will be asked if you can eat natto                                   |
| Matsuri             | Festivals, fireworks, and what to yell when you win a goldfish                   |
| Pop Culture         | Anime, manga, games — the gateway drugs of Japanese learning                     |
| Dialects            | Why Osaka people sound like they're always arguing (they're not)                 |
| Seasons & Nature    | Cherry blossoms, typhoons, and why season matters constantly                     |
| Traditional Arts    | Tea, kabuki, sumo, and the aesthetics that define Japan                          |
| Baseball & Sumo     | The two national pastimes — 1,500 years of ritual meets America's game           |
| Vtubers & Streaming | Live-comment culture and the language of the media young Japan actually consumes |

## Step 4 — Navigate real Japan

| Section          | What you'll learn                                              |
|------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Trains & Transit | IC cards, line changes, and why you missed the last train      |
| Cities & Regions | Tokyo, Osaka, Kyoto, and beyond                                |
| Shopping & Money | Konbini life, department stores, and saying no to plastic bags |
| Emergencies      | Phrases you hope you never need but absolutely must know       |

## Step 5 — Go deep on history

| Section             | What you'll learn                              |
|---------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Historical Overview | 2,000 years in one page (roughly)              |
| Samurai & Bushido   | Why honor culture still echoes in modern Japan |
| Postwar Japan       | How defeat became a cultural renaissance       |
| Language Evolution  | From classical Japanese to emoji               |

## Music

| Section           | What you'll learn                                    |
|-------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| J-Pop             | The soundtrack of modern Japan                       |
| Traditional Music | Enka, gagaku, and why grandma cries at certain songs |

## Choose Your Track

Already past the basics? Jump into the track that fits your vibe:

| Track             | For you if...                                                 |
|-------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| Anime Lover       | You want to understand characters without subtitles           |
| Manga Reader      | You want to read panels left to right (wait, that's wrong)    |
| Business Japanese | You're moving to Tokyo or dealing with Japanese clients       |
| News Japanese     | You want to read NHK and understand what's actually happening |
| JLPT N5           | You're starting from zero and want a certificate to prove it  |
| JLPT N4           | Survival-level conversations, building confidence             |
| JLPT N3           | The great leap into intermediate territory                    |
| JLPT N2           | Near-fluent, required for many Japanese universities/jobs     |
| JLPT N1           | The summit. Few reach it. You might.                          |

## A Few Things to Know Before You Start

Japanese has no spaces. Words run together. You'll adapt.

Pitch accent exists. 橋 (bridge) and 箸 (chopsticks) sound almost identical. Context saves you 99% of the time.

There is no "perfect" order. Kanji and grammar can be learned side by side. Do what keeps you showing up every day.

Immersion is the secret weapon. Every guide, app, and flashcard is just scaffolding. The real learning happens when you consume Japanese made for Japanese people.

Let's go. 行きましょう！

\newpage

## Hiragana — Your First 46 Friends

"Hiragana is the gateway. Once you know it, Japan opens up."

Welcome to the starting line. Hiragana is the foundational phonetic alphabet of Japanese — every sound the language makes can be written in hiragana. Most learners master it in 1–2 weeks with daily practice. There are no shortcuts, but there are mnemonics, and we've got them.

## What Is Hiragana, Exactly?

Japanese has three writing systems (yes, three — breathe):

| System   | Use                                            | Count                |
|----------|------------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| Hiragana | Native Japanese words, grammar, verb endings   | 46 base + variations |
| Katakana | Foreign loanwords, emphasis, science terms     | 46 base + variations |
| Kanji    | Meaning-based characters borrowed from Chinese | 2,000+ commonly used |

You'll use hiragana for everything at first. Most Japanese learning materials add small hiragana (called furigana) above kanji to help beginners read — so knowing hiragana unlocks a lot more than just hiragana words.

## The Full Hiragana Chart

Hiragana is organized by vowel columns and consonant rows. Learn the vowels first — they never change.

### The Five Vowels (and the heart of the system)

| Character | Reading | Sound like...                      |
|-----------|---------|------------------------------------|
| あ         | a       | "ah" (father)                      |
| い         | i       | "ee" (feet)                        |
| う         | u       | "oo" (but shorter, unrounded lips) |
| え         | e       | "eh" (bed)                         |
| お         | o       | "oh" (open)                        |

### Main Chart (Gojūon — 五十音)

|   | a | i | u | e | o |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Ø | あ | い | う | え | お |
| k | か | き | く | け | こ |
| s | さ | し | す | せ | そ |
| t | た | ち | つ | て | と |
| n | な | に | ぬ | ね | の |
| h | は | ひ | ふ | へ | ほ |
| m | ま | み | む | め | も |
| y | や | — | ゆ | — | よ |
| r | ら | り | る | れ | ろ |
| w | わ | — | — | — | を |
| n | ん |   |   |   |   |

Note: し is "shi" (not "si"), ち is "chi" (not "ti"), つ is "tsu" (not "tu"), ふ is "fu" (not "hu"). These are the famous exceptions — memorize them early.

## Dakuten & Handakuten (The Little Marks That Change Everything)

Add two dots (dakuten ◌゛) or a small circle (handakuten ◌゜) to some characters to voice them or change the sound:

| Base   | + Dakuten ◌゛ | Reading |
|--------|--------------|---------|
| か (ka) | が (ga)       |         |
| き (ki) | ぎ (gi)       |         |
| く (ku) | ぐ (gu)       |         |
| け (ke) | げ (ge)       |         |
| こ (ko) | ご (go)       |         |

| Base    | + Dakuten | Reading                       |
|---------|-----------|-------------------------------|
| さ (sa)  | ざ (za)    |                               |
| し (shi) | じ (ji)    |                               |
| す (su)  | ず (zu)    |                               |
| せ (se)  | ぜ (ze)    |                               |
| そ (so)  | ぞ (zo)    |                               |
| た (ta)  | だ (da)    |                               |
| ち (chi) | ぢ (ji)    | rare, almost always じ instead |
| つ (tsu) | づ (zu)    | rare, almost always ず instead |
| て (te)  | で (de)    |                               |
| と (to)  | ど (do)    |                               |
| は (ha)  | ば (ba)    |                               |
| ひ (hi)  | び (bi)    |                               |
| ふ (fu)  | ぶ (bu)    |                               |
| へ (he)  | べ (be)    |                               |
| ほ (ho)  | ぼ (bo)    |                               |

| Base   | + Handakuten | Reading |
|--------|--------------|---------|
| は (ha) | ぱ (pa)       |         |
| ひ (hi) | ぴ (pi)       |         |
| ふ (fu) | ぷ (pu)       |         |
| へ (he) | ぺ (pe)       |         |
| ほ (ho) | ぽ (po)       |         |

## Combination Characters (Yōon — 拗音)

Small や, ゆ, よ combine with the "i" sounds to create new syllables. The small size is important — it signals a combination, not two separate sounds.

| Base + small y | Reading |
|----------------|---------|
| きゃ             | kya     |
| きゅ             | kyu     |
| きょ             | kyo     |
| しゃ             | sha     |
| しゅ             | shu     |
| しょ             | sho     |
| ちゃ             | cha     |
| ちゅ             | chu     |
| ちょ             | cho     |
| にゃ             | nya     |
| にゅ             | nyu     |
| にょ             | nyo     |
| ひゃ             | hya     |
| ひゅ             | hyu     |
| ひょ             | hyo     |
| みゃ             | mya     |
| みゅ             | myu     |

| Base + small y | Reading |
|----------------|---------|
| みよ             | myo     |
| りや             | rya     |
| りゆ             | ryu     |
| りよ             | ryo     |
| ぎや             | gya     |
| じゃ             | ja      |
| じゆ             | ju      |
| じよ             | jo      |
| びや             | bya     |
| びゆ             | byu     |
| びよ             | byo     |
| ぴや             | pya     |
| ぴゆ             | pyu     |
| ぴよ             | pyo     |

## Special Characters

### Small っ (Double Consonant)

A small っ before a consonant doubles that consonant — creating a brief pause or "stop":

- きて (kitte) = stamp
- ざっし (zasshi) = magazine
- ちよっと (chotto) = a little

### Long Vowels

In hiragana, long vowels are extended with another vowel character:

- おかあさん (okaasan) = mother — the aa is one long "ah" sound
- おにいさん (oniisan) = older brother
- おおきい (ookii) = big

## Mnemonics to Make Them Stick

Here are memorable associations for the trickiest characters:

| Character | Mnemonic                                                   |
|-----------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| あ         | Looks like someone throwing their Arms up                  |
| き         | Looks like a key                                           |
| さ         | A fish on a safari — the horizontal line is the horizon    |
| し         | A fishhook — "she caught a fish"                           |
| す         | Like a swan's swinging neck                                |
| ち         | Looks like a 1 with a curve — like a cheek turned sideways |
| つ         | A tiny tsunami wave                                        |
| ふ         | Like a person bowing — full bow                            |
| む         | Like a cow's face saying "moo"                             |
| ゆ         | Like a fish on a hook — making a "yummy" face              |

| Character | Mnemonic                                            |
|-----------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| ら         | Like a backwards 5 — racing backwards               |
| れ         | Like a person with a flowing skirt — ready to dance |
| ろ         | Like the number 3 with a loop — rolling around      |

Pro tip: Use an app like Kana Pro or Dr. Moku for visual mnemonics — the pictorial method sticks dramatically faster than rote memorization.

## Stroke Order — The Complete Guide

Stroke order isn't just tradition — it creates the proportions, flow, and angles that make handwriting legible. Deviate from it and your characters look malformed, even to people who can't explain why. Learn it correctly from day one and it becomes automatic.

### The Seven Rules

| Rule                                    | Description                                                                                       |
|-----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. Top to bottom                        | Upper strokes come before lower strokes                                                           |
| 2. Left to right                        | Left strokes come before right strokes                                                            |
| 3. Horizontal before vertical           | When lines cross, draw the horizontal first (usually)                                             |
| 4. Diagonal right-to-left first         | /-type diagonals before \-type diagonals                                                          |
| 5. Center before outer                  | For symmetric characters, center stroke first                                                     |
| 6. Enclosure, then contents, then close | Draw the frame, fill it, then seal the bottom                                                     |
| 7. Compound strokes don't lift          | A "stroke" is everything written without lifting the pen — including curves and direction changes |

Rule 7 trips up most beginners. In hiragana especially, one stroke can change direction multiple times. Do not lift the pen mid-stroke.

### How to Read the Stroke Diagrams

Each character entry shows:

- The character and its stroke count
- Strokes numbered ①②③ in order
- Direction arrows: → right ↓ down ↙ down-left ↘ down-right ↻ curve

A single stroke may contain multiple arrows — follow the number through its full path.

Best practice: watch an animated stroke order guide once, then write the character 10 times. Hand memory locks in faster when you observe first, then produce.

### The Vowels — Master These First

Every Japanese syllable ends in one of these five sounds. They are the foundation.

あ (a) — 3 strokes



- ① ———  
 ② ↙ ↔ → ↗  
 ③ ↘

- ① Short horizontal stroke going right (upper area)  
 ② Start below ①, sweep down-left, loop back right, end with slight upward curve  
 ③ Short diagonal going down-right, crossing through the center of the loop

い (i) — 2 strokes

- ① ↙ ② ↗  
 ↗

- ① Left stroke: curves gently down and to the left  
 ② Right stroke: curves down, then hooks back up and to the right at the base

う (u) — 2 strokes

- ① —  
 ② → ↓ ∪

- ① Short near-horizontal mark at the very top (like a small accent)  
 ② Sweeps right, curves down, comes back up to the left — open shape, not fully closed

え (e) — 4 strokes

- ① ———  
 ② ↓  
 ③ ———  
 ④ ↘ ∪

- ① Horizontal right (top)  
 ② Short vertical down through the center  
 ③ Shorter horizontal right (middle area, left of ②)  
 ④ Starts right-center, sweeps out right, curves down-left, loops back up

お (o) — 3 strokes

- ① ———  
 ② ↓  
 ③ → ↙ ∪

- ① Horizontal right (top)  
 ② Vertical down (slight rightward curve at base)  
 ③ Horizontal right, then sweeps down-left, curves up forming a small hook

K-Row (か行)

| Char   | Count | Key notes                                                               |
|--------|-------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| か (ka) | 3     | ①→ ②↓ (curves slightly right) ③↙ diagonal crossing ②                    |
| き (ki) | 4     | ①→ ②→ (both horizontal) ③↓ ∪ (vertical with curve) ④↙ detached diagonal |
| く (ku) | 1     | Start upper-right, sweep ↙, curve right — one unbroken stroke           |

| Char   | Count | Key notes                                               |
|--------|-------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| け (ke) | 3     | ①↓ ②→ hooks ↓ ③↙ diagonal                               |
| こ (ko) | 2     | ①→ (top horizontal) ②→ sweeps down and curves back left |

< warning: Most beginners write this as two strokes. It is one. Keep the pen down through the entire sweep.

### S-Row (さ行)

| Char    | Count | Key notes                                                                  |
|---------|-------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| さ (sa)  | 3     | ①→ ②→ ③↓ sweeps right then curves up-right                                 |
| し (shi) | 1     | Start top-center, sweep ↓, curve strongly right at the bottom — one stroke |
| す (su)  | 2     | ①→↓ (cross shape) ②→ curves around into a downward loop                    |
| せ (se)  | 3     | ①↓ ②→ ③↓ with outward curve at base                                        |
| そ (so)  | 2     | ①→ ②S-like sweep: right, down-left, curves right                           |

し tip: The bottom hook is part of the same stroke as the downward sweep. Practice in one fluid motion.

### T-Row (た行)

| Char    | Count | Key notes                                                    |
|---------|-------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| た (ta)  | 4     | ①→ ②↓ ③→ hooks ↓ ④↙ diagonal                                 |
| ち (chi) | 2     | ①→ curves down ②larger curve ↓ loops right at bottom         |
| つ (tsu) | 1     | Sweep right → curve steeply ↓ → curve back left — one stroke |
| て (te)  | 1     | →, dips ↓, curves ↗ — one flowing stroke                     |
| と (to)  | 2     | ①↓ short vertical ②→ curves ↙, hooks back ↗                  |

て and つ are single strokes despite appearing complex. Write each without lifting the pen.

### N-Row (な行)

| Char   | Count | Key notes                                                         |
|--------|-------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| な (na) | 4     | ①→ ②↓ ③→ ④complex: ↙→↻ (loop)                                     |
| に (ni) | 3     | ①→ ②↓ ③↵ shape: → then ↓ with slight hook                         |
| ぬ (nu) | 2     | ①↓ curves right ②→↙↻ with a loop at bottom                        |
| ね (ne) | 2     | ①↓ ②→↙↻ large loop (similar to れ)                                 |
| の (no) | 1     | One clockwise oval: start upper-left, sweep → ↓ ← ↑, do not close |

の is a single oval stroke — continuous, never lifted, not fully closed at the top.

## H-Row (は行)

| Char   | Count | Key notes                                         |
|--------|-------|---------------------------------------------------|
| は (ha) | 3     | ① ↓ ② → ↓ ③ → ↗ ∪ (loop, like a lasso going left) |
| ひ (hi) | 2     | ① ↗ ② → curves into a closed loop                 |
| ふ (fu) | 4     | ① → ② ↗ ③ ↗ ④ ∪ small loop at bottom              |
| へ (he) | 1     | Simple: ↗ then ↘ — an inverted V                  |
| ほ (ho) | 4     | Like は + additional loop: ① ↓ ② → ↓ ③ → ④ ↗ ∪     |

へ is the simplest hiragana — one stroke, identical to the katakana ヘ.

## M-Row (ま行)

| Char   | Count | Key notes                             |
|--------|-------|---------------------------------------|
| ま (ma) | 3     | ① → ② → ↓ ③ ↗ ∪ loop                  |
| み (mi) | 2     | ① ↗ hook up ② → ↗ ∪ complex with loop |
| む (mu) | 3     | ① → ↓ ∪ ② → ③ ↘                       |
| め (me) | 2     | ① ↗ ↖ ② → ↗ ∪                         |
| も (mo) | 3     | ① → ② → (two short horizontals) ③ ↓ ∪ |

## Y-Row, R-Row, W-Row, and ん

| Char   | Count | Key notes                                                            |
|--------|-------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| や (ya) | 3     | ① ↗ ② → ↓ ∪ ③ →                                                      |
| ゆ (yu) | 2     | ① ↗ ∪ ② → ↓                                                          |
| よ (yo) | 2     | ① → ② → ↓ ↖ curves left at base                                      |
| ら (ra) | 2     | ① → ↓ ② → ↗ ∪                                                        |
| り (ri) | 2     | ① ↗ ② ↓ hooks right at base                                          |
| る (ru) | 1     | Sweep →, curve ↓, loop, end with small rightward hook                |
| れ (re) | 2     | ① ↓ ② → ↗ ∪ large loop                                               |
| ろ (ro) | 1     | Like る but without the final hook — ends going left                  |
| わ (wa) | 2     | ① ↓ ② → ↗ ∪                                                          |
| を (wo) | 3     | ① → ② → ↓ ③ → ↗ ∪ (rare in modern text)                              |
| ん (n)  | 1     | Start upper-right, curve ↗, swing right and ↑ — ends with a flourish |

ん catches everyone: the final flourish goes up and to the right — don't end it going down.

## Animated Stroke Order Resources

Text descriptions only go so far. Use these free tools to watch animated stroke order for every character:

| Resource  | What it does                                                           |
|-----------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Jisho.org | Search any kana or kanji → click the character → animated stroke order |

| Resource                          | What it does                                     |
|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| KanjiAlive                        | Animated stroke order with audio                 |
| Tofugu Hiragana Guide             | Illustrated stroke order for all 46 + variations |
| Kakijun                           | Japanese stroke order reference (in Japanese)    |
| Printable Kana Stroke Order Sheet | One-page printable reference for all kana        |

Workflow that works: Watch the animation once → write 10 times from memory → check again → repeat over 3 days.

## Practice Strategy

### Week 1: Drill Method

- Day 1–2: Vowels + k-row (あいうえお、かきくけこ)
- Day 3–4: s-row + t-row (さしすせそ、たちつてと)
- Day 5–6: n-row + h-row (なにぬねの、はひふへほ)
- Day 7: m-row + y-row + r-row + w-row + ん

### Week 2: Reading Practice

Once you know the characters, stop using romaji immediately. Cold turkey. It's uncomfortable for about a week and then everything clicks.

Try reading:

- Hiragana-only children's books (絵本 — ehon)
- NHK Web Easy (they have furigana on everything)
- Kids' anime with Japanese subtitles

### Recommended Tools

| Tool                    | Best for                                         |
|-------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| Anki (free)             | Flashcard drilling with spaced repetition        |
| Dr. Moku                | Visual mnemonic charts                           |
| Kana Pro                | Quick testing app                                |
| Tofugu's hiragana guide | Free online with mnemonics                       |
| Genki I                 | Textbook that integrates hiragana from chapter 1 |

## Quick Reference Card

Print this and stick it somewhere visible:

あいうえお  
かきくけこ  
さしすせそ  
たちつてと  
なにぬねの  
はひふへほ  
まみむめも

や ゆ よ  
ら り る れ ろ  
わ を  
ん

---

## You're Closer Than You Think

Once you know hiragana, you can read Japanese menus, station names (with furigana), children's books, and the grammar in every sentence. It's not fluency — but it's the foundation everything else is built on.

Next up: Katakana →

\newpage

## Katakana — The Angular Cousin

"Katakana looks intimidating. Then you realize it says 'hamburger' and you feel great."

Katakana represents the exact same sounds as hiragana — but it's used for completely different purposes, and it looks completely different. Angular where hiragana is round. Sharp where hiragana is flowing. Think of hiragana as cursive and katakana as print.

---

## When Is Katakana Used?

| Context                      | Example                               |
|------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Foreign loanwords            | コーヒー (kōhī) = coffee                  |
| Foreign names                | アメリカ (Amerika) = America              |
| Emphasis / impact            | Like using italics or bold in English |
| Scientific terms             | Plant/animal names in biology         |
| Onomatopoeia                 | ドキドキ (dokidoki) = heart pounding      |
| Slang & internet speak       | ガチ (gachi) = seriously/for real       |
| Menus in foreign restaurants | ピザ, パスタ, カレー                          |
| Brand names                  | ソニー (Sony), トヨタ (Toyota)              |

Learning katakana also unlocks a huge vocabulary shortcut: thousands of English words have been absorbed into Japanese. Once you recognize them, you have an instant head start.

---

## The Full Katakana Chart

|   | a | i | u | e | o |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Ø | ア | イ | ウ | エ | オ |
| k | カ | キ | ク | ケ | コ |
| s | サ | シ | ス | セ | ソ |
| t | タ | チ | ツ | テ | ト |
| n | ナ | ニ | ヌ | ネ | ノ |
| h | ハ | ヒ | フ | ヘ | ホ |

|   | a | i | u | e | o |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| m | マ | ミ | ム | メ | モ |
| y | ヤ | ー | ユ | ー | ヨ |
| r | ラ | リ | ル | レ | ロ |
| w | ワ | ー | ー | ー | ヲ |
| n | ン |   |   |   |   |

## Dakuten & Handakuten (Same Rules as Hiragana)

| Base    | Voiced          | Reading |
|---------|-----------------|---------|
| カ (ka)  | ガ (ga)          |         |
| キ (ki)  | ギ (gi)          |         |
| ク (ku)  | グ (gu)          |         |
| ケ (ke)  | ゲ (ge)          |         |
| コ (ko)  | ゴ (go)          |         |
| サ (sa)  | ザ (za)          |         |
| シ (shi) | ジ (ji)          |         |
| ス (su)  | ズ (zu)          |         |
| セ (se)  | ゼ (ze)          |         |
| ソ (so)  | ゾ (zo)          |         |
| タ (ta)  | ダ (da)          |         |
| テ (te)  | デ (de)          |         |
| ト (to)  | ド (do)          |         |
| ハ (ha)  | バ (ba) / パ (pa) |         |
| ヒ (hi)  | ビ (bi) / ピ (pi) |         |
| フ (fu)  | ブ (bu) / プ (pu) |         |
| ヘ (he)  | ベ (be) / ペ (pe) |         |
| ホ (ho)  | ボ (bo) / ポ (po) |         |

## The Long Vowel Mark: ー

In katakana, long vowels are written with a dash ー instead of repeating the vowel. This is one of the most common characters you'll see on signs and menus.

| Word   | Katakana | Meaning                      |
|--------|----------|------------------------------|
| coffee | コーヒー     | kōhī                         |
| beer   | ビール      | bīru                         |
| door   | ドア       | doa (no long vowel — short!) |
| car    | カー       | kā                           |
| email  | メール      | mēru                         |
| cool   | クール      | kūru                         |

## Combination Characters

Same combinations as hiragana, but angular:

| Characters | Reading | Example word    |
|------------|---------|-----------------|
| キャ         | kya     | キャンプ (camp)     |
| シャ         | sha     | シャワー (shower)   |
| チャ         | cha     | チャンス (chance)   |
| ジャ         | ja      | ジャズ (jazz)      |
| ニャ         | nya     | ニャー (meow)      |
| ビュ         | byu     | ビュッフェ (buffet)  |
| ファ         | fa      | ファン (fan)       |
| フィ         | fi      | フィルム (film)     |
| フェ         | fe      | フェリー (ferry)    |
| ティ         | ti/tee  | パーティー (party)   |
| ディ         | di      | ディナー (dinner)   |
| ウィ         | wi      | ウィスキー (whisky)  |
| ヴァ         | va      | ヴァイオリン (violin) |

ヴ (vu) is a special katakana character used for sounds that don't exist in native Japanese — mainly for "v" sounds in foreign words. You won't see it in hiragana.

## Confusing Pairs — The Katakana Traps

Some characters look dangerously similar. These are the ones that trip everyone up:

| Pair   | Characters          | How to tell apart                                              |
|--------|---------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| ア vs ア | ア = small hat shape | The cross piece angles differently                             |
| ソ vs ン | ソ (so) vs ン (n)     | ソ leans right, ン leans left — so vs n                          |
| シ vs ツ | シ (shi) vs ツ (tsu)  | シ has dots stacked left, ツ has dots stacked right              |
| ウ vs ㇿ | ウ (u) vs ㇿ (wo)     | ㇿ is almost never used in modern Japanese                      |
| ノ vs ソ | ノ (no) vs ソ (so)    | ノ is a single stroke; ソ has two extra marks                    |
| ㇿ vs 口 | ㇿ = katakana ro     | 口 = kanji for "mouth" — they look identical! Context tells you |

Memory trick for ソ vs シ: Think of ソ as a person (ソ) soaring to the right. シ faces left, like it's shy.

## Loanword Decoding: The Fun Part

One of the joys of katakana is recognizing English (and other languages) hiding inside:

| Katakana | Sounds like  | Meaning         |
|----------|--------------|-----------------|
| テレビ      | terebi       | television (TV) |
| スマホ      | sumaho       | smartphone      |
| アイスクリーム  | aisu kurīmu  | ice cream       |
| マクドナルド   | Makudonarudo | McDonald's      |
| スターバックス  | Sutābakkusu  | Starbucks       |
| エレベーター   | erebētā      | elevator        |

| Katakana | Sounds like | Meaning                                          |
|----------|-------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| アパート     | apāto       | apartment                                        |
| マンション    | manshon     | mansion (actually means "condo/apartment block") |
| ノート      | nōto        | notebook (not note!)                             |
| バイク      | baiku       | motorcycle (not bike!)                           |
| ガソリン     | gasorin     | gasoline                                         |
| ハンバーガー   | hanbāgā     | hamburger                                        |
| コンビニ     | konbini     | convenience store                                |

False friends alert: Some katakana words look like English but mean something different. マンション (mansion) is an apartment building. ノート (note) is a notebook. Smart (スマート) means "slim," not clever. Cunning (カンニング) means "cheating on a test."

## French, German, Portuguese Loanwords Too

Japan borrowed from multiple languages, so not all katakana is English:

| Katakana | Language   | Word     | Meaning              |
|----------|------------|----------|----------------------|
| アンケート    | French     | enquête  | survey/questionnaire |
| パン       | Portuguese | pão      | bread                |
| テンポ      | Italian    | tempo    | pace/speed           |
| アルバイト    | German     | Arbeit   | part-time job        |
| リュックサック  | German     | Rucksack | backpack             |
| ワイン      | French     | vin      | wine                 |
| クレヨン     | French     | crayon   | crayon               |

## Katakana in Pop Culture

Katakana shows up everywhere in manga, anime, and games — often for stylistic effect:

- Villains and robots often speak in katakana to sound mechanical or otherworldly
- Impact sounds are in katakana: ドカン (dokan = boom), パン (ban = bang)
- Power-up names in anime: スーパーサイヤ人 (Super Saiyan)
- Foreign characters in stories speak in katakana to signal their accent

## Stroke Order — Katakana

The stroke order rules from hiragana apply equally here: top to bottom, left to right, horizontal before vertical, no lifting the pen mid-stroke. What changes is the character of the strokes — katakana is angular and architectural where hiragana is curved and flowing. Most katakana characters have fewer strokes (1–3) and sharper direction changes than their hiragana equivalents.



## Why Katakana Stroke Order Especially Matters

The confusing pairs (ソ/ン, シ/ツ, ノ/ソ) are only distinguishable by stroke angle and direction. Knowing the correct stroke order makes these visually distinct:

| Pair               | How stroke order reveals the difference                                                                               |
|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| シ (shi) vs ツ (tsu) | シ: two dots go ↙ left-to-right, main stroke goes ↗ upward. ツ: two dots go ↘ right-to-left, main stroke goes ↗ upward. |
| ソ (so) vs ン (n)    | ソ: short stroke goes ↘ then long stroke sweeps ↗↗. ン: short stroke goes ↗ then long stroke sweeps ↘↘.                 |
| ノ (no) vs ソ (so)   | ノ is 1 stroke going ↘. ソ is 2 strokes: a short mark then a sweep                                                      |

Memorizing these as stroke-sequence patterns is more reliable than memorizing them as pictures.

## Vowels (ア行)

ア (a) — 2 strokes

- ① — ↘
- ② — ↓

- ① Diagonal going upper-left to lower-right
- ② Horizontal right, then turns sharply ↓

イ (i) — 2 strokes ① Short diagonal ↙  
② Longer diagonal ↙ (taller, parallel, further right)

ウ (u) — 3 strokes ① Short horizontal → at top  
② Left vertical ↓  
③ Right vertical ↓ (the two verticals are joined by ①)

エ (e) — 3 strokes ① Horizontal → (top)  
② Vertical ↓ (center)  
③ Horizontal → (bottom)

オ (o) — 3 strokes ① Horizontal →  
② Vertical ↓ (crosses ①)  
③ Diagonal ↙ starting from right of ①

## K-Row (カ行)

| Char   | Count | Key notes                                            |
|--------|-------|------------------------------------------------------|
| カ (ka) | 2     | ① → ↓ hook shape ② ↙ diagonal crossing ①             |
| キ (ki) | 3     | ① → ② → (two horizontals) ③ ↓ vertical crossing both |
| ク (ku) | 2     | ① ↙ short left ② → ↙ sweeps right then curves ↙      |
| ケ (ke) | 3     | ① ↓ ② → ↙ ③ →                                        |
| コ (ko) | 2     | ① → ↓ (top and right side, L-shape) ② → (bottom)     |

## S-Row (サ行)

| Char    | Count | Key notes                                                      |
|---------|-------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| サ (sa)  | 3     | ①→ ②→ ③↓ crossing both (resembles a table)                     |
| シ (shi) | 3     | ①↙ ②↙ (both dots go down-left) ③↗ long stroke going up-right   |
| ス (su)  | 2     | ①→↙ (top, curves down-left) ②↙ small hook at bottom            |
| セ (se)  | 2     | ①→↓ (top and right) ②→ (long horizontal left through ①)        |
| ソ (so)  | 2     | ①↘ short diagonal down-right ②↘↗ long sweep down then up-right |

シ vs ツ visual key: Tilt シ and it reads like 'shi' in English — the three strokes angle upward to the right. Tilt ツ and it reads like 'tsu' — the strokes angle downward.

#### T-Row (タ行)

| Char    | Count | Key notes                                                 |
|---------|-------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| タ (ta)  | 3     | ①→ ②↙ ③↓ hooks left at base                               |
| チ (chi) | 3     | ①→ ②→ ③↓ hooks left (like タ with horizontal ②)            |
| ツ (tsu) | 3     | ①↘ ②↘ (both dots go down-right) ③↓ long stroke going down |
| テ (te)  | 3     | ①→ ②→ (shorter) ③↓ sweeping ↙ at base                     |
| ト (to)  | 2     | ①↓ ②→ short horizontal from right side of ①               |

#### N-Row (ナ行)

| Char   | Count | Key notes                                         |
|--------|-------|---------------------------------------------------|
| ナ (na) | 2     | ①→ ②↙ long diagonal (crosses ①)                   |
| ニ (ni) | 2     | ①→ (short, top) ②→ (longer, bottom)               |
| ヌ (nu) | 2     | ①→↙ ②→↙ loops at lower-right                      |
| ネ (ne) | 4     | ①→ ②↓ ③↙ ④↙ loops                                 |
| ノ (no) | 1     | Single diagonal: ↘ from upper-left to lower-right |

#### H-Row (ハ行)

| Char   | Count | Key notes                                                          |
|--------|-------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ハ (ha) | 2     | ①↙ (left, slightly shorter) ②↙ (right, longer) — like an open book |
| ヒ (hi) | 2     | ①↓ ②→ (hooks from upper-right of ① to lower-right)                 |
| フ (fu) | 2     | ①→↓ (top and right) ②↙ single diagonal from upper-right            |
| ヘ (he) | 1     | Identical to hiragana ヘ: ↗ then ↘                                  |
| ホ (ho) | 4     | ①→ ②↓ (crosses ①) ③↙ ④↙ (two matching diagonals)                   |

#### M, Y, R, W Rows

| Char   | Count | Key notes                                                        |
|--------|-------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| マ (ma) | 2     | ①→↓ ②↙ crossing ①                                                |
| ミ (mi) | 3     | ①→ ②→ ③→ (three horizontals, each slightly longer)               |
| ム (mu) | 2     | ①↙↓ ②→↙                                                          |
| メ (me) | 2     | ①↘ ②↙ (they cross in the center)                                 |
| モ (mo) | 3     | ①→ ②→ ③↓→ (T-shape at bottom)                                    |
| ヤ (ya) | 3     | ①→↓ ②↗ ③→                                                        |
| ユ (yu) | 2     | ①→↓ (right angle) ②→ (bottom)                                    |
| ヨ (yo) | 3     | ①→↓ (right side) ②→ (middle) ③→ (bottom)                         |
| ラ (ra) | 2     | ①→↓ ②↙↺                                                          |
| リ (ri) | 2     | ①↙ hook up ②↓ hooks left at base                                 |
| ル (ru) | 2     | ①↘↓ ②→↙                                                          |
| レ (re) | 1     | Single: ↓ then curves ↗ at base                                  |
| ロ (ro) | 3     | ①↓ ②→↓ ③→ (a rectangle — draw left, right, then close at bottom) |
| ワ (wa) | 2     | ①→↓ ②↙                                                           |
| ヲ (wo) | 3     | ①→ ②→↓ ③→↙ (nearly obsolete)                                     |
| ン (n)  | 2     | ①↗ short diagonal up-right ②↙ long sweep down-left, curves up    |

ン vs ヌ final rule: ン's first stroke goes up-right (↗). ヌ's first stroke goes down-right (↘). This single difference is the key.

#### Animated Stroke Order Resources

| Resource              | Notes                                            |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| Jisho.org             | Animated stroke order for all katakana and kanji |
| KanjiAlive            | Clear animations with audio                      |
| Tofugu Katakana Guide | Full illustrated stroke order guide              |
| Kakijun               | Japanese stroke order reference                  |

#### Practice Strategy

Because katakana represents the same sounds as hiragana, you already know the phonetics — you just need to recognize new shapes. This makes katakana faster to learn for most people.

#### The Loanword Method (Fastest)

1. Learn the characters using mnemonics
2. Start reading katakana menus, signs, and labels immediately
3. Guess the English word — you'll be right surprisingly often
4. Keep a running list of false friends (they're fun)

#### Recommended Practice

- Read menus at restaurants (almost entirely katakana)
- Watch anime with Japanese subtitles — sound effects are katakana
- Scan train maps — many station names have katakana nearby
- Play Japanese games — item names and proper nouns are usually katakana

## Side-by-Side Comparison: Hiragana vs. Katakana

| Sound | Hiragana | Katakana |
|-------|----------|----------|
| a     | あ        | ア        |
| i     | い        | イ        |
| u     | う        | ウ        |
| e     | え        | エ        |
| o     | お        | オ        |
| ka    | か        | カ        |
| shi   | し        | シ        |
| tsu   | つ        | ツ        |
| no    | の        | ノ        |
| fu    | ふ        | フ        |

---

## You've Got Two Scripts Down

With hiragana and katakana under your belt, you can read a huge amount of real Japanese. Station signs, menus, manga furigana, subtitles — all of it is now within reach.

The road ahead leads to kanji. It's a longer road. But the views are incredible.

Next up: Kanji →

\newpage

## Kanji — The Deep End of the Pool

"The Japanese government says you need 2,136 kanji to be 'literate.' A newspaper uses around 3,000. A novelist might use 5,000+. Don't panic — most learners never need more than 2,000 and can read most things at 1,500."

Kanji are logographic characters borrowed (and adapted) from Chinese over more than a thousand years. Each one carries meaning, and most carry one or more readings. They're beautiful, maddening, and absolutely essential to reading real Japanese.

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## Why Kanji Exist (And Why They're Actually Useful)

Japanese has many homophones — words that sound identical but mean different things. Written in only hiragana, this sentence would be ambiguous:

かみ — hair? god? paper? upper? bite?

Written with kanji:

- 髪 = hair (on your head)
- 神 = god
- 紙 = paper
- 上 = upper / above
- 噛み = biting

Kanji resolve ambiguity instantly. They're one of the reasons Japanese can be read faster (per unit time) than almost any other language.

---

## Anatomy of a Kanji

### Radicals (部首 — bushu)

Every kanji is built from components called radicals. There are 214 in the traditional Kangxi system. Learning them transforms kanji from "random squiggles" into modular, decodable parts — you start seeing the logic embedded in the shapes.

Radicals serve two purposes:

1. Dictionary lookup — kanji are organized by their primary radical in traditional dictionaries
  2. Semantic hinting — the radical often (not always) gives you a clue about meaning
- 

### Nature & Elements

| Radical | Form                | Meaning      | Example kanji                                  |
|---------|---------------------|--------------|------------------------------------------------|
| 日       | 日                   | sun / day    | 明 (bright), 時 (time), 早 (early), 晴 (clear sky) |
| 月       | 月                   | moon / month | 朝 (morning), 期 (period), 服 (clothing)          |
| 山       | 山                   | mountain     | 岩 (rock), 峰 (peak), 岸 (shore)                  |
| 水/氵     | 氵 (3 drops)         | water        | 海 (sea), 泳 (swim), 洗 (wash), 清 (clear)         |
| 火/灬     | 灬 (4 dots at base)  | fire         | 燒 (burn), 炎 (flame), 熱 (heat), 照 (shine)       |
| 木       | 木                   | tree / wood  | 森 (forest), 机 (desk), 板 (plank), 根 (root)      |
| 土       | 土                   | earth / soil | 地 (ground), 場 (place), 城 (castle), 塔 (tower)   |
| 石       | 石                   | stone        | 岩 (rock), 砂 (sand), 硬 (hard)                   |
| 草/艸/艹   | 艹 (top grass shape) | plant        | 花 (flower), 草 (grass), 葉 (leaf), 茶 (tea)       |
| 風       | 风                   | wind         | 風 itself is the main radical form              |
| 雨       | 雨                   | rain         | 雪 (snow), 雷 (thunder), 電 (electricity)         |

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### People & Body

| Radical | Form          | Meaning          | Example kanji                                         |
|---------|---------------|------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| 人/亻     | 亻 (left side) | person           | 休 (rest), 作 (make), 使 (use), 体 (body)                 |
| 女       | 女             | woman            | 好 (like), 姉 (sister), 妹 (younger sister), 嫌 (dislike) |
| 子       | 子             | child            | 学 (study), 字 (character), 孫 (grandchild)              |
| 手/扌     | 扌 (left side) | hand             | 持 (hold), 打 (hit), 押 (push), 技 (skill), 指 (finger)    |
| 口       | 口             | mouth            | 話 (talk), 叫 (shout), 歌 (sing), 味 (taste), 唇 (lip)     |
| 目       | 目             | eye              | 見 (see), 眠 (sleep), 盲 (blind), 眼 (eyeball)            |
| 耳       | 耳             | ear              | 聞 (hear/ask), 聽 (listen carefully), 職 (occupation)    |
| 足/口     | 足             | foot / leg       | 跳 (jump), 踏 (step on), 距 (distance)                   |
| 心/忄     | 忄 (left side) | heart / feelings | 愛 (love), 悲 (sad), 怒 (angry), 思 (think), 忘 (forget)   |
| 骨       | 骨             | bone             | 骸 (skeleton), 髓 (marrow)                              |

---

### Actions & Concepts

| Radical | Form           | Meaning         | Example kanji                                 |
|---------|----------------|-----------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| 言/言     | 言 (left side)  | speech / words  | 話 (talk), 読 (read), 語 (language), 詩 (poem)    |
| 力       | 力              | power / effort  | 勉 (study hard), 動 (move), 助 (help), 加 (add)   |
| 刀/刂     | 刂 (right side) | sword / cut     | 切 (cut), 別 (separate), 判 (judge), 劍 (sword)   |
| 糸/纟     | 糸              | thread / fabric | 絵 (picture), 結 (tie), 続 (continue), 紙 (paper) |
| 金/金     | 金 (left side)  | metal / gold    | 銀 (silver), 鉄 (iron), 銅 (copper), 鋭 (sharp)   |
| 食/食     | 食 (left side)  | food / eat      | 飯 (cooked rice), 飲 (drink), 飢 (hunger)        |
| 車       | 車              | vehicle         | 転 (roll/turn), 輸 (transport), 軽 (light)       |
| 走       | 走              | run             | 起 (rise), 越 (exceed), 赴 (go toward)           |
| 見       | 見              | see / view      | 現 (appear), 規 (rule), 覚 (memorize)            |

### Buildings & Structures

| Radical | Form           | Meaning                         | Example kanji                                       |
|---------|----------------|---------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| 門       | 門              | gate                            | 聞 (hear), 間 (interval/between), 開 (open), 閉 (close) |
| 宀       | 宀 (roof shape) | roof / house                    | 家 (house), 室 (room), 宿 (lodging), 安 (safe/cheap)    |
| 口       | 口 (enclosure)  | enclosure                       | 国 (country), 園 (garden), 図 (diagram), 回 (round)     |
| 土       | 土              | earth (also used for buildings) | 基 (foundation), 壁 (wall), 堂 (hall)                  |

### Animals

| Radical | Form          | Meaning                       | Example kanji                            |
|---------|---------------|-------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| 魚       | 魚             | fish                          | 鯛 (sea bream), 鮭 (salmon), 鮪 (tuna)      |
| 鳥       | 鳥             | bird                          | 鶏 (chicken), 鴨 (duck), 鷹 (hawk)          |
| 虫       | 虫             | insect (also reptiles, worms) | 蛇 (snake), 蛙 (frog), 蝶 (butterfly)       |
| 馬       | 馬             | horse                         | 騎 (ride), 駅 (station), 驚 (surprised)     |
| 犬/犳     | 犳 (left side) | dog                           | 猫 (cat), 狼 (wolf), 独 (alone), 猿 (monkey) |

### Important Modifiers

| Radical | Form | Meaning            | Example kanji                                    |
|---------|------|--------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| 大       | 大    | large              | 太 (fat/thick), 央 (center), 奥 (deep inside)       |
| 小       | 小    | small              | 少 (few), 尖 (pointed), 省 (save/omit)              |
| 不       | 不    | not / negative     | 不満 (dissatisfied), 不安 (uneasy), 不思議 (mysterious) |
| 又       | 又    | again / right hand | 友 (friend), 取 (take), 受 (receive), 反 (oppose)    |
| 寸       | 寸    | unit / measure     | 対 (oppose/versus), 寺 (temple), 専 (exclusive)     |

Radical vs. component: Not every part of a kanji is its "official" radical (部首). The radical is specifically the part used to categorize the kanji in a dictionary. But visually, any recognizable sub-component helps you remember the whole. WaniKani, for example, uses its own set of "radicals" (which it calls components) that are optimized for memory, not dictionary lookup — both approaches are valid.

---

## Stroke Order for Kanji

The same seven rules from hiragana apply to kanji. Here they are again with kanji-specific examples:

### The Rules, Applied to Kanji

| Rule                                        | Kanji Example     | How it applies                                       |
|---------------------------------------------|-------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| Top to bottom                               | 三 (three)         | Three horizontal strokes: top → middle → bottom      |
| Left to right                               | 川 (river)         | Three verticals: left → center → right               |
| Horizontal before vertical                  | 十 (ten)           | → then ↓ — the cross horizontal first                |
| Diagonal right-to-left before left-to-right | 人 (person)        | ノ first, then the rightward stroke                   |
| Center before sides                         | 小 (small)         | Center vertical first, then left dot, then right dot |
| Enclosure before contents, close last       | 国 (country)       | Left-top-right of box → 玉 inside → close at bottom   |
| Don't lift mid-stroke                       | Any curved stroke | A stroke is one continuous line, however complex     |

---

### The Enclosure Rule in Detail

The enclosure rule (Rule 6) appears constantly in kanji. Three-sided enclosures work differently from four-sided ones:

Four-sided enclosure (口-type): ① Left side ↓ ② Top + right side: → then ↓ ③ Contents (if any) ④ Bottom → (closes the box)

Three-sided enclosure opening downward (凵-type / 凵-type): ① Top ② Left side ↓ ③ Contents ④ Right side ↓ (last — you "seal" right-to-left)

Three-sided enclosure opening rightward (匚-type): ① Top → ② Left side ↓ ③ Bottom → ④ Contents fit inside (like 医)

---

### Stroke Order Examples — Common Kanji

日 (sun/day) — 4 strokes

① | ② — | ③ — ④ —

① Left vertical ↓ (with upward hook at top)

② Top + right: → then ↓

③ First internal horizontal →

④ Bottom horizontal →

山 (mountain) — 3 strokes

② | ① — ③ |

① Center vertical ↓ (tallest)

② Left short vertical ↓

③ Right short vertical ↓

Center first — Rule 5

木 (tree) — 4 strokes

- ① —  
② ↓  
③ ↙ ④ ↘

- ① Horizontal →  
② Vertical ↓ (crosses ①)  
③ Left diagonal ↙  
④ Right diagonal ↘

- 国 (country) — 8 strokes ① ↓ left wall  
② → ↓ top + right wall  
③–⑦ 玉 inside: horizontal, vertical, horizontal, dot  
⑧ → bottom to close

### Stroke Count Reference (N5 Kanji)

| 1–2 strokes        | 3–4 strokes                    | 5–6 strokes                    | 7–8 strokes              |
|--------------------|--------------------------------|--------------------------------|--------------------------|
| 一 二 人 入 八<br>力 刀 十 | 三 山 川 口 土 大 小 女 子<br>日 月 木 火 水 | 本 目 耳 白 田 生 出 右 左<br>立 石 先 名 早 | 花 見 言 足 車 来 男<br>学 国 長 図 |

### Stroke Order Resources

| Resource                | Notes                                                   |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| Jisho.org               | Search any kanji → animated stroke order with numbering |
| KanjiAlive              | Clean animations, free                                  |
| Kakijun                 | Japanese stroke order reference site                    |
| Kanji Stroke Order Font | Downloadable font that shows numbers on each stroke     |
| WaniKani                | Teaches stroke order context through radical components |

### On-Readings and Kun-Readings

This is where most beginners get confused. Almost every kanji has two types of readings:

| Type           | Name             | Origin                               | When used                                |
|----------------|------------------|--------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| 音読み (on-yomi)  | Chinese reading  | Borrowed from Chinese pronunciation  | In compound words (two+ kanji together)  |
| 訓読み (kun-yomi) | Japanese reading | Native Japanese word for the concept | When kanji stands alone or with hiragana |

Example: 山 (mountain)

- Kun-yomi: やま (yama) — "the mountain"
- On-yomi: さん (san) or ざん (zan) — used in 富士山 (Fujisan), 火山 (kazan = volcano)



Example: 水 (water)

- Kun-yomi: みず (mizu) — "water" as a standalone word
- On-yomi: すい (sui) — used in 水曜日 (suiyōbi = Wednesday), 水泳 (suiei = swimming)

Example: 人 (person)

- Kun-yomi: ひと (hito) — "a person"
- On-yomi: じん (jin) or にん (nin) — 外国人 (gaikokujin = foreigner), 三人 (sannin = three people)

Rule of thumb: If a kanji is alone or attached to hiragana, use kun-yomi. If it's in a compound with another kanji, use on-yomi. There are exceptions — there are always exceptions in Japanese — but this gets you right ~70% of the time.

---

## JLPT Kanji Counts by Level

| Level | Approximate kanji | What you can read                     |
|-------|-------------------|---------------------------------------|
| N5    | ~100              | Numbers, days, basic signs            |
| N4    | ~300              | Simple sentences, common words        |
| N3    | ~650              | Manga, simple news, menus             |
| N2    | ~1,000            | Most newspapers, novels (with effort) |
| N1    | ~2,000+           | Nearly everything                     |

The Jōyō kanji (常用漢字) list — the government-approved "common use" kanji — contains 2,136 characters. This is the realistic target for full literacy.

---

## The Jōyō Kanji: Most Important by Category

### Numbers

| Kanji | Reading              | Meaning      |
|-------|----------------------|--------------|
| 一     | いち / ichi            | one          |
| 二     | に / ni               | two          |
| 三     | さん / san             | three        |
| 四     | し、よん / shi, yon      | four         |
| 五     | ご / go               | five         |
| 六     | ろく / roku            | six          |
| 七     | しち、なな / shichi, nana | seven        |
| 八     | はち / hachi           | eight        |
| 九     | く、きゅう / ku, kyū      | nine         |
| 十     | じゅう / jū             | ten          |
| 百     | ひゃく / hyaku          | hundred      |
| 千     | せん / sen             | thousand     |
| 万     | まん / man             | ten thousand |

### Time & Calendar

| Kanji | Reading              | Meaning                  |
|-------|----------------------|--------------------------|
| 年     | ねん、とし / nen, toshi   | year                     |
| 月     | つき、げつ / tsuki, gatsu | month / moon             |
| 日     | ひ、にち / hi, nichì     | day / sun                |
| 時     | じ、とき / ji, toki      | time / hour              |
| 分     | ふん、ぶん / fun, bun     | minute / portion         |
| 今     | いま / ima             | now                      |
| 昨     | さく / saku            | yesterday (in compounds) |
| 明     | あす、めい / asu, mei     | tomorrow / bright        |
| 週     | しゅう / shū            | week                     |

## People & Family

| Kanji | Reading              | Meaning         |
|-------|----------------------|-----------------|
| 人     | ひと、じん / hito, jin    | person          |
| 男     | おとこ、だん / otoko, dan  | man             |
| 女     | おんな、じょ / onna, jo    | woman           |
| 子     | こ、し / ko, shi        | child           |
| 父     | ちち、ふ / chichi, fu    | father          |
| 母     | はは、も / haha, mo      | mother          |
| 兄     | あに、けい / ani, kei     | older brother   |
| 姉     | あね、し / ane, shi      | older sister    |
| 弟     | おとうと、てい / otōto, tei | younger brother |
| 妹     | いもうと、まい / imōto, mai | younger sister  |

## Nature & Places

| Kanji | Reading            | Meaning      |
|-------|--------------------|--------------|
| 山     | やま、さん / yama, san  | mountain     |
| 川     | かわ、せん / kawa, sen  | river        |
| 海     | うみ、かい / umi, kai   | sea / ocean  |
| 空     | そら、くう / sora, kū   | sky / empty  |
| 木     | き、もく / ki, moku    | tree / wood  |
| 花     | はな、か / hana, ka    | flower       |
| 水     | みず、すい / mizu, sui  | water        |
| 火     | ひ、か / hi, ka       | fire         |
| 土     | つち、ど / tsuchi, do  | earth / soil |
| 石     | いし、せき / ishi, seki | stone        |

## The Kanji Learning Debate: What Method Works?

There are fierce opinions in the Japanese learning community. Here's an honest breakdown:

Method 1: Remembering the Kanji (RTK) by James Heisig

Learn all 2,200 kanji meanings using imaginative stories — no readings. Just shapes and meanings.

- Pros: Fast recognition, memorable stories, covers all joyo kanji

- Cons: You can recognize kanji but can't read them aloud. Readings must be learned separately.
- Best for: Learners who want to read (not speak) Japanese first

#### Method 2: WaniKani

SRS (spaced repetition system) that teaches radicals → kanji → vocabulary in a structured order.

- Pros: Teaches both meaning AND readings together, vocabulary reinforces kanji
- Cons: Paid subscription, takes 1–2 years to complete, you follow their order not your own
- Best for: Consistent learners who want structure

#### Method 3: KKLC (Kodansha Kanji Learner's Course)

2,300 kanji organized by visual similarity and meaning clusters.

- Pros: Great visual groupings, comprehensive, standalone book
- Cons: Dense, requires discipline
- Best for: Self-studiers who want a physical book

#### Method 4: Context-first Learning

Learn kanji through vocabulary. Read real Japanese, look up kanji as you encounter them, build Anki decks from your own reading.

- Pros: Only learn what's actually relevant, high retention from real context
- Cons: Chaotic, coverage gaps, requires significant effort to set up
- Best for: Intermediate learners who read a lot already

#### The Honest Answer

Most successful learners combine methods: use WaniKani or RTK to build a recognition base, then supplement with reading real material. The kanji you encounter in your specific interest area (manga, news, business) will stick fastest.

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## How to Use WaniKani — A Complete Beginner's Guide

WaniKani is a web-based kanji learning system built around spaced repetition. It teaches approximately 2,000 kanji and 6,000 vocabulary words across 60 levels. The first three levels are free; beyond that it requires a subscription.

#### The Core System: Radicals → Kanji → Vocabulary

WaniKani teaches in three layers:

| Layer      | What it is                                          | Example                                         |
|------------|-----------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Radical    | A named visual component                            | 氵 = "tsunami" (WK's name for the water radical) |
| Kanji      | Built from radicals, taught with meaning + readings | 海 (sea) — uses 氵 + 母 component                  |
| Vocabulary | Real words using the kanji you learned              | 海 → 海外 (overseas), 日本海 (Sea of Japan)           |

You cannot unlock kanji until you've learned their component radicals. You cannot unlock vocabulary until you know the relevant kanji. The system is deliberately sequential.

## The SRS Levels (Spaced Repetition System)

Every item you learn moves through a progression based on how accurately you answer reviews:

| Level        | Review interval | What it means                |
|--------------|-----------------|------------------------------|
| Apprentice 1 | 4 hours         | Just learned — high priority |
| Apprentice 2 | 8 hours         | Still fragile — review soon  |
| Apprentice 3 | ~1 day          | Building                     |
| Apprentice 4 | ~2 days         | Getting stable               |
| Guru 1       | ~1 week         | Solid short-term memory      |
| Guru 2       | ~2 weeks        | Moving to long-term          |
| Master       | ~1 month        | Long-term                    |
| Enlightened  | ~4 months       | Near-permanent               |
| Burned       | —               | Permanent — no more reviews  |

Answer incorrectly and the item drops back levels. This is intentional — the system is self-correcting.

### What a Typical Day Looks Like

Morning (10–20 min): Do your reviews first. WaniKani queues reviews based on the SRS intervals — they appear when you're supposed to see them, not when it's convenient. Skipping reviews causes a backlog.

Afternoon (5–15 min): Check for new lessons. Lessons introduce new items. Don't do more than 10–15 new lessons per day — each new lesson creates 8 reviews over the next two days. New learners often do 50 lessons at once and then drown in reviews two days later.

Before bed (5–10 min): Second review session. Because Apprentice 1 reviews come back in 4 hours, doing lessons in the morning and reviews in the evening keeps the cycle healthy.

### Common WaniKani Mistakes

| Mistake                     | Why it hurts                                                       | What to do instead                              |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Rushing lessons             | Floods your review queue in 1–2 days                               | Cap at 10–15 new lessons                        |
| Skipping vocabulary lessons | Vocab reinforces kanji — skipping it weakens retention             | Do all vocabulary unless you're overwhelmed     |
| Ignoring radicals           | Radicals are the memory hooks for kanji                            | Learn radical names and meanings                |
| Cheating reviews            | Marking wrong answers as correct destroys the SRS logic            | Answer honestly — the system is self-correcting |
| Stopping at level 20        | Very common stopping point (free levels are gone, motivation dips) | Set a consistent daily goal                     |
| Only doing WaniKani         | WaniKani teaches recognition, not usage                            | Read real Japanese and practice speaking        |

### WaniKani Tips from Experienced Users

- Use the Jisho companion: When you learn a kanji on WK, look it up on Jisho to see more real words using it.
- The mnemonic matters: WaniKani provides a story for each kanji. Read it carefully — don't just memorize the answer. The story is the point.
- Leeches are real: Some items will keep getting wrong over and over. These "leeches" need special attention. Use a leech trainer script or write the item out by hand several times.

- Level up takes ~7 days at the fastest pace. Don't try to speed-run — the SRS intervals exist for a reason.
- The WaniKani Community is genuinely helpful and has extensive resources including scripts, study guides, and encouragement.

---

## How to Use Anki — A Complete Beginner's Guide

Anki is free, open-source flashcard software built around spaced repetition. Unlike WaniKani, Anki is a blank tool — it doesn't come with Japanese content. You provide the cards, or download a pre-made deck.

### Getting Started

1. Download Anki from [apps.ankiweb.net](https://apps.ankiweb.net) — free for desktop (Windows/Mac/Linux) and Android; the iOS app costs a one-time fee.
2. Find a deck or make your own (see below).
3. Do your reviews every day. Anki's power is consistency — missing days causes a backlog that compounds quickly.

---

### Finding Japanese Decks

| Deck               | What it contains                                    | Best for                    |
|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| Core 2000/6000     | 2,000–6,000 most frequent Japanese words with audio | General vocabulary building |
| JLPT N5–N1 Vocab   | Vocabulary organized by JLPT level                  | Exam preparation            |
| Kanji Kentei / RTK | Kanji with meanings and readings                    | Kanji recognition           |
| Tango N5 / N4      | Sentence-based cards for JLPT levels                | Reading + vocab together    |

Search [ankiweb.net/shared/decks/japanese](https://apps.ankiweb.net/shared/decks/japanese) for the full library.

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### Key Settings to Configure

Anki's defaults are not optimized for heavy vocabulary learning. Adjust these in Deck Options:

| Setting              | Default | Recommended | Why                                                   |
|----------------------|---------|-------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| New cards per day    | 20      | 10–15       | More than 20/day creates an unsustainable review load |
| Maximum reviews/day  | 100     | 200–300     | Low caps cause cards to pile up                       |
| Graduating interval  | 1 day   | 1 day       | Fine as-is                                            |
| Easy interval        | 4 days  | 4 days      | Fine as-is                                            |
| New interval (lapse) | 0%      | 20%         | When you fail a card, don't reset it to zero          |
| Leech threshold      | 8       | 5           | Flag problem cards sooner                             |

## Two Card Types: Choose Your Strategy

Vocabulary cards — front: Japanese word, back: reading + meaning

Front: 電車

Back: でんしゃ (densha) — electric train

Fast to review, covers a lot of ground quickly. Risk: you may recognize the card without truly knowing the word in context.

Sentence cards — front: sentence with target word, back: reading + meaning of sentence

Front: 毎日電車で通勤しています。

Back: I commute by train every day.

電車 (densha) = electric train

Slower, but far higher retention and transfers better to real reading. Recommended for intermediate learners.

Best approach: Start with vocabulary cards at beginner level. As your vocabulary grows, switch to mining sentence cards from things you're actually reading (see below).

---

## Sentence Mining — The Advanced Technique

"Mining" means creating Anki cards directly from Japanese content you're consuming (manga, news articles, anime subtitles). Each card uses the original sentence as context.

Workflow:

1. Read/watch Japanese content
2. Encounter an unknown word that's important
3. Look it up with Yomitan (browser extension — hover for instant definition)
4. Yomitan can send the word + sentence directly to Anki with one click
5. Review the card daily

This approach creates cards from vocabulary you already have context for — dramatically improving retention compared to pre-made decks.

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## How to Review Properly

The honest answer rule: Mark a card as "Again" if you hesitated more than 2–3 seconds, made any error, or recognized it but couldn't produce it confidently. Anki only works if the data is accurate.

---

| Button | When to press it                             |
|--------|----------------------------------------------|
| Again  | Wrong, hesitated, or only vaguely recognized |
| Hard   | Got it, but it felt difficult                |
| Good   | Normal correct answer                        |
| Easy   | Instant recall, felt obvious                 |

---

Most reviews should be "Good" or "Again." If you're pressing "Easy" on everything, your new card rate is too low.

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## The Cardinal Rule

Do your reviews every day. Not every few days. Not when you feel like it. Every day.

Anki's spaced repetition only works with consistent intervals. A 10-minute daily review is worth far more than a 2-hour catch-up session on the weekend. Reviews missed today will reappear tomorrow, and the day after — the backlog compounds exponentially after just 3–4 missed days.

Set a fixed time (morning coffee, commute, before bed) and protect it.

## Kanji Compounds: Where It Gets Fun

Two kanji together create new meanings — often logical, sometimes poetic, occasionally bizarre:

| Compound | Kanji meanings        | Reading          | Actual meaning |
|----------|-----------------------|------------------|----------------|
| 電車       | electricity + vehicle | でんしゃ (densha)    | electric train |
| 新聞       | new + hear            | しんぶん (shinbun)   | newspaper      |
| 図書館      | map + book + building | としょかん (toshokan) | library        |
| 大学       | big + learning        | だいがく (daigaku)   | university     |
| 食べ物      | eat + thing           | たべもの (tabemono)  | food           |
| 飛行機      | fly + go + machine    | ひこうき (hikōki)    | airplane       |
| 自動車      | self + move + vehicle | じどうしゃ (jidōsha)  | automobile     |
| 入口       | enter + mouth         | いりぐち (iriguchi)  | entrance       |
| 出口       | exit + mouth          | でぐち (deguchi)    | exit           |
| 地震       | earth + shake         | じしん (jishin)     | earthquake     |

Fun fact: 入口 and 出口 are everywhere in Japan. Learning these two compound kanji is literally the first thing you should do before visiting.

## Onyomi vs. Kunyomi Quick-Reference: The Most Common

| Kanji | Kun-yomi                  | On-yomi     | Key compounds                        |
|-------|---------------------------|-------------|--------------------------------------|
| 食     | たべる (taberu) — to eat     | しょく (shoku) | 食事 (shokuji = meal)                  |
| 行     | いく (iku) — to go          | こう、ぎょう      | 銀行 (ginkō = bank), 旅行 (ryokō = trip) |
| 見     | みる (miru) — to see        | けん          | 意見 (iken = opinion)                  |
| 聞     | きく (kiku) — to listen/ask | ぶん          | 新聞 (shinbun = newspaper)             |
| 来     | くる (kuru) — to come       | らい          | 未来 (mirai = future)                  |
| 出     | でる (deru) — to exit       | しゅつ         | 出発 (shuppatsu = departure)           |
| 入     | はいる (hairu) — to enter    | にゅう         | 入学 (nyūgaku = school enrollment)     |
| 言     | いう (iu) — to say          | げん、ごん       | 言語 (gengo = language)                |
| 書     | かく (kaku) — to write      | しょ          | 図書館 (toshokan = library)             |

## Tips for Long-Term Kanji Learning

1. Learn vocabulary, not isolated kanji. 森 (mori = forest) is easier to remember when you know 木 (tree) and can picture a forest of trees.

2. Write them by hand occasionally. You don't need to write fluently, but physically drawing the strokes builds neural pathways that typing doesn't.
  3. Use SRS (Spaced Repetition Software). Anki or WaniKani optimizes when you review, so you don't waste time on cards you already know.
  4. Read things you actually enjoy. Manga kanji stick because you care what happens next.
  5. Don't try to learn more than 10–15 new kanji per day. Depth over breadth.
  6. Track your progress visually. Crossing off kanji on a paper chart is surprisingly motivating.
- 

## The 100 Most Useful Kanji to Learn First

These appear in everyday life constantly — master these and you'll recognize kanji in most common situations:

日月火水木金土年時間分今大小上下中外人口入出山川海空車電気食飲行来見聞言書読話会社学校店駅電話本国語名前何時  
(Learn these 100 with readings and you're already ahead of many visitors to Japan.)

---

## A Note on Kanji and Kana Together

Most Japanese text mixes all three systems in the same sentence:

私は毎日コーヒーを飲みます。(Watashi wa mainichi kōhī wo nomimasu.) "I drink coffee every day."

- 私 = kanji (I)
- は = hiragana (topic particle)
- 毎日 = kanji (every day)
- コーヒー = katakana (coffee)
- を = hiragana (object particle)
- 飲みます = kanji + hiragana (drink, polite form)

This mixing is completely normal and eventually feels completely natural.

Next up: Grammar Basics →

\newpage

## Grammar Basics — How Japanese Sentences Actually Work

"The first time you realize Japanese puts the verb at the end, your brain reboots. The second time, it feels completely logical."

Japanese grammar is simultaneously simpler and more different than English grammar. No gender. No plural forms for most nouns. No articles (no "a," "an," or "the"). But: verbs go at the end, particles mark every noun's role, and politeness is baked into the verb itself.

Let's break it down.

---



## The Core Structure: Subject-Object-Verb (SOV)

English: Subject + Verb + Object

I eat sushi.

Japanese: Subject + Object + Verb

私は寿司を食べます。(Watashi wa sushi wo tabemasu.) I [topic] sushi [object] eat.

The verb always goes at the end of the sentence (in standard Japanese). Adjectives, time expressions, location phrases — they all come before the verb. Get used to this, and everything else will fall into place.

---

## Particles — The Traffic Signs of Japanese

Particles are small hiragana attached to nouns that tell you what role that noun plays in the sentence. They're the most important grammatical concept in Japanese.

### The Essential Particles

| Particle  | Role                                  | Example                             |
|-----------|---------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| は (wa)    | Topic marker — "as for X"             | 私は学生です。I am a student.              |
| が (ga)    | Subject marker — emphasis, new info   | 猫が好きです。I like cats (specifically).  |
| を (wo/o)  | Object marker — what the verb acts on | 水を飲む。Drink water.                   |
| に (ni)    | Direction, location (existence), time | 東京に行く。Go to Tokyo.                  |
| で (de)    | Location (action), means/method       | 電車で来た。Came by train.                |
| と (to)    | And (nouns), together with            | 友達と行く。Go with a friend.             |
| の (no)    | Possessive, noun modifier             | 私の本。My book.                        |
| も (mo)    | Also, too                             | 私も行く。I'm going too.                 |
| か (ka)    | Question marker                       | これは何か？What is this?                 |
| ね (ne)    | Seeking agreement — "right?"          | 寒いですね。It's cold, isn't it.          |
| よ (yo)    | Assertive — "I'm telling you"         | 知ってますよ。I know, you know.            |
| から (kara) | From, because                         | 東京から来た。Came from Tokyo.             |
| まで (made) | Until, up to                          | 5時まで働く。Work until 5.                |
| より (yori) | Than (comparison)                     | 猫より犬が好き。I like dogs more than cats. |

### は (wa) vs. が (ga) — The Famous Nightmare

This is the most debated grammar point in Japanese. Here's the practical version:

- は introduces a topic you're talking about — general, already established context
- が marks the specific subject in a clause — new information, contrast, emphasis

象は鼻が長い。"As for elephants, (their) noses are long." (は marks "elephants" as the topic; が marks "noses" as the subject of 長い)

誰が来た？田中さんが来た。"Who came? Tanaka-san came." (が is used for new information answering a specific question)

Don't over-stress this distinction early on. Natives will understand you either way. Nuance comes with reading real Japanese.

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## Verbs — Three Groups and a Lot of Conjugation

All Japanese verbs end in う (u) sounds in their dictionary form. They fall into three groups:

### Group 1: U-verbs (五段動詞 — Godan)

The stem changes depending on the form. The final syllable changes across the u-row:

| Dictionary  | Meaning | Masu form | Nai form | Te form            |
|-------------|---------|-----------|----------|--------------------|
| 書く (kaku)   | write   | 書きます      | 書かない     | 書いて                |
| 話す (hanasu) | speak   | 話します      | 話さない     | 話して                |
| 飲む (nomu)   | drink   | 飲みます      | 飲まない     | 飲んで                |
| 読む (yomu)   | read    | 読みます      | 読まない     | 読んで                |
| 行く (iku)    | go      | 行きます      | 行かない     | 行って (irregular te) |
| 買う (kau)    | buy     | 買います      | 買わない     | 買って                |
| 待つ (matsu)  | wait    | 待ちます      | 待たない     | 待って                |

### Group 2: Ru-verbs (一段動詞 — Ichidan)

The stem doesn't change — just drop る and add endings:

| Dictionary    | Meaning | Masu form | Nai form | Te form |
|---------------|---------|-----------|----------|---------|
| 食べる (taberu)  | eat     | 食べます      | 食べない     | 食べて     |
| 見る (miru)     | see     | 見ます       | 見ない      | 見て      |
| 起きる (okiru)   | wake up | 起きます      | 起きない     | 起きて     |
| 寝る (neru)     | sleep   | 寝ます       | 寝ない      | 寝て      |
| 教える (oshieru) | teach   | 教えます      | 教えない     | 教えて     |

Warning: Some verbs that look like ru-verbs are actually u-verbs. 帰る (kaeru = return home), 走る (hashiru = run), 知る (shiru = know). These fool everyone.

### Group 3: Irregular Verbs

Only two — but you'll use them constantly:

| Dictionary | Meaning | Masu form | Nai form | Te form |
|------------|---------|-----------|----------|---------|
| する (suru)  | do      | します       | しない      | して      |
| くる (kuru)  | come    | きます       | こない      | きて      |

## Verb Conjugation Chart

The four most essential forms to learn first:

| Form       | Ending   | Usage                 | Example (食べる)   |
|------------|----------|-----------------------|-----------------|
| Dictionary | -ru / -u | Casual present/future | 食べる (taberu)    |
| Masu       | -masu    | Polite present/future | 食べます (tabemasu) |
| Nai        | -nai     | Negative              | 食べない (tabenai)  |

| Form    | Ending       | Usage                      | Example (食べる)       |
|---------|--------------|----------------------------|---------------------|
| Ta      | -ta / -da    | Past (casual)              | 食べた (tabeta)        |
| Mashita | -mashita     | Past (polite)              | 食べました (tabemashita) |
| Te      | -te / -de    | Connecting form            | 食べて (tabete)        |
| Tara    | -tara        | Conditional "if/when"      | 食べたら (tabetara)     |
| Ba      | -eba / -reba | Conditional (hypothetical) | 食べれば (tabereba)     |

## Adjectives — Two Flavors

### い-adjectives (i-adjectives)

End in い in their base form. Conjugate by changing the い:

| Form             | Example (大きい = big)     |
|------------------|-------------------------|
| Present positive | 大きい (ōkii)              |
| Present negative | 大きくない (ōkiku nai)       |
| Past positive    | 大きかった (ōkikatta)        |
| Past negative    | 大きくなかった (ōkiku nakatta) |
| Before noun      | 大きい犬 (big dog)          |
| As predicate     | 犬は大きい (The dog is big)  |

Common い-adjectives: 大きい (big), 小さい (small), 高い (tall/expensive), 安い (cheap), 新しい (new), 古い (old), 難しい (difficult), 易しい (easy), 楽しい (fun), 悲しい (sad), 暑い (hot), 寒い (cold)

### な-adjectives (na-adjectives)

Essentially nouns that can modify other nouns. Add な before a noun, add です to make a predicate:

| Form             | Example (きれい = pretty/clean) |
|------------------|------------------------------|
| Present positive | きれいです (kirei desu)           |
| Present negative | きれいじゃない / きれいではない            |
| Past positive    | きれいでした                       |
| Past negative    | きれいじゃなかった                    |
| Before noun      | きれいな花 (pretty flower)        |

Common な-adjectives: きれい (pretty/clean), 元気 (healthy/energetic), 好き (like), 嫌い (dislike), 有名 (famous), 便利 (convenient), 静か (quiet), 賑やか (lively), 丁寧 (polite), 親切 (kind)

Trap: いい (good) is an い-adjective but conjugates irregularly: negative is よくない, past is よかった.

## The Copula: です and だ

The equivalent of "to be" in Japanese:

| Style  | Present | Negative         | Past | Past negative |
|--------|---------|------------------|------|---------------|
| Polite | です      | じゃないです / ではありません | でした  | じゃなかったです      |
| Casual | だ       | じゃない             | だった  | じゃなかった        |

学生です。(Gakusei desu.) = I am a student. (polite) 学生だ。(Gakusei da.) = I'm a student. (casual) 学生じゃない。(Gakusei ja nai.) = I'm not a student. (casual)

## Question Formation — Just Add か

Unlike English, you don't rearrange words to form a question. Just add か at the end:

これは何ですか？(Kore wa nan desu ka?) = What is this? どこに行きますか？(Doko ni ikimasu ka?) = Where are you going? 田中さんは来ましたか？(Tanaka-san wa kimashita ka?) = Did Tanaka-san come?

In casual speech, か is often dropped and replaced with a rising intonation:

行く？(Iku?) = You going?

## Essential Question Words

| Japanese        | Romaji                 | Meaning                          |
|-----------------|------------------------|----------------------------------|
| 何 (なに/なん)       | nani / nan             | what                             |
| どこ              | doko                   | where                            |
| いつ              | itsu                   | when                             |
| だれ / どなた        | dare / donata          | who (casual / polite)            |
| なぜ / どうして / なんで | naze / dōshite / nande | why (formal / standard / casual) |
| どう / いかが        | dō / ikaga             | how (casual / polite)            |
| どれ              | dore                   | which (of three+)                |
| どちら / どっち       | dochira / docchi       | which (of two, polite / casual)  |
| いくら             | ikura                  | how much (price)                 |
| いくつ             | ikutsu                 | how many                         |

## て-form: The Swiss Army Knife

The て-form connects actions, makes requests, shows ongoing states, and appears in dozens of grammar patterns. It's the most versatile verb form:

| て-form use         | Example  | Meaning             |
|--------------------|----------|---------------------|
| Connecting actions | 食べて寝た    | Ate and slept       |
| Request (polite)   | 見てください   | Please look         |
| Progressive        | 食べています   | I am eating         |
| Permission         | 行ってもいい   | You may go          |
| Prohibition        | 触ってはいけない | You must not touch  |
| Try doing          | 食べてみた    | I tried eating it   |
| Do in advance      | 買っておく    | Buy (it) in advance |

| て-form use          | Example | Meaning                     |
|---------------------|---------|-----------------------------|
| Give/do for someone | 教えてあげる  | I'll teach you (as a favor) |

## Counters — A Uniquely Japanese Challenge

Japanese uses specific "counter" words depending on what you're counting. There's no generic "things":

| Counter        | For                  | Examples                                                     |
|----------------|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| 個 (こ / ko)     | small objects        | りんご2個 (2 apples)                                             |
| 枚 (まい / mai)   | flat things          | 紙3枚 (3 sheets of paper)                                      |
| 本 (ほん / hon)   | long, thin things    | ペン1本 (1 pen), ビール2本 (2 bottles of beer)                      |
| 冊 (さつ / satsu) | bound books          | 本5冊 (5 books)                                                |
| 台 (だい / dai)   | machines, vehicles   | 車2台 (2 cars)                                                 |
| 匹 (ひき / hiki)  | small animals        | 猫3匹 (3 cats)                                                 |
| 頭 (とう / tō)    | large animals        | 牛2頭 (2 cows)                                                 |
| 羽 (わ / wa)     | birds, rabbits       | 鳥5羽 (5 birds)                                                |
| 人 (にん / nin)   | people               | 3人 (3 people) — but: 1 person = 一人 (hitori), 2 = 二人 (futari) |
| 杯 (はい / hai)   | cups, glasses, bowls | コーヒー1杯 (1 cup of coffee)                                     |

## Sentence Patterns to Know at Every Level

### Beginner

- A は B です。 — A is B.
- A が好きです。 — I like A.
- A に行きます。 — I'm going to A.
- A をください。 — Please give me A.

### Intermediate

- A てから B。 — After doing A, do B.
- A ので B。 — Because of A, B. (reason)
- A たり B たりする。 — Do things like A and B.
- A ようになった。 — It came to be that A. (change over time)

### Advanced

- A に違いない。 — It must certainly be A.
- A わけにはいかない。 — I can't possibly do A (given the circumstances).
- A かねない。 — There's a risk that A might happen.
- A にもかかわらず。 — Despite A, nevertheless...

## Common Mistakes and How to Avoid Them

| Mistake                      | Wrong    | Right   | Why                                       |
|------------------------------|----------|---------|-------------------------------------------|
| Using の for all possession   | 私の行く     | 私が行く    | の doesn't replace が as subject            |
| Forgetting verb-final order  | 私は飲む水を   | 私は水を飲む  | Verb always at end                        |
| は vs が confusion             | 誰は来た？    | 誰が来た？   | Question words use が                      |
| Adjective past tense         | 美しかったです  | 美しいでした  | い-adj conjugates before です                |
| Direct translation of "have" | 私は弟があります | 私は弟がいます | あります is for things; います for living beings |

Grammar is a tool, not a cage. The more you read and listen to Japanese, the more these patterns will become intuitive. Don't aim to memorize rules — aim to recognize patterns.

Next up: Core Vocabulary →

\newpage

## Core Vocabulary — The 500 Words That Carry You Everywhere

"Research suggests the top 1,000 words in any language cover about 85% of everyday speech. Learn the top 500 and you're already more than halfway there."

This isn't a random word dump. Every word here was chosen because it appears constantly in daily Japanese life — on signs, in conversation, on menus, in news. Master these and almost every real-world situation becomes navigable.

## Greetings & Social Phrases

| Japanese   | Romaji                  | Meaning                                 | Notes                        |
|------------|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------|
| おはようございます  | ohayō gozaimasu         | Good morning                            | Drop ございます with close        |
| こんにちは      | konnichiwa              | Hello / Good afternoon                  |                              |
| こんばんは      | konbanwa                | Good evening                            |                              |
| おやすみなさい    | oyasuminasai            | Good night                              |                              |
| さようなら      | sayōnara                | Goodbye (formal, somewhat final)        | Multi-purpose: getting atten |
| じゃあね / またね | jā ne / mata ne         | See you / Bye (casual)                  |                              |
| ありがとうございます | arigatō gozaimasu       | Thank you very much                     |                              |
| ありがとう      | arigatō                 | Thank you (casual)                      |                              |
| どういたしまして   | dō itashimashite        | You're welcome                          | Agreement/consideration      |
| すみません      | sumimasen               | Excuse me / I'm sorry                   |                              |
| ごめんなさい     | gomen nasai             | I'm sorry (sincere)                     |                              |
| はい         | hai                     | Yes                                     |                              |
| いいえ        | iie                     | No                                      | Said constantly — at introd  |
| そうです       | sō desu                 | That's right                            |                              |
| そうですね      | sō desu ne              | I see / Yes, indeed                     |                              |
| よろしくお願いします | yoroshiku onegaishimasu | Please treat me well / Nice to meet you |                              |
| はじめまして     | hajimemashite           | Nice to meet you (first meeting)        | Polite response to above     |
| おげんきですか    | ogenki desu ka          | How are you?                            |                              |
| おかげさまで     | okagesama de            | Thanks to you, I'm fine                 |                              |

## Numbers

| Number      | Kanji | Hiragana | Romaji        |
|-------------|-------|----------|---------------|
| 0           | 零/〇   | ぜろ/れい    | zero / rei    |
| 1           | 一     | いち       | ichi          |
| 2           | 二     | に        | ni            |
| 3           | 三     | さん       | san           |
| 4           | 四     | し/よん     | shi / yon     |
| 5           | 五     | ご        | go            |
| 6           | 六     | ろく       | roku          |
| 7           | 七     | しち/なな    | shichi / nana |
| 8           | 八     | はち       | hachi         |
| 9           | 九     | く/きゅう    | ku / kyū      |
| 10          | 十     | じゅう      | jū            |
| 11          | 十一    | じゅういち    | jūichi        |
| 20          | 二十    | にじゅう     | nijū          |
| 100         | 百     | ひゃく      | hyaku         |
| 1,000       | 千     | せん       | sen           |
| 10,000      | 万     | まん       | man           |
| 100,000,000 | 億     | おく       | oku           |

Japan uses 万 (10,000) as a base unit, not thousand. So 30,000 is 三万 (sanman), not "thirty thousand." This trips up English speakers when reading prices.

## Time

| Japanese | Romaji   | Meaning                    |
|----------|----------|----------------------------|
| 今        | ima      | now                        |
| 今日       | kyō      | today                      |
| 明日 / あした | ashita   | tomorrow                   |
| 昨日       | kinō     | yesterday                  |
| 今週       | konshū   | this week                  |
| 来週       | raishū   | next week                  |
| 先週       | senshū   | last week                  |
| 今月       | kongetsu | this month                 |
| 来月       | raigetsu | next month                 |
| 今年       | kotoshi  | this year                  |
| 来年       | rainen   | next year                  |
| 朝        | asa      | morning                    |
| 昼        | hiru     | noon / daytime             |
| 夜        | yoru     | night                      |
| 午前       | gozen    | AM                         |
| 午後       | gogo     | PM                         |
| 〜時       | ~ji      | o'clock (3時 = 3 o'clock)   |
| 〜分       | ~fun/pun | minutes (30分 = 30 minutes) |
| 〜秒       | ~byō     | seconds                    |
| 週末       | shūmatsu | weekend                    |
| 平日       | heijitsu | weekday                    |

## Days of the Week

| Japanese | Kanji     | Day       | Memory trick   |
|----------|-----------|-----------|----------------|
| 月曜日      | getsuyōbi | Monday    | 月 = moon       |
| 火曜日      | kayōbi    | Tuesday   | 火 = fire       |
| 水曜日      | suiyōbi   | Wednesday | 水 = water      |
| 木曜日      | mokuyōbi  | Thursday  | 木 = wood/tree  |
| 金曜日      | kin'yōbi  | Friday    | 金 = gold/money |
| 土曜日      | doyōbi    | Saturday  | 土 = earth      |
| 日曜日      | nichiyōbi | Sunday    | 日 = sun        |

## Months

January = 一月 (ichigatsu), February = 二月 (nigatsu) ... December = 十二月 (jūnigatsu). Simple: number + 月.

## Family

| Japanese   | Romaji          | Meaning         | Notes                                                                 |
|------------|-----------------|-----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 家族         | kazoku          | family          |                                                                       |
| 父 / お父さん   | chichi / otōsan | father          | chichi = my father; otōsan = someone else's / respectful same pattern |
| 母 / お母さん   | haha / okāsan   | mother          |                                                                       |
| 兄 / お兄さん   | ani / oniisan   | older brother   |                                                                       |
| 姉 / お姉さん   | ane / onēsan    | older sister    |                                                                       |
| 弟          | otōto           | younger brother |                                                                       |
| 妹          | imōto           | younger sister  |                                                                       |
| 祖父 / おじいさん | sofu / ojiisan  | grandfather     |                                                                       |
| 祖母 / おばあさん | sobo / obāsan   | grandmother     |                                                                       |
| 夫 / 旦那     | otto / danna    | husband         |                                                                       |
| 妻 / 奥さん    | tsuma / okusan  | wife            |                                                                       |
| 息子         | musuko          | son             |                                                                       |
| 娘          | musume          | daughter        |                                                                       |
| 友達         | tomodachi       | friend          |                                                                       |

## Food & Drink

| Japanese | Romaji   | Meaning     |
|----------|----------|-------------|
| ご飯       | gohan    | rice / meal |
| パン       | pan      | bread       |
| 肉        | niku     | meat        |
| 魚        | sakana   | fish        |
| 野菜       | yasai    | vegetables  |
| 果物       | kudamono | fruit       |
| 卵        | tamago   | egg         |
| 豆腐       | tōfu     | tofu        |
| 味噌       | miso     | miso        |



| Japanese | Romaji       | Meaning                    |
|----------|--------------|----------------------------|
| 醤油       | shōyu        | soy sauce                  |
| 水        | mizu         | water                      |
| お茶       | ocha         | tea (especially green tea) |
| コーヒー     | kōhī         | coffee                     |
| ビール      | bīru         | beer                       |
| 酒 / お酒   | sake / osake | sake / alcohol in general  |
| ラーメン     | rāmen        | ramen                      |
| 寿司       | sushi        | sushi                      |
| 天ぷら      | tenpura      | tempura                    |
| うどん      | udon         | udon noodles               |
| そば       | soba         | soba noodles               |
| カレー      | karē         | curry                      |
| 弁当       | bentō        | lunchbox                   |
| おにぎり     | onigiri      | rice ball                  |

## Places

| Japanese | Romaji       | Meaning                         |
|----------|--------------|---------------------------------|
| 家 / うち   | ie / uchi    | house / home (uchi = "my home") |
| 学校       | gakkō        | school                          |
| 大学       | daigaku      | university                      |
| 会社       | kaisha       | company                         |
| 病院       | byōin        | hospital                        |
| 薬局       | yakkyoku     | pharmacy                        |
| 銀行       | ginkō        | bank                            |
| 郵便局      | yūbinkyoku   | post office                     |
| 図書館      | toshokan     | library                         |
| 駅        | eki          | train station                   |
| 空港       | kūkō         | airport                         |
| ホテル      | hoteru       | hotel                           |
| コンビニ     | konbini      | convenience store               |
| スーパー     | sūpā         | supermarket                     |
| デパート     | depāto       | department store                |
| レストラン    | resutoran    | restaurant                      |
| 公園       | kōen         | park                            |
| 神社       | jinja        | Shinto shrine                   |
| お寺       | otera        | Buddhist temple                 |
| 博物館      | hakubutsukan | museum                          |
| 海        | umi          | sea / ocean                     |
| 山        | yama         | mountain                        |
| 川        | kawa         | river                           |

## Transportation

| Japanese | Romaji     | Meaning           |
|----------|------------|-------------------|
| 電車       | densha     | train (electric)  |
| 地下鉄      | chikatetsu | subway / metro    |
| バス       | basu       | bus               |
| タクシー     | takushī    | taxi              |
| 飛行機      | hikōki     | airplane          |
| 船        | fune       | boat / ship       |
| 自転車      | jitensha   | bicycle           |
| バイク      | baiku      | motorcycle        |
| 車        | kuruma     | car               |
| 乗り換え     | norikae    | transfer (trains) |
| 切符       | kippu      | ticket            |
| 改札       | kaisatsu   | ticket gate       |
| ホーム      | hōmu       | platform          |
| 終電       | shūden     | last train        |

## Essential Verbs

| Japanese | Romaji    | Meaning                   |
|----------|-----------|---------------------------|
| ある / いる  | aru / iru | to exist (thing / person) |
| する       | suru      | to do                     |
| 来る       | kuru      | to come                   |
| 行く       | iku       | to go                     |
| 帰る       | kaeru     | to return home            |
| 食べる      | taberu    | to eat                    |
| 飲む       | nomu      | to drink                  |
| 見る       | miru      | to see / watch            |
| 聞く       | kiku      | to listen / ask           |
| 話す       | hanasu    | to speak                  |
| 読む       | yomu      | to read                   |
| 書く       | kaku      | to write                  |
| 買う       | kau       | to buy                    |
| 売る       | uru       | to sell                   |
| 持つ       | motsu     | to hold / have            |
| 使う       | tsukau    | to use                    |
| 作る       | tsukuru   | to make                   |
| 開ける      | akeru     | to open                   |
| 閉める      | shimeru   | to close                  |
| 起きる      | okiru     | to wake up                |
| 寝る       | neru      | to sleep                  |
| 着る       | kiru      | to wear (clothes)         |
| 脱ぐ       | nugu      | to take off (clothes)     |
| 待つ       | matsu     | to wait                   |
| 会う       | au        | to meet                   |
| 知る       | shiru     | to know                   |
| 分かる      | wakaru    | to understand             |
| 思う       | omou      | to think (opinion)        |
| 考える      | kangaeru  | to think (deliberate)     |
| 忘れる      | wasureru  | to forget                 |

| Japanese | Romaji   | Meaning                |
|----------|----------|------------------------|
| 覚える      | oboeru   | to memorize / remember |
| 始める      | hajimeru | to begin               |
| 終わる      | owaru    | to end / finish        |
| 入る       | hairu    | to enter               |
| 出る       | deru     | to exit / leave        |
| 乗る       | noru     | to ride / board        |
| 降りる      | oriru    | to get off             |
| 教える      | oshieru  | to teach / tell        |
| 手伝う      | tetsudau | to help                |
| 貸す       | kasu     | to lend                |
| 借りる      | kariru   | to borrow              |

## Essential Adjectives

| Japanese | Romaji            | Meaning          |
|----------|-------------------|------------------|
| 大きい      | ōkii              | big              |
| 小さい      | chīsai            | small            |
| 多い       | ōi                | many / a lot     |
| 少ない      | sukunai           | few / not many   |
| 高い       | takai             | high / expensive |
| 安い       | yasui             | cheap            |
| 長い       | nagai             | long             |
| 短い       | mijikai           | short            |
| 広い       | hiro              | wide / spacious  |
| 狭い       | semai             | narrow           |
| 新しい      | atarashii         | new              |
| 古い       | furui             | old              |
| 早い / 速い  | hayai             | early / fast     |
| 遅い       | osoi              | late / slow      |
| 暑い       | atsui             | hot (weather)    |
| 寒い       | samui             | cold (weather)   |
| 熱い       | atsui             | hot (to touch)   |
| 冷たい      | tsumetai          | cold (to touch)  |
| 難しい      | muzukashii        | difficult        |
| 易しい / 簡単 | yasashii / kantan | easy             |
| 楽しい      | tanoshii          | fun              |
| 面白い      | omoshiroi         | interesting      |
| つまらない    | tsumaranai        | boring           |
| かわいい     | kawaii            | cute             |
| かっこいい    | kakkoi            | cool / stylish   |
| きれい      | kirei             | pretty / clean   |
| 汚い       | kitanai           | dirty            |
| 重い       | omoi              | heavy            |
| 軽い       | karui             | light            |
| 強い       | tsuyoi            | strong           |
| 弱い       | yowai             | weak             |
| 忙しい      | isogashii         | busy             |
| 暇        | hima              | free / not busy  |

| Japanese | Romaji   | Meaning |
|----------|----------|---------|
| 嬉しい      | ureshii  | happy   |
| 悲しい      | kanashii | sad     |
| 怖い       | kowai    | scary   |
| 痛い       | itai     | painful |
| 眠い       | nemui    | sleepy  |

## Useful Connectors & Expressions

| Japanese | Romaji      | Meaning                   |
|----------|-------------|---------------------------|
| でも       | demo        | but / however (casual)    |
| しかし      | shikashi    | however (formal)          |
| そして      | soshite     | and then / and            |
| それから     | sorekara    | and after that            |
| だから      | dakara      | therefore / so            |
| でも       | demo        | but                       |
| もし       | moshi       | if                        |
| たぶん      | tabun       | probably                  |
| きっと      | kitto       | surely / I'm sure         |
| もちろん     | mochiron    | of course                 |
| やっぱり     | yappari     | as expected / after all   |
| まあ       | mā          | well... (filler)          |
| ちょっと     | chotto      | a little / just a moment  |
| すごく      | sugoku      | very (casual)             |
| とても      | totemo      | very                      |
| もっと      | motto       | more                      |
| あまり～ない   | amari ~nai  | not very ~, not much ~    |
| 全然～ない    | zenzen ~nai | not at all ~              |
| ぜひ       | zehi        | by all means / definitely |

## Body

| Japanese | Romaji | Meaning  |
|----------|--------|----------|
| 頭        | atama  | head     |
| 目        | me     | eye      |
| 耳        | mimi   | ear      |
| 鼻        | hana   | nose     |
| 口        | kuchi  | mouth    |
| 歯        | ha     | tooth    |
| 顔        | kao    | face     |
| 首        | kubi   | neck     |
| 肩        | kata   | shoulder |
| 手        | te     | hand     |
| 腕        | ude    | arm      |
| 指        | yubi   | finger   |

| Japanese | Romaji | Meaning          |
|----------|--------|------------------|
| 足        | ashi   | foot / leg       |
| 背中       | senaka | back             |
| お腹       | onaka  | stomach / belly  |
| 心臓       | shinzō | heart (organ)    |
| 心        | kokoro | heart (feelings) |

## Asking for Help (Survival Phrases)

| Japanese      | Romaji                              | Meaning                        |
|---------------|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| ～はどこですか？      | ~wa doko desu ka?                   | Where is ~?                    |
| ～をください。       | ~wo kudasai.                        | Please give me ~.              |
| ～はありますか？      | ~wa arimasu ka?                     | Do you have ~?                 |
| いくらですか？       | ikura desu ka?                      | How much is it?                |
| 分かりません。       | wakarimasen.                        | I don't understand.            |
| もう一度お願いします。   | mō ichido onegaishimasu.            | Please say that again.         |
| ゆっくり話してください。  | yukkuri hanashite kudasai.          | Please speak slowly.           |
| 日本語が少しだけ話せます。 | nihongo ga sukoshi dake hanasemasu. | I can speak a little Japanese. |
| 英語を話せますか？     | eigo wo hanasemasu ka?              | Can you speak English?         |
| 助けてください！      | tasukete kudasai!                   | Please help me!                |
| 道に迷いました。      | michi ni mayoimashita.              | I'm lost.                      |

These 500 words are your toolkit. They won't make you fluent, but they'll get you through almost every real-world situation you'll encounter in Japan — and they form the foundation for every grammar structure you'll learn next.

Next up: Phrases & Idioms →

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## Phrases & Idioms — Sound Like You Know What You're Doing

"The difference between a textbook learner and someone who sounds natural is usually a handful of idioms and phrases that native speakers use without thinking."

Japanese is full of expressions that can't be translated word for word — and many of them are used so constantly that skipping them means missing half of what's happening around you.

## Survival Phrases — Day One Essentials

At a Restaurant

| Japanese   | Romaji               | Meaning                      |
|------------|----------------------|------------------------------|
| いらっしゃいませ！  | irasshaimase!        | Welcome! (staff says to you) |
| ～をひとつください。 | ~wo hitotsu kudasai. | One ~, please.               |

| Japanese    | Romaji                        | Meaning                                                           |
|-------------|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| これをください。    | kore wo kudasai.              | I'll have this one.                                               |
| おすすめは何ですか？  | osusume wa nan desu ka?       | What do you recommend?                                            |
| 辛いですか？      | karai desu ka?                | Is it spicy?                                                      |
| アレルギーがあります。 | arerugi ga arimasu.           | I have an allergy.                                                |
| お会計をお願いします。 | okaiki wo onegaishimasu.      | Check, please.                                                    |
| 別々をお願いします。  | betsu betsu de onegaishimasu. | Separate checks, please.                                          |
| ごちそうさまでした。  | gochisōsama deshita.          | Thank you for the meal (said after eating — to staff, host, etc.) |
| いただきます。     | itadakimasu.                  | Let's eat / Thank you for this food (said before eating)          |

### At a Shop

| Japanese        | Romaji                           | Meaning                   |
|-----------------|----------------------------------|---------------------------|
| 見てだけです。         | miteru dake desu.                | Just looking.             |
| 試着できますか？        | shichaku dekimasu ka?            | Can I try this on?        |
| 他のサイズはありますか？    | hoka no saizu wa arimasu ka?     | Do you have another size? |
| クレジットカードは使えますか？ | kurejitto kōdo wa tsukaemasu ka? | Can I use a credit card?  |
| 袋はいりません。        | fukuro wa irimasen.              | I don't need a bag.       |
| 領収書をください。       | ryōshūsho wo kudasai.            | Could I have a receipt?   |

### Getting Around

| Japanese   | Romaji               | Meaning                     |
|------------|----------------------|-----------------------------|
| 〜までいくらですか？ | ~made ikura desu ka? | How much to ~? (taxi, fare) |
| 〜はどこですか？   | ~wa doko desu ka?    | Where is ~?                 |
| 〜に行きたいです。  | ~ni ikitai desu.     | I want to go to ~.          |
| ここで降ります。   | koko de orimasu.     | I'll get off here.          |
| 次は〜ですか？    | tsugi wa ~ desu ka?  | Is the next stop ~?         |

## Social Lubricant — Phrases Japanese People Say All the Time

These are the phrases that fill conversation. Use them and you'll immediately sound more natural:

| Phrase      | Reading                 | When to use it                                               |
|-------------|-------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| お疲れ様です      | otsukaresama desu       | "Good work" — said to coworkers constantly, when leaving     |
| ご苦労様です      | gokurōsama desu         | "Thank you for your hard work" — said downward to staff/s    |
| よろしくお願いします  | yoroshiku onegaishimasu | "Please treat me well / I'm counting on you" — essential for |
| お世話になっております | osewa ni natte orimasu  | "Thank you for your continued support" — how almost every    |
| なるほど        | naruhodo                | "I see / That makes sense" — shows you're following along    |
| そうですね       | sō desu ne              | "Indeed / Is that so?" — thoughtful agreement, buying thing  |
| ちょっと...     | chotto...               | "Hmm, that's a bit..." — polite, vague refusal. Japanese pe  |
| 大丈夫です       | daijōbu desu            | "It's fine / I'm okay" — can mean yes OR no depending on     |
| 頑張ってください    | ganbatte kudasai        | "Do your best / Good luck" — said before exams, events, c    |
| 頑張ります       | ganbarimasu             | "I'll do my best" — the response                             |
| お邪魔します      | ojama shimasu           | "Excuse the intrusion" — said when entering someone's ho     |
| ただいま / おかえり | tadaima / okaeri        | "I'm home" / "Welcome back" — the pair that every househ     |

| Phrase            | Reading                  | When to use it                                              |
|-------------------|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| いってきます / いってらっしゃい | ittekimasu / itterasshai | "I'm heading out" / "Have a good day" — the other essential |

## Idioms — Japanese Has Some Great Ones

Japanese idioms often have beautiful imagery. These are widely used in everyday speech:

| Idiom         | Reading                           | Literal meaning                               | Ac  |
|---------------|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|-----|
| 七転び八起き        | nana korobi ya oki                | Fall down seven times, get up eight           | Pe  |
| 猫に小判          | neko ni koban                     | Gold coins to a cat                           | Ca  |
| 石の上にも三年       | ishi no ue ni mo san nen          | Three years sitting on a stone                | Pa  |
| 井の中の蛙         | i no naka no kawazu               | A frog in a well                              | Sc  |
| 花より団子         | hana yori dango                   | Dumplings over flowers                        | Pr  |
| 取らぬ狸の皮算用      | toranu tanuki no kawazanyō        | Counting raccoon dog skins you haven't caught | Do  |
| 二兎を追う者は一兎をも得ず | nito wo ou mono wa itto wo mo ezu | Chase two rabbits and catch neither           | Yo  |
| 馬の耳に念仏        | uma no mimi ni nenbutsu           | Buddhist prayer to a horse's ears             | Ta  |
| 目から鱗          | me kara uroko                     | Scales falling from eyes                      | A   |
| 一石二鳥          | isseki nichō                      | One stone, two birds                          | Kil |
| 棚から牡丹餅        | tana kara botamochi               | Mochi falling from a shelf                    | Lu  |
| 口は災いの元        | kuchi wa wazawai no moto          | The mouth is the source of disaster           | Lo  |

## Yojijukugo — Four-Kanji Idioms (四字熟語)

These four-kanji compound expressions are used everywhere in Japanese writing, speeches, and even casual conversation. Knowing a few makes a strong impression:

| Expression | Reading          | Meaning                                                                        |
|------------|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 一期一会       | ichi go ichi e   | "One time, one meeting" — treasure each encounter, it may not happen again     |
| 自業自得       | ji gō ji toku    | "Your own actions, your own result" — you reap what you sow                    |
| 八方美人       | happō bijin      | "Beautiful in all directions" — a people-pleaser who agrees with everyone      |
| 臨機応変       | rinki ōhen       | Adapting flexibly to circumstances                                             |
| 以心伝心       | i shin den shin  | "Mind to mind transmission" — understanding someone without words              |
| 七転八倒       | shichiten battō  | Writhing in agony / chaos                                                      |
| 一日千秋       | ichinichi senshu | "A thousand autumns in a day" — longing intensely for something                |
| 十人十色       | jūnin toiro      | "Ten people, ten colors" — to each their own                                   |
| 温故知新       | on ko chi shin   | "Warm up the old, know the new" — learn from history to understand the present |
| 大器晩成       | taiki bansei     | "Great vessels take long to complete" — late bloomers become great             |

## Proverbs (ことわざ)

Shorter proverbs used in everyday speech:

| Proverb    | Reading                      | Meaning                                                              |
|------------|------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 案ずるより産むが易し | anzuru yori umu ga yasushi   | The act of doing is easier than the worry about it                   |
| 急がば回れ      | isogaba maware               | If you're in a hurry, take the long way round — shortcuts backfire   |
| 笑う門には福来る   | warau kado ni wa fuku kitaru | Happiness comes to those who smile / Laughter brings good fortune    |
| 知らぬが仏      | shiranu ga hotoke            | Ignorance is bliss (literally: not knowing is like being Buddha)     |
| 出る杭は打たれる   | deru kui wa utareru          | The nail that sticks out gets hammered in — don't stand out too much |
| 論より証拠      | ron yori shōko               | Evidence over argument — show, don't tell                            |
| 継続は力なり     | keizoku wa chikara nari      | Continuity is power — consistency wins                               |

出る杭は打たれる is essential cultural knowledge — it explains a lot about Japanese social dynamics, workplace behavior, and why standing out can be uncomfortable in Japan.

## Onomatopoeia — Japanese Goes Way Beyond "Woof" and "Meow"

Japanese onomatopoeia (擬音語 — giongo for actual sounds, 擬態語 — gitaigo for states/feelings) is spectacularly rich. These appear constantly in manga, conversation, and everyday description:

### Sound-Based (擬音語)

| Onomatopoeia | Reading  | Meaning                             |
|--------------|----------|-------------------------------------|
| ドキドキ         | dokidoki | heart pounding (excitement, fear)   |
| ワクワク         | wakuwaku | excited anticipation                |
| ピカピカ         | pikapika | sparkling clean / shining           |
| ガタガタ         | gatagata | shaking/rattling                    |
| ザーザー         | zāzā     | pouring rain                        |
| サラサラ         | sarasara | smooth / silky / flowing            |
| フワフワ         | fuwafuwa | fluffy / light                      |
| ドカン          | dokan    | boom / explosion                    |
| バラバラ         | barabara | scattered / in pieces               |
| ゴロゴロ         | gorogoro | rolling / thunder / lounging around |

### Feeling/State-Based (擬態語)

| Onomatopoeia | Reading     | Meaning                    |
|--------------|-------------|----------------------------|
| ニコニコ         | nikoniko    | smiling happily            |
| イライラ         | iraira      | irritated / frustrated     |
| キラキラ         | kirakira    | sparkling / glittering     |
| ウキウキ         | ukiuki      | giddy / lighthearted       |
| ムカムカ         | mukamuka    | nauseous / irritated       |
| ボーっとする       | bō tto suru | spacing out / daydreaming  |
| グズグズ         | guzuguzu    | dawdling / procrastinating |
| ダラダラ         | daradara    | sluggish / lazy            |
| ペラペラ         | perapera    | fluent (language)          |
| ビクビク         | bikubiku    | nervous / jumpy            |



## Context-Dependent Phrases

Japanese has many phrases that change meaning entirely based on delivery and situation:

### 大丈夫 (daijōbu) — The Wildcard

- "大丈夫ですか?" → "Are you okay?"
- "大丈夫です。" → Could mean "I'm fine" OR "No thank you" OR "It's alright, don't worry"
- Context is everything. Watch for which question came before it.

### ちょっと (chotto) — The Soft Refusal

- Direct: "Just a minute" / "A little bit"
- Social: "That's... a bit..." (the trailing off means no, and pressing further is rude)

### なんか / なんて (nanka / nante) — Softeners

Used to soften statements, express mild self-deprecation, or add vagueness:

- なんか面白い — "It's sort of interesting"
- 私なんて... — "Someone like me..." (self-deprecating)

### よろしく — The Phrase That Does Everything

In emails, meetings, introductions, requests, and farewells:

- At an introduction: "I look forward to working with you"
- In an email sign-off: "Best regards / Thanks in advance"
- After handing off a task: "I'm counting on you"
- Alone as a casual reply to thanks: "No worries"

---

## Useful Filler Words (and Why They Matter)

Fillers show active listening and keep conversation flowing:

| Filler   | Meaning/Use                            |
|----------|----------------------------------------|
| えーと / あの | Um... / Uh... (thinking pause)         |
| そうですね... | "Let me see..." (politely buying time) |
| なるほど     | "I see" / "That makes sense"           |
| うん       | Yeah (casual agreement)                |
| へー！      | "Oh really!" (surprise/interest)       |
| まあね      | "Well, sort of / I guess"              |
| 確かに      | "Certainly / That's true"              |
| それはそうと   | "By the way" (topic change)            |

Japanese conversation involves a lot of あいづち (aizuchi) — back-channel responses that show you're listening. Nodding and saying うん、なるほど、そうですね while someone speaks is expected and polite. Silent listening can feel disengaged to Japanese speakers.

---

## Phrases to Learn by Level

### Beginner

すみません。ここはどこですか？ (Sumimasen. Koko wa doko desu ka?) Excuse me, where is this?

### Intermediate

お時間があればお話ししたいのですが。 (Ojikan ga areba ohanashi shitai no desu ga.) If you have time, I'd like to have a talk.

### Advanced

ご指摘の点、真摯に受け止めております。 (Goshiteki no ten, shinshi ni uketomete orimasu.) I take your feedback very seriously. (Business/formal apology)

Next up: Spoken vs. Written Japanese →

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## Spoken vs. Written Japanese — Two Different Animals

"If you only study from textbooks, the first time you listen to real Japanese conversation you'll wonder if you learned the wrong language."

Japanese has a bigger gap between spoken and written forms than almost any other major language. Textbooks teach you polished, grammatically complete sentences. Real Japanese — especially casual spoken Japanese — drops particles, contracts verbs, swallows endings, and runs words together in ways that would horrify a grammar teacher.

Here's your decoder ring.

---

## The Register Spectrum

Japanese exists on a sliding scale of formality:

← More Casual

More Formal →

|             |           |           |           |                  |
|-------------|-----------|-----------|-----------|------------------|
| くだけた語       | 普通語       | 丁寧語       | 敬語 (敬体)   | 書き言葉             |
| (kudaketa)  | (futsūgo) | (teinego) | (keigo)   | (kakikotoba)     |
| Very casual | Neutral   | Polite    | Honorific | Written/literary |
| Friends     | Thinking  | Service   | Business  | News/documents   |

Most learners spend all their time in the middle (丁寧語) and are unprepared for both ends: the casual end (which is most real conversation) and the written end (which is most real text).

---

## What Gets Dropped in Casual Speech

### 1. Sentence-Final Particles

In formal speech:

明日、学校に行きますか？ (Ashita, gakkō ni ikimasu ka?) Are you going to school tomorrow?

In casual speech:

明日、学校行く？ (Ashita, gakkō iku?) Going to school tomorrow?

What dropped: は particle, に particle, the full verb conjugation, and か

## 2. Verb Endings

| Full form | Casual contraction | Meaning                             |
|-----------|--------------------|-------------------------------------|
| ～ている      | ～てる                | ongoing action: "doing ~"           |
| ～ておく      | ～とく                | do in advance: "do ~ ahead"         |
| ～てしまう     | ～ちゃう / ～じゃう        | complete regrettably / accidentally |
| ～ていない     | ～てない               | not doing / haven't done            |
| ～てはいけない   | ～ちゃいけない            | must not do                         |
| ～なければいけない | ～なきゃ / ～なくちゃ       | must do                             |
| ～てあげる     | ～たげる               | do as favor for someone             |

Examples:

- 食べている → 食べてる (eating)
- 行ってしまった → 行っちゃった (ended up going / oops, went)
- 行かなければ → 行かなきゃ (have to go)

## 3. だ and です Dropping

In casual speech, copulas often disappear entirely or get replaced:

| Formal     | Casual        | Notes         |
|------------|---------------|---------------|
| そうです       | そう / そうだ      | That's right  |
| 分かりません     | 分からない / 分かんない | I don't know  |
| ありがとうございます | ありがとう         | Thanks        |
| 大丈夫ですか？    | 大丈夫？          | Are you okay? |

## 4. Vowel Sounds Getting Swallowed

| Full pronunciation | Casual      | What changed                    |
|--------------------|-------------|---------------------------------|
| わからない              | わかんない       | ra → n                          |
| ～ている               | ～てる         | i dropped                       |
| そういう               | そういう → そーゆー | vowel lengthening + contraction |
| やはり                | やっぱり        | emphatic contraction            |
| やはり                | やっぱ         | even shorter                    |
| どうして               | なんで         | register shift + word swap      |

## Gendered Speech Patterns

Traditionally, Japanese has had distinct male and female speech patterns. While this is fading among younger generations, you'll still hear it in:

### Female Speech Markers

- わ sentence ending: そうだわ (That's how it is)
- の sentence ending (falling intonation): 行くの (Going, you know)
- かしら (I wonder): 何かしら (I wonder what it is)
- わよ combination: そうよ (That's right!)
- More frequent use of ね for seeking agreement

### Male Speech Markers

- ぞ / ぜ sentence endings: 行くぞ! (We're going!)
- だ instead of です in more contexts
- おれ (ore) instead of わたし (watashi) for "I"
- Dropping more particles, rougher contractions

### Modern Reality

Many younger Japanese speakers (especially in cities) mix these freely or use neutral forms. Overusing stereotypically gendered speech as a learner can sound outdated or odd. Listen to real media from people your age for the most current patterns.

---

## Written Japanese: A Different World

Written Japanese — especially newspapers, official documents, literature, and academic writing — uses features you almost never hear in speech:

### 1. Formal Written Verb Endings

| Form  | Example  | Usage                                    |
|-------|----------|------------------------------------------|
| 〜する   | 述べる、記す   | Formal literary present                  |
| 〜である  | これである    | Written "is/am/are" — literary copula    |
| 〜であった | これであった   | Written past                             |
| 〜において | 会議において   | "At / in (the context of)" — very formal |
| 〜に関して | この問題に関して | "Regarding ~" — written only             |
| 〜とともに | 時代とともに   | "Together with / as ~ does"              |

### 2. Passive Voice is Extremely Common in Writing

News Japanese loves the passive:

首相は会見を開いた。 — The PM held a press conference. (active, spoken-style) 記者会見が開かれた。 — A press conference was held. (passive, news-style)

### 3. Nominalizations

Written Japanese frequently turns verbs into nouns using **こと** or **の**:

- 彼が来ることは知っている。(I know the fact of him coming.)
- 泳ぐのが好きだ。(I like swimming — the act of swimming.)

This structure exists in spoken language too, but is much more frequent in writing.

### 4. Classical Grammar Remnants

These appear in written documents, formal speeches, and literature:

| Classical form | Meaning         | Modern equivalent |
|----------------|-----------------|-------------------|
| 〜せず            | without doing ~ | 〜しないで             |
| 〜べし            | should do ~     | 〜すべきだ             |
| 〜なり            | is/am/are       | 〜だ / 〜である         |
| 〜たり            | state of ~      | 〜ている              |

### Pitch Accent — The Sound Level

Japanese has pitch accent (高低アクセント) rather than stress accent like English. Syllables are either High (H) or Low (L) pitch, and the pattern is word-specific and dialect-specific.

This doesn't usually impede communication — context resolves most ambiguity — but it explains why you might be misunderstood occasionally:

| Word      | Meaning    | Pitch pattern (Tokyo) |
|-----------|------------|-----------------------|
| 橋 (hashi) | bridge     | LH                    |
| 箸 (hashi) | chopsticks | HL                    |
| 端 (hashi) | edge       | HL                    |
| 雨 (ame)   | rain       | LH                    |
| 飴 (ame)   | candy      | HL                    |

Most learners don't study pitch accent explicitly and still become fluent. If you're aiming for native-like pronunciation or plan to live in Japan long-term, it's worth studying the Tokyo dialect accent system. The app Migaku and the book Japanese Phonetics by Dogen are the main resources for this.

### Dialect (方言) vs. Standard (標準語)

Standard Japanese (標準語 — hyōjungo) is based on Tokyo dialect and is what textbooks teach. But Japan's regional dialects are strong and distinctive:

| Region       | Dialect | Example difference                     |
|--------------|---------|----------------------------------------|
| Osaka/Kansai | 関西弁     | やん instead of でしょ; めっちゃ instead of とても |
| Kyoto        | 京都弁     | Softer, more classical-sounding        |
| Fukuoka      | 博多弁     | とっと instead of してる                     |
| Tohoku       | 東北弁     | Vowel shortening; え sounds become い    |

| Region  | Dialect | Example difference                                           |
|---------|---------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Okinawa | 沖縄弁     | So different it's arguably a separate language<br>でかい → でっけー |
| Nagoya  | 名古屋弁    |                                                              |

Most Japanese people can switch between their dialect and standard Japanese when needed. If you're watching local news, regional drama, or talking to grandparents in the countryside, you'll hear dialects immediately.

## Register Shifts in Practice

Here's the same sentence in five registers:

Situation: Asking someone to wait

| Register         | Japanese              | Notes                           |
|------------------|-----------------------|---------------------------------|
| Casual (friend)  | ちょっと待って！              | Direct, short                   |
| Neutral          | 少し待ってください。            | Polite request                  |
| Polite           | 少々お待ちください。            | Service/shop context            |
| Formal (keigo)   | しばらくお待ちいただけますでしょうか。   | Business email / formal request |
| Written/official | お待ちくださいますようお願い申し上げます。 | Official announcement           |

Notice: the core meaning stays the same. The register shifts through vocabulary choice, verb form, and sentence length.

## Common "Natural Japanese" Patterns

These patterns appear constantly in speech but are rarely in textbooks:

| Natural Japanese | What it means                                                                 |
|------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| へじゃん / へじゃない？    | "Isn't it ~?" (assertive/seeking agreement)                                   |
| へかな              | "I wonder..." (thinking aloud)                                                |
| へけど / へけどもさ      | "But... / Though..." (softener, trailing off)                                 |
| へんだ / へんです       | "The thing is..." (explaining/clarifying)                                     |
| へじゃないですか         | "Isn't it the case that..." (explaining)                                      |
| へってば！            | "I said ~!" (exasperated repetition)                                          |
| へねへ              | Extending ね for warmth or emphasis                                            |
| 全然大丈夫！           | "Totally fine!" (全然 with positive — technically ungrammatical but ubiquitous) |

## Practical Takeaway

To understand spoken Japanese: Immerse in native content — dramas, variety shows, anime without subtitles. Your brain will gradually pattern-match the contractions.

To produce natural spoken Japanese: Listen carefully to how people your age talk. Find a language partner on HelloTalk, Tandem, or iTalki and get comfortable with being slightly wrong.

To understand written Japanese: Read — a lot. NHK Web Easy → news → literature. Written grammar is learnable but requires separate exposure.

The gap narrows with time and input. Every hour of real Japanese you consume makes both sides more accessible.

Next up: Internet & Slang →

\newpage

## Internet & Slang — www and Other Mysteries

"Japanese internet culture has evolved its own language. Understanding it unlocks a massive slice of modern Japan — and honestly, it's hilarious."

Japanese internet slang is rich, weird, creative, and changes fast. A lot of it originated on 2channel (now 5channel), Japan's legendary anonymous bulletin board, spread through Twitter/X and LINE, and eventually became mainstream. Understanding it helps with anime, manga, social media, and just... being on the internet in Japanese.

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### The Basics: www

Let's start with the most iconic.

w = laughing (like LOL)

The origin: 笑い (warai) = laughter. The kanji 笑 (wara) → romanized as "w" → used as shorthand. Stack them for intensity:

| Expression | Meaning        |
|------------|----------------|
| w          | lol            |
| ww         | haha           |
| www        | lmao           |
| wwwwww     | I am losing it |
| wwwwwwwww  | I am dying     |

Sometimes written as 草 (kusa = grass) — because a field of w's looks like grass. "草生えた" (kusa haeta = grass grew) = something is really funny.

---

### Text/Chat Expressions

| Slang         | Origin        | Meaning                                                                                           |
|---------------|---------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| なう (nau)      | English "now" | "[doing X] right now" — used in old Twitter-style status updates                                  |
| リア充 (riaichū) | リアル充実         | Someone whose real life is fulfilling (social, romantic, active) — often said of anime characters |
| 陰キャ / 陽キャ     | 陰気/陽気 + キャラ   | Introverted / extroverted character archetype                                                     |
| ぼっち           |               | Being alone / friendless — not always negative; ぼっちメシ = eating alone                              |
| ガチ            |               | "For real" / "seriously"                                                                          |
| ガチ勢           |               | People who are seriously into something (hardcore players, fans)                                  |
| 厨二病           | 中二病           | "Eighth-grade syndrome" — embarrassing teenage edgelord behavior                                  |

| Slang                     | Origin        | Meaning                                                                                      |
|---------------------------|---------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 神 (kami)                  |               | "God-tier" — ultimate compliment                                                             |
| 草                         |               | Laughing (see above)                                                                         |
| 卍 (manji)                 |               | Among young people: "yay" / "awesome" / chaotic energy (different from the religious symbol) |
| ぴえん                       |               | Crying emotionally — comes from the pouting emoji                                            |
| メンヘラ                      |               | Mental health struggles / emotionally volatile (can be self-deprecating or threatening)      |
| 闇深 (yamifu/yami ga fukai) |               | "Deep darkness" — something with a disturbing or tragic backstory                            |
| 尊い (tōtoi)                |               | "Holy / precious" — used when something is incredibly beautiful or emotional                 |
| エモい (emoi)                | English "emo" | Nostalgic, sentimental, emotionally moving                                                   |
| ヤバイ (yabai)               |               | "Dangerous/crazy" — evolved to mean anything from terrible to amazing                        |
| ワンチャン (wan chan)          | "one chance"  | Maybe / there's a chance                                                                     |
| ガン無視 (gan mushi)          |               | Completely ignoring someone                                                                  |
| 秒で (byō de)               |               | "In seconds" — instantly                                                                     |
| 全力 (zenryoku)             |               | "Full power" — going all out                                                                 |
| 〜みが深い                     |               | "Very ~" / "deep ~ vibes" (deep sadness = 悲しみが深い as slang)                                   |

## 2channel / 5channel Culture

These terms came from Japan's anonymous internet boards and spread into mainstream use:

| Term         | Meaning                                                              |
|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 煽る (aoru)    | To troll / bait / provoke                                            |
| 荒らし (arashi) | Troll / someone who disrupts discussions                             |
| 釣り (tsuri)   | Clickbait / deliberately misleading post (literally: fishing)        |
| まとめ (matome) | A "roundup" — compilation of posts or news                           |
| スレ (sure)    | Thread (from "thread")                                               |
| レス (resu)    | Reply (from "response")                                              |
| ksg / 空気読めない | Someone who can't read the room                                      |
| 乙 (otsu)     | "Good work" / "thanks" — casual sign-off after someone did something |
| GJ (ジーケー)    | Good job                                                             |
| 乙乙           | Double compliment / thanks for the effort                            |
| スルーカ         | Ability to ignore / let things slide                                 |

## LINE Sticker Culture

LINE is the dominant messaging app in Japan (like WhatsApp in the US). Its sticker system has heavily influenced how Japanese people communicate online — and created its own vocabulary:

- 既読スルー (kidoku suru) — "Read-ignore" — seeing a message and deliberately not responding. One of the most discussed concepts in modern Japanese relationships.
- ライン交換 (LINE kōkan) — Exchanging LINE IDs — the Japanese equivalent of "can I get your number?"
- ブロック (burokku) — Being blocked on LINE — quite serious socially



## Gyaru Language (ギャル語)

From 1990s–2000s youth culture, this heavily contracted, playful dialect influenced a lot of modern slang:

| Gyaru            | Standard    | Meaning                          |
|------------------|-------------|----------------------------------|
| ウザい (uzai)       | うるさい / 鬱陶しい | Annoying                         |
| ムカつく (mukatsuku) | 腹が立つ        | Irritating                       |
| めっちゃ             | とても         | Very (now mainstream everywhere) |
| まじ / まじで         | 本当に         | Really / Seriously               |
| だるい (darui)      | 面倒くさい       | Tiresome / can't be bothered     |
| キモい (kimoi)      | 気持ち悪い       | Gross / creepy                   |
| チョー              | 超           | Super / ultra                    |
| テンション上がる         |             | Getting excited / hyped          |

## Anime/Manga Fandom Slang

| Slang                | Meaning                                                                                 |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 推し (oshi)            | Your favorite — the character or person you support most. Comes from アイドル culture.      |
| 推し活 (oshi-katsu)     | Activities around supporting your oshi — buying merch, attending events, etc.           |
| 二次創作 (nijisōsaku)    | Fan-made works — fan fiction, doujinshi, fan art                                        |
| 同人 (dōjin)           | Self-published / fan-created works                                                      |
| コミケ (Komike)         | Comiket — the twice-yearly massive doujin/fan convention in Tokyo                       |
| 萌え (moe)             | Feeling of warmth/affection for a character — complex but essentially: adoration        |
| ツンデレ (tsundere)      | Cold on the outside, warm inside — famous character archetype                           |
| ヤンデレ (yandere)       | Loving but unhinged — obsessive love interest                                           |
| クーデレ (kūdere)        | Cool/emotionless exterior but secretly loving                                           |
| 壁ドン (kabadon)        | Pinning someone against a wall — romantic trope in manga/drama                          |
| 告白 (kokuhaku)        | Confessing romantic feelings — a formal and significant act in Japanese dating culture  |
| 聖地巡礼 (seichi junrei) | "Pilgrimage to holy sites" — visiting real locations that inspired anime/manga settings |
| 生き様 (ikizama)        | One's way of living — used approvingly of characters with strong convictions            |

## Modern Youth Slang (2020s)

Language moves fast. These are current as of the mid-2020s:

| Slang            | Meaning                                                                                       |
|------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| タイパ (taipha)     | Time performance — getting maximum value from minimum time (binge-watching at 2x speed, etc.) |
| コスパ (kosupa)     | Cost performance — value for money (been around a while but still everywhere)                 |
| 沼る (numaru)      | To fall into a "swamp" — getting obsessed with something                                      |
| 沼 (numa)         | The obsession itself: "I fell into the BTS 沼"                                                 |
| 有識者 (yūshikisha) | Literally "expert" — used ironically online for anyone with strong opinions                   |
| 解像度 (kaizōdo)    | Resolution — "your understanding/picture of X is high resolution" = you really get it         |
| 刺さる (sasaru)     | "Pierces" — when content really hits you emotionally: 刺さった = that really got me               |
| 踏み台 (fumidai)    | Stepping stone — someone used as a stepping stone (callous)                                   |
| マウント取る           | Taking high ground — being condescending or showing off                                       |
| 既出 (既出)          | Already mentioned — "this has been posted before"                                             |

| Slang           | Meaning                                                    |
|-----------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| 逆張り (sakahari)  | Contrarian — someone who always takes the opposite opinion |
| バズる (bazuru)    | To go viral (from "buzz")                                  |
| プロフィール (purofu) | Profile (SNS bio)                                          |
| フォローバ (foroba)  | Follow-back                                                |
| インフル            | Influencer (short for インフルエンサー)                            |

## Abbreviations Common in Japanese Texting

| Abbrev.   | Full form  | Meaning                                  |
|-----------|------------|------------------------------------------|
| マジ        | マジで        | Seriously                                |
| ありあり      | ありがとうありがとう | Thanks thanks (enthusiastic)             |
| おつ        | お疲れ        | Good work (casual sign-off)              |
| わかた       | 分かった       | Got it                                   |
| むり        | 無理         | No way / impossible / can't deal         |
| きつい       |            | Tough / brutal                           |
| はよ        | 早よ         | Hurry up (Kansai origin, now nationwide) |
| あざ / あざす  | ありがとうございます | Thanks (very casual, young people)       |
| ちな        | ちなみに       | By the way                               |
| ていうか / つか | というか       | I mean / rather                          |

## Kaomoji (顔文字) — Japan's Sideways-Proof Emoticons

Long before emoji, Japan had 顔文字 (kaomoji) — emoticons you read upright, no head-tilting required. Western emoticons are sideways and built around the mouth: :) :( . Kaomoji face you directly and are built around the eyes: (^\_^), (T\_T), (・・). (Linguists link this to the fact that East-Asian readers weight the eyes when reading emotion, Westerners the mouth.) They're far more expressive — arms, sweat drops, and whole flailing bodies are fair game.

| Category      | Examples             | Emotion                                    |
|---------------|----------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Happy         | (^_^) (^ω^)\(^o^)/   | smiling, celebrating                       |
| Sad           | (T_T) (;_;) (つ_____) | crying, sorrow                             |
| Anger         | \( `Д´)/ (≡ 〇_____)  | rage, glaring                              |
| Sweat/awkward | (^_~;) (-_-;)        | nervous — the ; is a sweat drop            |
| Surprise      | (O_O) Σ(°△°   )      | shock                                      |
| Love          | (^▽^)(づ。●_____。)づ    | affection, a hug                           |
| Shrug         | _ヽ(ツ)_/              | "dunno / whatever" — the ツ is katakana tsu |
| Despair       | orz (´・ω・`)          | defeat, gloom — orz is a person kneeling   |
| Table-flip    | (´°□°)ノへ ㄣ           | flipping out (卓袱台返し)                       |

Many of these are Japanese inventions that went global: orz (a kneeling figure, from a 2002 forum), (´・ω・`) "shobon" (dejected, from 2channel), and the \_ヽ(ツ)\_/ shrug all started in Japan. On a Japanese keyboard, typing 「かお」 suggests ready-made kaomoji.

\*\* Reality check (2025):\*\* kaomoji now read as nostalgic — people in their 30s+ still use them, but Gen Z leans on LINE stickers and emoji instead. Recognize them everywhere; know that leading with (´ ω `) dates you a little.

For the newest slang — current youth vocabulary, this year's buzzwords, and words that recently flipped meaning — see Contemporary & Emerging Japanese.

## Numbers as Words (Goroawase — 語呂合わせ)

Japanese wordplay using numbers is popular because each digit can be read multiple ways:

| Number | Possible readings |
|--------|-------------------|
| 1      | ichi, i, hi       |
| 2      | ni, fu, tsu       |
| 3      | san, mi, sa       |
| 4      | shi, yo, yon      |
| 5      | go, ko, o         |
| 6      | roku, ro, mu      |
| 7      | shichi, nana, na  |
| 8      | hachi, ha, ya, pa |
| 9      | ku, kyu, ko       |
| 0      | zero, re, o, wa   |

Famous examples:

- 110 (hyaku-jū) = police emergency number but also read as one-one-zero
- 4649 = よろしく (yoroshiku) — read as yo-ro-shi-ku
- 0840 = おはよう (ohayō) — read as o-ha-yo-u
- 724106 = 何もしない (nanimoshinai) = doing nothing

These show up in phone numbers, product names, and internet jokes constantly.

## The Internet Gave Japanese New Kanji Uses

Creative kanji repurposing happens constantly online:

| Usage       | Traditional meaning | Internet meaning                          |
|-------------|---------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| 草 (kusa)    | grass               | lol (see www section)                     |
| 神 (kami)    | god                 | god-tier, incredible                      |
| 闇 (yami)    | darkness            | dark/disturbing depth                     |
| 鬼 (oni)     | demon/ogre          | "super~" (鬼速い = insanely fast)            |
| 爆 (baku)    | explosion           | "explosively ~" (爆笑 = burst out laughing) |
| 秒 (byō)     | second              | "instantly" / "already done"              |
| 廃人 (haijin) | ruined person       | someone who plays a game unhealthily much |

Internet Japanese is a living language that evolves weekly. The best way to stay current: follow Japanese Twitter/X, watch YouTube videos with Japanese comments on, and join a Japanese Discord server or LINE group. Real usage beats any vocabulary list.

# Contemporary & Emerging Japanese — The Language That Won't Sit Still



"Every language evolves, but Japanese does it loudly — buzzwords get an annual award, words flip their meaning in a generation, and a slang term can go from cool to cringe in eighteen months. This page is your moving target."

This is the living-language page. Everything else in the guide is fairly stable — hiragana isn't going to change. But slang, buzzwords, and the meanings of everyday words drift constantly. So this page is dated on purpose and meant to be updated.

**\*\* Freshness:\*\*** The slang here is accurate as of 2025. Some of it will feel dated by 2027 — that's the nature of the beast. Items we believe are already fading or cringe are flagged so you don't accidentally sound like a try-hard. See [How to Stay Current](#) at the bottom.

For the older, more settled internet vocabulary (www, 草, 2ch culture, LINE), see [Internet & Slang](#). This page is the bleeding edge.

## The Yearly Anchor: 新語・流行語大賞

Japan has an official Buzzword of the Year award — 新語・流行語大賞 (shingo・ryūkōgo taishō) — announced every December. A grand prize plus a "Top Ten" are chosen from ~30 nominees. It's the single best way to track what a year sounded like, and it's a perfect study habit: each December, learn that year's list.

Heads up: The award skews toward news events, sports, and TV — not all winners are slang you'd actually say. Some are politely mocked even in Japan (2024's ふてほど won despite the lead actor admitting nobody ever said it). Treat it as a cultural snapshot, not a usage guide.

| Year | Grand Prize           | Reading        | What it was                                              |
|------|-----------------------|----------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| 2022 | 村神様                   | Murakami-sama  | "God Murakami" — slugger Munetaka Murakami's record      |
| 2023 | アレ / A.R.E.           | are            | Hanshin Tigers manager's superstitious euphemism for     |
| 2024 | ふてほど                  | futehodo       | Abbreviation of the TBS drama 不適切にもほどがある                 |
| 2025 | 働いて働いて...まいります / 女性首相 | hataraitete... | PM Takaichi's "I'll work and work and work..." line as J |

Top-Ten highlights worth knowing as vocabulary:

| Term     | Reading        | Year  | Meaning                                                                     |
|----------|----------------|-------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 知らんけど    | shiran kedo    | 2022  | "...but I dunno" — a Kansai comedic hedge tacked onto confident statements  |
| リスキリング   | risukiringu    | 2022  | "Reskilling" — learning new job skills (cooling off now)                    |
| タイパ      | taipa          | 2022* | "Time performance" — value per unit time (*from 三省堂's separate New Words    |
| 蛙化現象     | kaeruka genshō | 2023  | Suddenly turned off by a crush over a trivial flaw ( already fading)        |
| 生成AI     | seisei AI      | 2023  | "Generative AI" — now the dominant tech term                                |
| 闇バイト     | yami baito     | 2023  | "Dark gig" — illegal job recruiting (e.g. via shady SNS posts)              |
| 界隈       | kaiwai         | 2024  | "Scene / sphere" — the Gen-Z sense (see below). One of the most productive  |
| オールドメディア | ōrudo media    | 2025  | "Legacy media" — used pejoratively against TV/newspapers                    |
| 二季       | niki           | 2025  | "Two seasons" — wry commentary that Japan now feels like it has only summer |

| Term | Reading | Year | Meaning |
|------|---------|------|---------|
|------|---------|------|---------|

## Current Youth Slang (若者言葉) — Reliably Alive

These are genuinely in use as of 2024–2025. Register ranges from "near-mainstream" to "texting with friends only" — noted where it matters.

| Japanese  | Reading        | Meaning                                                  | Notes                             |
|-----------|----------------|----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| それな       | sore na        | "Exactly / so true / facts"                              | So entrenched it's nearly neutral |
| あーね       | āne            | "Ahh, I see" (from あーなるほどね)                              | Soft, casual backchannel          |
| 過去ー       | kako-ichi      | "Best ___ ever"                                          | 過去ーかわいい = "cutest ever"           |
| エグい / えぐい | egui           | "Insane / extreme / sick" (good or bad)                  | The younger replacement for       |
| しんどい      | shindoi        | "So good/cute it physically hurts"                       | Fandom sense — 尊すぎてし              |
| フツ軽       | fuk-karu       | "Quick to act, always down to go out"                    | 「フットワークが軽い」comp                   |
| チル / チルい  | chiru / chirui | "Chill, mellow vibe"                                     | From English "chill." Broad, re   |
| ガチ恋       | gachi-koi      | Genuine romantic feelings for an idol/streamer           | Carries an over-invested edge     |
| 限界オタク     | genkai otaku   | A fan so overwhelmed they lose the ability to form words | Affectionate now, not insulting   |
| ーじゃん      | -jan           | "...right?" confirmation ender                           | Fully naturalized, neutral        |
| ーすぎ / すぎる | -sugi          | "Way too ~" — now bolts onto anything                    | 無理すぎ, 良すぎ. Grammatical            |
| キャぱい      | kyapai         | "Over capacity, overwhelmed"                             | From キャパシティ                       |
| メロい       | meroi          | "So cute I melt" (メロメロ → メロい)                            | Affectionate                      |
| ビジュ       | biju           | "Looks / visuals"                                        | ビジュいい = "great visuals."          |
| 飯テロ       | meshi-tero     | Posting tempting food pics late at night                 | "Food terrorism." Age-broad, s    |

The two most productive patterns of 2024–25

ー界限 (kaiwai) — "the \_\_\_ scene / people who are into \_\_\_" Originally just "vicinity/area," now means an online subculture or crowd. It attaches to anything:

- 風呂キャンセル界限 (furo-kyanseru kaiwai) — the "too drained to take a bath today" club. Mental-health humor; topped a 2025 slang ranking.
- 界限 — name any hobby, fandom, or behavior and add 界限.

ー構文 (kōbun) — "\_\_\_ syntax / the \_\_\_ speech pattern" Labels a recognizable, often manipulative or meme-y way of talking:

- ヒス構文 (hisu kōbun) — the "hysterical" guilt-tripping speech pattern.
- ちいかわ構文 — talking like the Chiikawa characters: ワア ..., .....ってコト!?, ヤーッ!!, やんのか? Cutesy and ironic at once.

## Fading or Cringe — Recognize, Don't Use

This is the part most slang lists won't tell you. These were real, but using them earnestly in 2025 marks you as out of touch (痛い) — or worse, as a middle-aged person trying too hard. Understand them; don't deploy them.

| Japanese  | Reading         | Was                        | Why it's flagged now           |
|-----------|-----------------|----------------------------|--------------------------------|
| ぴえん超えてぱおん | pien koete paon | "Beyond crying, it's paon" | Effectively dead. The single h |

| Japanese           | Reading          | Was                                 | Why it's flagged now           |
|--------------------|------------------|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| り / りょ             | ri / ryo         | Abbreviated 了解 ("got it")           | Boomer-coded — teens drop      |
| ぐうかわ               | guu-kawa         | "Insanely cute"                     | ~2013 vintage. Using it gets y |
| とりま                | torima           | "Anyway, for now" (とりあえずまあ)         | 2000s gyaru origin; on "dead   |
| メンブレ               | menbure          | "Mental breakdown"                  | Peaked mid-2010s; reads old    |
| 推ししか勝たん            | oshi shika katan | "My fave is the only winner"        | Peaked 2020–22; now treated    |
| 〜み (つらみ/わかりみ/しんどみ) | -mi              | Cutesy nominalizer ("so relatable") | ~2015. Around half of people   |
| 蛙化現象               | kaeruka genshō   | Crush-killed-by-a-flaw              | A 2023 buzzword already dec    |
| インスタ映え             | insuta-bae       | "Instagrammable"                    | The bare 映え survives; イン       |
| ぴえん                | pien             | Cute whimper                        | Earnest use now reads childis  |

The meta-lesson: the speed of this turnover is itself the point. Words signal which generation and which year you belong to. Native speakers read these signals instantly. When in doubt, lean on the "reliably alive" table above, or just speak plainly — neutral Japanese never goes out of style.

## Words That Flipped Meaning (意味変化)

Nothing illustrates "a living language" better than words whose meaning changed — sometimes recently, sometimes a century ago. These are everywhere, and the generational splits cause real misunderstandings.

| Word          | Reading           | Older meaning                        | Current meaning                              |
|---------------|-------------------|--------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| 全然 + positive | zenzen            | "(not) at all" — required a negative | 全然いい / 全然大丈夫 = "totally fine"                |
| 普通に           | futsū ni          | "normally, in the usual way"         | A sincerity/degree marker: 普通に美味しい = "ge     |
| ヤバイ           | yabai             | "dangerous / bad"                    | All-purpose intensifier, good or bad by tone |
| エモい           | emoi              | (from "emo")                         | "nostalgic / moving / bittersweet"           |
| 微妙            | bimyō             | "subtle, delicate, profound"         | "meh / so-so / iffy"                         |
| 適当            | tekitō            | "appropriate, just right"            | "haphazard / half-hearted"                   |
| ガチ            | gachi             | sumo "a serious bout"                | "serious / for real" intensifier             |
| 確信犯           | kakushinhan       | acting on moral conviction           | "doing something knowing it's wrong"         |
| 役不足           | yakubusoku        | the role is too small for the person | (misused as) the person is inadequate        |
| 鳥肌が立つ         | torihada ga tatsu | goosebumps from fear/cold            | also "deeply moved"                          |

## Loanwords That Became Verbs (and Other Wasei Magic)

Japanese turns foreign nouns into verbs by bolting on ーる and conjugating them like any godan verb: ググる → ググった → ググって.

| Japanese               | Reading | Meaning                                         | Status         |
|------------------------|---------|-------------------------------------------------|----------------|
| ググる                    | guguru  | to Google                                       | Core           |
| ポチる                    | pochiru | to buy online / "click-order"                   | Current        |
| バズる                    | bazuru  | to go viral                                     | Mainstream     |
| ディスる                   | disuru  | to diss / disrespect                            | Current        |
| サボる                    | saboru  | to slack off / skip (← French sabotage, 1920s!) | Fully standard |
| リムる                    | rimuru  | to unfollow on SNS                              | Current        |
| ウバる                    | ubaru   | to order Uber Eats                              | Emerging       |
| メモる / ミスる / パニくる / バグる | —       | to jot down / mess up / panic / glitch          | Current        |

| Japanese | Reading | Meaning             | Status           |
|----------|---------|---------------------|------------------|
| タクル      | takuru  | to take a taxi      | Dead (1990s)     |
| タピる      | tapiru  | to drink bubble tea | Faded (2019 fad) |

Wasei-eigo & abbreviations (English-derived but Japanese-made):

| Japanese       | Reading           | Meaning                                             | Status                      |
|----------------|-------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------|
| サブスク           | sabusuku          | subscription                                        | Mainstream                  |
| コスパ / タイパ      | kosupa / taipu    | cost- / time-performance                            | Entrenched                  |
| ステマ            | sutema            | stealth marketing                                   | Current (re-energized by 1) |
| 映え             | bae               | photogenic                                          | Current (root survives; 1)  |
| 〇〇活 (ヌン活, ソロ活) | -katsu            | "doing 〇〇" (afternoon tea / solo activities)        | Productive                  |
| 親ガチャ           | oya-gacha         | "parent lottery" — the luck of who your parents are | Current                     |
| リモート / テレワーク   | rimōto / terewāku | remote work                                         | リモート reads current; 1       |

## Tech & AI Vocabulary (現在進行形 — very much in progress)

This vocabulary is expanding faster than any other right now.

| Japanese           | Reading                  | Meaning                         | Notes                                   |
|--------------------|--------------------------|---------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| 生成AI               | seisei AI                | generative AI                   | The single most-used AI term since 2023 |
| チャットGPT / チャッピ     | chatto-jī-pī-tī / chappī | ChatGPT (and its cute nickname) | Both spellings seen                     |
| プロンプト              | puronputo                | prompt                          |                                         |
| DX                 | dī-ekkusu                | digital transformation          | Read as "D-X," not spelled out          |
| AIエージェント           | AI ējento                | AI agent                        | The rising buzzword of 2025             |
| 大規模言語モデル           | daikibo gengo moderu     | large language model (LLM)      |                                         |
| ハルシネーション           | harushinēshon            | AI "hallucination"              |                                         |
| ディープフェイク           | dīpu feiku               | deepfake                        |                                         |
| メタバース / NFT / Web3 | —                        | —                               | Cooled hard — now in the "trough"       |

## How to Stay Current

A printed list ages. A habit doesn't. To keep your contemporary Japanese fresh:

- Each December, learn the 新語・流行語大賞 Top Ten. Built-in yearly refresh.
- Follow the 三省堂「今年の新語」 — a dictionary publisher's pick of words with staying power (more linguistically serious than the buzzword award).
- Watch how young Japanese people actually talk — short-form video (TikTok/YouTube Shorts), streamers, and X replies are where slang lives first.
- Use a slang-aware dictionary — weblio and numan用語集 define current terms that 国語辞典 won't have yet.
- When unsure, don't force it. Reaching for slang you're not sure about is the fastest way to sound off. Neutral Japanese is always safe; slang is seasoning, not the meal.

The fact that this page needs updating is the whole lesson. Japanese is alive — keep listening, and you'll keep up.

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## Role Language — 役割語 (Yakuwarigo)

"No real Tokyo grandfather says 「わしが知っておるんじゃ」. No real heiress ends every sentence with 「ですわ」. But the moment you hear those lines, you picture exactly who's speaking. That's role language — and anime, manga, and games run on it."

役割語 (yakuwarigo) is a stylized way of speaking that instantly signals a character's type — their age, gender, class, era, region, or personality — from a single line. The term was coined by linguist 金水敏 (Kinsui Satoshi) in his 2003 book ヴァーチャル日本語 役割語の謎.

This page is essential for two reasons:

1. It unlocks fiction. Once you can read role language, anime and manga characters tell you who they are before the plot does.
2. It warns you what not to copy. Role language is a convention for the audience, not a transcript of real speech. Speaking it in real life ranges from charmingly odd to genuinely strange.

**\*\* The one rule that matters:\*\*** Role language is fictional. Recognize it for comprehension; don't adopt it as your own Japanese. Heavy role language often marks a character as a stereotype (脇役) rather than a real person — that's part of how it works.

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## First-Person Pronouns — Who Says "I"

English has one word for "I." Japanese has dozens, and the choice is a costume. This single chart explains a huge amount of character speech.

| Pronoun | Reading   | Who uses it / what it signals                                                        |
|---------|-----------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 私       | watashi   | Universal neutral-polite, both genders. For men, reads formal/businesslike           |
| 私       | watakushi | More formal and refined — heiresses, butlers, formal speeches                        |
| 僕       | boku      | Boys and soft/intellectual men. Polite, gentle, the "nice guy"                       |
| 俺       | ore       | Rough, casual, masculine. Tough guys, and ordinary men among friends                 |
| 俺様      | ore-sama  | "The great me" — arrogant princes and villains                                       |
| あたし     | atashi    | Casual feminine — softer/girlier than わたし (real women use it too)                    |
| あたい     | atai      | Rough, working-class or tomboy girl. Old downtown (下町) flavor; dated                 |
| うち      | uchi      | A girl's casual "I" — strongly Kansai-flavored, now widespread among young women     |
| わし      | washi     | Elderly men and bosses. The "old geezer" register (West-Japan dialect, transplanted) |
| 拙者      | sessha    | Samurai/ninja — "this unworthy one." Pairs with 一でござる                                |
| 我輩 / 吾輩 | wagahai   | Pompous, self-important older man. From Sōseki's 吾輩は猫である                             |
| おいら     | oira      | Rustic, easygoing country boy. Folksy and low-key masculine                          |
| 朕       | chin      | The Emperor, in formal edicts. (Hirohito used it in the 1945 surrender broadcast)    |
| 麻呂      | maro      | Heian court noble — the aristocrat caricature. Archaic                               |

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## Second-Person Pronouns — Who Says "You" (and How Rudely)

A recurring pattern: Japanese "you" words tend to decay from polite to rude over centuries. 貴様 and お前 both started as honorifics.



| Pronoun | Reading | Politeness                     | Who uses it                                                          |
|---------|---------|--------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| あなた     | anata   | Neutral-polite, but distancing | Polite yet cold; also a wife → husband form. Not safe with superiors |
| 君       | kimi    | Mild, slightly downward        | Superior → junior, boy → girl, intimate. Condescending if aimed upwa |
| お前      | omae    | Rough, downward                | Close male friends — or contempt. Originally honorific (御前), degra   |
| てめえ     | temē    | Very rude, aggressive          | Picking a fight. From 手前                                             |
| 貴様      | kisama  | Very rude, hostile             | Spat at enemies. Like 御前, started honorific and fell                 |
| 汝       | nanji   | Archaic, literary              | Bible, fantasy "thou" — commanding or scriptural                     |
| おぬし     | onushi  | Archaic, peer-or-below         | Samurai-era, toward equals or inferiors                              |
| お宅      | otaku   | Polite-distant, stiff          | Toward someone whose name you don't know. (Yes — this noun late      |

## Sentence Enders & Copulas — The Character Tags (キャラ語尾)

The way a sentence ends is often the loudest signal of all. These markers are how a translator's "ye olde" or "kawaii" flavor gets built in the original.

| Ender           | Reading                 | Archetype                                                       | E |
|-----------------|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|---|
| 〜じゃ / 〜のじゃ      | -ja / -no ja            | Professor / elderly (博士キャラ)                                     | わ |
| 〜ぜ / 〜ぞ         | -ze / -zo               | Rough, cool male                                                | 行 |
| 〜わ / 〜のよ / 〜かしら | -wa / -no yo / -kashira | Feminine "women's language"                                     | そ |
| 〜ですわ / 〜ですの     | -desu wa / -desu no     | Rich young lady (お嬢様)                                           | 準 |
| 〜でござる           | -de gozaru              | Samurai / ninja                                                 | 拙 |
| 〜ニャ / 〜にゃん      | -nya / -nyan            | Cat characters                                                  | お |
| 〜だっちゃ           | -daccha                 | Space alien — Lum from Urusei Yatsura (based on Tōhoku dialect) | 好 |
| 〜なのだ / 〜のだ      | -nano da                | Quirky/childlike — Bakabon's Papa                               | こ |
| 〜っす             | -ssu                    | Casual-polite junior (real slang!) — sporty younger men         | お |
| 〜なり             | -nari                   | Classical copula, or robot/mascot characters                    | 我 |
| 〜アル             | -aru                    | Stereotyped Chinese character                                   | 私 |

## The Archetypes at a Glance

Put the pronoun, the enders, and a few extra features together and you get a recognizable "kit":

| Archetype              | "I"       | Enders               | Other tells                                 |
|------------------------|-----------|----------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| 博士キャラ (professor/sage) | わし        | 〜じゃ / 〜おる            | 知っておる, slow grave tone                      |
| お嬢様 (rich lady)        | わたくし      | 〜ですわ / 〜ですの          | ごきげんよう, "ohohoho" laugh, lavish v           |
| 武士 / 侍 (samurai)       | 拙者 / 我輩   | 〜でござる / 〜なり          | 〜申す, かたじけない, archaic verbs                  |
| 田舎者 (country bumpkin)  | おら / おいら  | 〜だべ / 〜ずら / 〜だっぺ     | A composite fake dialect — no single rea    |
| 関西人キャラ (Kansai)        | うち / わて   | 〜や / 〜やで / 〜やん / 〜へん | ほんま, あかん, なんてやねん — comed                    |
| 男の子 / 女の子              | 僕・俺 / あたし | 〜だ・〜ぜ / 〜わ・〜かしら      | Boys assertive; girls softer, more final pa |
| オネエ言葉                  | あたし       | 〜のよ / 〜じゃない          | Exaggerated women's language layered        |

## The Stereotypes Worth Flagging

Role language is built from stereotypes, and a few have aged badly. Knowing them is part of media literacy — but treat them as history, not models.

- へアル / 中華キャラ (the "Chinese" voice): Comes from 協和語 (kyōwa-go), a broken Japanese associated with the colonial Manchukuo era. It's now widely recognized as an ethnic caricature. Understand it when you meet it in old media; never imitate it.
- 女言葉 (へわ / へかしら / へのよ): Today this is largely a fictional and older-generation convention. Most Japanese women under ~50 don't actually speak this way — but anime heroines and subtitles keep it alive, which can mislead learners into thinking it's standard "female Japanese." It isn't.
- オネエ言葉: A performed, exaggerated register — not an accurate representation of how LGBTQ+ people actually speak.

## Bonus: Furigana Wordplay (義訓 / ルビ表現)

Manga has a second trick for character and emotion: making the furigana say something different from the kanji. The kanji carries the literal/written meaning; the small reading above carries what's spoken or felt. You read both at once.

| Written | Furigana                  | Literal meaning      | The effect                                     |
|---------|---------------------------|----------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| 本気      | マジ (maji)                 | "seriousness"        | Formal kanji, slangy spoken voice — at the sa  |
| 機械鎧     | オートメール (Automail)         | "machine armor"      | English ruby names the prosthetic (Fullmetal A |
| 負けて死ね   | バイツァ・ダスト (Bites the Dust) | "lose and die"       | Kanji = the lethal command; English = the Que  |
| 親友      | ライバル (rival)              | "close friend"       | Contrasting ruby compresses a whole relation   |
| 永遠      | とわ                        | "eternity" (vs えいえん) | A softer, more poetic reading                  |

This is the creative extreme of 義訓 (gikun) — improvised, meaning-based readings. (Compare the fixed, dictionary versions: 梅雨 = つゆ, 大人 = おとな.) More on this, plus sound effects and silence (シーン), in the Manga Reader track.

Role language is one of the most fun things to notice once you know it's there. Every time a character opens their mouth, listen for the costume.

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## Politeness Levels — The System That Runs Everything

"In English you might speak differently to your boss vs. your friends. In Japanese, those differences are baked into the grammar itself. Get the level wrong and you're either rude or robotic."

Politeness in Japanese isn't just about choosing nice words — it's a grammatical system. Verb forms change. Vocabulary changes. Even which word you use for "I" or "you" signals your social register. Understanding this system is essential to sounding natural in any Japanese environment.

### Why This System Exists

Japanese society has historically organized itself around relationships: insider/outsider (内/外 — uchi/soto), senior/junior (先輩/後輩 — senpai/kōhai), and social hierarchy. The language evolved to encode these relationships directly.

Crucially, the appropriate level depends on the relationship, not just the situation. You might use casual Japanese in a formal place (talking to a close friend at a fancy restaurant) or polite Japanese in an informal place (talking to an unfamiliar person at a festival).

The key factors:

1. Familiarity — How well do you know this person?
  2. Social hierarchy — Are they senior/junior to you?
  3. Group membership — Are they inside your group (uchi) or outside (soto)?
  4. Context — Is this a professional, social, or personal situation?
- 

## The Three Major Levels

Level 1: Casual / Informal (タメ語 — tamego)

Used with: Close friends, family members, people younger than you in casual settings, pets

- Verbs in plain form (行く、食べる、来る)
- Copula: だ instead of です
- Particles often dropped
- Contractions common (〜てる、〜ちゃう)
- First-person pronoun: 俺 (ore) for males, うち (uchi) / あたし (atashi) for females, or just drop it entirely

Level 2: Polite / Standard (丁寧語 — teinego)

Used with: Strangers, acquaintances, people you've just met, in service contexts, mild professional settings

- Verbs in masu-form (行きます、食べます、来ます)
- Copula: です
- Particles mostly present
- First-person: 私 (watashi)

This is the level taught in most Japanese textbooks. It's the safe default for any new relationship.

Level 3: Honorific / Formal (敬語 — keigo)

Used with: Superiors, clients, important guests, formal occasions, elderly people, people you respect highly

- Special vocabulary (行く → いらっしゃる、言う → おっしゃる、食べる → 召し上がる)
- Complex auxiliary constructions (〜でいらっしゃる、〜ていただく)
- Much longer sentences
- First-person: 私 (watashi) or 弊社 (heisha — "our humble company") in business

Keigo is a system within itself — covered in detail in Honorific Japanese →.

---

## Quick Reference: Same Concept, Three Levels

| Concept        | Casual   | Polite      | Honorific |
|----------------|----------|-------------|-----------|
| I              | 俺/あたし/オレ | 私 (watashi) | 私 / 弊社    |
| You            | あなた / お前 | あなた / ーさん   | ー様 / 御社   |
| To be (person) | いる       | います         | いらっしゃいます  |
| To eat         | 食べる      | 食べます        | 召し上がります   |
| To go          | 行く       | 行きます        | いらっしゃいます  |
| To say         | 言う       | 言います        | おっしゃいます   |
| To come        | 来る       | 来ます         | いらっしゃいます  |
| To know        | 知ってる     | 知っています      | ご存知です     |

| Concept        | Casual | Polite     | Honorific         |
|----------------|--------|------------|-------------------|
| To receive     | もらう    | もらいます      | いただきます            |
| To give (up)   | あげる    | 差し上げます     | —                 |
| To give (down) | くれる    | くださいます     | —                 |
| Thank you      | ありがとう  | ありがとうございます | ありがとうございます (same) |
| Sorry          | ごめん    | すみません      | 申し訳ございません         |

## The "I" Problem

Japanese has many first-person pronouns. The one you use says a lot:

| Pronoun         | Who uses it                  | Impression                           |
|-----------------|------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| 私 (watashi)     | Everyone, polite             | Standard, neutral                    |
| 僕 (boku)        | Males, soft/gentle           | Boyish, somewhat humble              |
| 俺 (ore)         | Males, casual                | Masculine, direct, casual            |
| 俺様 (ore-sama)   | Arrogant characters in manga | "I, the magnificent" — never sincere |
| うち (uchi)       | Females (esp. Kansai)        | Casual, regional                     |
| あたし (atashi)    | Females, casual              | Soft, feminine                       |
| あたくし (atakushi) | Very formal, older females   | Ultra-formal, elegant                |
| 自分 (jibun)      | Military / masculine / Osaka | "Myself" — contextual                |
| わし (washi)      | Older males / dialect        | Aged, regional feel                  |
| 我が (waga)       | Written/formal               | "Our ~" — 我が国 = "our nation"         |

## The "You" Problem (Avoid あなた)

This surprises many learners: あなた (anata) is awkward in most real-world contexts. Using it directly to address someone sounds either distant, confrontational, or like a soap opera.

What Japanese people actually say:

| Situation             | What to use                     | Example         |
|-----------------------|---------------------------------|-----------------|
| Addressing someone    | Use their name + さん             | 田中さんは...?       |
| Addressing a superior | Their title                     | 先生は... / 部長は... |
| To a close partner    | あなた (affectionate, traditional) | まあ、あなた...       |
| Writing/lyrics        | あなた (poetic, fine in text)      | あなたを愛してる        |
| In a group            | 皆さん (mina-san)                  | 皆さんはどうですか?      |

When in doubt: use their name. Always.

## The Uchi/Soto Dimension (内/外)

This is one of the most important cultural concepts behind politeness:

- 内 (uchi) = inside / my group (family, close friends, your company)
- 外 (soto) = outside / other groups (strangers, other companies, society)

The rule: elevate outsiders, humble your insiders.

This means when talking to someone from another company about your own colleague:

「田中は只今席を外しております。」 "Tanaka is currently away from his desk." (No **さん** for Tanaka — he's **uchi**, so you humble him)

But when talking about the same colleague to him directly:

「田中さん、お客様がいらっしゃいました。」 "Tanaka-san, a customer has arrived." (**さん** returns because now you're speaking **TO** him, not **ABOUT** him to an outsider)

This dimension is what trips up learners most: the same person gets different treatment depending on who's listening.

---

## Social Situations and Their Default Levels

| Situation                                | Default level  | Notes                                                              |
|------------------------------------------|----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Meeting someone for the first time       | Polite (丁寧語)   | Always start polite, let the other person signal a shift to casual |
| At a convenience store                   | Polite         | Basic politeness expected                                          |
| With close friends                       | Casual         | Staying formal with close friends is awkward and distancing        |
| With your boss                           | Polite → Keigo | Depends on company culture                                         |
| With a client                            | Keigo          | Non-negotiable in business                                         |
| In a job interview                       | Keigo          | Use it throughout                                                  |
| Sending a work email                     | Polite → Keigo | Formal written style                                               |
| On social media                          | Casual         | Personal accounts are casual; business accounts are polite         |
| Talking to elderly people you don't know | Polite         | Respectful default                                                 |
| In a group with mixed familiarity        | Polite         | Accommodate the least familiar person                              |

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## When Levels Get Mixed Up: The Consequences

Getting the level wrong has real social consequences:

Too casual too soon: Rude, presumptuous, especially with seniors or in professional settings. Creates immediate awkwardness.

Too formal with close friends: Creates distance, feels cold or sarcastic. Like responding to "you coming out tonight?" with "I am unable to attend this evening."

Using keigo incorrectly: Can actually be worse than not using it — garbled keigo sounds condescending or bizarre. If you're not sure, polite (丁寧語) is always acceptable.

The good news: Japanese people are generally very forgiving of foreign speakers' level mistakes. A sincere attempt matters more than perfection.

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## Code-Switching: How Japanese People Do It

Native speakers shift levels seamlessly mid-conversation. They might:

- Use casual Japanese chatting with a coworker at lunch
- Switch to polite as soon as a manager walks up
- Use full keigo when the client calls

- Switch back to casual in a message to the same coworker five minutes later

This code-switching is natural, constant, and doesn't feel like effort to natives. For learners, the goal isn't to always be in the right register — it's to gradually develop sensitivity to which register the situation calls for.

Next up: Casual Japanese → | Polite Japanese → | Honorific Japanese →

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## Casual Japanese — How Friends Actually Talk

"Textbook Japanese is a suit. Casual Japanese is what you actually wear. You'll spend most of your life in one of them."

Casual Japanese (タメ語 — tamego, or くれた話し方) is what Japanese people speak with close friends, family, and anyone they're genuinely comfortable around. It's fast, contracted, particle-light, and often doesn't bother finishing sentences.

Mastering it takes time — but even recognizing it will transform your comprehension of anime, drama, and real conversation.

### The Core Shifts from Polite to Casual

#### 1. Drop the ます / です

| Polite | Casual        |
|--------|---------------|
| 行きます   | 行く            |
| 食べます   | 食べる           |
| 来ます    | 来る            |
| します    | する            |
| そうです   | そう / そうだ      |
| 大丈夫です  | 大丈夫 / 大丈夫だ    |
| 分かりません | 分からない / 分かんない |

#### 2. Drop Particles

| Full sentence | Casual version |
|---------------|----------------|
| 学校に行く         | 学校行く           |
| これを食べる        | これ食べる          |
| 明日は暇ですか？      | 明日暇？           |
| どこへ行くの？       | どこ行くの？         |

#### 3. Contract Verbs

| Polite/Plain | Casual contracted | Meaning        |
|--------------|-------------------|----------------|
| 〜ている         | 〜てる               | ongoing action |
| 〜ていた         | 〜てた               | was doing      |
| 〜てしまう        | 〜ちゃう              | end up doing   |
| 〜てしまった       | 〜ちゃった             | ended up doing |

| Polite/Plain | Casual contracted | Meaning                 |
|--------------|-------------------|-------------------------|
| 〜ておく         | 〜とく               | do in advance           |
| 〜てしまえ        | 〜ちゃえ              | just go ahead and do it |
| 〜なければいけない    | 〜なきゃ / 〜なくちゃ      | have to do              |
| 〜なければならない    | 〜なきゃいけない          | have to do              |

## Sentence Endings That Carry Meaning

Sentence-final particles and endings shape the entire tone of casual speech:

| Ending     | Gender lean            | Meaning                                               |
|------------|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| 〜ね         | Neutral                | Seeking agreement / "right?"                          |
| 〜よ         | Neutral                | Asserting, informing — "you know"                     |
| 〜ぞ         | Male                   | Strong assertion — "I'm telling you"                  |
| 〜ぜ         | Male                   | Casual assertion / emphasis                           |
| 〜わ         | Female                 | Soft emphasis (Kansai also uses for strong assertion) |
| 〜の         | Neutral (often female) | Seeking explanation / softener                        |
| 〜な         | Male / Kansai          | Agreement / thinking out loud                         |
| 〜かな        | Neutral                | "I wonder..."                                         |
| 〜じゃん       | Neutral (youth)        | "Isn't it? / Clearly, right?"                         |
| 〜もん / 〜もの  | Female / child-like    | "Because..." (pouting/justifying)                     |
| 〜っけ        | Neutral                | Trying to remember: "wasn't it...?"                   |
| 〜よな / 〜だよな | Male                   | Strong agreement-seeking                              |
| 〜だっけ?      | Neutral                | "Was it...? / Remind me..."                           |

## Common Casual Expressions

### Affirmatives

| Expression | Meaning                     |
|------------|-----------------------------|
| うん         | Yeah                        |
| そうそう       | Yeah exactly / That's right |
| だよな!       | Right?! Exactly!            |
| まじで        | Seriously? / For real       |
| 確かに        | That's true / Fair point    |
| ほんとに?      | Really?                     |
| そうなんだ      | Oh is that so               |
| あー、なるほど    | Ah, I see                   |

### Negatives / Refusals

| Expression | Meaning                   |
|------------|---------------------------|
| ちよっと...    | That's a bit... (soft no) |
| むり         | No way / impossible       |

| Expression | Meaning                        |
|------------|--------------------------------|
| やだ / いやだ   | No / I don't want to           |
| どうかな...    | I'm not sure...                |
| うーん...     | Hmm... (considering, maybe no) |

## Reactions

| Expression | Meaning                               |
|------------|---------------------------------------|
| え！？        | What?! (surprise)                     |
| うそ！        | No way! / You're kidding!             |
| マジか！       | Seriously?!                           |
| すごい！       | Amazing!                              |
| やばい！       | Crazy! / Whoa! (positive or negative) |
| さすが！       | As expected / Impressive              |
| かわいいー！     | So cute!                              |
| 最高！        | The best!                             |
| ウケる        | That's hilarious                      |

## Casual Questions

Questions in casual speech don't need か — intonation does the work:

| Casual question | Meaning                                              |
|-----------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| 行く？             | You going?                                           |
| 何してる？           | What are you doing? / What are you up to?            |
| どうした？           | What happened? / You okay?                           |
| 大丈夫？            | You alright?                                         |
| どうだった？          | How was it?                                          |
| 何食べたい？          | What do you want to eat?                             |
| 一緒に行かない？        | Want to come along? (negative question = invitation) |
| これ知ってる？         | You know this? / Have you seen this?                 |

## The Art of the Incomplete Sentence

Japanese allows sentences to trail off with just a particle, leaving the meaning implied:

| Said    | Unsaid   | Full meaning                               |
|---------|----------|--------------------------------------------|
| ちょっと... | 難しいです    | That's a bit... [difficult]                |
| 行けたら... | 行きます     | If I can make it... [I'll go]              |
| それって... | 変じゃない？   | That's kind of... [weird, isn't it?]       |
| 実は...   | 言にくいんだけど | The thing is... [this is hard to say]      |
| でも...   |          | But... [I don't agree / there's a problem] |

Trailing off is a social skill in Japanese. It lets you say something without committing to it — giving the listener room to offer an out. Learning to read the implied meaning is part of learning the language.



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## How to Invite, Accept, and Decline Casually

### Inviting

今夜飲みに行かない？ (Tonight, want to go for drinks? — negative question = casual invitation)

明日ヒマ？一緒にどこか行こうよ。 (Free tomorrow? Let's go somewhere together.)

### Accepting

いいね！行こう！ (Sounds good! Let's go!)

まじ？行く行く！ (Really? Definitely coming!)

### Declining (the art of the soft no)

ちょっとその日は... (That day is a bit... [busy/not great])

今日はちょっと体調が悪くて... (Today I'm feeling a bit under the weather...)

次回ぜひ！ (Next time for sure!)

The key: you almost never say a flat "no" directly in Japanese. Give a vague excuse and trail off. The listener understands.

---

## Casual Japanese by Context

### With Close Friends (砕けた)

A: ねえ、今日何する？ B: うーん、別に何も。映画でも見る？ A: いいじゃん！何がいい？ B: ホラーとか見たくない？ A: えー、怖いのが苦手だよ。 B: じゃ、アクションにしよ。

(Hey, what are you doing today? / Hmm, nothing in particular. Watch a movie? / Sounds good! What do you want to see? / Don't you want to watch horror? / Eh~, I'm bad with scary stuff. / Then let's go with action.)

### With Younger Siblings / Kids

#### Casual but often instructive:

ご飯食べたの？ (Did you eat?) もうお風呂入りなよ。 (Go take a bath already.)

### SNS / Chat

#### Maximum abbreviation and minimal politeness with peers:

おはよー！今日学校？ (Morning~! School today?) 無理、眠すぎ (Can't, too sleepy)

---

## Things to Watch Out For

### Casual Can Flip to Rude Fast

The same sentence can be rude or friendly based on tone and relationship:

何してんの？ (What are you doing?) — affectionate with a friend, accusatory to a stranger

### Don't Be Too Casual Too Soon

In Japan, relationships typically require a "warming period" before casual speech is appropriate. Using casual speech with someone you just met can come across as arrogant or disrespectful — especially with older people.

General rule: Follow the other person's lead. If they shift to casual, you can follow. Don't initiate the shift unless you're clearly both on the same level.

あの... and えっと...

These are absolutely normal filler words. Using them makes you sound more natural, not less confident.

---

## Casual Speech for Different Ages

Japan's casual speech isn't monolithic — teenagers, young adults, middle-aged people, and elderly people all use different casual vocabulary:

| Age group | Distinctive casual features                                 |
|-----------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| Teens     | Heavy use of slang, ヤ/バい, ぎつい, エモい, ぴえん                     |
| 20s–30s   | Moderate slang, LINE-influenced, some 2ch vocabulary        |
| 40s–50s   | More traditional casual forms, fewer recent slang           |
| 60s+      | Regional dialect features, older vocabulary, もの/のだ patterns |

Next up: Polite Japanese →

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## Polite Japanese — The Everyday Standard

"です/ます form is like saying 'please' and 'thank you.' It's the baseline of civilized interaction with anyone who isn't your best friend."

Polite Japanese (丁寧語 — teinego, or ですます体) is the default register for almost all public-facing interaction in Japan. It's what shop staff use with you, what you use with strangers, what coworkers use when they first meet, and what textbooks spend most of their time teaching.

If casual Japanese is the t-shirt, polite Japanese is the business casual — appropriate nearly everywhere, never wrong.

## The Core Forms

Verbs: The **ます** Form

The polite present/future is made by replacing the verb's plain form ending with **ます**:

| Plain form   | ます form            | Meaning |
|--------------|--------------------|---------|
| 行く (iku)     | 行きます (ikimasu)     | go      |
| 食べる (taberu) | 食べます (tabemasu)    | eat     |
| 飲む (nomu)    | 飲みます (nomimasu)    | drink   |
| 来る (kuru)    | 来ます (kimasu)       | come    |
| する (suru)    | します (shimasu)      | do      |
| 話す (hanasu)  | 話します (hanashimasu) | speak   |
| 見る (miru)    | 見ます (mimasu)       | see     |
| 読む (yomu)    | 読みます (yomimasu)    | read    |
| 書く (kaku)    | 書きます (kakimasu)    | write   |

### Full Conjugation Table (ます Form)

| Tense / Mood            | Form    | Example                          |
|-------------------------|---------|----------------------------------|
| Present/future positive | ～ます     | 食べます                             |
| Present/future negative | ～ません    | 食べません                            |
| Past positive           | ～ました    | 食べました                            |
| Past negative           | ～ませんでした | 食べませんでした                         |
| Volitional ("let's")    | ～ましょう   | 食べましょう                           |
| Invitation / suggestion | ～ませんか？  | 食べませんか？ (Would you like to eat?) |
| Request                 | ～てください  | 食べてください                          |

The Copula: **です**

| Form             | Japanese                       |
|------------------|--------------------------------|
| Present positive | です                             |
| Present negative | じゃないです / ではありません (more formal) |
| Past positive    | でした                            |
| Past negative    | じゃなかったです / ではありませんでした          |

## Standard Polite Phrases for Every Situation

### Introductions

はじめまして。田中と申します。どうぞよろしくお願ひします。(Hajimemashite. Tanaka to mōshimasu. Dōzo yoroshiku onegaishimasu.) Nice to meet you. My name is Tanaka. I look forward to getting to know you.

こちらこそよろしくお願ひします。(Kochira koso yoroshiku onegaishimasu.) Likewise, the pleasure is mine.

## Making Requests

～をお願いできますか？ (～ wo onegai dekimasu ka?) Would you be able to ~?

～していただけますか？ (～ shite itadakemasen ka?) Would you please ~? (polite-leaning toward keigo)

～てください。 (～ te kudasai.) Please ~. (standard polite request)

## Offering and Receiving

どうぞ。 (Dōzo.) Please, go ahead. / Here you are.

ありがとうございます。 (Arigatō gozaimasu.) Thank you very much.

いただきます。 / ごちそうさまでした。 (Itadakimasu. / Gochisōsama deshita.) Thank you for the meal (before / after eating).

## Apologies

申し訳ありません。 (Mōshiwake arimasen.) I'm very sorry. (Stronger than すみません)

ご迷惑をおかけしました。 (Gomeiwaku wo okake shimashita.) I'm sorry for the trouble I've caused.

失礼いたしました。 (Shitsurei itashimashita.) Excuse me for my rudeness. (Formal apology for a minor breach)

## Polite Vocabulary Swaps

Some words have a polite counterpart that you use when speaking politely about or to others:

| Casual/neutral | Polite version | Meaning           |
|----------------|----------------|-------------------|
| 家 (ie/uchi)    | お宅 (otaku)     | house / home      |
| 名前 (namae)     | お名前 (onamae)   | name              |
| 弁当 (bentō)     | お弁当 (obentō)   | lunchbox          |
| 金 (kane)       | お金 (okane)     | money             |
| 茶 (cha)        | お茶 (ocha)      | tea               |
| 腹 (hara)       | お腹 (onaka)     | stomach           |
| 酒 (sake)       | お酒 (osake)     | alcohol           |
| 見舞い (mimai)    | お見舞い (omimai)  | visiting the sick |
| 祝い (iwai)      | お祝い (oiwai)    | celebration/gift  |
| 礼 (rei)        | お礼 (orei)      | thanks/gratitude  |

The お (o-) or ご (go-) prefix adds a layer of politeness. It's used:

- With words relating to the other person
- With words relating to shared experiences (meals, events)
- NOT typically with foreign loanwords (おコーヒー sounds odd; コーヒー is fine)

## Asking Politely vs. Casually

The same request in three styles:

"Could you show me this?"

| Level       | Japanese        | Notes                     |
|-------------|-----------------|---------------------------|
| Casual      | 見せて             | Just the te-form — direct |
| Polite      | 見せてください         | Standard polite           |
| More polite | 見せていただけますか？     | Bordered on keigo         |
| Keigo       | お見せいただけますでしょうか？ | Full keigo                |

## Polite Telephone Japanese

Phone calls in Japanese have specific conventions:

Answering the phone (private):

はい、田中です。(Hai, Tanaka desu.) Yes, this is Tanaka.

Answering the phone (business):

お電話ありがとうございます。〇〇会社でございます。(Odenwa arigatō gozaimasu. 〇〇 kaisha de gozaimasu.) Thank you for calling. This is 〇〇 Company.

Asking for someone:

〇〇さんはいらっしゃいますか？(〇〇-san wa irasshaimasu ka?) Is 〇〇 there?

Saying you'll call back:

後ほどまたご連絡いたします。(Nochihodo mata go-renraku itashimasu.) I'll contact you again later.

## Polite Written Japanese (Emails & Letters)

Written polite Japanese has set phrases for openings and closings:

### Email Opening Phrases

| Phrase          | Use                                                               |
|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| お世話になっております。    | "Thank you for your continued support" — standard business opener |
| いつもお世話になっております。 | "Always thank you for your support" — the most common opener      |
| 突然のご連絡失礼いたします。  | "I apologize for this sudden contact" — cold outreach             |
| ご無沙汰しております。     | "It's been a while" — reconnecting with someone                   |

### Email Closing Phrases

| Phrase       | Meaning                                 |
|--------------|-----------------------------------------|
| よろしく願いいたします。 | Please take care of this / Best regards |

| Phrase            | Meaning                      |
|-------------------|------------------------------|
| ご確認よろしくお願いいたします。  | Please review / Kindly check |
| 引き続きよろしくお願いいたします。 | Continued regards            |
| お返事お待ちしております。     | I look forward to your reply |

### Letter Opening Phrases (very formal)

拝啓 時下ますますご清祥のことと存じます。(Haikei. Jika masumasu go-seishō no koto to zonjimasu.) Dear [recipient], I trust this letter finds you in good health.

This level of formality is used in official letters, wedding invitations, and legal correspondence. In everyday email, start with お世話になっております and you'll be fine.

### Polite Refusals

Japanese polite refusals almost never involve saying a direct "no." Instead:

| Refusal style            | Example         | Translation                                |
|--------------------------|-----------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Trailing negative        | ちょっと難しくて...     | It's a bit difficult...                    |
| Expressing difficulty    | なかなか難しい状況でして... | The situation makes it rather difficult... |
| Expressing consideration | 検討してみます。        | I'll think about it. (Often means no)      |
| Redirecting              | また次の機会に。        | Perhaps another time.                      |
| Expressing regret        | あいにく〜でして...     | Unfortunately, ~                           |

The silence after a trailing off is an answer. Don't press for clarification — that's considered rude.

### Polite Japanese in Service Contexts

Japan's service industry uses an ultra-polite sub-dialect called 丁寧語 (teinego) at its most elevated — a few degrees below full keigo:

いらっしゃいませ！(Irasshaimase!) Welcome! (Staff greeting — you don't need to respond)

こちらへどうぞ。(Kochira e dōzo.) This way, please.

ただいまご案内いたします。(Tadaima go-annai itashimasu.) I'll guide you right away.

少々お待ちくださいませ。(Shōshō omachi kudasaimase.) Please wait just a moment.

ご注文はお決まりでしょうか？(Go-chūmon wa okimari deshō ka?) Have you decided on your order?

ありがとうございました。またのお越しをお待ちしております。(Arigatō gozaimashita. Mata no okoshi wo omachi shite orimasu.) Thank you very much. We look forward to your next visit.

### Moving Between Polite and Casual

The shift from polite to casual usually happens gradually as a relationship develops. Signs that someone is inviting a shift:

- They start dropping です/ます themselves
- They ask "タメ語でいいよ" (You can talk casually)
- They're clearly your age or younger and relaxed
- The conversation has moved to very personal topics

When in doubt: stay polite. You can never offend someone by being too polite.

Next up: Honorific Japanese →

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## Honorific Japanese — 敬語 (Keigo)

"Keigo is where Japanese stops being a language and becomes a performance. Master it and you'll command rooms. Fumble it and you'll apologize profusely — also in keigo."

敬語 (keigo) is the Japanese system of honorific speech. It's not just "being polite" — it's a grammatically distinct system that encodes the social relationship between speaker, listener, and subject into every verb and noun. It's essential in business, required in formal settings, and a mark of cultural sophistication.

### The Three Pillars of Keigo

Keigo has three sub-systems that often work together:

| System | Name     | Direction                        | Purpose                   |
|--------|----------|----------------------------------|---------------------------|
| 尊敬語    | Sonkeigo | Elevates the OTHER person        | "What you do is elevated" |
| 謙讓語    | Kenjōgo  | Humbles YOURSELF (or your group) | "What I do is humble"     |
| 丁寧語    | Teinego  | Adds general politeness          | The です/ます system          |

The first two are the heart of keigo. They work as a pair:

When your boss does something → use 尊敬語 (elevate their action) When you do something for your boss → use 謙讓語 (humble your action)

### 尊敬語 — Sonkeigo (Elevating Others)

#### Special Sonkeigo Verbs

These replace everyday verbs when describing what a superior does:

| Plain verb | Meaning      | Sonkeigo form | Meaning              |
|------------|--------------|---------------|----------------------|
| いる         | be (person)  | いらっしゃる        | to be (honorific)    |
| 行く         | go           | いらっしゃる        | to go (honorific)    |
| 来る         | come         | いらっしゃる        | to come (honorific)  |
| 食べる        | eat          | 召し上がる         | to eat (honorific)   |
| 飲む         | drink        | 召し上がる         | to drink (honorific) |
| 言う         | say          | おっしゃる         | to say (honorific)   |
| する         | do           | なさる           | to do (honorific)    |
| 知っている      | know         | ご存知だ          | to know (honorific)  |
| くれる        | give (to me) | くださる          | to give (honorific)  |

| Plain verb | Meaning | Sonkeigo form | Meaning                                      |
|------------|---------|---------------|----------------------------------------------|
| もらう        | receive | いただく          | to receive (humble — used in keigo contexts) |
| 見る         | see     | ご覧になる         | to see (honorific)                           |
| 読む         | read    | お読みになる        | to read (honorific)                          |
| 思う         | think   | お思いになる        | to think (honorific)                         |

Note: いらっしゃる handles three verbs (いる、行く、来る). Context determines which.

### The お〜になる Construction

For verbs without a special sonkeigo form, use: お + verb stem + になる

| Verb             | Sonkeigo construction |
|------------------|-----------------------|
| 待つ (wait)        | お待ちになる                |
| 帰る (return home) | お帰りになる                |
| 使う (use)         | お使いになる                |
| 書く (write)       | お書きになる                |
| 持つ (hold)        | お持ちになる                |

Example:

社長はもうお帰りになりました。 The president has already returned home.

## 謙譲語 — Kenjōgo (Humbling Yourself)

### Special Kenjōgo Verbs

These replace everyday verbs when describing what YOU or your group does toward a superior:

| Plain verb | Meaning       | Kenjōgo form  |
|------------|---------------|---------------|
| いる         | be (person)   | おる            |
| 行く         | go            | 参る (mairu)    |
| 来る         | come          | 参る (mairu)    |
| 食べる / 飲む   | eat / drink   | いただく          |
| 言う         | say           | 申す (mōsu)     |
| する         | do            | いたす           |
| もらう        | receive       | いただく          |
| あげる        | give (upward) | 差し上げる (さしあげる) |
| 知っている      | know          | 存じる / 存じ上げる   |
| 見る         | see           | 拝見する (はいけんする) |
| 読む         | read          | 拝読する (はいどくする) |
| もらう        | receive       | いただく          |
| 聞く         | ask / listen  | 伺う (うかがう)     |
| 訪ねる        | visit         | 伺う (うかがう)     |
| 思う         | think         | 存じます (ぞんじます)  |

Examples:

明日、御社に伺います。 (Ashita, onsha ni ukagaimasu.) I will visit your company tomorrow.



先ほど田中様よりご連絡をいただきました。(Sakihodo Tanaka-sama yori go-renraku wo itadakimashita.) I received a message from Tanaka-sama just now.

## 丁寧語 — Teinego (General Politeness)

This is the です/ます system from Polite Japanese, elevated further:

| Standard polite | Elevated teinego                             |
|-----------------|----------------------------------------------|
| です              | でございます                                       |
| あります            | ございます                                        |
| ありがとうございます      | ありがとうございます (same, but said with full weight) |
| すみません           | 失礼いたします / 申し訳ございません                          |
| 分かりました          | かしこまりました / 承知いたしました                          |

かしこまりました vs. 承知いたしました

Both mean "understood" / "I will take care of that" — but:

- かしこまりました — extremely formal, used in high-end service (luxury hotels, department stores)
- 承知いたしました — formal business Japanese, used in offices and professional emails

Neither sounds odd in context. Both sound far more professional than ただ了解です (which is casual and considered slightly abrupt in business).

## Keigo Vocabulary Pairs

Many nouns also have honorific / humble versions:

| Neutral           | Honorific (for others) | Humble (for yourself)          |
|-------------------|------------------------|--------------------------------|
| 名前 (name)         | お名前                    | 私の名前は                          |
| 会社 (company)      | 御社 (おんしゃ)              | 弊社 (へいしゃ)                      |
| 人 (person)        | お方 (おかた)               | 者 (もの)                         |
| 家 (house/home)    | お宅                     | 自宅                             |
| 意見 (opinion)      | ご意見                    | 私見                             |
| 挨拶 (greeting)     | ご挨拶                    | ご挨拶 (same)                     |
| 連絡 (contact)      | ご連絡                    | ご連絡 (same form, humble intent) |
| 確認 (confirmation) | ご確認                    | 確認 / ご確認                       |
| 説明 (explanation)  | ご説明                    | ご説明                            |
| 報告 (report)       | ご報告                    | ご報告                            |

御社 vs. 弊社: Always use 御社 (onsha) for the OTHER company. Always use 弊社 (heisha) for YOUR company. Getting these backwards is a significant error in business Japanese.

## Keigo in Real Situations

Business Phone Call

お電話ありがとうございます。株式会社〇〇でございます。(Odenwa arigatō gozaimasu. Kabushiki kaisha 〇〇 de gozaimasu.) Thank you for calling. This is 〇〇 Inc.

少々お待ちいただけますでしょうか。(Shōshō omachi itadakemasu deshō ka?) Could you please hold for just a moment?

田中はただいま席を外しております。(Tanaka wa tadaima seki wo hazushite orimasu.) Tanaka is currently away from his desk. (Note: No さん for Tanaka — he's uchi, and you're humbling him to the outside caller)

折り返しご連絡させていただきます。(Orikaeshi go-renraku sasete itadakimasu.) I will have him return your call.

#### Business Email (Full Template)

件名：〇〇のご確認について

〇〇株式会社  
〇〇部 〇〇様

お世話になっております。  
株式会社〇〇の田中でございます。

先日はお時間をいただきありがとうございました。  
早速ではございますが、ご確認いただきたい件がございます。

[本文]

ご不明な点がございましたら、どうぞお気軽にご連絡ください。  
引き続きよろしくお願いいたします。

〇〇株式会社  
田中 太郎

#### Meeting Phrases

ご説明いただけますでしょうか。 Could you please explain that?

おっしゃる通りでございます。 Exactly as you say / I agree completely.

検討させていただきます。 We will consider it. (Often means "we'll think about a polite way to say no")

おかげさまで順調に進んでおります。 Thanks to you, things are proceeding smoothly.

---

### The Keigo Mistakes That Reveal a Learner

#### Mistake 1: Using Keigo for Your Own Group to an Outsider

田中様はいらっしゃいます。(Elevating your own colleague to an outside party) 田中はおります。  
(Humbling your colleague when speaking to outsiders)

#### Mistake 2: Double Keigo (二重敬語)

Using two levels of honorific simultaneously:

おっしゃられました (おっしゃる already sonkeigo; adding られ is redundant/incorrect)  
おっしゃいました

### Mistake 3: Using いただく for Third-Party Actions

社長がいただきます (いただく is YOUR humble receiving verb, not for the president)  
社長が召し上がります (use sonkeigo for the president's actions)

### Mistake 4: ご〜する vs お〜する

- Chinese-origin words use ご: ご確認、ご連絡、ご説明
- Japanese-origin words use お: お知らせ、お待ち、お届け
- Exceptions exist — learn them case by case

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## The Double Humble Construction: させていただく

This construction — literally “allow me to humbly do X” — is extremely common in modern Japanese keigo and deserves special attention:

確認させていただきます。(Kakunin sasete itadakimasu.) Allow me to confirm that. / I will confirm that.

出席させていただきます。I will humbly attend.

休業させていただきます。We will be closed. (Literally: we humbly allow ourselves to be closed)

It's everywhere — perhaps overused in modern Japanese, but entirely expected in business settings. Using it signals consideration for the listener.

---

## Summary: Which Keigo Form to Use?

| Who is acting?    | Action toward whom?      | Use            |
|-------------------|--------------------------|----------------|
| Superior / client | —                        | 尊敬語            |
| You               | Toward superior / client | 謙譲語            |
| Colleague (uchi)  | — mentioned to outsider  | 謙譲語 (humbling) |
| You               | General polite statement | 丁寧語 (でございます)   |

When in doubt: if they're doing it, elevate. If you're doing it, humble.

Next: Culture & Norms →

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## Modern & “Manual” Keigo — バイト敬語 and the Living Politeness System

“Walk into any convenience store and you'll hear keigo that grammar textbooks call wrong — and language purists complain about in newspaper columns. But it's everywhere, every day. Politeness is evolving in real time, and the konbini counter is the front line.”

The Honorific Japanese page covers 敬語 as the textbook teaches it. This page covers what actually comes out of cash-register staff's mouths: バイト敬語 (baito keigo), also called マニュアル敬語 or コンビニ敬語 — the polite forms that spread through service-industry training manuals in the late 1990s–2000s.

Some of it is "incorrect" by traditional rules. Some of it has a defensible internal logic that linguists actually argue about. Either way, you will hear all of it constantly — so the priority is to recognize it, then decide what to say yourself.

Why this matters for learners: Textbooks teach you to produce correct keigo. They rarely teach you to understand the slightly-off keigo you'll hear 20 times a day. This page fills that gap — and shows the "correct" alternative for each.

## The Classic "Wrong" Phrases

For each: what you'll hear, why purists object, and what they'd prefer instead.

| You'll hear      | Reading            | The objection                                                          |
|------------------|--------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| お皿のほう、お下げします     | ...no hō...        | のほう normally marks a direction or a contrast between options —         |
| こちら、コーヒーになります    | ...ni narimasu     | なる = "to become." The coffee isn't transforming — it already is coffee |
| 1000円からお預かりします   | 1000-en kara...    | から marks a range start. The clerk receives the whole note, not "part"  |
| 1000円ちょうどお預かりします | ...chōdo...        | お預かりする implies returning change. If it's exact, nothing is returned    |
| ご注文はよろしかったでしょうか  | ...yoroshikatta... | Past tense (かった) to confirm a present order — a tense mismatch         |
| お会計のほう、1万円になります  | —                  | Stacks both errors: contrast-less のほう and the なる misuse                |

The catch: several of these aren't as clearly "wrong" as purists claim. ーになります legitimately means "amounts to" (合計1000円になります, for a computed total, is fine). よろしかったでしょうか may come from Hokkaidō/Tōhoku dialect, where a past form adds politeness by softening responsibility. Language isn't always on the prescriptivists' side — which is exactly why these forms survive.

## 二重敬語 — Double Keigo

This is the opposite failure mode: being too polite by stacking two honorifics of the same type on one verb. The 文化庁 (Agency for Cultural Affairs) flags most of these as errors — though it notes a few have become conventionally accepted (お召し上がりになる is fine).

| You'll hear | Reading               | Why it's "excessive"                                              |
|-------------|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| おっしゃられる     | osshara-reru          | おっしゃる is already the honorific of 言う; られる adds a second honorific |
| ご覧になられる     | go-ran ni nara-reru   | ご覧になる is already honorific; られる piles on another                  |
| 拝見させていただく   | haiken sasete itadaku | 拝見 is already the humble form of 見る; させていただく adds more humility   |

## The させていただく Problem

「ーさせていただく」 has exploded into an all-purpose humility softener — often where it makes no logical sense. The 文化庁's official guidance (敬語の指針, 2007) says it's appropriate basically only when both of these hold:

- 許可 — you're doing the thing with the other party's permission, and
- 恩恵 — you actually benefit from doing it.

| Overused    | Reading           | Why it's off                                                         | Bett |
|-------------|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|------|
| 休業させていただきます | kyūgyō sasete...  | No permission or benefit relationship — closing is your own decision | 休業   |
| 担当させていただきます | tantō sasete...   | Usually no explicit permission; reflexive over-humility              | 担当   |
| 確認させていただきます | kakunin sasete... | An all-purpose softener where いたします is plenty                        | 確認   |

This one is worth watching in business Japanese too, not just retail — see the Business Japanese track. Overusing *させていただきます* is the corporate equivalent of saying "if that makes sense" after every sentence.

## The Service Phrases You Should Learn

Not everything at the register is controversial. These are completely correct, ubiquitous, and oddly absent from many textbooks. Learn to recognize — and ideally use — them.

| Japanese       | Reading                | When it's said                                                          |
|----------------|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| いらっしゃいませ       | irasshaimase           | "Welcome" on entry (expects no reply)                                   |
| かしこまりました       | kashikomarimashita     | "Certainly / understood" — on taking your order. More deferential       |
| 承知いたしました       | shōchi itashimashita   | "Understood / noted" — the business-side equivalent                     |
| 少々お待ちください (ませ) | shōshō o-machi kudasai | "One moment, please" (use 少々, not ちょっと)                                 |
| お待たせいたしました     | o-matase itashimashita | "Thank you for waiting" — on returning to you                           |
| 恐れ入りますが        | osore-irimasu ga       | A cushion phrase: "I'm terribly sorry, but..." before a request. Polite |
| 申し訳ございません      | mōshiwake gozaimasen   | "I am very sorry" — preferred over <i>すみません</i> in service              |
| 〜円のお返しです       | ...en no o-kaeshi desu | "Here's your ¥— change"                                                 |
| 〜でございます        | ...de gozaimasu        | The polite copula "it is..." — the correct alternative to ーになります        |

And a few "fake keigo" to avoid producing yourself:

| Avoid       | Reading            | Say instead                              |
|-------------|--------------------|------------------------------------------|
| とんでもございません  | tondemo gozaimasen | 恐れ入ります                                   |
| なるほどですね     | naruhodo desu ne   | おっしゃる通りです                                |
| お名前を頂戴できますか | ...chōdai...       | お名前をうかがえますか (you can't "receive" a name) |

## The Bigger Picture: Politeness Is Alive

The reason these forms exist — and the reason people argue about them — is that politeness systems evolve like everything else in language. 貴様 (kisama) and お前 (omae) were once respectful; they decayed into insults over centuries (see Role Language). バイト敬語 is the same process, caught in the act: service workers reaching for extra politeness, the language settling into new conventions, and an older generation insisting it's wrong.

Practical advice for learners:

- On the job in Japan? Follow your workplace's manual, even if it uses バイト敬語. That's what your manager expects.
- For your own polished speech? Use the "correct" forms in this guide — they're never wrong.
- Always? Learn to recognize every form here, because you'll hear them daily and need to understand what's being asked.

Discomfort with these forms keeps rising in the 文化庁's national language surveys — yet the forms keep spreading. That tension is a living language. You're watching Japanese evolve at the cash register.

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Next time a barista tells you your coffee 「になります」, you'll know exactly what's happening — grammatically and sociolinguistically. That's a quietly satisfying superpower.

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## Culture & Norms — The Unspoken Rules

"In Japan, what isn't said matters as much as what is. The unspoken rules aren't hidden — they're everywhere. You just have to know how to look."

Understanding Japanese culture isn't just about avoiding embarrassing mistakes — it's the key to understanding why the language works the way it does. The politeness system, the indirect communication style, the obsession with ma (間 — negative space): it all comes from deeply embedded cultural values.

---

### Uchi and Soto — The Most Important Framework

内 (uchi) means inside. 外 (soto) means outside.

Every Japanese social situation involves an inner circle (your group, your company, your family) and an outer circle (everyone else). The rules are different depending on where someone falls:

| Uchi                                          | Soto                                 |
|-----------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| Be familiar, informal, sometimes blunt        | Be polite, careful, deferential      |
| Speak casually                                | Use appropriate keigo / polite forms |
| You can humble your uchi members to outsiders | You elevate soto people              |
| Trust is assumed                              | Trust must be earned                 |

This creates an interesting paradox: Japanese people can seem cold to strangers (soto) but intensely warm and loyal to those inside their group (uchi).

If a Japanese person invites you into their home, their inner circle, or treats you as uchi — this is a significant gesture of trust and affection.

---

### 間 (Ma) — The Space Between Things

間 (ma) is one of Japan's most fundamental aesthetic and social concepts. It refers to the pause, the gap, the negative space — and it's considered just as meaningful as what fills it.

In conversation: silence is not awkward. A Japanese person who goes quiet after a question is often thinking carefully. They're not uncomfortable — and neither should you be. Filling every silence with words is considered nervous and exhausting.

In architecture: the empty corner of a room, the space between garden stones, the negative space in a painting — all deliberately crafted.

In music: the rest between notes is part of the composition.

In relationships: reading what someone doesn't say (空気を読む — kuuki wo yomu — "reading the air") is a key social skill.

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## 空気を読む — Reading the Air

"空気を読めない" (kuuki wo yomenai) — "can't read the air" — is one of the worst social labels in Japan. It means someone who doesn't pick up on implicit social cues.

Japanese communication is highly high-context — a huge amount of information is conveyed through situation, timing, tone, and what's not said. Compare to English, which is relatively low-context (you say what you mean explicitly).

What "reading the air" looks like in practice:

- Understanding that "ちょっと..." means no without them saying no
- Knowing when someone needs help without them asking
- Recognizing that a topic should be dropped without being told
- Understanding the mood of a room and adjusting behavior accordingly

This is learnable, but it takes time. The more Japanese media you consume (especially drama and variety shows), the more your pattern-matching for these cues develops.

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## 和 (Wa) — Harmony

和 (wa) — harmony, peace, balance — is a cornerstone of Japanese social values. Conflict is not avoided because people are weak; it's managed because social cohesion is genuinely valued over individual expression.

This shows up in:

- Consensus decision-making (根回し — nemawashi — cultivating consensus before a meeting so nothing surprising happens in the room)
  - Avoiding direct confrontation (indirect refusals, vague language)
  - 出る杭は打たれる (deru kui wa utareru — "the nail that sticks out gets hammered in") — the cultural pressure against standing out in problematic ways
  - Tatamae and honne (see below)
- 

## Tatamae and Honne — The Public Face and the True Feeling

建前 (tatamae) = what you present publicly / the official position 本音 (honne) = your true feeling / actual desire

Most cultures have some version of this. Japan's version is exceptionally structured.

Examples:

- Tatamae: "I'll think about it." / Honne: "Absolutely not."
- Tatamae: "Please don't hesitate to contact me anytime." / Honne: "Please don't actually call me after 5pm."
- Tatamae: "That proposal is very interesting." / Honne: "That proposal will not work."

Understanding tatamae is essential to navigating professional and social Japan. The gap isn't dishonesty — it's social lubrication. The social cost of expressing honne bluntly is often high enough that tatamae protects relationships.

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## Bowing — 礼 (Rei)

Bowing is not a single gesture. It's a whole language of its own:

| Bow angle | Occasion               | Meaning                                |
|-----------|------------------------|----------------------------------------|
| 15°       | Brief nod              | Casual acknowledgment, passing someone |
| 30°       | Standard greeting      | Meeting someone, basic thank you       |
| 45°       | Deeper thanks, apology | Genuine gratitude, sincere apology     |
| 90°       | Deepest formal apology | "I have done something very wrong"     |

Key rules:

- The lower-status person bows more deeply
- The higher-status person initiates rising from the bow
- Bowing wars (both people keep bowing lower repeatedly) happen — just enjoy it
- You do not need to bow when talking on the phone, but many Japanese people do anyway (it's subconscious at this point)
- Westerners are generally not expected to bow but making the effort earns enormous goodwill

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## Shoes — The Line Between Inside and Outside

Removing shoes at the door is non-negotiable in homes, many ryokan (traditional inns), some restaurants, and certain temples.

The genkan (玄関) is the entryway — a slightly lowered area where you remove shoes before stepping up into the living space. Stepping on this raised floor with outdoor shoes is a significant breach.

Rule: If there's a genkan, shoes come off. If there are slippers lined up, put them on. If there are slippers near a toilet door, they're toilet slippers — change into them, and change back out.

Forgetting and wandering out of the toilet in toilet slippers is a classic foreigner mistake. Entertaining, but still a mistake.

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## 気遣い (Kizukai) — Consideration for Others

気遣い — thoughtful consideration of others' feelings — is highly valued. It means anticipating needs, not imposing on others, and making an effort so that others don't have to.

In practice:

- Holding doors, but quietly — no big gesture
- Offering the last piece of food to others, even if you want it
- Not talking loudly on trains
- Returning a favor promptly (or you carry social debt)
- Not making others wait

The corresponding sin: 迷惑をかけること (meiwaku wo kakeru koto) — causing trouble or inconvenience for others. This is genuinely distressing for most Japanese people, which explains behavior that can seem excessive to outsiders (triple apologies, declining help, insisting on doing everything themselves).



## Gift Giving — 贈り物 (Okurimono)

Gifts are deeply woven into Japanese social fabric:

Omiyage (お土産): When you travel anywhere — even just a day trip — you're expected to bring small gifts back for coworkers and family. This is non-negotiable in many workplaces.

Key gift-giving rules:

- Gifts are given wrapped and often with both hands
- It's polite to say "これはつまらないものですが..." (this is a trivial thing, but...) when presenting a gift — false modesty is expected
- Gifts are generally NOT opened in front of the giver (opposite of Western convention) unless invited to do so
- Certain gifts carry bad luck: four of anything (4 = 死, death), handkerchiefs (funeral associations), knives (cutting ties), chrysanthemums (funerals)

Major gifting seasons:

- お中元 (ochūgen) — summer gifts (July/August)
  - お歳暮 (oseibo) — year-end gifts (December)
  - When visiting someone's home for the first time
  - When someone does you a significant favor
- 

## 謙遜 (Kenson) — Modesty

Modesty is not performance in Japan — it's embedded in the language.

When you give a compliment, the proper response is to deflect:

"Your Japanese is amazing!" "Thank you, I've been working hard." "No no, it's still very poor."

When you present your own work:

"I think this is excellent." "This is a rough version, but please take a look."

When someone thanks you for a gift:

"I thought you'd love it." "It's nothing special."

This constant deflection can feel dishonest to Westerners, but in Japan it signals social awareness and prevents the impression of arrogance.

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## Punctuality

Japan takes punctuality extremely seriously. Being on time means arriving 5 minutes early. Arriving exactly at the meeting time is considered slightly late. Arriving late with a casual excuse is a genuine offense in professional contexts.

Trains are famously on-time (JR issues apology notices for delays over 5 minutes). This culture extends to all professional interactions.

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## Cleanliness and Order

Japan has deeply ingrained norms around cleanliness:

- Streets are strikingly clean despite relatively few public trash cans (people carry their trash home)
- Shoes off at the door (as above)
- Hospitals and schools have formal cleaning schedules where students clean their own classrooms
- Personal appearance (especially in business) is carefully managed

This isn't compliance — it's cultural identity. Cleanliness reflects respect for shared space.

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## Eye Contact and Personal Space

Eye contact: Less direct than in Western contexts. Sustained eye contact, especially with superiors, can feel confrontational. Looking slightly down or to the side is respectful, not evasive.

Physical contact: Much less than many Western cultures. Hugging, backslapping, and touching acquaintances on the arm are unusual. Bowing, handshakes (increasingly common in business), and maybe the occasional tap on the shoulder among close friends.

Personal space: Generally larger than Southern Europe but similar to Northern Europe. Don't stand too close.

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## Eating and Drinking Norms

- Itadakimasu (いただきます) before eating and gochisōsama deshita (ごちそうさまでした) after — always. Even alone. It acknowledges the effort made to prepare food.
  - Don't stick chopsticks vertically into rice — funeral symbolism. Pass food chopstick-to-chopstick between people? Also funeral association.
  - Slurping noodles is fine — actually signals enjoyment.
  - Don't pour your own drink — pour for others and let them pour for you.
  - Kanpai (乾杯) before drinking — wait for it.
  - In business, never let a superior's glass go empty — watch and refill.
- 

## Onsen Etiquette

Onsen (温泉 — hot springs) are central to Japanese leisure culture. The rules:

1. Shower and wash completely before entering the bath
  2. No swimwear — you enter naked (most onsen are gender-separated)
  3. Keep your small towel out of the water (or fold it on your head)
  4. Don't submerge your head
  5. Those with tattoos — check the policy. Many onsen prohibit tattoos due to historical yakuza associations, though this is changing.
- 

## The Culture Behind the Language

Every grammar concept we covered in the earlier sections connects to culture:

| Language feature  | Cultural root                     |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Keigo system      | Hierarchical relationships (上下関係) |
| Indirect refusals | Harmony (和) and face-saving       |

| Language feature                | Cultural root                                  |
|---------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| uchi/soto vocabulary shifts     | Group identity and loyalty                     |
| Passive voice in formal writing | Depersonalization, diffusing responsibility    |
| Dropping the subject            | Contextual communication, group vs. individual |
| Sentence-final particles (ね、よ)  | Seeking connection, asserting shared knowledge |

Understanding the culture doesn't just help you behave appropriately — it makes the language itself make sense.

Next up: Food →

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## Japanese Food — Eating Your Way Through the Language

"Japan has more Michelin stars than any other country. It also has the world's greatest convenience store food. Both things are true. Both are wonderful."

Food is one of the fastest ways into Japanese culture — and one of the most delicious reasons to learn the language. Menus, ingredient names, restaurant phrases, regional specialties — it's all accessible and immediately rewarding to study.

### The Philosophy of Japanese Food

Japanese cuisine (和食 — washoku) was designated UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage in 2013. Its defining qualities:

- Umami (旨味): The "fifth taste" — savory, deep flavor from dashi, soy sauce, miso, fermented ingredients. The concept was identified and named by Japanese chemist Kikunae Ikeda in 1908.
- Seasonality (旬 — shun): Ingredients are used at their peak season. Eating out-of-season ingredients is aesthetically wrong, not just culinarily.
- Presentation (盛り付け — moritsuke): How food looks is part of how it tastes. Japanese plating is a craft.
- Balance (五味 — gomi): The five tastes (sweet, sour, salty, bitter, umami) should be represented.
- Freshness: Especially for raw fish. Japan's fish markets (like Tsukiji/Toyosu) operate on a different plane.

### Essential Food Vocabulary

#### Cooking Methods

| Japanese | Romaji  | Meaning                |
|----------|---------|------------------------|
| 焼く       | yaku    | grill / bake / pan-fry |
| 煮る       | niru    | simmer / boil          |
| 揚げる      | ageru   | deep-fry               |
| 蒸す       | musu    | steam                  |
| 炒める      | itameru | stir-fry               |
| 生        | nama    | raw                    |
| 刺身       | sashimi | raw sliced fish        |

| Japanese | Romaji  | Meaning           |
|----------|---------|-------------------|
| 茹でる      | yuderu  | boil (in water)   |
| 漬ける      | tsukeru | pickle / marinate |

## Flavors

| Japanese  | Romaji        | Meaning                 |
|-----------|---------------|-------------------------|
| 甘い        | amai          | sweet                   |
| 辛い        | karai         | spicy / hot             |
| 塩辛い       | shiokarai     | salty                   |
| 酸っぱい      | suppai        | sour                    |
| 苦い        | nigai         | bitter                  |
| 旨い / 美味しい | umai / oishii | delicious               |
| まずい       | mazui         | bad-tasting             |
| こってり      | kotteri       | rich / heavy            |
| あっさり      | assari        | light / mild            |
| 濃い        | koi           | strong / thick (flavor) |
| 薄い        | usui          | light / thin (flavor)   |

## The Big Dishes

### Sushi (寿司)

Not just raw fish on rice. The world:

| Type                  | Description                               |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| 握り寿司 (nigirizushi)    | Hand-pressed fish on seasoned rice        |
| 巻き寿司 (makizushi)      | Rolls — inside-out, maki, etc.            |
| ちらし寿司 (chirashizushi) | Scattered toppings over a bowl of rice    |
| ちゃんこ寿司                | Regional variations                       |
| 押し寿司 (oshizushi)      | Pressed sushi in a mold (Osaka specialty) |

At a sushi restaurant:

〜をひとつください。 — One ~, please. おまかせをお願いします。 — Chef's choice (omakase — "I leave it to you") わさびぬきをお願いします。 — Without wasabi, please. 醤油はどこですか？ — Where's the soy sauce?

### Ramen (ラーメン)

Ramen is a regional religion in Japan. The four main bases:

| Style         | Region         | Broth      | Characteristics         |
|---------------|----------------|------------|-------------------------|
| 醤油 (shōyu)    | Tokyo          | Soy sauce  | Clear to brown, classic |
| 塩 (shio)      | Hokkaido       | Salt       | Clear, delicate         |
| 味噌 (miso)     | Sapporo        | Miso paste | Rich, hearty            |
| 豚骨 (tonkotsu) | Fukuoka/Hakata | Pork bone  | Opaque, rich, fatty     |

Ordering ramen:

硬めをお願いします。 — Firm noodles, please. 替え玉ください。 — Another portion of noodles, please. (Hakata specialty) からめをお願いします。 — Extra rich seasoning, please.

### Izakaya Food (居酒屋)

The izakaya — Japanese pub — is one of Japan's greatest inventions. Shared small plates, drinks, and hours:

| Dish  | Romaji         | Description                      |
|-------|----------------|----------------------------------|
| 枝豆    | edamame        | Salted boiled soybeans           |
| 唐揚げ   | karaage        | Japanese fried chicken           |
| 焼き鳥   | yakitori       | Grilled chicken skewers          |
| たこ焼き  | takoyaki       | Octopus balls (Osaka)            |
| お好み焼き | okonomiyaki    | Savory pancake                   |
| 刺身盛り  | sashimi mori   | Sashimi assortment               |
| 冷やっこ  | hiyayakko      | Cold tofu with toppings          |
| 漬物    | tsukemono      | Pickled vegetables               |
| 締めのご飯 | shime no gohan | The final carb course at the end |

Izakaya vocabulary:

生中ください！ — One draft beer (medium), please! とりあえずビールで。 — Beer to start, for now. おつまみ何かありますか？ — Do you have any bar snacks? お通しは何ですか？ — What's the cover charge dish? (お通し is a small appetizer you're charged for automatically)

### Other Essential Dishes

| Dish                 | Description                                            |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| 天ぷら (tempura)        | Lightly battered, deep-fried seafood and vegetables    |
| うどん (udon)           | Thick wheat noodles — cold (ざる) or hot (かけ)            |
| そば (soba)            | Buckwheat noodles                                      |
| カレーライス (karē raisu)  | Japanese curry rice — a national comfort food          |
| 焼き肉 (yakiniku)       | Korean-influenced grilled meat at the table            |
| しゃぶしゃぶ (shabu-shabu) | Thinly sliced meat swirled in hot broth                |
| すき焼き (sukiyaki)      | Sweet soy-simmered beef with vegetables and egg        |
| 親子丼 (oyakodon)       | Chicken and egg over rice ("parent and child" bowl)    |
| 牛丼 (gyūdon)          | Beef bowl — Yoshinoya and Sukiya are the famous chains |
| 納豆 (nattō)           | Fermented soybeans — love or hate, no in-between       |
| 味噌汁 (misoshiru)      | Miso soup — made daily in most homes                   |

## Regional Food Culture

Japan's regional food differences are serious business. Locals feel strongly about their local specialties:

| Region   | Famous food                                                                   |
|----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Hokkaido | Seafood, dairy (butter, milk, cheese), soup curry, miso ramen                 |
| Tohoku   | Wanko soba (small bowls of soba served continuously), kiritanpo (rice sticks) |

| Region    | Famous food                                                                         |
|-----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Tokyo     | Monjayaki, Tokyo ramen (shōyu), Edomae sushi                                        |
| Osaka     | Takoyaki, okonomiyaki, kushikatsu (deep-fried skewers), udon                        |
| Kyoto     | Kaiseki (multi-course formal cuisine), yudōfu (tofu hot pot), Kyoto-style tsukemono |
| Hiroshima | Okonomiyaki (different from Osaka — layered, not mixed), oysters                    |
| Fukuoka   | Hakata ramen (tonkotsu), mentaiko (spiced cod roe), motsu nabe                      |
| Okinawa   | Champuru (stir-fry), Okinawa soba, goya (bitter melon), Awamori (spirit)            |

## The Convenience Store Revolution

Japanese convenience stores (コンビニ — konbini) are a phenomenon. 7-Eleven, FamilyMart, and Lawson operate at a standard that would be upscale in other countries.

What you can get at a konbini:

- Hot steamed nikuman (meat buns)
- Onigiri (rice balls) in 20+ varieties
- Fresh sushi and sashimi
- Hot coffee
- Egg salad sandwiches (surprisingly incredible)
- Oden (hot pot in heated display case)
- Printouts, tax payments, event tickets, cash withdrawals
- Alcohol (until midnight in most prefectures)

Konbini vocabulary:

温めますか？ — Shall I heat this up? (Staff will ask about prepared foods) 袋はよろしいですか？  
— Do you need a bag? ポイントカードはお持ちですか？ — Do you have a points card?

## Restaurant Phrases in Full

### Arriving

いらっしゃいませ！ (staff) — Welcome! 〜名です。 — (Number) people. [Hold up fingers]  
禁煙席をお願いします。 — Non-smoking section, please. 予約しています。田中です。 — I  
have a reservation. Name is Tanaka.

### Ordering

注文してもいいですか？ — May I order? これをください。 — I'll have this. [Point at menu]  
おすすめは何ですか？ — What do you recommend? 〜抜きをお願いします。 — Without ~,  
please. 〜アレルギーがあります。 — I have a ~ allergy. ベジタリアンです。 — I am vegetar-  
ian.

### During and After

美味しいです！ — It's delicious! お会計をお願いします。 — Check, please. 全部一緒にいいです。  
— All together is fine. (One check) 別々をお願いします。 — Separate checks, please.  
ごちそうさまでした。 — Thank you for the meal.

## Food Taboos and Restrictions

Japan is not always easy for special diets, but awareness is growing:

Vegetarians/Vegans: Fish-based dashi (出汁) is in almost everything. Ask:

出汁はどんなものを使っていますか？ — What kind of dashi do you use? 魚介類は入っていますか？  
— Does this contain seafood?

Gluten-free: Very difficult in Japan. Soy sauce contains wheat. Ask:

グルテンフリーのものはありますか？ — Do you have gluten-free options?

Halal: Growing availability in tourist areas, especially Tokyo and Osaka. Look for ハラル (harāru) certification.

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## Drinking Culture

お酒 (osake): Alcohol in general. The naming hierarchy:

- ビール (bīru) — beer: usually 生ビール (draft) first
- 日本酒 (nihonshu) — sake: served hot (熱燗 — atsukan) or cold (冷 — hiya)
- 焼酎 (shōchū) — distilled spirit from sweet potato, barley, or rice
- ハイボール (haibōru) — whisky soda, massively popular
- チューハイ (chūhai) — fruit soda + shōchū, accessible and light
- ウイスキー (uisukī) — Japanese whisky: Suntory, Nikka — world-class

Non-alcohol:

- お茶 (ocha) — green tea: served free at many restaurants
  - 麦茶 (mugicha) — barley tea: especially cold in summer
  - 水 (mizu) — water: tap water in Japan is excellent and safe everywhere
- 

## Eating Customs at a Glance

| Do                                 | Don't                                    |
|------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| Say いただきます / ごちそうさまでした             | Stick chopsticks upright in rice         |
| Slurp noodles                      | Pass food chopstick-to-chopstick         |
| Pour drinks for others             | Pour your own drink (let others do it)   |
| Try everything                     | Waste food if you can avoid it           |
| Eat with both hands (hold bowl up) | Walk and eat in public (considered rude) |

Next up: Matsuri →

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## Matsuri — Japan's Festival Soul

"Japan doesn't just celebrate — it transforms. A quiet neighborhood becomes a river of lanterns, a hillside becomes a sea of fireworks, and a street becomes a parade of gods."

祭り (matsuri) — festivals — are at the heart of Japanese community life. Rooted in Shinto and Buddhist traditions, they mark the rhythms of seasons, honor local deities, celebrate harvests, and remember the dead. There are estimated 300,000+ matsuri in Japan every year. You will almost certainly stumble into one.

## The Vocabulary of Matsuri

| Japanese | Romaji             | Meaning                                 |
|----------|--------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| 祭り / お祭り | matsuri / omatsuri | festival                                |
| 神社       | jinja              | Shinto shrine                           |
| お寺       | otera              | Buddhist temple                         |
| 神輿       | mikoshi            | portable shrine carried through streets |
| 山車       | dashi / yatai      | festival float                          |
| 屋台       | yatai              | festival food stall                     |
| 浴衣       | yukata             | light summer kimono worn at festivals   |
| 盆踊り      | bon odori          | Obon festival folk dance                |
| 花火       | hanabi             | fireworks (literally: flower + fire)    |
| 花火大会     | hanabi taikai      | fireworks show                          |
| 縁日       | ennichi            | festival fair / fete                    |
| 御神輿      | omikoshi           | sacred portable shrine                  |
| 担ぐ       | katsugu            | to carry (a mikoshi, etc.)              |
| わっしょい！   | wasshoi!           | Traditional cry when carrying a mikoshi |

## Major National Festivals

Hanami (花見) — Cherry Blossom Viewing

Season: Late March – April Where: Everywhere — especially Ueno Park (Tokyo), Maruyama Park (Kyoto), Shinjuku Gyoen

Not technically a matsuri, but one of Japan's most beloved cultural events. People gather under sakura trees for outdoor picnics and parties, often with alcohol and bento boxes.

- Season words: 桜前線 (sakura zensen — "cherry blossom front") tracks the blooming from south to north on the news like a weather event
- Mono no aware (物の哀れ): The Japanese aesthetic of the bittersweet beauty of things that fade — cherry blossoms are the defining symbol of this
- Tip: Book picnic spots early — people leave tarps to claim spots under trees the night before

Vocabulary:

花見しませんか？ — Want to do hanami? 桜が満開です。 — The cherry blossoms are in full bloom. 散り始めましたね。 — They're starting to fall, aren't they.

Gion Matsuri (祇園祭)

When: All of July, main procession July 17 Where: Kyoto



One of Japan's three great festivals. A month-long celebration at Yasaka Shrine in central Kyoto. The Yamaboko Junko procession features massive, ornate floats some of which take a whole neighborhood a full year to prepare.

- Origin: 869 CE plague prevention ritual
  - The floats weigh up to 12 tons
  - Crowds of over a million people during peak dates
- 

### Tenjin Matsuri (天神祭)

When: July 24–25 Where: Osaka (Temmangu Shrine)

One of Japan's three great festivals alongside Gion Matsuri and Kanda Matsuri. Features processions on both land and water — thousands of people in traditional clothing, mikoshi carried through streets, fireworks over the river.

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### Obon (お盆)

When: August 13–15 (varies by region) Everywhere: National

Obon is when the spirits of ancestors are said to return to the living world. Families visit graves (お墓参り — ohakamairi), clean and decorate them, light incense, and perform bon odori — circular folk dances in the street.

- Bon odori: Anyone can join. The dances are simple and repetitive — the point is communal participation, not skill.
  - Obon week is travel season: Japan's highways and shinkansen are packed with people returning to hometowns (帰省 — kisei). Book early.
  - Lanterns (灯籠): In some regions, paper lanterns are floated on rivers to guide spirits home.
- 

### Awa Odori (阿波踊り)

When: August 12–15 Where: Tokushima, but dances happen across Japan

One of Japan's most famous folk dances. Energetic, rhythmic, and genuinely fun to watch. Participants shout “eらっしやい、よっしや来い！” The saying goes: “It's a fool who dances and a fool who watches, so if you're a fool either way, you might as well dance!”

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### Oshōgatsu (お正月) — New Year's

When: January 1–3 (preparations from late December) Everywhere: National

Japan's most important holiday. Almost everything closes. Families gather, eat traditional osechi ryōri (おせち料理 — boxes of preserved New Year's foods with lucky symbolism), and visit temples or shrines for 初詣 (hatsumōde) — the first shrine visit of the year.

- 年越しそば (toshikoshi soba): Eaten on New Year's Eve — the long noodles symbolize longevity
- お年玉 (otoshidama): New Year's money given to children in decorated envelopes
- 初日の出 (hatsu hi no de): Watching the first sunrise of the year — some people climb mountains to do this

- 年賀状 (nengajō): New Year's postcards — Japan's postal service guarantees delivery on January 1st if sent by late December
- 

### Setsubun (節分)

When: February 3 (eve of the first day of spring by the old calendar) Where: Everywhere

The bean-throwing festival. Roasted soybeans are thrown while shouting:

”鬼は外！福は内！” (Oni wa soto! Fuku wa uchi!) ”Demons out! Good fortune in!”

People also eat 恵方巻き (ehōmaki) — a thick sushi roll eaten in silence while facing the lucky direction of the year.

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### Hina Matsuri (雛祭り) — Girls' Day

When: March 3 Where: Homes, public displays

Decorative sets of imperial court dolls (雛人形 — hinaningyo) are displayed. The tradition is to wish for the health and happiness of daughters.

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### Kodomo no Hi (子どもの日) — Children's Day

When: May 5 (Golden Week) Where: Everywhere

Originally Boys' Day. Carp-shaped streamers called 鯉のぼり (koinobori) fly from poles — the carp that swims upstream symbolizes strength and perseverance.

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### Tanabata (七夕)

When: July 7 (or August 7 in some regions) Where: Sendai's version is famous nationwide

The star festival, based on the legend of two stars (Vega and Altair — representing lovers Orihime and Hikoboshi) who are separated by the Milky Way and can only meet once a year.

People write wishes on colored paper strips (短冊 — tanzaku) and hang them on bamboo branches. Towns decorate with enormous streamers and ornaments.

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### Autumn Foliage (紅葉 — Kōyō)

Season: October–December (varies by region)

Like hanami but for autumn leaves. Parks, temples, and mountain paths fill with people appreciating the red, orange, and gold foliage. Kyoto in November is one of Japan's most spectacular sights.

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## Regional Festivals Worth Knowing

| Festival                     | Location  | When          | What it is                                                        |
|------------------------------|-----------|---------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 雪まつり (Sapporo Snow Festival) | Sapporo   | February      | Massive snow and ice sculptures                                   |
| ねぶた祭り (Nebuta Festival)      | Aomori    | August        | Giant illuminated paper floats                                    |
| 博多どんたく (Hakata Dontaku)      | Fukuoka   | May           | Parades, dancing, street performances                             |
| 仙台七夕 (Sendai Tanabata)       | Sendai    | August        | Japan's most famous Tanabata celebration                          |
| 高山祭り (Takayama Matsuri)      | Takayama  | April/October | Elaborately decorated floats in a mountain town                   |
| なまはげ (Namahage)              | Akita     | January       | Men in demon masks visit homes to frighten children               |
| 岸和田だんじり (Kishiwada Danjiri)  | Kishiwada | September     | Massive wooden floats pulled at full speed through narrow streets |

## Festival Food — The Yatai Experience

The 屋台 (yatai) — street stalls — are as much a part of the festival as the shrines and dances:

| Food    | Reading       | Description                        |
|---------|---------------|------------------------------------|
| たこ焼き    | takoyaki      | Octopus balls in batter            |
| 焼きそば    | yakisoba      | Stir-fried soba noodles            |
| 唐揚げ     | karaage       | Fried chicken                      |
| チョコバナナ  | choko banana  | Chocolate-dipped banana on a stick |
| わたあめ    | wataame       | Cotton candy                       |
| りんご飴    | ringo ame     | Candy apple                        |
| フランクフルト | furankufuruto | Frankfurter on a stick             |
| かき氷     | kakigōri      | Shaved ice with syrup              |
| 金魚すくい   | kingyo sukui  | Goldfish scooping game             |
| 射的      | shateki       | BB gun shooting gallery            |

## What to Wear: Yukata (浴衣)

A yukata is a casual summer kimono worn at matsuri, onsen towns, and ryokan. Renting or buying one is entirely appropriate for foreigners:

- Worn with a wide sash (帯 — obi)
- Left side crosses over right (right over left is for funerals)
- Wooden sandals (下駄 — geta) complete the look
- Many ryokan provide yukata as room wear

## Festival Phrases

| Japanese      | Romaji                              | Meaning                                       |
|---------------|-------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| お祭り楽しかった！     | omatsuri tanoshikatta!              | The festival was fun!                         |
| 花火がきれいですね。    | hanabi ga kirei desu ne.            | The fireworks are beautiful.                  |
| わっしょい！        | wasshoi!                            | Festival carrying cheer                       |
| 〜一つください。      | ~hitotsu kudasai.                   | One ~ please. (at a stall)                    |
| 浴衣が素敵ですね。     | yukata ga suteki desu ne.           | Your yukata is lovely.                        |
| 初詣はどこに行きましたか？ | hatsumōde wa doko ni ikimashita ka? | Where did you go for New Year's shrine visit? |

Next up: Pop Culture →

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## Pop Culture — Japan's Soft Power

"Anime, manga, games, and J-pop have collectively made Japanese one of the most studied languages in the world. If you're learning Japanese because of them, you're in excellent company."

Japan's pop culture is a genuine global phenomenon. More people have probably picked up the word 頑張って (ganbatte — do your best) from anime than from any textbook. Pop culture isn't a side path to learning Japanese — for millions of people, it's the reason to learn it.

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### Why Pop Culture Is a Legitimate Learning Path

Consuming Japanese pop culture:

- Provides massive listening input — the most effective way to internalize pronunciation and rhythm
- Teaches natural speech patterns — especially anime (which skews casual) and manga
- Builds vocabulary organically — in context, which means higher retention
- Keeps you motivated — you're watching something you love, not drilling flashcards

The caveat: anime Japanese ≠ real Japanese. Characters in anime (especially battle manga) speak unnaturally dramatically. Speech patterns, vocabulary, and behavior vary wildly by genre. A diet of only shonen battle anime will leave gaps. Diversify your input.

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## Anime — アニメ

Japan's animation industry produces hundreds of titles per year across every genre imaginable. Some key vocabulary:

### Anime Genres

| Japanese | Romaji     | Meaning                                                                        |
|----------|------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 少年       | shōnen     | For boys — action, friendship, growth (Naruto, Demon Slayer, My Hero Academia) |
| 少女       | shōjo      | For girls — romance, emotion (Sailor Moon, Fruits Basket)                      |
| 青年       | seinen     | For adult men — often darker, more complex (Berserk, Attack on Titan)          |
| 女性       | josei      | For adult women — more realistic romance                                       |
| 異世界      | isekai     | "Other world" — protagonist transported to a fantasy world                     |
| 日常       | nichijou   | Slice of life — everyday situations                                            |
| 魔法少女     | mahō shōjo | Magical girl                                                                   |
| メカ       | meka       | Giant robots (Gundam, Evangelion)                                              |

### Classic and Cultural Touchstones

| Title                 | Why it matters                                                                            |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ジブリ作品 (Studio Ghibli) | Miyazaki's films — cultural touchstones for all Japanese people. Totoro, Spirited Away, H |
| ドラゴンボール (Dragon Ball) | Defined shonen manga and anime globally                                                   |
| ワンピース (One Piece)     | Best-selling manga of all time                                                            |

| Title                   | Why it matters                                                                   |
|-------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ナルト (Naruto)            | Gateway anime for many Western learners                                          |
| エヴァンゲリオン (Evangelion)   | Psychological mecha — changed what anime could be                                |
| 進撃の巨人 (Attack on Titan) | Recent global phenomenon                                                         |
| 鬼滅の刃 (Demon Slayer)     | Became highest-grossing anime film ever                                          |
| ドラえもん (Doraemon)        | Iconic children's anime — great for beginners (simple vocabulary, everyday life) |
| サザエさん (Sazae-san)       | Running since 1969 — traditional Japanese family life                            |

## Learning from Anime

- Best for beginners: Doraemon, Chi's Sweet Home, Shirokuma Cafe — slow speech, simple vocabulary
- Best for casual speech: Ghibli films, Nichijou, Toradora
- Best for formal speech: Older period dramas, samurai anime
- Enable Japanese subtitles (not English) — trains reading alongside listening

## Manga — 漫画

Manga is read right to left, top to bottom within each panel. If you're turning pages the "wrong" way, you're reading the back.

## Reading System

| Term             | Meaning                                                    |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| コマ (koma)        | Panel                                                      |
| フキダシ (fukidashi) | Speech bubble                                              |
| ふりがな (furigana)  | Small hiragana above kanji — your best friend as a learner |
| 効果音 (kōkaon)     | Sound effects — usually katakana                           |
| ト書き (togaki)     | Narrative text/caption boxes                               |

## Types of Manga

| Type                 | Target      | Examples                                       |
|----------------------|-------------|------------------------------------------------|
| 少年 (shōnen)          | Boys        | Naruto, Dragon Ball, Bleach, My Hero Academia  |
| 少女 (shōjo)           | Girls       | Sailor Moon, Cardcaptor Sakura                 |
| 青年 (seinen)          | Adult men   | Vagabond, Berserk, Oyasumi Punpun              |
| 女性 (josei)           | Adult women | Nana, Skip Beat                                |
| 4コマ (yonkoma)        | All         | 4-panel gag strips — Azumanga Daioh            |
| 学習漫画 (gakushū manga) | Children    | Educational manga — history, science, Japanese |

## Manga Vocabulary

| Japanese         | Meaning                                        |
|------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| 吹き出し (fukidashi) | Speech bubble                                  |
| モノローグ (monorōgu) | Internal monologue                             |
| 集中線 (shūchūsen)  | Speed lines (visual effect around face/object) |
| スクリーントーン         | Screen tone — dotted texture patterns          |

| Japanese       | Meaning                           |
|----------------|-----------------------------------|
| 原作 (gensaku)   | Original story (of an adaptation) |
| 作画 (sakuga)    | Art/drawings                      |
| 連載 (rensai)    | Serialization                     |
| 単行本 (tankōbon) | Volume / collected edition        |
| 同人誌 (dōjinshi) | Fan-made manga                    |

## Sound Effects in Manga

Manga sound effects are their own creative language:

| Effect | Sound    | Used for                           |
|--------|----------|------------------------------------|
| ドキドキ   | dokidoki | Heart beating fast                 |
| ドーン    | dōn      | Impact, revelation                 |
| ザーザー   | zāzā     | Heavy rain                         |
| ガン     | gān      | Shock/devastation                  |
| キラキラ   | kirakira | Sparkling                          |
| ズーン    | zūn      | Foreboding / depression setting in |
| ニヤリ    | niyari   | Sinister smirk                     |

## Video Games — ゲーム

Japan's game industry (Nintendo, Sony, Sega, Capcom, Square Enix, Konami, Namco...) has defined gaming culture globally. Japanese games are excellent for language learning because:

- They often have furigana (Nintendo games especially)
- RPGs have enormous amounts of text
- You're highly motivated to understand what's happening

## Useful Gaming Vocabulary

| Japanese           | Meaning                                   |
|--------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| レベル上げ (reberu age) | Grinding / leveling up                    |
| 裏技 (urawaza)       | Secret technique / cheat                  |
| 攻略 (kōryaku)       | Strategy / walkthrough                    |
| ボス (bosu)          | Boss enemy                                |
| セーブ (sēbu)         | Save (game)                               |
| ゲームオーバー            | Game over                                 |
| 主人公 (shujinkō)     | Protagonist                               |
| ラスボス (rasubosu)    | Final boss                                |
| ソロ / パーティ          | Solo / Party                              |
| 廃人 (haijin)        | No-life gamer (playing unhealthy amounts) |
| 推し (oshi)          | Your favorite character                   |

## Games Great for Learning Japanese

- Nintendo games (ポケモン、どうぶつの森) — furigana, simple vocabulary
- Dragon Quest — furigana on all kanji, classic JRPG

- Final Fantasy XIV — massive online RPG with a huge community
- Persona series — heavy on modern Japanese culture and slang

## Otaku Culture

オタク (otaku) originally meant someone obsessively interested in manga/anime/games — often with a negative connotation in Japan (socially awkward, obsessive). Globally, it's been reclaimed as a positive self-identifier by fans.

### Key Locations

| Place             | Where           | What                                                  |
|-------------------|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| 秋葉原 (Akihabara)   | Tokyo           | Electronics, anime goods, manga, maid cafes           |
| 池袋 (Ikebukuro)    | Tokyo           | Anime goods, manga, reverse maid cafes (butler cafes) |
| 日本橋 (Nippombashi) | Osaka           | Osaka's Akihabara equivalent                          |
| コミケ (Comiket)     | Tokyo Big Sight | Twice-yearly fan convention, ~750,000 attendees       |
| ジャンプショップ          | Tokyo/Osaka     | Official Shonen Jump merchandise                      |

### Maid Cafes (メイドカフェ)

Staff dress as maids and perform rituals like casting spells on your food:

「萌え萌えキyun!」 (Moe moe kyun!) You're expected to say it back. Yes, really.

## Cosplay (コスプレ)

Japan's cosplay culture is among the world's most serious and celebrated. Cosplayers (コスプレイヤー) invest enormous effort in costume accuracy.

Major cosplay vocabulary: | Japanese | Meaning | |---|---| | 仮装 (kasō) | Costume / masquerade | | 着替え (kigae) | Changing clothes | | 撮影 (satsuei) | Photography (cosplay photo sessions are formalized) | | 完成度 (kanseido) | Level of completion / accuracy | | 自作 (jisaku) | Self-made | | 既製品 (kiseihin) | Store-bought |

## Idols — アイドル

The idol industry is massive in Japan — groups of young performers (often trained from childhood) who sell music, merchandise, handshake events, and parasocial relationships to dedicated fan bases.

Key groups and concepts: | Group/Term | Notes | |---|---| | AKB48 | The archetypal idol group — multiple theater-based teams, fan voting for singles | | Nogizaka46 / Sakurazaka46 | "Anti-idol" idol groups, more artistic direction | | ジャニーズ (Johnny's) | Male idol agency — Arashi, SMAP, KinKi Kids | | 推し (oshi) | Your favorite member — intense, loyal support | | 握手会 (akushukai) | Handshake events — buy CDs to get handshake tickets | | 総選挙 (sōsenkyo) | AKB48 popularity election — fans vote by buying CDs |

## Kawai Culture

かわいい (kawaii) isn't just "cute" — it's an aesthetic philosophy, a cultural force, and a multi-billion yen industry. Characters like Hello Kitty (ハローキティ), Pikachu (ピカチュウ), and Rilakkuma (リラックマ) are recognized globally.

Where kawaii shows up:

- Mascot characters for cities, banks, government agencies (every Japanese institution seems to have one)
- Character goods filling entire department store floors
- Kawaii fashion (ロリータ — Lolita fashion, Harajuku style)
- Food presentation — character bento (キャラ弁 — charaben)

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## Harajuku (原宿) — Street Fashion

Harajuku in Tokyo has been the global epicenter of Japanese street fashion since the 1980s:

| Style              | Description                                                                 |
|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ロリータ (Lolita)      | Victorian-influenced, elaborate lace and petticoats                         |
| 原宿系 (Harajuku-kei) | Colorful, layered, eclectic                                                 |
| ストリート系             | Streetwear-influenced                                                       |
| 地雷系 (Jiraie-kei)   | Pastel goth / sad girl aesthetic                                            |
| 量産型 (ryōsankata)   | "Mass-produced type" — soft, feminine basic style popular among young women |

Next up: Dialects →

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## Dialects — 方言 (Hōgen)

"Standard Japanese will get you understood everywhere. But the moment someone slips into Osaka dialect, you'll realize the textbook only taught you one Japan."

Japan's regional dialects (方言 — hōgen) are alive and vibrant. While everyone learns standard Japanese (標準語 — hyōjungo, based on Tokyo speech) in school, regional dialects are used at home, with friends, and in casual life across the country. Some are close to standard; some are so different they're nearly incomprehensible to outsiders.

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## Standard Japanese vs. Dialects

Standard Japanese (標準語 / 共通語):

- Based on educated Tokyo speech
- Used in news broadcasts, textbooks, official communications
- What you're learning in this guide

Dialect (方言):

- Regional variation in pronunciation, vocabulary, and grammar
- Used with family, friends, and in regional communities
- A source of regional pride — don't make fun of someone's dialect



The divide is real: a Tohoku grandmother speaking full dialect and an Osaka businessman speaking full Kansai-ben might struggle to understand each other. Most people code-switch depending on context.

## Kansai-ben (関西弁) — The Most Famous Dialect

Kansai dialect (spoken in Osaka, Kyoto, Kobe, Nara, and surroundings) is so prevalent in comedy, drama, and pop culture that most Japanese learners encounter it early. It sounds warmer, more rhythmic, and frankly more fun than Tokyo Japanese.

### Key Grammar Differences

| Standard    | Kansai-ben      | Meaning            |
|-------------|-----------------|--------------------|
| ～じゃない       | ～ちゃう / ～やん      | Isn't it? / Right? |
| ～ている        | ～てる / ～とる       | Ongoing action     |
| ～している       | ～しとる / ～しててる    | Doing              |
| ～しない        | ～せえへん           | Don't do           |
| ～しなかった      | ～せえへんかった        | Didn't do          |
| ～しています      | ～してます           | (Standard applies) |
| だ / です      | や / です          | is/am/are          |
| 違う (chigau) | ちゃう (chau)      | Wrong / different  |
| どうして        | なんで             | Why                |
| 本当に         | ほんまに (honma ni) | Really             |

### Key Vocabulary Differences

| Standard | Kansai         | Meaning                              |
|----------|----------------|--------------------------------------|
| とても      | めっちゃ           | Very (now nationally popular)        |
| ありがとう    | おおきに (ōkini)   | Thank you (mostly Kyoto/traditional) |
| ありがとう    | ありがとう          | (same in most casual contexts now)   |
| 捨てる      | ほかす (hokasu)   | To throw away                        |
| 疲れた      | しんどい (shindoi) | Tired / exhausted                    |
| 面白い      | おもしろい (omoroi) | Interesting / funny                  |
| いい       | ええ (ē)         | Good                                 |
| ダメ       | あかん (akan)     | No good / can't do                   |
| 良い / いい  | ええ             | Good                                 |
| ～しましょうよ  | ～しよ / ～しよか     | Let's ~                              |
| それ       | それ / そっち       | That                                 |

### Osaka vs. Kyoto: A Subtle Difference

Both speak Kansai-ben, but:

- Osaka dialect is louder, more direct, comedic — the stereotype of Osakans being naturally funny isn't entirely wrong
- Kyoto dialect is softer, more musical, sometimes even more indirect than standard — centuries of court culture left their mark

## Hakata-ben (博多弁) — Fukuoka

Fukuoka's dialect is melodic and distinct. The city is often ranked Japan's most livable.

| Standard | Hakata     | Meaning            |
|----------|------------|--------------------|
| ～している    | ～しとつと      | Doing ~            |
| ありがとう    | ありがとう / よか | Thanks / good      |
| すごい      | すごか        | Incredible         |
| 来ない      | こんと / こん   | Isn't coming       |
| 行く       | 行くと？       | Going?             |
| 美味しい     | うまか        | Delicious          |
| ～ですよ     | ～ばい        | Emphatic assertion |
| ～ですね     | ～たい        | Seeking agreement  |

"The last train" in standard: 終電が来ましたよ In Hakata: 終電きとうばい

## Tohoku-ben (東北弁)

Spoken in the northeastern region of Honshū. Often considered the hardest dialect for standard Japanese speakers to understand.

Key features:

- Vowel merger: い and え become the same sound; う and お can merge
- Consonant changes: sh → s, ch → ts
- Unique vocabulary: completely different words for common concepts

| Standard   | Tohoku          | Meaning      |
|------------|-----------------|--------------|
| 寒い (samui) | しゃっこい (shakkoi) | Cold         |
| すごい        | どんだ             | Incredible   |
| ～です        | ～だ (flat)       | Is           |
| 来ない        | こね              | Isn't coming |
| いない        | ね               | Not there    |

## Nagoya-ben (名古屋弁) — Chubu Region

Nagoya dialect features distinctive sentence endings and unique vocabulary:

| Standard | Nagoya  | Meaning    |
|----------|---------|------------|
| ～じゃない    | ～じゃん    | Isn't it?  |
| ～でしょ     | ～だぎゃ    | Right?     |
| すごく大きい   | えらい大きい  | Very big   |
| ありがとう    | ありがとうさん | Thank you  |
| 来ない      | きやあせん   | Won't come |

えらい (erai): In standard Japanese, this means "great/admirable." In Nagoya dialect, it means "very" (like めっちゃ in Kansai). Context matters.

## Hiroshima-ben

Hiroshima has a distinctive, direct-sounding dialect associated with old yakuza movies (unfairly — it's a wonderful city):

| Standard | Hiroshima | Meaning     |
|----------|-----------|-------------|
| 〜だ       | 〜じゃ       | Is          |
| 〜だろう     | 〜じゃろう     | Probably is |
| 〜ではない    | 〜じゃない     | Isn't       |
| 来なさい     | きんさい      | Come here   |
| 見なさい     | みんさい      | Look        |
| 〜してください  | 〜しんさい     | Please do ~ |

## Okinawa-ben / Uchinaaguchi

Okinawa's language is more accurately a distinct language (or language family) rather than a dialect. Standard Japanese speakers cannot understand it without study.

| Standard | Uchinaaguchi                                  | Meaning                 |
|----------|-----------------------------------------------|-------------------------|
| こんにちは    | はいさい (haisai) [male] / はいたい (haitai) [female] | Hello                   |
| ありがとう    | にふえーでーびる (nifēdēbiru)                         | Thank you               |
| おじさん     | おじい (ojī)                                     | Grandfather / old man   |
| おばさん     | おばあ (obā)                                     | Grandmother / old woman |
| ビール      | バクスー (bakusū)                                 | Beer                    |

Okinawa also has チャンプルー文化 (chanpurū bunka — "chanpuru culture") — chanpurū means "something mixed" in Okinawan. It reflects the island's history of blending Ryukyuan, Japanese, Chinese, and American influences.

## Dialect in Media

Many Japanese TV shows, films, and manga feature dialect speakers:

- 吉本興業 (Yoshimoto Kogyo) — the major comedy production company — is based in Osaka, and most famous Japanese comedians speak Kansai-ben
- こち亀、じゃリン子チエ — manga set in Osaka featuring strong Kansai dialect
- ゴールデンカムイ — features Hokkaido Ainu cultural references alongside period Japanese
- 龍馬伝 — NHK drama featuring Tosa dialect (Kochi prefecture)

## Dialects and Identity

方言コンプレックス (hōgen kompurekkusu): Dialect complex — the self-consciousness some regional Japanese feel about their dialect in Tokyo or national media. As a learner, expressing genuine interest in someone's dialect is usually warmly received.

方言の復権 (hōgen no fukken): Dialect revival — there's growing appreciation for regional language as cultural heritage. Many younger people in regional cities are proud of their dialects.

## Should Learners Study Dialects?

Generally: no, not until intermediate or advanced level.

Learn standard Japanese first. Once you're comfortable, you'll start naturally picking up dialect features from media and real conversation. If you're moving to a specific region, learning a few phrases in the local dialect earns enormous goodwill.

One exception: Kansai-ben is so prevalent in anime, comedy, and casual media that passive recognition from early on is useful. You don't need to produce it, but understanding it matters.

Next up: Seasons & Nature →

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## Seasons & Nature — 四季と自然

"Japan experiences the seasons with an intensity that shapes language, food, clothing, greetings, decor, festivals, and poetry. Learning seasonal vocabulary isn't optional — it's structural."

Japan's four seasons (四季 — shiki) are woven into the fabric of daily life in a way that surprises many visitors. Seasonal references appear in everything from formal letter openers to ramen menus. The Japanese word 旬 (shun) — peak season for food, the perfect moment — captures this perfectly.

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### 春 — Haru (Spring)

Months: March, April, May

Spring is the season of new beginnings: the school year starts, companies' fiscal years begin, cherry blossoms bloom, and the air shifts.

#### Spring Vocabulary

| Japanese | Romaji        | Meaning                                        |
|----------|---------------|------------------------------------------------|
| 桜        | sakura        | cherry blossom                                 |
| 花見       | hanami        | cherry blossom viewing                         |
| 春一番      | haruichiban   | First strong south wind of spring              |
| 入学式      | nyūgakushiki  | School entrance ceremony                       |
| 卒業式      | sotsugyōshiki | Graduation ceremony                            |
| 霞        | kasumi        | spring haze / mist                             |
| うぐいす     | uguisu        | bush warbler (its call is the sound of spring) |
| たんぽぽ     | tanpopo       | dandelion                                      |
| 菜の花      | nanohana      | rapeseed flower (bright yellow fields)         |
| つくし      | tsukushi      | horsetail plant (edible spring vegetable)      |

#### Spring in Language

Traditional letter openings for spring:

春暖の候、いかがお過ごしでしょうか。 "In this warm spring season, how have you been?"

The word 春めく (harumeku) — "to become spring-like" — captures the feeling when spring arrives.

花吹雪 (hanafubuki) — "flower blizzard" — the shower of cherry blossom petals falling in the wind. One of the most beautiful words in Japanese.

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## 夏 — Natsu (Summer)

Months: June, July, August

Japanese summer is hot and humid — especially in Tokyo, Osaka, and the major cities. The rainy season arrives first, then the punishing heat of late July–August.

### Summer Vocabulary

| Japanese | Romaji        | Meaning                                 |
|----------|---------------|-----------------------------------------|
| 梅雨       | tsuyu / baiu  | Rainy season (June–July)                |
| 蒸し暑い     | mushiatsui    | Hot and humid                           |
| 打ち水      | uchimizu      | Splashing water on streets to cool them |
| 夏祭り      | natsumatsuri  | Summer festival                         |
| 花火大会     | hanabi taikai | Fireworks festival                      |
| 盆踊り      | bon odori     | Obon festival dance                     |
| 蝉        | semi          | cicada — the sound of Japanese summer   |
| 蛍        | hotaru        | firefly                                 |
| 西瓜       | suika         | watermelon                              |
| かき氷      | kakigōri      | shaved ice                              |
| 浴衣       | yukata        | light summer kimono                     |
| 向日葵      | himawari      | sunflower                               |
| 扇子       | sensu         | folding fan                             |
| うちわ      | uchiwa        | round fan                               |
| 熱中症      | necchūshō     | heat stroke                             |
| 台風       | taifū         | typhoon                                 |

### The Sound of Summer

The cicada (蝉 — semi) is so strongly associated with summer that 蝉時雨 (semishigure — “cicada shower”) — the sound of thousands of cicadas — is a season word (季語) that immediately evokes midsummer.

梅雨明け (tsuyu ake) — “end of the rainy season” — is announced by the Japan Meteorological Agency and celebrated like a holiday.

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## 秋 — Aki (Autumn)

Months: September, October, November

Japan's autumn is spectacular. The maple leaves (紅葉 — kōyō) turn fiery red and gold. The heat breaks, the food peaks, and the air becomes crisp.

### Autumn Vocabulary

| Japanese | Romaji        | Meaning                       |
|----------|---------------|-------------------------------|
| 紅葉       | kōyō / momiji | Autumn foliage / maple        |
| もみじ      | momiji        | Japanese maple (specifically) |
| 銀杏       | ichō          | ginkgo (turns bright yellow)  |

| Japanese | Romaji             | Meaning                                            |
|----------|--------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| 実り       | minori             | harvest / fruit bearing                            |
| 秋晴れ      | akibare            | clear autumn sky                                   |
| 秋風       | akikaze            | autumn breeze                                      |
| 虫の音      | mushi no ne        | sound of insects (crickets at night)               |
| 松茸       | matsutake          | matsutake mushroom (expensive, aromatic, seasonal) |
| 栗        | kuri               | chestnut                                           |
| 柿        | kaki               | persimmon                                          |
| 梨        | nashi              | Japanese pear                                      |
| さんま      | sanma              | Pacific saury (grilled autumn fish)                |
| 月見       | tsukimi            | moon-viewing                                       |
| お月見      | otsukimi           | October moon-viewing festival                      |
| 中秋の名月    | chūshū no meigetsu | Harvest moon                                       |
| 衣替え      | koromogae          | Changing seasonal wardrobe                         |

### 食欲の秋 (Shokuyoku no Aki)

"Autumn of appetite" — Japanese recognize autumn as the peak season for eating. 芸術の秋 (autumn of the arts), 読書の秋 (autumn of reading), スポーツの秋 (autumn of sports) are the other "autumns." Every pleasant activity becomes "the \_\_\_ of autumn."

### Tsukimi — Moon Viewing

On the 15th night of the 8th lunar month, Japanese traditionally view the harvest moon, eat 月見団子 (tsukimi dango — rice dumplings) and seasonal foods, and appreciate the moon's beauty. Many ramen shops release 月見ラーメン (egg-topped ramen) during this season.

## 冬 — Fuyu (Winter)

Months: December, January, February

Winter brings snow to large parts of Japan (Hokkaido gets enormous snowfall), bare trees, cold winds — and the year's greatest holidays and warmest food.

### Winter Vocabulary

| Japanese | Romaji      | Meaning                                                          |
|----------|-------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 雪        | yuki        | snow                                                             |
| 初雪       | hatsuyuki   | first snow of the season                                         |
| 雪景色      | yukigeshiki | snowy scenery                                                    |
| 霜        | shimo       | frost                                                            |
| 氷        | kōri        | ice                                                              |
| こたつ      | kotatsu     | heated table (blanket covers the top — everyone sits underneath) |
| おでん      | oden        | hot pot dish, winter comfort food                                |
| 鍋        | nabe        | hot pot (general term)                                           |
| ゆず       | yuzu        | yuzu citrus — fragrant, used at winter solstice baths            |
| 冬至       | tōji        | winter solstice                                                  |
| ゆず湯      | yuzuyu      | yuzu-infused bath at winter solstice                             |
| 年末       | nenmatsu    | year end                                                         |
| 大晦日      | ōmisoka     | New Year's Eve                                                   |

| Japanese | Romaji       | Meaning                                          |
|----------|--------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| 除夜の鐘     | joya no kane | New Year's Eve bell (rung 108 times at midnight) |
| 初詣       | hatsumōde    | first shrine visit of the New Year               |
| お正月      | oshōgatsu    | New Year                                         |
| お節料理     | osechi ryōri | New Year's traditional food                      |

## コタツ Culture

The こたつ (kotatsu) is a low table with a built-in heater, covered by a thick blanket (布団 — futon). You sit with legs underneath in the warmth. It's an institution:

コタツから出られない。(Kotatsu kara derarenai.) "I can't get out of the kotatsu." (Relatable seasonal complaint)

There is also a こたつ猫 (kotatsu neko) phenomenon — cats that colonize the kotatsu and refuse to share.

## Seasonal Greetings (季節の挨拶)

Japanese people adjust their greetings and letter openings by season. This is considered refined communication:

### Spring

春暖の候 / 花の便りも聞こえてくる今日この頃 "In this warm spring / as word of blooming flowers arrives"

### Summer

盛夏の候 / 猛暑の候 "In the height of summer / In this fierce heat"

暑中お見舞い申し上げます。 Summer greeting (July–August): "Warm wishes to you in this summer heat"

残暑お見舞い申し上げます。 Late summer greeting (August after Obon): "Warm wishes in this lingering summer heat"

### Autumn

秋冷の候 / 紅葉の便りも聞こえる頃 "As autumn cools / as news of autumn leaves arrives"

### Winter

師走の候 / 年の瀬も押し迫って "In this end-of-year rush / as year's end approaches"

寒中お見舞い申し上げます。 Winter greeting: "Warm wishes in this cold season"

## 季語 — Kigo (Season Words)

In 俳句 (haiku), every poem traditionally contains a 季語 (kigo) — a season word that places the poem in a specific time of year. Learning kigo is an elegant way to understand seasonal association:

| Season | Kigo                | Association         |
|--------|---------------------|---------------------|
| Spring | 桜 (sakura)          | Cherry blossoms     |
| Spring | うぐいす (uguisu)       | Bush warbler's call |
| Spring | 霞 (kasumi)          | Haze                |
| Summer | 蛍 (hotaru)          | Firefly             |
| Summer | 蝉 (semi)            | Cicada              |
| Summer | 梅雨 (tsuyu)          | Rainy season        |
| Autumn | 紅葉 (momiji)         | Maple leaves        |
| Autumn | 名月 (meigetsu)       | Harvest moon        |
| Autumn | 虫の音 (mushi no ne)   | Insect sounds       |
| Winter | 雪 (yuki)            | Snow                |
| Winter | 除夜の鐘 (joya no kane) | New Year's Eve bell |
| Winter | こたつ                 | Heated table        |

## Nature Vocabulary Beyond Seasons

### The Sky and Weather

| Japanese | Romaji   | Meaning       |
|----------|----------|---------------|
| 晴れ       | hare     | Clear, sunny  |
| 曇り       | kumori   | Cloudy        |
| 雨        | ame      | Rain          |
| 雪        | yuki     | Snow          |
| 霧        | kiri     | Fog           |
| 嵐        | arashi   | Storm         |
| 虹        | niji     | Rainbow       |
| 雷        | kaminari | Thunder       |
| 稲妻       | inazuma  | Lightning     |
| 風        | kaze     | Wind          |
| 日差し      | hizashi  | Sunlight      |
| 夕焼け      | yūyake   | Sunset glow   |
| 朝焼け      | asayake  | Sunrise glow  |
| 三日月      | mikazuki | Crescent moon |
| 満月       | mangetsu | Full moon     |

### Landscape

| Japanese | Romaji   | Meaning        |
|----------|----------|----------------|
| 山        | yama     | Mountain       |
| 川        | kawa     | River          |
| 海        | umi      | Sea / ocean    |
| 湖        | mizūmi   | Lake           |
| 森        | mori     | Forest         |
| 野原       | nohara   | Field / meadow |
| 滝        | taki     | Waterfall      |
| 崖        | gake     | Cliff          |
| 砂浜       | sunahama | Sandy beach    |
| 温泉       | onsen    | Hot spring     |



| Japanese | Romaji | Meaning              |
|----------|--------|----------------------|
| 火山       | kazan  | Volcano              |
| 棚田       | tanada | Terraced rice fields |

## Haiku — A Quick Word

Haiku (俳句) is Japan's most famous poetic form: three lines of 5-7-5 mora (sound units). They almost always contain a kigo and a kireji (cutting word — a pause or turn).

Matsuo Bashō's most famous:

古池や 蛙飛び込む 水の音 (Furuike ya / kawazu tobikomu / mizu no oto) Old pond — a frog jumps in — sound of water

The seasons aren't background in Japan. They're foreground.

Next up: Traditional Arts →

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## Traditional Arts — 伝統芸能と文化

"Japan has preserved arts that are a thousand years old. Tea ceremonies, kabuki, ikebana, sumo — these aren't museum pieces. They're living traditions that shape how Japanese people think about beauty, discipline, and craft."

Understanding traditional arts gives you a richer relationship with the language. The vocabulary, the values, and the aesthetic principles from these arts appear everywhere in modern Japanese — in business meetings, in poetry, in the way a gift is wrapped, in how a plate of food is arranged.

## 茶道 — Chado / Sado (The Way of Tea)

Tea ceremony is perhaps Japan's most famous traditional art. But it's much more than making tea.

What It Is

Sen no Rikyū (千利休, 1522–1591) formalized the tea ceremony (茶の湯 — chanoyu) into a complete aesthetic philosophy:

一期一会 (ichi-go ichi-e): Each meeting, each cup of tea, is a once-in-a-lifetime encounter. Treat it accordingly.

和敬清寂 (wa kei sei jaku): Harmony, respect, purity, tranquility — the four principles of tea.

The Space

- 茶室 (chashitsu): Tea room — intentionally small, unadorned, humble
- にじり口 (nijiriguchi): Small crawling entrance — everyone must bow to enter, equalizing all guests regardless of rank
- 床の間 (tokonoma): Alcove with a hanging scroll and seasonal flower arrangement
- 露地 (roji): The garden path leading to the tea room — part of the psychological transition

## The Vocabulary

| Japanese | Romaji   | Meaning                            |
|----------|----------|------------------------------------|
| 抹茶       | matcha   | Powdered green tea                 |
| 茶碗       | chawan   | Tea bowl                           |
| 茶筴       | chasen   | Bamboo whisk                       |
| 茶杓       | chashaku | Bamboo scoop                       |
| 棗        | natsume  | Tea caddy                          |
| 菓子       | okashi   | Sweet served before tea            |
| 点前       | temae    | The procedure of making tea        |
| 客        | kyaku    | Guest                              |
| 亭主       | teishu   | Host                               |
| 侘び       | wabi     | Beauty in simplicity, imperfection |
| 寂び       | sabi     | Patina of age, quiet beauty        |

侘び寂び (wabi-sabi): The aesthetic of finding beauty in imperfection, incompleteness, and transience. A cracked glaze, a weathered stone, an asymmetrical bowl — these are more beautiful than perfection in Japanese aesthetics.

## 生け花 / 華道 — Ikebana / Kadō (Flower Arrangement)

Western flower arranging fills vases with abundance. Ikebana does something different: it uses space and asymmetry to create a conversation between stems, leaves, and empty air.

### Main Schools

| School        | Style     | Characteristic                                      |
|---------------|-----------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| 池坊 (Ikenobō)  | Classical | Oldest school (15th century), formal and structured |
| 草月流 (Sōgetsu) | Modern    | Any materials, very free-form                       |
| 小原流 (Ohara)   | Natural   | Uses Western flowers, landscape arrangements        |

### Vocabulary

| Japanese            | Romaji      | Meaning                                      |
|---------------------|-------------|----------------------------------------------|
| 生ける                 | ikeru       | To arrange (flowers)                         |
| 花器                  | kaki        | Flower vessel / vase                         |
| 剣山                  | kenzan      | Needle frog / pin holder                     |
| 真 (shin)            | shin        | Formal, upright branch                       |
| 副 (soe)             | soe         | Secondary branch                             |
| 体 (tai) / 控 (hikae) | tai / hikae | Tertiary, lowest element                     |
| 間 (ma)              | ma          | Negative space (as important as the flowers) |

## 歌舞伎 — Kabuki

Kabuki is Japan's most celebrated classical theater form — a combination of drama, dance, and spectacular visual design that has been performed since the early 17th century.

## What Makes Kabuki Kabuki

- 女形 (onnagata): Male actors who specialize in female roles — considered an art in itself
- 隈取り (kumadori): Bold, stylized stage makeup in red, blue, and black — each color conveys a character type
- 花道 (hanamichi): The "flower path" — a walkway through the audience used for dramatic entrances and exits
- 見得 (mie): A dramatic frozen pose held at climactic moments, accompanied by loud wooden clappers (拍子木)
- 大向こう (ōmukō): The practice of shouting an actor's theatrical house name (屋号 — yagō) at the right moment — an art form practiced by dedicated fans
- 荒事 (aragoto): Rough, wild style — exaggerated heroics (Ichikawa Danjūrō style)
- 和事 (wagoto): Gentle, realistic style — romantic leads (Sakata Tōjūrō style)

## Famous Plays

| Play              | Notes                                                   |
|-------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| 忠臣蔵 (Chūshingura) | 47 Ronin story — the ultimate tale of loyalty and honor |
| 勧進帳 (Kanjinchō)   | Benkei and Yoshitsune evade a checkpoint                |
| 連獅子 (Renjishi)    | Father and son lion dance — spectacular                 |

## At a Kabuki Theater

イヤホンガイド — audio guide in Japanese and English explaining the plot 幕見席 (makumi seki) — cheap tickets for single acts — a great first way to experience it 掛け声 (kakegoe) — shouting at actors (屋号) — learning one to shout is deeply cool

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## 能 / 狂言 — Noh and Kyōgen

Kabuki is the popular art. 能 (Noh) is the aristocratic one — ancient, austere, and profound.

### Noh

- Developed by Zeami Motokiyo (1363–1443)
- Extremely slow, minimalist — silence and stillness are the medium
- Masks (能面 — nōmen) carry the entire emotional range of the character
- Text (謡 — utai) is chanted in an ancient, almost unrecognizable Japanese
- Themes: ghosts, spirits, the lingering of the past

幽玄 (yūgen): The aesthetic ideal of Noh — mysterious, profound beauty that cannot be described, only felt.

### Kyōgen

Comic interludes performed between Noh plays. Earthy, funny, often featuring servants outwitting masters. Much more accessible than Noh.

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## 武道 — Budō (Martial Arts)

Japan's martial arts are about far more than fighting technique — they're philosophical paths (道 — dō / michi):

| Art | Kanji    | Meaning                  | Focus                          |
|-----|----------|--------------------------|--------------------------------|
| 柔道  | Jūdō     | Gentle way               | Throws and ground work         |
| 空手道 | Karatedo | Empty hand way           | Striking                       |
| 剣道  | Kendō    | Way of the sword         | Bamboo sword (shinai) sparring |
| 弓道  | Kyūdō    | Way of the bow           | Archery as meditation          |
| 合気道 | Aikidō   | Way of harmonious spirit | Using opponent's energy        |
| 相撲  | Sumō     | —                        | Japan's ancient national sport |

## Sumo (相撲)

Sumo deserves special mention as Japan's oldest professional sport and its only truly national sport:

| Term            | Meaning                        |
|-----------------|--------------------------------|
| 土俵 (dohyō)      | The clay ring                  |
| 横綱 (yokozuna)   | Grand champion — highest rank  |
| 大関 (ōzeki)      | Champion — second highest      |
| 力士 (rikishi)    | Sumo wrestler                  |
| 場所 (basho)      | Tournament (6 per year)        |
| 仕切り (shikiri)   | Pre-bout stare-down            |
| 塩 (shio)        | Salt thrown to purify the ring |
| 立ち合い (tachi-ai) | The charge at the start        |
| 勝ち (kachi)      | Win                            |
| 負け (make)       | Loss                           |

The 15 honbasho (本場所) tournaments take place in Tokyo (January, May, September), Osaka (March), Nagoya (July), and Fukuoka (November). Attending a tournament is one of Japan's great live experiences.

## 書道 — Shodō (Calligraphy)

Japanese calligraphy is a fine art and a discipline. Written with brushes (毛筆 — mōhitsu) and ink (墨 — sumi) on paper (和紙 — washi):

| Style | Name   | Description                         |
|-------|--------|-------------------------------------|
| 楷書    | Kaisho | Block print — clearest, most formal |
| 行書    | Gyōsho | Semi-cursive — flowing, everyday    |
| 草書    | Sōsho  | Full cursive — highly abstract      |

Writing New Year's calligraphy (書き初め — kakizome) on January 2nd is a traditional New Year's activity.

## 折り紙 — Origami

Paper folding as art and mathematical form. 鶴 (tsuru — crane) is the most famous origami figure: fold 1,000 cranes (千羽鶴 — senbazuru) and your wish will be granted. Sadako Sasaki, the Hiroshima girl who died of radiation sickness, folded cranes while ill — her story made it a symbol of peace.

## 伝統工芸 — Traditional Crafts

| Craft                     | Region                                  | Description                                            |
|---------------------------|-----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| 漆器 (urushi / lacquerware) | Wajima, Aizu                            | Lacquer-coated wood — incredibly durable and beautiful |
| 陶磁器 (tōjiki / ceramics)   | Arita (porcelain), Kyoto (Kiyomizuyaki) | Japan has distinct regional ceramic traditions         |
| 西陣織 (Nishijin-ori)        | Kyoto                                   | Luxury woven silk fabric — used in kimono              |
| 友禅 (Yūzen)                | Kyoto / Kanazawa                        | Resist-dyeing technique for kimono                     |
| 江戸切子 (Edo kiriko)         | Tokyo                                   | Cut glass — geometric patterns                         |
| 南部鉄器 (Nambu tekki)        | Iwate                                   | Cast iron — especially teapots (tetsubin)              |

## 和の美学 — Japanese Aesthetics: A Quick Glossary

These concepts appear in art, design, everyday Japanese speech, and literary criticism:

| Concept | Reading       | Meaning                                                                            |
|---------|---------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 侘び寂び    | wabi-sabi     | Beauty in imperfection and transience                                              |
| 幽玄      | yūgen         | Mysterious, profound depth                                                         |
| 物の哀れ    | mono no aware | The pathos / bittersweet beauty of things                                          |
| 間       | ma            | Meaningful negative space                                                          |
| 粋       | iki           | Sophisticated, stylish chic — the Edo ideal                                        |
| 雅       | miyabi        | Courtly elegance                                                                   |
| 残心      | zanshin       | Remaining mind — sustained awareness after an action (martial arts and daily life) |
| 守破離     | shu-ha-ri     | Follow rules → break rules → transcend rules. The path of mastery in any art       |

守破離 (shu-ha-ri) is worth lingering on. It describes the three stages of mastery in any Japanese art or discipline:

1. 守 (shu): Follow the teacher's form exactly. No improvisation.
2. 破 (ha): Begin to break away. Find your own variations.
3. 離 (ri): Transcend the form entirely. Be yourself.

This applies to language learning too.

Next up: Trains & Transit →

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## Baseball & Sumo — Japan's Two National Pastimes

"Sumo is 1,500 years old and rooted in Shinto ritual. Baseball arrived in 1872 and became a national obsession within a generation. That Japan made both its own — completely, unapologetically — tells you everything about how this country absorbs and transforms what it loves."

Japan takes sports seriously. Not just as entertainment, but as expression: of discipline, of identity, of regional pride, of the values that matter. These two sports couldn't be more different in origin, but they've both come to carry enormous cultural weight in contemporary Japan.

## 野球 — Yakyū (Baseball)

### How Baseball Became Japanese

Baseball arrived in Japan in 1872, introduced by American teacher Horace Wilson at what is now Tokyo University. Within two decades it had spread to schools and universities across the country. Within a generation, it was no longer "an American sport" — it was Japanese.

The reason baseball took root so deeply is cultural alignment: the game rewards patience, precision, group discipline, and individual excellence within a team structure — values that mapped almost perfectly onto the Japanese aesthetic. A pitcher's psychological duel with a batter. The geometry of fielding. The patience of waiting for the right pitch. It felt familiar even when it was new.

By the 1930s, Japan was already producing world-class players. By the 1960s, professional baseball (プロ野球 — puroyakyū) had become the country's dominant spectator sport. It has never fully relinquished that position.

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### 安部磯雄 — Abe Isoo: The Father of Japanese Baseball

If Horace Wilson brought the ball and the bat, 安部磯雄 (Abe Isoo, 1865–1949) gave the game its soul.

Born in Fukuoka to a family of the declining samurai class, Abe was educated at 同志社大学 (Dōshisha University) before traveling to the United States in 1891 to study at Hartford Theological Seminary in Connecticut. He spent four transformative years in America — years that would shape everything that came after. He returned to Japan in 1895 carrying three things that seem almost impossible to reconcile: a deep Christian faith, a commitment to socialist reform, and an evangelical passion for baseball.

He joined 早稲田大学 (Waseda University) as a professor and promptly introduced baseball to the campus. But Abe's approach was never just about the sport. He saw baseball as a moral and educational instrument — a way to build character, cultivate discipline, and foster the kind of cooperative individualism he believed modern Japan needed. Where other educators saw athletics as a distraction, Abe saw it as a curriculum.

In 1905, he organized Japan's first collegiate baseball tournament — a landmark moment that planted the seed for the structured, deeply competitive university and high school baseball culture that defines the sport in Japan today. The obsession with Kōshien, the emotional weight carried by school baseball, the idea that playing the game properly is as important as winning it — these trace a direct line back to Abe's foundational philosophy.

What makes Abe Isoo so remarkable is the coherence of his contradictions. He was a Christian pacifist who corresponded with Leo Tolstoy on questions of peace, non-violence, and social reform — a genuinely extraordinary intellectual exchange across two cultures. He was a socialist politician who founded the Socialist Democratic Party and championed workers' rights at a time when doing so carried real personal risk. And he was a baseball evangelist who believed sport could quietly transform a society that lectures and pamphlets could not reach.

He understood something that took the rest of the world decades to articulate: that how a nation plays says as much about its values as how it governs. The patience, the respect between opponents, the emphasis on form and process alongside outcome — Abe encoded these into Japanese baseball from the beginning.

His influence is mostly invisible now, the way the foundations of a building are invisible. But walk into Kōshien during the Summer tournament, watch a team bow to the field after losing, watch players scoop up the infield dirt to take home, and you are standing inside something Abe Isoo built.

「野球は人格を鍛える最良の手段の一つだ。」 "Baseball is one of the finest means of forging human character." — Abe Isoo

| Key fact            | Detail                                                                      |
|---------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 生誕 (Birth)          | 1865, Fukuoka                                                               |
| 没年 (Death)          | 1949                                                                        |
| 大学 (University)     | 同志社大学 → Hartford Theological Seminary                                       |
| 職 (Role)            | Professor at Waseda University                                              |
| 業績 (Achievement)    | Introduced baseball to Waseda; organized first collegiate tournament (1905) |
| 政治 (Politics)       | Founder, Socialist Democratic Party                                         |
| 信仰 (Faith)          | Christian pacifist                                                          |
| 文通 (Correspondence) | Leo Tolstoy — on peace and non-violence                                     |
| 称号 (Title)          | 日本野球の父 — Father of Japanese Baseball                                        |
| 出典 (Source)         | abe-isoo.vercel.app/en                                                      |

## プロ野球 — Professional Baseball

Japan's professional baseball league is the 日本プロ野球 (Nihon Puroyakyū — NPB), divided into two leagues:

| League               | チーム                         | 本拠地           |
|----------------------|-----------------------------|---------------|
| セントラル・リーグ (Central)  | 読売ジャイアンツ (Yomiuri Giants)   | Tokyo         |
|                      | 阪神タイガース (Hanshin Tigers)    | Osaka/Koshien |
|                      | 中日ドラゴンズ (Chunichi Dragons)  | Nagoya        |
|                      | 横浜DeNAベイスターズ                | Yokohama      |
|                      | 広島東洋カープ (Hiroshima Carp)    | Hiroshima     |
|                      | ヤクルトスワローズ (Yakult Swallows) | Tokyo         |
| パシフィック・リーグ (Pacific) | 福岡ソフトバンクホークス                | Fukuoka       |
|                      | 北海道日本ハムファイターズ               | Sapporo       |
|                      | 東北楽天ゴールデンイーグルス              | Sendai        |
|                      | 埼玉西武ライオンズ                   | Saitama       |
|                      | オリックス・バファローズ                | Osaka         |
|                      | 千葉ロッテマリーンズ                  | Chiba         |

The climax of the NPB season: The 日本シリーズ (Nihon Series — Japan Series), held each October. Central League champion vs. Pacific League champion. The equivalent of the World Series.

## 読売ジャイアンツ vs 阪神タイガース — The Greatest Rivalry

The 巨人 (Kyojin — Giants) vs 阪神 (Hanshin Tigers) rivalry is the Yankees–Red Sox of Japan, except the cultural stakes may be even higher because it maps directly onto the Tokyo vs. Osaka cultural divide.

- Giants: Based in Tokyo, backed by the Yomiuri newspaper empire. The most decorated team in Japanese history (21 Japan Series titles). Many outside Tokyo consider rooting for them an act of cultural submission.
- Tigers: Based in the old Koshien Stadium in Nishinomiya (between Osaka and Kobe). Passionate, regional, and defined by their fans rather than their trophy case. Tigers fans are legendary for their intensity.

When the Tigers won the Japan Series in 2023 — their first championship in 38 years — Osaka erupted. Fans jumped into the 道頓堀 (Dōtonbori) canal in a tradition so established that the city prepared for it with safety measures.

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## 甲子園 — Kōshien: High School Baseball's Cathedral

甲子園球場 (Kōshien Kyūjō) in Nishinomiya is one of the most emotionally significant sports venues in Japan. Twice a year it hosts:

- 選抜高等学校野球大会 (Spring Kōshien): March/April — invitation-based tournament
- 全国高等学校野球選手権大会 (Summer Kōshien): August — the national championship

High school baseball at Kōshien is not just a tournament. It's a cultural institution. NHK broadcasts every game. The nation watches. Teams from small rural schools compete against urban powerhouses. When teams lose, they scoop up infield dirt to take home as a keepsake (土を持ち帰る — tsuchi wo mochikaeru). Players cry openly. Coaches cry. The crowd cries.

The pitcher who dominates a Summer Kōshien becomes a national hero overnight. This is where careers are made, dreams are set, and the entire country witnesses it together.

「甲子園に行きたい」 "I want to go to Kōshien." — The dream of every high school baseball player in Japan.

高校野球 (kōkō yakyū — high school baseball) has its own deeply embedded culture:

- Teams travel in matching uniforms even to watch other games
- Players shave their heads (丸刈り — marugari) as a sign of commitment
- Exhausted pitchers throwing complete games despite injury — and the debate this sparks about player welfare
- The song 「栄冠は君に輝く」 (Eikin wa Kimi ni Kagayaku) played at the championship

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## 日本の野球とメジャーリーグ — Japan and the Majors

Japan has exported baseball talent to MLB for decades, but the modern era is something different entirely:

野茂英雄 (Nomo Hideo, 1968–): The first to truly break through in MLB (Dodgers, 1995). His "tornado" delivery and immediate dominance shocked America and opened the door permanently.

イチロー (Ichiro Suzuki, 1973–): Redefined what a Japanese player could be in MLB. 3,089 MLB hits. 10 Gold Gloves. A style of play — precise, disciplined, relentless — that looked like a different game from what Americans were used to. He didn't adapt to American baseball; American baseball had to make room for him.

松井秀喜 (Matsui Hideki, 1974–): "Godzilla." Giants legend who became a World Series MVP with the Yankees (2009).

大谷翔平 (Ohtani Shōhei, 1994–): The phenomenon. A two-way player (投手/打者 — pitcher/hitter) at elite level simultaneously — something that hadn't been done sustainably since Babe Ruth. His 2021 season (9 wins as pitcher, 46 home runs as hitter) was statistically unprecedented. His \$700M contract with the Dodgers in 2023 was the largest in professional sports history. In Japan, his games air at 6am and people set alarms. He is genuinely the most famous person in the country.

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## Baseball Vocabulary — 野球用語

### On the Field



| Japanese     | Romaji                   | Meaning                     |
|--------------|--------------------------|-----------------------------|
| ピッチャー / 投手   | pitchā / tōshu           | Pitcher                     |
| キャッチャー / 捕手  | kyatchā / hoshu          | Catcher                     |
| バッター / 打者    | battā / dasha            | Batter                      |
| 外野手          | gaiyashu                 | Outfielder                  |
| 内野手          | naiyashu                 | Infielder                   |
| 一塁 / 二塁 / 三塁 | ichirui / nirui / sanrui | First / second / third base |
| 本塁 / ホームベース  | honrui / hōmu bēsu       | Home plate                  |
| マウンド         | maundo                   | Mound                       |

## Pitching

| Japanese   | Romaji            | Meaning                            |
|------------|-------------------|------------------------------------|
| ストライク      | sutoraiku         | Strike                             |
| ボール        | bōru              | Ball                               |
| アウト        | auto              | Out                                |
| 三振         | sanshin           | Strikeout                          |
| 完投         | kantō             | Complete game                      |
| 先発         | senpatsu          | Starting pitcher                   |
| 中継ぎ        | tsunagiri         | Middle reliever                    |
| 抑え / クローザー | osae / kurōzā     | Closer                             |
| 速球 / ストレート | sokkyū / sutorēto | Fastball                           |
| 変化球        | henkayū           | Breaking ball (general)            |
| スライダー      | suraidā           | Slider                             |
| カーブ        | kābu              | Curve                              |
| フォーク       | fōku              | Forkball (Japan's signature pitch) |
| 防御率        | bōgyoritsu        | ERA (Earned Run Average)           |
| 奪三振        | datsusanshin      | Strikeouts (statistic)             |

## Hitting

| Japanese    | Romaji              | Meaning                    |
|-------------|---------------------|----------------------------|
| ホームラン / 本塁打 | hōmuran / honrui da | Home run                   |
| ヒット / 安打    | hitto / anda        | Hit                        |
| 打率          | daritsu             | Batting average            |
| 打点          | daten               | RBIs                       |
| 盗塁          | tōrui               | Stolen base                |
| バント         | banto               | Bunt                       |
| 犠打          | gida                | Sacrifice bunt             |
| 満塁          | manrui              | Bases loaded               |
| 代打          | daida               | Pinch hitter               |
| 三冠王         | sankannō            | Triple Crown (BA, HR, RBI) |

## Game Situations

| Japanese | Romaji      | Meaning                 |
|----------|-------------|-------------------------|
| 表 / 裏    | omote / ura | Top/bottom of an inning |
| 延長       | enchō       | Extra innings           |

| Japanese  | Romaji          | Meaning                      |
|-----------|-----------------|------------------------------|
| 引き分け      | hikiwake        | Draw / tie                   |
| 逆転        | gyakuten        | Comeback / reversal of score |
| 逆転サヨナラ    | sayanara        | Walk-off victory             |
| 完全試合      | kanzen jiai     | Perfect game                 |
| ノーヒットノーラン | nō-hitto nō-ran | No-hitter                    |

## Baseball Fan Culture

Japanese baseball fans are among the most organized in the world:

- 応援団 (ōendan): Cheer squads in the outfield bleachers with trumpets, drums, coordinated chants for every player. The sound level is extraordinary.
- 選手別応援歌 (player-specific cheer songs): Each player has their own theme song. When they come up to bat, the crowd sings it in unison.
- 傘 (kasa — umbrellas): Yakult Swallows fans open umbrellas in unison after home runs.
- 応援グッズ (cheer goods): Plastic inflatable sticks (風船 — fūsen), megaphones, happi coats in team colors.
- 甲子園の六甲おろし: The Tigers' anthem — Kōshien shakes when 40,000 people sing it.

Stadium vocabulary: | Japanese | Meaning | |---|---| | 外野席 (gaiyaseki) | Outfield bleachers (cheapest, loudest, most fun) | | 内野席 (naiyaseki) | Infield seats | | 一塁側 / 三塁側 | Home team side / visiting team side | | 球場グルメ | Stadium food — a whole culture unto itself |

## 相撲 — Sumō

### The Ancient Sport

Sumo is not simply a sport. It is a 神事 (shinji) — a Shinto ritual — that has been practiced for at least 1,500 years. According to the Kojiki (712 CE), the fate of the Japanese islands was decided by a sumo bout between gods. The sport is wrapped in ritual, symbolism, and ceremony that makes it unlike any other athletic competition on earth.

Every element of sumo has meaning:

- The 土俵 (dohyō — ring) is a sacred space, constructed by a Shinto carpenter, purified with salt
- The roof above the dohyō at the major tournaments resembles a Shinto shrine roof
- The referee (行司 — gyōji) carries a short sword — symbolically, he is prepared to commit ritual suicide if he makes a wrong call
- Wrestlers throw salt (塩) to purify the ring before the bout
- The 横綱 (yokozuna) performs a rope dance (土俵入り — dohyōiri) derived from Shinto ritual

### The Ranking System — 番付 (Banzuke)

Sumo's hierarchical ranking system is one of the most rigorous in professional sport. Rankings are published on the 番付表 (banzuke-hyō — ranking sheet) before each tournament:

| Rank | Japanese | Notes                                                                                      |
|------|----------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 横綱   | Yokozuna | Grand champion — the pinnacle. Rarely more than 3–4 active at once. Can never be demoted — |

| Rank | Japanese   | Notes                                                         |
|------|------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| 大関   | Ōzeki      | Champion — second highest. Demoted if poor results sustained. |
| 関脇   | Sekiwake   | Third rank                                                    |
| 小結   | Komusubi   | Fourth rank                                                   |
| 前頭   | Maegashira | Upper division (numbered 1–17, lower number = higher rank)    |
| 幕下   | Makushita  | Second division — not paid professionals                      |
| 三段目  | Sandanme   | Third division                                                |
| 序二段  | Jonidan    | Fourth division                                               |
| 序ノ口  | Jonokuchi  | Entry level                                                   |

幕内 (Makuuchi) — the top division (横綱 through 前頭) — is what you watch at major tournaments. Only ~42 wrestlers compete here.

昇格 / 降格 (shōkaku / kōkaku): Promotion and demotion happen every tournament based on 勝ち越し (kachikoshi — winning majority) or 負け越し (makekoshi — losing majority) records.

#### The Six Tournaments — 本場所 (Honbasho)

| Tournament           | Location    | Month     |
|----------------------|-------------|-----------|
| 初場所 (Hatsu Basho)    | 両国国技館 Tokyo | January   |
| 春場所 (Haru Basho)     | 大阪府立体育会館    | March     |
| 夏場所 (Natsu Basho)    | 両国国技館 Tokyo | May       |
| 名古屋場所 (Nagoya Basho) | ドルフィンズアリーナ  | July      |
| 秋場所 (Aki Basho)      | 両国国技館 Tokyo | September |
| 九州場所 (Kyūshū Basho)  | 福岡国際センター    | November  |

Each tournament runs 15 days. Top-division wrestlers fight once per day. A 15-0 record is a 優勝 (yūshō — championship). 8 wins is the minimum to maintain rank.

両国国技館 (Ryōgoku Kokugikan): Tokyo's sumo arena — the spiritual home of the sport. Rows of box seats (枡席 — masuseki — literally "square seats") where parties of four share a small tatami-floored area with cushions. An extraordinary experience.

#### A Bout: What's Actually Happening

A sumo match (一番 — hitotsu) is often over in seconds. But everything before the first charge (立ち合い — tachi-ai) is theater:

1. 入場 (nyūjō): Wrestlers enter to their own theme music, wearing elaborate decorated aprons (化粧廻し — keshōmawashi)
2. 四股 (shiko): The iconic leg-stamping — purifying the ring, driving evil spirits into the earth
3. 塩まき (shio maki): Throwing salt to purify the ring
4. 仕切り (shikiri): The wrestlers crouch, stare each other down, and rise — repeatedly — until they're ready. Top division wrestlers get up to 4 minutes for this psychological duel.
5. 立ち合い (tachi-ai): The simultaneous charge — the most important moment. A false start (フライング) is called back.
6. 取組 (torikumi): The bout itself

Winning conditions: You win by either:

- Pushing/forcing your opponent out of the ring (押し出し — oshidashi)
- Making any part of their body other than the foot soles touch the ground (down = loss)

There are no weight classes, no time limits, no rounds.

### 決まり手 — Kimarite (Winning Techniques)

The Japan Sumo Association officially recognizes 82 kimarite (winning techniques). The most common:

| Kimarite | Reading        | Meaning                   |
|----------|----------------|---------------------------|
| 押し出し     | oshidashi      | Push out                  |
| 寄り切り     | yorikiri       | Force out (while holding) |
| 投げ       | nage           | Throw (various types)     |
| 上手投げ     | uwatenage      | Overarm throw             |
| 下手投げ     | shitatenage    | Underarm throw            |
| 突き出し     | tsukidashi     | Thrust out                |
| 引き落とし    | hikiotoshi     | Pull down                 |
| 叩き込み     | hatakikomi     | Slap down                 |
| 足取り      | ashitori       | Leg pick                  |
| 上手出し投げ   | uwatedashinage | Outside forward throw     |

The announcer calls the kimarite immediately after each bout — learning to recognize them dramatically improves the viewing experience.

### Sumo Vocabulary — 相撲用語

#### People

| Japanese | Romaji    | Meaning                                          |
|----------|-----------|--------------------------------------------------|
| 力士       | rikishi   | Sumo wrestler                                    |
| 親方       | oyakata   | Stable master / trainer                          |
| 行司       | gyōji     | Referee                                          |
| 呼出し      | yobidashi | Ring announcer (also maintains the ring)         |
| 床山       | tokoyama  | Hairdresser (builds the topknot)                 |
| 審判       | shinpan   | Judge (5 former yokozuna/ōzeki sitting ringside) |

#### Clothing and Equipment

| Japanese | Romaji       | Meaning                                                  |
|----------|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| まわし      | mawashi      | Loincloth — the only garment in competition              |
| 化粧廻し     | keshōmawashi | Ornate apron worn during ring ceremony                   |
| 横綱       | yokozuna     | Also refers to the thick rope worn by the grand champion |
| 大銀杏      | ōichō        | The topknot — wrestlers grow their hair to wear this     |

#### The Ring and Ceremony

| Japanese | Romaji      | Meaning                                                                 |
|----------|-------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 土俵       | dohyō       | The clay ring (4.55m diameter)                                          |
| 俵        | tawara      | Straw bales forming the ring boundary                                   |
| 徳利       | tokkuri     | The two mounds of clay inside the ring boundary (where wrestlers start) |
| 仕切り線     | shikiri-sen | Starting lines                                                          |
| 塩        | shio        | Salt (thrown before each bout)                                          |
| 柝        | ki          | Wooden clappers struck to mark ceremony beats                           |
| 懸賞金      | kenshōkin   | Prize money envelopes — waved around the ring before a major bout       |

## Results and Rankings

| Japanese | Romaji               | Meaning                                     |
|----------|----------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| 優勝       | yūshō                | Tournament championship                     |
| 幕内最多優勝   | makuuchi saita yūshō | Most career championships (all-time record) |
| 千秋楽      | senshūraku           | Final day of the tournament                 |
| 勝ち越し     | kachikoshi           | Winning majority (8+ from 15) — safe        |
| 負け越し     | makekoshi            | Losing majority — demotion                  |
| 全勝       | zenshō               | Perfect record (15-0)                       |
| 不戦勝      | fusenshō             | Win by default (opponent withdraws)         |
| 休場       | kyūjō                | Absence from tournament (injury)            |

## Legendary Yokozuna

The title of 横綱 (Yokozuna) is the most prestigious in Japanese sport. Only 73 have ever been awarded it. Each defined an era:

双葉山定次 (Futabayama, 1912–1968) — 69th consecutive wins The record that may never be broken. Yokozuna Futabayama won 69 consecutive bouts between 1936–1943. In defeat, he reportedly sent a telegram reading: 「未だ木鶏たリエズ」 — "I have not yet achieved the state of the wooden rooster" (a Zhuangzi reference — the highest state of calm mastery). That quote is quoted by sumo fans 80 years later.

千代の富士貢 (Chiyonofuji, 1955–2016) — "The Wolf" Perhaps the most popular yokozuna of the modern era. Lean and muscular in a sport of giants, he dominated the 1980s through intelligence and technique over raw mass. His retirement announcement press conference — where he said simply 「体力の限界です。引退します」 ("I have reached my physical limit. I will retire.") — was watched live by millions and remains one of the most quoted moments in Japanese sports history.

曙太郎 (Akebono, 1969–2024) — First foreign-born Yokozuna The American-born Hawaiian who became the first non-Japanese yokozuna in 1993. His promotion sparked intense national debate about tradition and identity — the Japan Sumo Association ultimately concluded that sumo is universal, not ethnic. Akebono's achievement opened the door for the Mongolian era that followed.

朝青龍明德 (Asashōryū, 1980–) and 白鵬翔 (Hakuhō, 1985–) — The Mongolian Dominance From the mid-2000s through the 2020s, Mongolian wrestlers — primarily Asashōryū and Hakuhō — dominated sumo completely. Hakuhō's 45 tournament championships is a record that obliterates all prior benchmarks. This dominance triggered complicated national conversations about the sport's identity, with Japanese fans simultaneously proud of sumo's global appeal and longing for a Japanese champion.

照ノ富士春雄 (Terunofuji, 1991–) — The Comeback King Mongolian-born, reached ōzeki in 2015, then collapsed to the lowest division due to catastrophic knee injuries. Most assumed his career was over. He

rebuilt himself, won his way back through every single division, and became yokozuna in 2021. His story is the most extraordinary sporting comeback in recent Japanese memory.

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## Sumo and Contemporary Japan

The "Japanese yokozuna problem": Japan has not had a Japanese-born yokozuna since 稀勢の里寛 (Kisenosato, 1986–), who was promoted in 2017 and retired in 2019 after injury. The national longing for a Japanese champion is acute — stadium attendance spikes dramatically when a Japanese wrestler performs well in a tournament.

国技 (kokugi — national sport): Sumo holds this distinction. No other sport does. But what "national" means when the top performers are often Mongolian, Georgian, Bulgarian, or Hawaiian has been a live cultural question for two decades.

Sumo's appeal to young Japanese: TV ratings for sumo have struggled among younger demographics. The Japan Sumo Association has responded with social media, YouTube highlights, and promoting charismatic younger wrestlers. The sport is genuinely trying to evolve while preserving its ritual soul.

Foreign interest: Sumo tourism has grown rapidly. The "sumo experience" (相撲体験 — sumō taiken) at stable morning practices (朝稽古見学 — asa-geiko kengaku) has become popular with international visitors. Some stables allow observation of morning practice — a genuinely extraordinary thing to witness.

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## Watching Sumo: What to Know

Attending a tournament:

- 枡席 (masuseki): Box seats, tatami-floored, 4 per box — shared with strangers if you buy individual seats
- 椅子席 (isu-seki): Chair seats, more conventional
- 立ち見 (tachimi): Standing room — available on the day, cheapest option
- Morning bouts feature lower-division wrestlers. Top division starts late afternoon.
- Arrive by 3:30pm to see the full upper-division program
- The 千秋楽 (senshūraku — final day) has the most drama and longest ceremony

Watching on TV:

- NHK broadcasts all six tournaments live from 3:00pm daily
- NHK BS often shows additional coverage
- The NHK sumo broadcast team is an institution — their calm, knowledgeable commentary is itself part of the experience

Essential viewing moments:

- 横綱土俵入り (yokozuna dohyōiri) — the grand champion's ring entrance ceremony. If a yokozuna is active, do not miss this.
  - 千秋楽の優勝決定戦 — championship playoff or deciding final-day bout
  - The 懸賞金 (kenshōkin) parade — advertisers sponsor prizes; the yobidashi walks the ring holding banners before a featured bout
- 

## Baseball and Sumo Together: What They Mean to Japan

The two sports occupy different emotional territories:

Baseball is Japan as it chose to become — the Meiji embrace of the foreign, the transformation of something external into something deeply national. It's regional pride (阪神 vs 巨人), youth and possibility (Kōshien), and now global validation (Ohtani).

Sumo is Japan as it has always been — ancient, ritualized, rooted in Shinto, carrying the weight of history in every salt throw. It asks what "Japanese" means and doesn't always give a comfortable answer.

Together, they hold the country's sporting identity between them: one looking outward at the world, one looking inward at what makes Japan Japan.

「野球は国民的娯楽、相撲は国技。どちらも日本の心です。」 "Baseball is the national pastime; sumo is the national sport. Both are the soul of Japan."

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## Vtubers, Streaming & Live-Comment Culture — 配信文化

"For a huge slice of young Japan, the dominant media isn't TV or even anime — it's livestreams. And live Japanese has its own vocabulary, written in scrolling comments at the speed of a slot machine. Learn it, and a whole world of natural, current Japanese opens up."

Japanese streaming culture — from the pioneering ニコニコ動画 (Niconico) to today's Vtuber empires (ホロライブ, にじさんじ) — produced a rich, fast-moving vocabulary. It's some of the most current Japanese you can study, and unlike scripted anime, it's real people talking in real time. This page covers the comment-culture, the fan jargon, and the general streaming terms you'll meet everywhere.

Register key: 【コメント】 = typed by viewers in live chat · 【ファン語】 = fan jargon you'll hear and read · 【死語気味】 = nostalgic/dated but still recognizable.

### Niconico & 弹幕 — Where Comment Culture Began

ニコニコ動画 pioneered comments that scroll across the video itself, synced to the timestamp. When a big moment hits, the screen floods — that's 弹幕 (danmaku), "barrage," borrowed from bullet-hell shooters. This culture seeded almost all Japanese live-comment language, and much of it migrated to YouTube Live and Twitch.

| Term              | Reading          | Meaning                                                                                  |
|-------------------|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 888888            | (pachi-pachi)    | Applause. 「8」 reads pa(chi) — the clap sound — repeated                                  |
| 草 / www           | kusa             | "lol" — 笑 → w → a field of w's looks like grass (草)                                      |
| 主                 | nushi            | The uploader/streamer (from 投稿主). 生主 = live streamer                                     |
| 神回                | kami-kai         | "God episode" — an exceptional stream or installment                                     |
| うぽっ               | upotsu           | "Thanks for uploading" (アップ + 乙)                                                         |
| おつ / 乙            | otsu             | "Good work / thanks / cya" (from お疲れ様)                                                   |
| 公式が病気             | kōshiki ga byōki | "The official account is sick" — admiring disbelief at something gloriously over-the-top |
| ｷﾀ━━━━(ﾟ∀ﾟ)━━━━!! | kitā             | "It's here! / Here we go!"                                                               |
| 弹幕薄いぞ!            | danmaku usui zo  | "The barrage is thin — what are you doing!" (demands more comments)                      |
| テラー / ギガー         | tera / giga      | SI-prefix intensifiers: ギガかわいい = "mega-cute"                                             |

A note on ASCII art (AA): Niconico and the textboard 2channel developed elaborate multi-line Shift-JIS art and characters like モナー (Monā), a cat whose catchphrase 「オマエモナー」 ("you too!") became a standard retort. It's nostalgic now, but it's the ancestor of today's emoji-and-sticker culture. See the Internet & Slang page for more 2ch heritage.

## Vtuber Fan Vocabulary — The Current Core

The Vtuber (バーチャルYouTuber) boom — anonymous performers streaming as animated avatars — created the most active fan vocabulary in Japan today. This is current, high-frequency, and increasingly mainstream.

### The performer and the avatar

| Term | Reading      | Meaning                                                                                      |
|------|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 中の人  | naka no hito | "The person inside" — the performer behind the avatar (mildly sensitive to mention)          |
| 魂    | tamashii     | "Soul" — the performer, especially the voice. Same idea as 中の人                               |
| ガワ   | gawa         | "Shell / skin" — the avatar model itself (as opposed to the 魂)                               |
| 前世   | zensei       | "Past life" — the performer's prior identity/account. Often taboo to bring up on stream      |
| 卒業   | sotsugyō     | "Graduation" — the euphemism for retiring or leaving an agency (cf. 引退, a harder retirement) |

### Money, clips, and metrics

| Term         | Reading      | Meaning                                                            |
|--------------|--------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| スパチャ         | supacha      | Super Chat — a paid, highlighted comment (YouTube tipping)         |
| 赤スパ / スパチャ 赤 | aka-supacha  | A "red superchat" — the top ¥10,000 tier, red banner               |
| 投げ銭          | nagesen      | "Tossed money" — tipping/gifting in general                        |
| 切り抜き         | kirinuki     | A clip — an edited excerpt of a stream                             |
| 切り抜き師        | kirinuki-shi | A "clipper" — someone who makes clips (often officially permitted) |
| 同接           | dōsetsu      | Concurrent viewers (同時接続者数) — the key popularity metric            |
| 案件           | anken        | A sponsored / tie-in stream (paid promotion)                       |

### Fans and how they organize

| Term      | Reading               | Meaning                                                                                        |
|-----------|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 推し        | oshi                  | The person/character you support and stan                                                      |
| 推し活       | oshi-katsu            | "Stanning activities" — everything you do to support your 推し                                   |
| 単推し / 箱推し | tan-oshi / hako-oshi  | Supporting one member only / supporting the whole "box" (agency)                               |
| ガチ恋       | gachi-koi             | "Genuine love" — a fan really in romantic love with the talent (carries an over-invested edge) |
| 〇〇民       | -min                  | Fanbase suffix: "the 〇〇 folk"                                                                  |
| リスナー      | risunā                | The viewers/listeners                                                                          |
| 凸待ち / 凸   | totsu-machi / totsu   | "Charge in" — waiting for others to call in / a collab call-in                                 |
| 個人勢 / 企業勢 | kojin-zei / kigyō-zei | Independent Vtuber / agency-affiliated Vtuber                                                  |

Tone warning: 信者 (shinja, "believer"), 養分 (yōbun, "nutrients" — a fan who keeps spending), アンチ (anti — hater), and ガチ恋 all carry a loaded or critical edge. They're not neutral — handle with care.

## General Streaming Japanese

Useful on YouTube, Twitch, and TikTok Live alike — the everyday plumbing of stream culture.



| Term        | Reading                | Meaning                                                                 |
|-------------|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 配信 / 生配信    | haishin / nama-haishin | Stream / live stream                                                    |
| 配信者         | haishin-sha            | Streamer (cf. ストリーマー, 実況者 for game commentary)                          |
| アーカイブ       | ākaibu                 | The VOD — the recording left up afterward. アーカイブ勢 = watch-later viewers |
| チャンネル登録     | channeru tōroku        | "Subscribe"                                                             |
| 高評価         | kō-hyōka               | "Like" (thumbs-up). 「高評価よろしく」 = "please like"                           |
| 待機          | taiki                  | "Standing by" before a stream starts. Viewers type 待機 in chat; 待機画面 =   |
| 初見          | shoken                 | A first-time viewer. 「初見です」 in chat; 初見さん歓迎 = newcomers welcome         |
| 定期          | teiki                  | "Recurring" — tag for a habitual comment or a scheduled stream          |
| モデレーター / モデ | moderētā / mode        | Moderator / "mod"                                                       |
| 荒らし         | arashi                 | Troll / chat griever                                                    |

## SNS Platform Language (TikTok / Instagram / X)

The places slang is born before it reaches anywhere else.

| Term          | Reading                       | Meaning                                                               |
|---------------|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| おすすめ          | osusume                       | The "For You" / recommended feed. 「おすすめに乗る」 = hit the FYP             |
| バズり / バズる     | bazuri / bazuru               | To go viral (from "buzz")                                             |
| 拡散            | kakusan                       | To spread/signal-boost. 「拡散希望」 = please share                         |
| 映え            | bae                           | Photogenic (from インスタ映え — the root survives; the full phrase is       |
| ストーリー / リール   | sutōrī / rīru                 | Instagram Stories / Reels                                             |
| 裏垢 / 鍵垢 / 病み垢 | ura-aka / kagi-aka / yami-aka | Alt account / locked (private) account / "venting" mental-health acco |
| リプ            | ripu                          | A reply (cf. ふぁぼ "fav," now dated — replaced by いいね)                  |
| 空リプ           | kara-ripu                     | "Empty reply" — posting at someone without @-mentioning them          |
| 引用            | in'yō                         | Quote-post (quote tweet). Post-rebrand: ツイート→ポスト, リツイ                 |
| FF外から失礼します    | FF-gai kara shitsurei shimasu | "Excuse me, replying as a non-mutual" (FF = Follow/Follower) — p      |

## How to Use This for Learning

Streaming is a goldmine because it's unscripted, but pace yourself:

1. Start with 切り抜き (clips). Bite-sized, often subtitled by fans, and they pick the funniest/clearest moments.
2. Read the live chat. It's a real-time vocabulary drill — you'll see 草, 888888, 初見です, and 待機 used in context within minutes.
3. Pick a streamer who speaks clearly. Variety/chatting (雑談配信) streams are better for language than fast-paced gameplay.
4. Cross-reference with the Contemporary Japanese page — streamers are where this year's slang shows up first.

Reality check: Some of this vocabulary (the niconico-era memes especially) is nostalgic, and fan jargon assumes you're inside the culture. Don't lead with スパチャ slang in a job interview. But for connecting with young Japanese people and consuming the media they actually consume, this is the real, living language.

The stream never stops, and neither does the language. うぼつ for reading this far.

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## Trains & Transit — Getting Around Japan

”Japan's train system is the greatest in the world. It's also complex enough to intimidate first-timers. But once you understand the logic, it's intuitive — and you'll miss it when you leave.”

Japan moves by train. The network is vast, punctual, clean, and covers virtually every corner of the country. Understanding how it works is essential for visiting, and it's loaded with useful vocabulary.

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### The Basics: Types of Trains

Japan's rail network is operated by dozens of companies. The major categories:

| Type                | Japanese         | Description                                                      |
|---------------------|------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| JR (Japan Railways) | JR               | National network — runs the Shinkansen and connects major cities |
| 私鉄 (shitetsu)       | Private Railways | Company-owned lines — Tokyo has ~10 major ones                   |
| 地下鉄 (chikatetsu)    | Subway/Metro     | Underground lines — Tokyo Metro, Osaka Metro                     |
| 新幹線 (shinkansen)    | Bullet Train     | High-speed intercity trains                                      |
| モノレール (monorēru)    | Monorail         | Airport connections, urban routes                                |
| バス (basu)           | Bus              | Supplements trains, essential in rural areas                     |

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### IC Cards — The Magic Card

IC cards (ICカード) are prepaid contactless transit cards. The major ones:

| Card         | Where                  | Works      |
|--------------|------------------------|------------|
| Suica (スイカ)  | Tokyo / JR East        | Nationwide |
| PASMO (パスモ)  | Tokyo private railways | Nationwide |
| ICOCA (イコカ)  | Osaka/Kansai           | Nationwide |
| Manaca (マナカ) | Nagoya                 | Nationwide |
| TOICA (トイカ)  | Nagoya/JR Central      | Nationwide |

Important: Since 2023, you can add Suica to Apple Wallet and Google Pay on your phone. This is the easiest option for visitors.

Using an IC card:

- Touch the sensor at the entry gate → green light → pass through
- Touch again at the exit gate → fare is automatically deducted
- You can also use IC cards to pay at konbini, vending machines, and some shops
- When card is low: 乗り越し清算機 (norioeshi seisanki — fare adjustment machine) at exit

## Train Vocabulary

| Japanese | Romaji         | Meaning                                                                 |
|----------|----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 改札       | kaisatsu       | Ticket gate                                                             |
| ホーム      | hōmu           | Platform                                                                |
| 電車       | densha         | Train (electric)                                                        |
| 路線       | rosen          | Train line                                                              |
| 乗り換え     | norikae        | Transfer (changing trains)                                              |
| 終電       | shūden         | Last train of the night                                                 |
| 始発       | shihatssu      | First train of the day                                                  |
| 快速       | kaisoku        | Rapid (fewer stops)                                                     |
| 急行       | kyūkō          | Express                                                                 |
| 特急       | tokkyū         | Limited express (faster, sometimes needs extra ticket)                  |
| 各駅停車     | kakueki teisha | Local (stops at every station)                                          |
| 回送       | kaisō          | Out of service / not in service                                         |
| 遅延       | chien          | Delay                                                                   |
| 振替輸送     | furikae yusō   | Alternative transport (when your train is delayed)                      |
| 指定席      | shiteiseki     | Reserved seat                                                           |
| 自由席      | jiyūseki       | Non-reserved seat                                                       |
| グリーン車    | gurīnsha       | Green Car (first class)                                                 |
| 人身事故     | jinshin jiko   | "Person accident" — someone on the tracks. All trains on the line stop. |

## Reading a Train Map

Japanese train maps use kanji station names — learning the kanji for your destination is essential.

Pro tip: Every station has a station number (letters + numbers, e.g., JY01, G03). This is displayed alongside the kanji name. Look for your number if the kanji is unfamiliar.

The station structure:

路線名 (Line Name) ← You need to know which line

駅名 (Station Name) ← Your destination

番線 (Platform Number) ← Which platform

## Tokyo's Key Lines

| Line              | Notable stations                              | Note                                     |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| 山手線 (Yamanote)    | Tokyo, Shinjuku, Shibuya, Harajuku, Akihabara | The green loop — connects all major hubs |
| 中央線 (Chūō)        | Tokyo → Shinjuku → Kichijoji                  | Red/orange line heading west             |
| 東海道線 (Tōkaidō)    | Tokyo → Yokohama                              | South/southwest                          |
| 総武線 (Sōbu)        | Tokyo → Akihabara → Ochanomizu                | Yellow line, east-west                   |
| 丸ノ内線 (Marunouchi) | Shinjuku → Tokyo (metro)                      | Red Tokyo Metro line                     |
| 渋谷から各線            | Shibuya hub                                   | Multiple private lines from Shibuya      |

## Platform Announcements — What You'll Hear

Japanese station announcements follow a pattern. Here's what to listen for:

## On the Platform

〇〇番線に〇〇行き〇〇が参ります。黄色い線の内側にお下がりください。 "The [bound for destination] [train type] will arrive on track [number]. Please step back behind the yellow line."

ドアが閉まります。ご注意ください。 "Doors are closing. Please be careful."

まもなく〇〇番線に列車が参ります。 "A train will arrive at platform [number] shortly."

## On the Train

次は〇〇、〇〇です。 "Next is [station name], [station name]." (Repeated in Japanese then often English on major lines)

お乗り換えの方は... "For passengers transferring to..."

この電車は〇〇行きです。 "This train is bound for [destination]."

まもなく〇〇に到着します。 "We will soon arrive at [station]."

終点、〇〇です。全員降りてください。 "This is the final stop, [station]. All passengers please exit."

## The Shinkansen (新幹線)

The bullet train is one of Japan's great achievements — and a great experience:

| Line              | Route                             | Max speed |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------|-----------|
| 東海道新幹線 (Tōkaidō)  | Tokyo → Osaka (via Nagoya, Kyoto) | 285 km/h  |
| 山陽新幹線 (Sanyō)     | Osaka → Hiroshima → Fukuoka       | 300 km/h  |
| 東北新幹線 (Tōhoku)    | Tokyo → Sendai → Morioka → Aomori | 320 km/h  |
| 北陸新幹線 (Hokuriku)  | Tokyo → Kanazawa → Fukui (new)    | 260 km/h  |
| 九州新幹線 (Kyūshū)    | Fukuoka → Kagoshima               | 260 km/h  |
| 北海道新幹線 (Hokkaidō) | Aomori → Hakodate → Sapporo       | 260 km/h  |

## Shinkansen Types (Tōkaidō Line, Tokyo–Osaka)

| Name         | Stops                                      |
|--------------|--------------------------------------------|
| のぞみ (Nozomi) | Fewest — fastest (Tokyo → Osaka in ~2h20m) |
| ひかり (Hikari) | More stops                                 |
| こだま (Kodama) | All stops — slowest                        |

JR Pass: If you're visiting Japan, a JR Pass (purchased outside Japan) can cover unlimited Shinkansen travel. Do the math — for multiple intercity trips it pays for itself.

Buying tickets:

- 自動券売機 (jidō kenbaiki) — vending machine
- みどりの窓口 (midori no madoguchi) — "green counter" — staffed JR ticket office
- Online at smart-ex.jp (for the Tōkaidō/Sanyō lines)

## Trains at Night: The Last Train (終電)

In Japan, missing the last train (終電を逃す — shūden wo nogasu) is a real concern. Trains stop running at midnight or earlier in most cities. The concept is important enough that:

- Izakaya TV ads always show people drinking and then rushing for the last train
- Many people plan their evening around the last train time
- Taxis after midnight are expensive (and fare can increase ~20%)
- Some people take 漫画喫茶 (manga kissa) — internet cafes — as emergency overnight stays

Check last train times on Google Maps Japan or Hyperdia.

---

## Etiquette on Trains

Japanese train etiquette is quietly strict:

| Do                                                  | Don't                                                        |
|-----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Line up on the platform markers                     | Eat on commuter trains (long-distance shinkansen is fine)    |
| Let passengers exit before boarding                 | Talk loudly on the phone (step off at a station if you must) |
| Give up priority seats (優先席) to those who need them | Put your bag on a seat during rush hour                      |
| Set phone to manner mode (マナーモード)                   | Play audio without headphones                                |
| Be quiet and still                                  | Push when boarding/exiting                                   |

Women-only cars (女性専用車両): Many lines have women-only cars during peak hours. Marked prominently. Men who enter are politely but firmly redirected.

Crowded trains during rush hour: Tokyo rush hour (7:30–9:00am on major lines) is genuinely intense. Train staff (押し屋 — oshiya, "pushers") sometimes help compress passengers into cars. It's uncomfortable and everyone knows it.

---

## Buses (バス)

Buses are essential in smaller cities and rural areas. The system varies by region:

Paying:

- Flat fare (均一料金 — kin'itsu ryōkin): Drop payment in the box when you board
- Zone fare: Take a numbered ticket when boarding, pay based on number when exiting

整理券をお取りください。"Please take a numbered ticket."

〇番の方はいくらですか？ "How much is ticket number ~?"

Hailing a bus: In some rural areas you must wave (手を挙げる — te wo ageru) to stop the bus. Don't stand stiffly hoping it will stop — it won't.

---

## Taxis (タクシー)

Japanese taxis are clean, reliable, and expensive:

- Red/orange flag light (空車 — kūsha) = available
- Green light (貸走 — chinso) = occupied

- Door opens automatically — do NOT try to open or close it yourself

〜までお願いします。 — To~, please. ここで降ります。 — I'll get off here. 領収書をください。

— Receipt please. メーターで行ってください。 — By meter, please.

Important: Car-sharing services like Uber exist in Japan but are restricted. In most areas, taxis are the only option.

## Navigating in Japanese

Essential apps: | App | What it does | |---|---| | Google Maps (with Japanese set) | Best overall navigation, includes transit | | Hyperdia | Detailed transit routes, fare calculation | | Yahoo! 乗り換え案内 | Japanese transit app — preferred by locals | | NAVITIME | Multi-modal Japan navigation |

Key questions:

〜はどこですか？ — Where is ~? 〜に行くにはどの電車ですか？ — Which train goes to ~?

この電車は〜に止まりますか？ — Does this train stop at ~? 乗り換えは何番線ですか？ — Which platform for the transfer?

Next up: Cities & Regions →

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## Cities & Regions — Japan Beyond Tokyo

"Tokyo is extraordinary — but it's not all of Japan. Every city has its own dialect, its own food, its own pace, and its own personality. The more cities you see, the more you understand the country."

Japan is divided into 47 prefectures (都道府県 — todōfuken) across four main islands (Honshū, Hokkaidō, Shikoku, Kyūshū) and Okinawa. Here's a guide to the major cities and regions, with the language and cultural notes you need for each.

### 東京 (Tōkyō) — The Capital

Population: ~14 million (metro: ~37 million — largest in the world) Dialect: Standard Japanese / Tokyo dialect (東京弁) Vibe: Intense, efficient, endlessly varied, expensive

Tokyo isn't one city — it's 23 special wards (特別区 — tokubetsuku) plus countless adjacent cities, each with distinct personality:

| Area                | Character                                                            |
|---------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 新宿 (Shinjuku)       | Skyscrapers, Golden Gai, Kabukicho red-light district, transport hub |
| 渋谷 (Shibuya)        | Youth fashion, Shibuya Crossing, music venues                        |
| 原宿 (Harajuku)       | Street fashion, Takeshita Street, Omotesando luxury                  |
| 秋葉原 (Akihabara)     | Electronics, anime goods, manga, maid cafes                          |
| 浅草 (Asakusa)        | Old Tokyo (下町 — shitamachi), Senso-ji temple, rickshaws              |
| 銀座 (Ginza)          | High-end shopping, galleries, cocktail bars                          |
| 六本木 (Roppongi)      | Nightlife, international crowd, art museums                          |
| 上野 (Ueno)           | Museums, zoo, Ameyoko market, Ueno Park                              |
| 下北沢 (Shimokitazawa) | Vintage shops, live music, indie cafes                               |
| 吉祥寺 (Kichijoji)     | Inokashira Park, consistently voted "best place to live in Tokyo"    |



- 一見さんお断り (Ichigen-san okotowari): Some traditional establishments in Gion don't accept first-time customers without an introduction. This is old merchant culture.
  - Geisha vs. Maiko: Geisha (芸者/芸妓) are fully trained. Maiko (舞妓) are apprentices. Photographing them without permission is considered rude — Gion has had to put up "no photography" signs.
  - Kyoto dialect is softer and more polite-sounding than Osaka dialect — centuries of court proximity.
- 

## 神戸 (Kōbe) — The Cosmopolitan Port

Population: ~1.5 million Dialect: Kansai-ben (milder than Osaka) Vibe: Stylish, international, comfortable

Japan's gateway to the world since 1858. Kobe has large Chinese and Western historical presence, resulting in a distinctive cosmopolitan character.

- 南京町 (Nankingai): Kobe's Chinatown — Japan's most authentic
  - 北野異人館 (Kitano Ijinkan): Western-style houses from the foreign settlement era
  - 神戸牛 (Kōbe Gyū): Kobe beef — some of the world's most expensive meat. Raised in the Tajima region.
  - ルミナリエ (Luminarie): Annual December light installation commemorating the 1995 Great Hanshin Earthquake
- 

## 名古屋 (Nagoya) — The Practical City

Population: ~2.3 million Dialect: Nagoya-ben Vibe: Industrial, practical, understated, strong local identity

Japan's fourth-largest city, home to Toyota HQ. Often overlooked by tourists — which means it's less crowded and more affordable.

Nagoya food (名古屋めし — Nagoya meshi): | Food | Description | |---|---| | 味噌カツ (miso katsu) | Pork cutlet with rich miso sauce | | 手羽先 (tebasa) | Chicken wings — sweet soy and pepper | | 名古屋コーチン (Nagoya Kochin) | Local chicken breed — superior quality | | あんかけスパ (ankake spa) | Thick sauce spaghetti — only in Nagoya | | ひつまぶし (hitsumabushi) | Grilled eel over rice, eaten three ways | | 小倉トースト (ogura toast) | Toast with red bean paste and butter |

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## 広島 (Hiroshima) — Resilience and Peace

Population: ~1.2 million Dialect: Hiroshima-ben Vibe: Warm, resilient, surprisingly vibrant

Hiroshima is an extraordinary city — rebuilt from nuclear destruction in 1945 into a thriving modern city that now advocates powerfully for peace.

Essential visits:

- 平和記念公園 (Heiwa Kinen Kōen): Peace Memorial Park and Museum — deeply moving
- 原爆ドーム (Genbaku Dōmu): Atomic Bomb Dome — only surviving structure near the hypocenter
- 宮島 (Miyajima): Nearby island with the famous floating torii gate of Itsukushima Shrine

Hiroshima food:

- お好み焼き (okonomiyaki) — Hiroshima style is layered (noodles inside), not mixed
  - 牡蠣 (kaki) — Hiroshima produces ~60% of Japan's oysters
  - もみじまんじゅう (momiji manjū) — maple leaf-shaped sweet filled with red bean paste
-



## 福岡 (Fukuoka) — Gateway to Asia

Population: ~1.6 million Dialect: Hakata-ben (博多弁) Vibe: Energetic, youthful, warm, growing fast

Japan's fastest-growing major city. Closest major city to China and Korea — the cultural crossover shows in the food and atmosphere. The city is divided into two areas: Fukuoka (newer, western) and Hakata (older, eastern, where the station is).

Fukuoka food: | Food | Description | |---|---| | 博多ラーメン (Hakata ramen) | Tonkotsu broth, thin noodles, 替え玉 (extra noodles) | | 明太子 (mentaiko) | Spiced cod roe — Fukuoka's most famous export | | もつ鍋 (motsu nabe) | Offal hot pot — rich, deeply flavored | | 水炊き (mizutaki) | Chicken hot pot with ponzu | | 屋台 (yatai) | Fukuoka has Japan's most famous yatai stalls — open-air food stalls at night along the river |

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## 札幌 (Sapporo) — Hokkaido's Capital

Population: ~1.96 million Dialect: Hokkaido dialect (closest to standard Japanese) Vibe: Cold, open, outdoorsy, dairy-obsessed

Hokkaido is Japan's northernmost and newest major island — only settled from the 1870s (the indigenous Ainu people have lived there for thousands of years). Hokkaido has wide roads, open landscapes, and a different feel from the rest of Japan.

Sapporo food (Hokkaido食文化): | Food | Description | |---|---| | 味噌ラーメン (miso ramen) | Sapporo's contribution to ramen culture | | ジンギスカン (Genghis Khan / Jingsukan) | Lamb BBQ — barbecue on a dome grill | | カニ (kani) | Crab — especially 毛ガニ (hairy crab) and タラバ (king crab) | | スープカレー (soup curry) | Sapporo's unique curry style — thin, spiced broth | | 乳製品 (nyūseihin) | Dairy — Hokkaido milk, butter, cheese, soft-serve ice cream | | ジャガイモ (jagaimo) | Potatoes — Hokkaido grows Japan's best |

Sapporo Snow Festival (さっぽろ雪まつり): February event with enormous ice and snow sculptures — one of Japan's great winter events.

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## 沖縄 (Okinawa) — The Tropical Islands

Population: ~1.47 million Language: Okinawan Japanese / Uchinaaguchi Vibe: Relaxed, warm, culturally distinct, subtropical

Okinawa is its own cultural world — historically the independent Ryūkyū Kingdom (琉球王国) until the late 19th century. The climate, food, music, and people have a different character from mainland Japan.

| Area                       | Character                                            |
|----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| 那覇 (Naha)                  | Capital — Shuri Castle, Kokusai-dōri shopping street |
| 美ら海水族館 (Churaumi Aquarium) | World-class aquarium with whale sharks               |
| 古宇利島 (Kouri Island)        | Beautiful bridge, beaches                            |
| 竹富島 (Taketomi Island)      | Traditional white-walled village                     |

Okinawan food: | Food | Description | |---|---| | ゴーヤーチャンプルー | Bitter melon stir-fry — Okinawa's most iconic dish | | ソーキそば | Okinawan noodles with pork ribs | | ラフテー (rafute) | Slow-braised pork belly | | ヒラヤーチー | Thin savory pancake | | 泡盛 (awamori) | Distilled Okinawan spirit — made from Thai-style rice |

Okinawa and longevity: Okinawa has long had one of the world's highest concentrations of centenarians (百寿者 — hyakujusha). This has been attributed to diet (lots of vegetables, tofu, and small portions of pork), community, sense of purpose (生き甲斐 — ikigai), and slower pace of life.

## Regional Language Quick Reference

| Region    | Key phrase     | Standard | Dialect                |
|-----------|----------------|----------|------------------------|
| Osaka     | "Isn't it?"    | でしょ      | やん / ちゃう               |
| Fukuoka   | "Right?"       | ですよ      | ばい                     |
| Nagoya    | "That's right" | そうですね    | そうだがや                  |
| Hiroshima | Request        | ーしてください  | ーしんさい                  |
| Kyoto     | "Thank you"    | ありがとう    | おおきに (formal contexts) |
| Okinawa   | "Hello"        | こんにちは    | はいさい / はいたい            |

## The 8 Regions of Japan

| Region               | Prefectures                                              | Key cities           |
|----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| 北海道 (Hokkaidō)       | Hokkaido                                                 | Sapporo, Hakodate    |
| 東北 (Tōhoku)          | Aomori, Iwate, Miyagi, Akita, Yamagata, Fukushima        | Sendai               |
| 関東 (Kantō)           | Tokyo, Kanagawa, Saitama, Chiba, Ibaraki, Tochigi, Gunma | Tokyo, Yokohama      |
| 中部 (Chūbu)           | Aichi, Shizuoka, Niigata, etc.                           | Nagoya, Kanazawa     |
| 近畿/関西 (Kinki/Kansai) | Osaka, Kyoto, Hyogo, Nara, Shiga, Wakayama, Mie          | Osaka, Kyoto, Kobe   |
| 中国 (Chūgoku)         | Hiroshima, Okayama, Tottori, Shimane, Yamaguchi          | Hiroshima            |
| 四国 (Shikoku)         | Ehime, Kagawa, Kochi, Tokushima                          | Matsuyama, Takamatsu |
| 九州 (Kyūshū)          | Fukuoka, Nagasaki, Kumamoto, Oita, etc.                  | Fukuoka, Nagasaki    |

Next up: Shopping & Money →

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## Shopping & Money — Life in Japan's Consumer Paradise

"Japan is simultaneously one of the best and most expensive places to shop in the world. It depends entirely on what you're shopping for and where."

Shopping in Japan is an experience in itself — whether you're in a hyaku-en (100-yen) shop buying everything imaginable for ¥110, navigating a seven-floor department store, or finding vintage treasures in a back-alley shop. Here's everything you need.

### Money Basics — お金 (Okane)

Japan remains largely cash-based compared to most developed countries, though this is changing fast.

## Currency

| Coin/Note             | Value   | Notes                                   |
|-----------------------|---------|-----------------------------------------|
| 1円 (ichi-en)          | ¥1      | Lightweight aluminum                    |
| 5円 (go-en)            | ¥5      | Hole in center, used as good luck       |
| 10円 (jū-en)           | ¥10     | Bronze                                  |
| 50円 (go-jū-en)        | ¥50     | Hole in center                          |
| 100円 (hyaku-en)       | ¥100    | Common silver coin                      |
| 500円 (go-hyaku-en)    | ¥500    | Most valuable coin, updated design      |
| 1,000円 (sen-en)       | ¥1,000  | Note — Noguchi Hideyo                   |
| 5,000円 (go-sen-en)    | ¥5,000  | Note — Higuchi Ichiyo                   |
| 10,000円 (ichi-man-en) | ¥10,000 | Highest denomination — Fukuzawa Yukichi |

Japan uses 万 (man = 10,000) as its base unit. A ¥30,000 item is 三万円 (sanman-en), not "thirty thousand yen." This is important when reading prices.

## ATMs

- International cards: Works at コンビニATM (7-Eleven, FamilyMart, Lawson) and Japan Post ATMs (ゆうちょATM)
- Most other ATMs (especially bank ATMs) don't accept foreign cards
- 7-Bank ATMs (inside 7-Eleven) are the most reliable internationally

## Cashless Payment

Japan is adopting cashless rapidly: | Method | Brand | Notes | |---|---|---| | IC Cards | Suica, PASMO | Also accepted at many shops | | QR Code | PayPay, LINE Pay, Rakuten Pay | Huge in Japan since 2018 | | Credit Card | Visa, Mastercard | Widely accepted in cities now | | NFC/Tap | Apple Pay, Google Pay | Works at most konbini and convenience |

## Vocabulary for Shopping

| Japanese        | Romaji                         | Meaning                    |
|-----------------|--------------------------------|----------------------------|
| いくらですか？         | ikura desu ka?                 | How much is it?            |
| ～はありますか？        | ~wa arimasu ka?                | Do you have ~?             |
| 試着してもいいですか？     | shichaku shite mo ii desu ka?  | May I try this on?         |
| 見てるだけです         | miteru dake desu               | Just looking               |
| レジはどこですか？       | reji wa doko desu ka?          | Where is the cashier?      |
| 袋はいりません         | fukuro wa irimasen             | I don't need a bag         |
| 領収書をください        | ryōshūsho wo kudasai           | Receipt please             |
| ポイントカードはお持ちですか？ | Pointo kâdo wa omochi desu ka? | Do you have a points card? |
| カードは使えますか？      | kâdo wa tsukaemasu ka?         | Can I use a card?          |
| 現金でお願いします       | genkin de onegaishimasu        | I'll pay in cash           |
| 税込みですか？         | zeikomi desu ka?               | Is tax included?           |
| 返品できますか？        | henpin dekimasu ka?            | Can I return this?         |

## Types of Stores

### コンビニ (Konbini) — Convenience Stores

The backbone of daily life in Japan. Open 24/7, they sell almost everything:

The major chains: | Chain | Notes | |---|---| | セブンイレブン (7-Eleven) | Considered best food quality, most ATMs | | ファミリーマート (FamilyMart) | Strong on hot foods, brand collabs | | ローソン (Lawson) | Strong selection, Lawson 100 (¥100 grocery section) |

What konbini sells:

- Hot foods: nikuman (meat buns), oden, karaage, fries
- Onigiri (rice balls), sandwiches, sushi
- Ready-to-eat bento
- All beverages including alcohol
- Stationery, medicine, cosmetics
- ATMs, fax, printing, paying bills
- Buying event/concert tickets
- Sending packages (宅急便 — takkyūbin)

### スーパーマーケット (Sūpā) — Supermarkets

For regular groceries. Major chains: イオン (Aeon), ライフ (Life), 西友 (Seiyu), OK ストア (OKStore). Discount hours: fresh items go on sale (割引 — waribiki) in the evening before closing.

### デパート (Depāto) — Department Stores

Multiple floors of everything, with immaculate service and corresponding prices. The 地下 (chika = basement) is the most important floor — the depachika (デパ地下) is a food paradise of sweets, prepared foods, and takeaway dishes. Worth visiting even if you don't buy.

Major chains: 伊勢丹 (Isetan), 高島屋 (Takashimaya), 三越 (Mitsukoshi), 大丸 (Daimaru)

### 100円ショップ (Hyaku-en Shoppu) — 100-Yen Shops

Everything ¥100–¥330. Quality varies but often excellent for kitchen goods, stationery, seasonal items, travel accessories.

Major chains: ダイソー (Daiso), セリア (Seria), キャンドゥ (Can Do)

Daiso has become internationally popular. Their Japanese packaging makes excellent listening practice.

### ドンキホーテ (Donki / Don Quijote)

The chaotic discount emporium. Open until midnight or 24 hours. Stacked floor-to-ceiling with everything imaginable — electronics, cosmetics, food, costumes, luggage, tax-free goods for tourists. The theme song will live in your head forever:

ドン・ドン・ドン・ドンキ！ドン・キホーテ！

### 古着屋 (Furugiya) — Vintage/Secondhand Shops

Japan's vintage clothing culture is world-class. 下北沢 (Shimokitazawa) in Tokyo and アメリカ村 (Amerika-Mura) in Osaka are the major vintage districts.

BOOKOFF (ブックオフ): Japan's secondhand bookstore chain — also sells CDs, games, manga, and increasingly clothing. Excellent and cheap.

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## Tax-Free Shopping (免税 — Menzei)

Non-Japanese residents can receive consumption tax (消費税 — shōhizei, currently 10%) refunds on purchases over ¥5,000 at participating stores:

1. Show your passport at the register
2. Ask 「免税をお願いします」 (menzei de onegaishimasu)
3. Items may be sealed in a bag until you leave Japan
4. Keep receipts — may be checked at the airport

Large stores, electronics retailers (ヨドバシカメラ、ビックカメラ — Yodobashi Camera, Bic Camera), and pharmacies commonly offer this.

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## Electronics Shopping

Akihabara (秋葉原) in Tokyo is the world capital of consumer electronics, though Osaka's 日本橋 (Nippombashi) and Nagoya's 大須 (Ōsu) are strong competitors.

Major electronics chains: | Chain | Notes | |---|---| | ヨドバシカメラ | Large, good prices, wide selection | | ビックカメラ | Similar to Yodobashi | | ノジマ | Regional chain, competitive | | エディオン | Strong in Kansai | | ヤマダ電機 | Japan's largest electronics chain |

Tip: For cameras, laptops, and audio gear, prices in Japan (especially at gray market/used) are often significantly lower than Western markets.

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## Pharmacy and Drugstores

Japanese drugstores (ドラッグストア — doraggu sutoa) sell cosmetics, OTC medicine, snacks, and a surprisingly good selection of food:

| Chain                       | Notes                        |
|-----------------------------|------------------------------|
| マツモトキヨシ (Matsumoto Kiyoshi) | Nationwide, strong cosmetics |
| ウエルシア (Welcia)              | Large, food section          |
| ツルハ (Tsuruha)               | Strong in eastern Japan      |
| コスモス (Cosmos)               | Discount focus               |

Popular items to buy at Japanese pharmacies:

- 龍角散 (Ryūkakusan) — throat drops / powder
  - バンテリン (Vantelin) — muscle/joint pain
  - 正露丸 (Seirogan) — stomach pills (extreme smell)
  - SPF50+ sunscreen — Japan makes excellent formulas
  - Hand cream — Japanese skincare generally excellent
- 

## Markets

| Market                | Location     | What                                              |
|-----------------------|--------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| 豊洲市場 (Toyosu Ichiba)  | Tokyo        | Tuna auction (reservation required), fish market  |
| 錦市場 (Nishiki Ichiba)  | Kyoto        | Food market in covered arcade                     |
| 黒門市場 (Kuromon Ichiba) | Osaka        | "Osaka's kitchen" — seafood and produce           |
| アメ横 (Ameyoko)         | Tokyo (Ueno) | Open-air market, discount goods, New Year's crowd |

## Bargaining Culture

Don't bargain in Japanese shops. The listed price is the price. Asking for a discount in a regular store will cause visible discomfort. Exceptions:

- Flea markets (フリマ — furima) and antique fairs — mild negotiation acceptable
- Electronics for large purchases — sometimes a minor discount if you ask politely
- Outlet malls (アウトレット) — price is already discounted

## Seasonal Sales

Japan has predictable sale seasons: | Season | Period | Notes | |---|---|---| | 冬のセール | January | Post-New Year sales | | 福袋 (fukubukuro) | January 1-2 | "Lucky bags" — sealed bags of goods at discount | | バレンタイン | February | Reverse in Japan: women give chocolate to men | | ゴールデンウィーク | Late April-May | Crowded but some sales | | 夏のセール | July | Summer clearance | | ブラックフライデー | November | Growing in Japan since ~2016 |

福袋 (fukubukuro) — lucky bags — are a January tradition. Shops sell sealed bags containing multiple items (usually above their combined retail value). People queue from the previous night for popular brands.

Next up: Emergencies →

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## Emergencies — Phrases You Hope You Never Need

"Japan is remarkably safe. Crime rates are low, hospitals are excellent, and public services work. But emergencies happen everywhere, and knowing what to say — or recognizing what's being said — can make a critical difference."

Bookmark this page. Print it. Save it to your phone offline. You won't need it 99% of the time, and you absolutely want it for that 1%.

## Emergency Numbers

| Number | Service               | Notes                                 |
|--------|-----------------------|---------------------------------------|
| 110    | Police (警察)           | Crime, accidents, suspicious activity |
| 119    | Fire & Ambulance (救急) | Both fire and medical emergencies     |
| 118    | Japan Coast Guard     | Maritime emergencies                  |
| #9110  | Police consultation   | Non-emergency police line             |

Important: English support is available at these numbers, but response varies by region. Some operators will immediately connect you to an interpreter. Speak clearly and slowly.

Tourist emergency hotline:

- Japan Tourism Agency: 050-3816-2787 (24 hours, multiple languages)
- JNTO: Japan National Tourism Organization operates regional multilingual lines

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## Medical Emergencies (病院・救急)

### Calling an Ambulance

救急車を呼んでください！ (Kyūkyūsha wo yonde kudasai!) Please call an ambulance!

〜に怪我をしました。 (~ni kega wo shimashita.) I have an injury to my ~.

意識がありません。 (Ishiki ga arimasen.) They are unconscious.

胸が痛いです。 (Mune ga itai desu.) Chest pain.

息ができません。 (Iki ga dekimasen.) I can't breathe.

〜にアレルギーがあります。 (~ni arerugi ga arimasu.) I'm allergic to ~.

薬は〜を飲んでいます。 (Kusuri wa ~ wo nonde imasu.) I'm taking ~ medication.

### At a Hospital / Clinic

| Japanese | Romaji      | Meaning                 |
|----------|-------------|-------------------------|
| 救急       | kyūkyū      | Emergency (room)        |
| 内科       | naika       | Internal medicine       |
| 外科       | geka        | Surgery / orthopedics   |
| 整形外科     | seikei geka | Orthopedic surgery      |
| 小児科      | shōnika     | Pediatrics              |
| 皮膚科      | hifuka      | Dermatology             |
| 眼科       | ganka       | Ophthalmology (eye)     |
| 耳鼻咽喉科    | jibiinkōka  | ENT (ear, nose, throat) |
| 歯科       | shika       | Dentistry               |
| 薬局       | yakkyoku    | Pharmacy                |
| 保険証      | hokenshō    | Health insurance card   |
| 処方箋      | shohōsen    | Prescription            |

### Key Medical Phrases

保険はありますか？ — Do you have insurance? 旅行保険があります。 — I have travel insurance. ここが痛いです。 — It hurts here. [point] 熱があります。 — I have a fever. 吐き気がします。 — I feel nauseous. 下痢をしています。 — I have diarrhea. 妊娠しています。 — I am pregnant. 血液型はAです。 — My blood type is A.

Travel insurance tip: Japan's healthcare is excellent but not free for non-residents. Even a routine ER visit can cost ¥5,000–¥30,000 or more. Comprehensive travel insurance is strongly recommended.

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## Crime and Police (警察)

Japan is one of the world's safest countries. Violent crime involving tourists is rare. Common issues: pick-pocketing (rare but exists in crowded areas), lost items, and occasional scams in entertainment districts.

### Calling Police / Reporting a Crime

助けてください！ (Tasukete kudasai!) Help me!

泥棒です！ (Dorobō desu!) Thief! (泥棒 = thief)

警察を呼んでください！ (Keisatsu wo yonde kudasai!) Please call the police!

財布をすられました。 (Saifu wo suraremashita.) My wallet was stolen. (Pickpocketed)

パスポートをなくしました。 (Pasupōto wo nakushimashita.) I lost my passport.

～に痴漢されました。 (~ni chikan saremashita.) I was groped/molested by ~. (Chikan is a serious crime in Japan)

### At a Police Box (交番 — Kōban)

Japan has an extensive network of 交番 (kōban) — small neighborhood police boxes staffed by local officers. These are your first port of call for:

- Lost items (日本人は届け出る — Japanese people return lost items at extraordinary rates)
- Directions
- Non-emergency reports

忘れ物をしました。 — I left something behind. 財布が見つかりましたか？ — Has my wallet been found? 盗難届を出したいです。 — I'd like to file a theft report.

Lost and Found: Japan's lost-and-found system is remarkable. If you lose something on a train, call the terminal station. Wallets with cash are routinely turned in intact.

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## Natural Disasters — 自然災害 (Shizen Saigai)

Japan experiences earthquakes, typhoons, tsunamis, and volcanic activity. This isn't rare — it's part of daily life for Japanese people, and the emergency systems are excellent.

### Earthquakes (地震 — Jishin)

If indoors during a major earthquake:

1. Get under a sturdy table or desk (身を守る — mi wo mamoru)
2. Stay away from windows
3. Do NOT run outside during shaking
4. If the shaking stops, exit carefully — check for structural damage

If outdoors:

1. Move away from buildings, utility poles, trees
2. Protect your head
3. Move to open ground

Earthquake alerts: Japan's 緊急地震速報 (Kinkyu Jishin Sokuho — Earthquake Early Warning) system sends alerts to all mobile phones seconds before shaking begins. You'll hear a distinctive alarming tone. This system genuinely saves lives.



Earthquake vocabulary: | Japanese | Meaning | |---| | 地震 (jishin) | Earthquake | | 震度 (shindo) | Seismic intensity (Japanese scale 1–7, not Richter) | | マグニチュード | Magnitude | | 震源地 (shingenchū) | Epicenter | | 津波 (tsunami) | Tsunami | | 避難 (hinan) | Evacuation | | 避難場所 (hinanbasho) | Evacuation site | | 余震 (yoshin) | Aftershock |

Tsunami warning:

津波注意報 (tsunami chūihō) — Tsunami watch 津波警報 (tsunami keihō) — Tsunami warning  
大津波警報 (ōtsunami keihō) — Major tsunami warning

If you hear a tsunami warning: Get to high ground immediately. Don't wait to see the water. Tsunamis move faster than people expect and the first wave is rarely the largest.

Typhoons (台風 — Taifū)

Typhoon season: July–October (peaks September). Japan is directly in the Pacific typhoon belt.

When a typhoon is coming:

- Trains and flights will be cancelled for major typhoons
- Convenience stores will run out of emergency supplies (bread, batteries, water)
- 暴風域 (bōfūiki) — storm zone — avoid being outdoors
- Plan to stay indoors

Typhoon vocabulary: | Japanese | Meaning | |---| | 暴風雨 (bōfūu) | Violent storm | | 大雨 (ōame) | Heavy rain | | 洪水 (kōzui) | Flood | | 土砂崩れ (dosha kuzure) | Landslide | | 避難勧告 (hinan kankoku) | Evacuation advisory | | 避難指示 (hinan shiji) | Evacuation order (mandatory) |

Emergency Alerts on Your Phone

Enable J-Alert (全国瞬時警報システム) if possible — Japan's missile and natural disaster alert system. All phones in Japan receive alerts automatically, but you may need to enable location services for your phone number in Japan.

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Fire (火事 — Kaji)

火事です！ (Kaji desu!) Fire!

逃げてください！ (Nigete kudasai!) Run! / Evacuate!

人が中にいます。 (Hito ga naka ni imasu.) There is someone inside.

Fire emergency number: 119

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Lost or Missing Person (迷子 — Maigo)

If you lose a child or someone loses you:

子供がいなくなりました。 (Kodomo ga inaku narimashita.) My child is missing.

迷子になりました。 (Maigo ni narimashita.) I'm lost.

At train stations and department stores, there are 迷子センター (maigo sentā) — lost children's centers. Announcements over the PA system for lost children use this phrase:

迷子のお知らせをいたします。○○ちゃん、○歳のお子様をお預かりしています。 "We have an announcement for a lost child. We have [child's name], a [age]-year-old child in our care."

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## Useful Emergency Vocabulary Summary

| Japanese | Romaji         | Meaning                                                     |
|----------|----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| 助けて！     | tasukete!      | Help!                                                       |
| 救急車！     | kyūkyūsha!     | Ambulance!                                                  |
| 消防車！     | shōbōsha!      | Fire truck!                                                 |
| 警察！      | keisatsu!      | Police!                                                     |
| 危ない！     | abunai!        | Danger! / Watch out!                                        |
| 逃げて！     | nigete!        | Run! / Escape!                                              |
| 火事！      | kaji!          | Fire!                                                       |
| 泥棒！      | dorobō!        | Thief!                                                      |
| 痴漢！      | chikan!        | Perver! / Molester! (shout this loudly on trains if needed) |
| 怪我       | kega           | Injury                                                      |
| 出血       | shukketsu      | Bleeding                                                    |
| 骨折       | kossetsu       | Broken bone                                                 |
| アレルギー    | arerugī        | Allergy                                                     |
| 痛い       | itai           | Painful / it hurts                                          |
| 気分が悪い    | kibun ga warui | Feeling unwell / nauseous                                   |

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## Practical Preparation

Before visiting Japan, do these:

1. Save emergency numbers in your phone (110, 119)
2. Photo your passport and store it in the cloud
3. Get travel insurance with medical evacuation coverage
4. Note your hotel address in Japanese — taxi drivers may not read English
5. Download Google Translate with Japanese offline — camera translation mode reads signs
6. Check travel advisories for typhoon season and earthquake-prone areas

Japan is safe. But prepared is better.

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## Japanese History — 2,000 Years in One Page (Roughly)

"You can't fully understand why Japanese people bow, why certain words are taboo, why the emperor still exists, or why Japan is simultaneously ancient and futuristic without knowing some history."

Japan's history is long, dramatic, and full of turns that shaped the language and culture at every step. This isn't a textbook — it's the essential context.

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## Timeline at a Glance

| Period         | Dates           | What defined it                                                       |
|----------------|-----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 縄文 (Jōmon)     | ~14,000–300 BCE | Hunter-gatherer culture, pottery, the original Japanese               |
| 弥生 (Yayoi)     | 300 BCE–300 CE  | Rice farming arrives from continent, social stratification            |
| 古墳 (Kofun)     | 300–538 CE      | Burial mound culture, early state formation, contact with Korea/China |
| 飛鳥 (Asuka)     | 538–710 CE      | Buddhism introduced, Chinese influence, early written laws            |
| 奈良 (Nara)      | 710–794 CE      | First permanent capital, Buddhism flourishes, kanji system formalized |
| 平安 (Heian)     | 794–1185 CE     | Kyoto as capital, aristocratic culture, classical literature          |
| 鎌倉 (Kamakura)  | 1185–1333 CE    | First shogunate, samurai rise to power, Zen Buddhism                  |
| 室町 (Muromachi) | 1336–1573 CE    | Ashikaga shogunate, Noh theater, tea ceremony develops                |
| 戦国 (Sengoku)   | 1467–1615 CE    | Warring States — constant civil war, Europeans arrive                 |
| 江戸 (Edo)       | 1603–1868 CE    | Tokugawa isolation, peace, merchant culture, ukiyo-e                  |
| 明治 (Meiji)     | 1868–1912 CE    | Modernization, westernization, empire-building                        |
| 大正 (Taishō)    | 1912–1926 CE    | Democracy, liberalism, early mass culture                             |
| 昭和 (Shōwa)     | 1926–1989 CE    | WWII, defeat, occupation, economic miracle                            |
| 平成 (Heisei)    | 1989–2019 CE    | Bubble bust, lost decade, digital age                                 |
| 令和 (Reiwa)     | 2019–present    | New era under Emperor Naruhito                                        |

## The Ancient Periods — Before Written History

Jōmon (縄文) — ~14,000–300 BCE

The Jōmon people were among the earliest pottery-makers in the world. They hunted, fished, and gathered, living in pit dwellings across the archipelago. Their name comes from the "rope pattern" (縄文) on their pottery.

Modern Japanese are genetically a mixture of Jōmon descendants (especially in Okinawa and Hokkaido) and later Yayoi immigrants.

Yayoi (弥生) — 300 BCE–300 CE

Wet rice agriculture arrived from the Korean peninsula and China, bringing social hierarchy, bronze and iron tools, and a new population. The Yayoi gradually absorbed or displaced much of the Jōmon culture — this is the foundation of what we now recognize as "Japanese" society.

## Classical Japan — The Era of Aristocrats

Asuka Period (飛鳥) — 538–710 CE

Buddhism was officially introduced in 552 CE from Korea, and transformed Japan culturally, artistically, and philosophically. Prince Shōtoku (聖徳太子) promoted Buddhism and Chinese governance models. Japan began using Chinese writing (eventually adapting it into kanji + kana).

Nara Period (奈良) — 710–794 CE

Japan's first permanent capital at Nara. The great Tōdai-ji temple (東大寺) with its enormous bronze Buddha was built. The Man'yōshū (万葉集) — Japan's oldest poetry anthology — was compiled. Chinese cultural influence reached its peak.

## Heian Period (平安) — 794–1185 CE

Kyoto (then called Heian-kyō) became the capital and remained so for over 1,000 years. This is the golden age of Japanese aristocratic culture:

- The Tale of Genji (源氏物語) by Murasaki Shikibu — often called the world's first novel (1021 CE)
- The Pillow Book (枕草子) by Sei Shōnagon — brilliant court memoir
- Hiragana and katakana were developed in this era — allowing Japanese to write their language phonetically instead of only in Chinese characters
- Court ladies wrote extensively in Japanese (hiragana); men wrote in Chinese (kanji)

The Heian ideal: もののあわれ (mono no aware) — the bittersweet pathos of things. Cherry blossoms, autumn leaves, the fragility of beauty. This aesthetic still defines Japanese sensibility.

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## The Age of Warriors — Samurai Japan

### Kamakura Period (鎌倉) — 1185–1333 CE

The imperial court lost effective power to the samurai class. Minamoto no Yoritomo established Japan's first shogunate (幕府 — bakufu) in Kamakura. The country was now ruled by military commanders while the emperor remained a figurehead in Kyoto — a split that persisted for 700 years.

Zen Buddhism (禅) flourished, influencing martial culture, art, and aesthetics. The Mongol invasions of 1274 and 1281 were repelled partly by typhoons — the 神風 (kamikaze — "divine wind") — which took on mythological significance.

### Muromachi Period (室町) — 1336–1573 CE

The Ashikaga shogunate moved back to Kyoto. This era saw the development of:

- 能楽 (Nōgaku) — Noh theater
- 茶の湯 (chanoyu) — tea ceremony
- 生け花 (ikebana) — flower arrangement
- 枯山水 (karesansui) — dry rock gardens
- 水墨画 (suibokuga) — ink wash painting

The Ōnin War (1467) began the Sengoku Jidai (戦国時代 — Warring States Period), a century of brutal civil war among feudal lords (大名 — daimyo).

### Sengoku Period (戦国) — 1467–1615 CE

Japan's most turbulent era — and one of its most romanticized. Three figures dominate:

織田信長 (Oda Nobunaga, 1534–1582): Ruthless, innovative, nearly unified Japan. Welcomed Portuguese missionaries and firearms. Betrayed and forced to commit suicide by a vassal.

豊臣秀吉 (Toyotomi Hideyoshi, 1536–1598): The peasant who rose to rule all Japan. Banned swords for non-samurai, invaded Korea twice, and left a fragile succession.

徳川家康 (Tokugawa Ieyasu, 1543–1616): Patient, strategic, waited for his moment. After the Battle of Sekigahara (関ヶ原の戦い) in 1600, he established 250 years of peace under the Tokugawa shogunate.

Europeans arrive: Portuguese traders reached Japan in 1543. Christianity spread rapidly until Hideyoshi and the Tokugawa banned and suppressed it, fearing European influence.

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## The Edo Period — Isolation and Culture

Edo Period (江戸) — 1603–1868 CE

Tokugawa Ieyasu established his shogunate in Edo (today's Tokyo). The Sakoku (鎖国 — "chained country") policy isolated Japan from most foreign contact for ~200 years.

What isolation produced:

- Population grew to ~30 million
- Peace allowed merchant culture to flourish
- 浮世絵 (ukiyo-e) — woodblock prints — emerged (Hokusai, Hiroshige)
- 歌舞伎 (kabuki) flourished as popular theater
- 俳句 (haiku) reached its peak with Matsuo Bashō
- Edo language (Tokyo dialect) became the de facto standard

The merchant class (商人 — shōnin) grew wealthy despite officially being the lowest rung of society (士農工商 — samurai, farmer, artisan, merchant). Their culture — sharp, witty, pleasure-seeking — produced ukiyo-e, kabuki, and the concept of 粋 (iki — stylish sophistication).

Forced opening: In 1853, American Commodore Matthew Perry arrived with black warships (黒船 — kurofune) and demanded Japan open its ports. The shock of this ended the Tokugawa shogunate within 15 years.

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## The Modern Era — Transformation at Speed

Meiji Period (明治) — 1868–1912 CE

The Meiji Restoration (明治維新) was one of the most rapid transformations in human history. The emperor was restored to power, the samurai class was abolished, and Japan deliberately modernized by adopting Western technology, law, education, and military systems.

In one generation, Japan went from feudal isolation to:

- Constitutional government (1889)
- Modern army and navy
- Railroads, telegraph, universities
- Victory over China (1895) and Russia (1905) — shocking the world

Japanese was standardized during this period — regional dialects suppressed in schools, literacy driven to near 100%, and a standard written language established.

The loanword explosion began: hundreds of Western concepts were translated into new compound kanji words (電話 — telephone, 鉄道 — railway, 民主主義 — democracy) or borrowed as katakana (ビール, テレビ, etc.).

Taishō Period (大正) — 1912–1926 CE

A brief democratic flowering. Jazz arrived. Western fashion arrived. Modern cities emerged. The Great Kanto Earthquake of 1923 killed ~100,000 and destroyed much of Tokyo and Yokohama.

Shōwa Period: Militarism and War (昭和) — 1926–1945

Military factions gained control of the government. Japan invaded Manchuria (1931), then China (1937 — Nanjing Massacre), then Southeast Asia and the Pacific (1941). The attack on Pearl Harbor brought the US into WWII.

Japan surrendered on August 15, 1945 — after atomic bombs on Hiroshima (August 6) and Nagasaki (August 9), and the Soviet declaration of war. Emperor Hirohito's radio broadcast (玉音放送 — Gyokuon-hōsō, "Jewel Voice Broadcast") announcing surrender was the first time most Japanese had heard his voice.

### Postwar Japan — Covered in Detail

→ See Postwar Japan for the full story of occupation, recovery, and the economic miracle.

### The Era System (元号 — Gengō)

Japan uses both Western (2025) and imperial era dates. The era changes with each new emperor:

| Era         | Emperor   | Years        | Key meaning           |
|-------------|-----------|--------------|-----------------------|
| 明治 (Meiji)  | Mutsuhito | 1868–1912    | "Enlightened rule"    |
| 大正 (Taishō) | Yoshihito | 1912–1926    | "Great righteousness" |
| 昭和 (Shōwa)  | Hirohito  | 1926–1989    | "Radiant Japan"       |
| 平成 (Heisei) | Akihito   | 1989–2019    | "Achieving peace"     |
| 令和 (Reiwa)  | Naruhito  | 2019–present | "Beautiful harmony"   |

Japanese official documents, some businesses, and many older people still use era years. 令和7年 = 2025.

### Language and History: The Direct Connections

| Historical event               | Language impact                                                  |
|--------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Chinese influence (Asuka/Nara) | Kanji system, on-yomi readings, Chinese-origin vocabulary        |
| Heian aristocratic culture     | Hiragana/katakana development, classical Japanese literary forms |
| Samurai culture (Kamakura–Edo) | Martial vocabulary, code of conduct language, bushido terms      |
| Edo merchant culture           | Humor, irony, colloquialisms, urban slang (江戸っ子言葉)               |
| Meiji westernization           | Massive katakana loanword adoption, language standardization     |
| WWII and occupation            | American English loanwords, simplified writing reform            |
| Postwar pop culture            | New slang, manga/anime language, youth speech patterns           |

Every layer of Japanese history left a layer in the language. That's why Japanese feels simultaneously ancient and ultra-modern.

Next: Samurai & Bushido → | Postwar Japan →

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### Samurai & Bushido — The Code That Still Echoes

"Japan hasn't had samurai for 150 years. And yet: the vocabulary, the ethics, the aesthetics, and the social expectations they created are everywhere in modern Japan."

The samurai (侍) were the warrior class of feudal Japan — not just fighters, but an entire social caste with its own code, culture, aesthetics, and worldview. Understanding them explains a lot about modern Japan: why honor matters so much, why shame is so powerful, why discipline and craft are revered, and why the concept of "the path" (道 — dō) appears in everything from martial arts to tea ceremony.

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## Who Were the Samurai?

The word 侍 (samurai) comes from the verb 侍う (saburau) — to serve. Samurai were originally palace guards and warriors in service to noble houses. By the Kamakura Period (1185), they had become the ruling class.

The samurai were one of four official social classes in Edo Japan:

1. 士 (shi) — Samurai (top, despite being theoretically servants)
2. 農 (nō) — Farmers
3. 工 (kō) — Artisans
4. 商 (shō) — Merchants (bottom, despite often being the wealthiest)

Samurai identified by their two swords (大小 — daishō): a long sword (大刀 — daitō, or 刀 — katana) and a short sword (小刀 — shōtō, or 脇差 — wakizashi). Carrying both was the exclusive right of the samurai class.

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## Bushido — 武士道 (The Way of the Warrior)

武士道 (bushidō) — literally "the way of the warrior" — is the ethical code of the samurai. It wasn't a written legal code but a lived philosophy passed through training, literature, and example.

The concept was formalized in the book 『葉隠』 (Hagakure, c. 1709) by Yamamoto Tsunetomo:

「武士道とは、死ぬことと見つけたり」 "Bushidō is the way of dying."

This deliberately provocative statement means: a samurai should live as though already dead — free from the fear of death, able to act with complete commitment to duty and honor.

## The Seven Virtues of Bushido

Different sources vary slightly, but these are the core values:

| Virtue | Japanese | Meaning                       |
|--------|----------|-------------------------------|
| 義      | Gi       | Righteousness / moral justice |
| 勇      | Yū       | Courage / bravery             |
| 仁      | Jin      | Benevolence / compassion      |
| 礼      | Rei      | Respect / courtesy            |
| 誠      | Makoto   | Sincerity / honesty           |
| 名誉     | Meiyo    | Honor                         |
| 忠義     | Chūgi    | Loyalty                       |

These aren't abstract ideals — they governed daily behavior, speech, and social interaction in the samurai class.

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## 切腹 — Seppuku (Ritual Suicide)

切腹 (seppuku) — also known as harakiri (腹切り) — was ritual self-disembowelment. It sounds extreme because it is. But understanding it illuminates the samurai worldview:

- Death before dishonor: Capture, failure, or disgrace meant loss of honor that could not be recovered. Death by one's own hand was considered far superior to an ignoble death or surrender.
- Agency in death: Performing seppuku correctly was itself an act of courage and honor. A designated second (介錯人 — kaishaku-nin) would behead the samurai at the right moment to prevent unnecessary suffering.
- Social function: Seppuku was also a formal punishment, sometimes ordered by a lord. The condemned performed it with dignity — sparing themselves execution by an enemy.

The most famous example in popular culture: 忠臣蔵 (Chūshingura) — the 47 Ronin, who avenged their master's forced seppuku and then performed seppuku themselves. This story has been retold in every art form for 300 years.

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## Key Concepts That Survive in Modern Japan

### 恥 (Haji) — Shame

Shame in Japanese culture is not just personal embarrassment — it's a social force. Losing face (顔を潰す — kao wo tsubusu) in front of others carries enormous weight. This is samurai ethics secularized into modern social norms.

恥をさらす (haji wo sarasu) — To expose one's shame 恥ずかしい (hazukashii) — Shameful / embarrassing

### 義理 (Giri) — Duty / Obligation

義理 (giri) is the obligation you have to those who have done something for you. It's the engine of Japanese social reciprocity — gifts, favors, and effort must be acknowledged and returned.

In contrast: 人情 (ninjō) — human feeling, spontaneous emotion. The tension between giri (obligation) and ninjō (feeling) is a central theme in Japanese literature, film, and drama.

### 面目 (Menmoku) — Face

Honor in the eyes of others. Samurai lived and died for face. Modern Japanese culture continues to place enormous importance on not losing face — your own, or causing someone else to lose theirs.

### 克己 (Kokki) — Self-Mastery

The samurai ideal of controlling emotions, desires, and reactions. Shows up in the discipline expected in schools, companies, martial arts, and traditional arts (茶道、剣道、etc.).

### 残心 (Zanshin) — Remaining Awareness

After completing an action, maintain focused awareness. In sword fighting — stay alert after the strike. In everyday life — remain present and attentive after completing a task. Still explicitly taught in kendo, archery, and other martial arts.

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## Famous Samurai and Their Legacy

宮本武蔵 (Miyamoto Musashi, 1584–1645)

Japan's most famous swordsman. Fought 60+ duels and reportedly never lost. His 『五輪書』 (The Book of Five Rings) remains a classic text on strategy studied by business executives worldwide.

「千日の稽古を鍛とし、万日の稽古を錬とす。」 "A thousand days of practice is discipline; ten thousand days is mastery."

武田信玄 (Takeda Shingen, 1521–1573)

Warlord of Kai province, legendary for cavalry tactics and governance. His motto:

「人は城、人は石垣、人は堀、情けは味方、仇は敵なり」 "People are the castle, people are the walls, people are the moat. Sympathy is an ally, cruelty an enemy."

上杉謙信 (Uesugi Kenshin, 1530–1578)

Rival of Takeda Shingen, considered the "God of War." Known for rigid personal ethics — he even sent salt to Shingen when an economic blockade was cutting off Kai province's salt supply.

土方歳三 (Hijikata Toshizō, 1835–1869)

Vice-commander of the Shinsengumi (新選組) — the pro-Shogunate police force in Kyoto during the Meiji transition. Fought to the end at Hakodate in the last battle of the Boshin War. A romanticized figure representing samurai loyalty.

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## Samurai Aesthetics — Beautiful and Deadly

刀 (Katana) — The Soul of the Samurai

A Japanese sword is not just a weapon — it's considered a work of art and the physical embodiment of the samurai's soul. The creation of a katana involves:

- Tamahagane (玉鋼) — special steel made from iron sand
- Folding the steel up to 1,000 times
- Differential hardening (土取り — tsuchidori) — creating a hard edge and flexible spine

Sword vocabulary: | Japanese | Meaning | |---|---| | 刀 (katana) | Japanese sword (general / long) | | 脇差 (wakizashi) | Short companion sword | | 鐔 (tsuba) | Guard / hand protector | | 刃 (ha) | Blade / edge | | 鞘 (saya) | Scabbard | | 鍛冶師 (kajishi) | Swordsmith | | 銘 (mei) | Signature on the blade |

甲冑 (Katchū) — Armor

Japanese armor is extraordinary as functional design and art. Lacquered plates (小札 — kozane), elaborate helmets (兜 — kabuto) with decorative crests (前立 — maedate), and flowing lacing (威し — odoshi) in bright colors.

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## Samurai in Modern Culture

The samurai never fully disappeared — they transformed:

Business:

- Corporate loyalty culture echoes samurai loyalty to their lord
- Lifetime employment (終身雇用 — shūshin koyō) was samurai service in modern dress
- 武士道 vocabulary appears in corporate speeches and motivational culture

Martial arts: Kendo (剣道), judo (柔道), aikido (合気道), and other modern 道 (dō) arts explicitly transmit samurai values of discipline, humility, and self-improvement.

Media: Samurai appear in literature, film (黒澤明 — Kurosawa Akira's masterpieces), anime (Rurouni Kenshin, Sword of the Stranger, Samurai Champloo), and games (Ghost of Tsushima, Sekiro).

Language: Samurai-era vocabulary pervades everyday Japanese: | Samurai term | Modern use | |---|---| | 道 (michi/dō) | "The way" — in 剣道, 茶道, 料理道, and everyday "path" | | 覚悟 (kakugo) | Resolve, readiness — used casually: 覚悟して! = "Brace yourself!" | | 武器 (buki) | Weapon — used metaphorically: 言葉が武器 = "words are weapons" | | 修行 (shugyō) | Austere training — now used for any hard practice or job training | | 流派 (ryūha) | School/style — now used for any style or tradition |

## The Meiji End of Samurai

The Meiji government abolished the samurai class in stages:

- 1869: Samurai lost exclusive right to carry swords
- 1871: Domains abolished, samurai stipends cut
- 1876: 廃刀令 (Haitōrei) — the Sword Abolition Edict — wearing swords in public was banned

The 西南戦争 (Seinan Sensō — Satsuma Rebellion, 1877) was the last gasp of samurai resistance, led by 西郷隆盛 (Saigō Takamori) — the "Last Samurai." He fought his former allies in the Meiji government, lost, and died in battle or by suicide. His legacy was immediately romanticized.

The samurai as a legal class ended in 1877. As a cultural force, they never left.

Next: Postwar Japan →

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## Postwar Japan — From Ruins to Renaissance

"In 1945, Japan's cities were ash. By 1964 Tokyo hosted the Olympics. By 1980 it had the world's second-largest economy. No country has transformed as fast or as completely."

The postwar period is the most direct ancestor of modern Japan. The language you're learning, the pop culture you love, the companies you recognize — most of it emerged from this extraordinary 40-year arc.

### The Surrender — August 15, 1945

Japan surrendered unconditionally after atomic bombs destroyed Hiroshima (August 6) and Nagasaki (August 9), and the Soviet Union declared war on Japan (August 8).

Emperor Hirohito's 玉音放送 (gyokuon-hōsō — "Jewel Voice Broadcast") on August 15 announced the surrender in archaic formal Japanese. Millions of Japanese people — who had been told they were winning, and that the emperor was a god — heard his voice for the first time and struggled to understand what he said, let alone process what it meant.

「耐え難きを耐え、忍び難きを忍び…」 "Endure the unendurable, bear the unbearable..."

The date is still observed: 終戦の日 (shūsen no hi) — "Day of the end of war" — August 15.

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## The Occupation (1945–1952)

The Allied Occupation of Japan, effectively run by US General Douglas MacArthur (known as マッカーサー元帥), lasted until 1952.

### What Changed

Almost everything. The Occupation rewrote Japanese society with remarkable speed:

Constitution (日本国憲法 — Nihonkoku Kenpō, 1947): Article 9 renounced war permanently:

「日本国民は、正義と秩序を基調とする国際平和を誠実に希求し、国権の発動たる戦争と、武力による威嚇又は武力

This "Peace Constitution" remains in force, making Japan one of the few nations constitutionally forbidden from maintaining war potential.

### Political reform:

- Emperor became a symbolic figure (象徴天皇 — shōchō tennō), not divine
- Women received the right to vote (1945)
- Land reform broke up large estates and redistributed to farmers
- Labor unions were legalized

### Educational reform:

- Pre-war militarist education was purged
- 6-3-3-4 school system established (6 elementary, 3 middle, 3 high, 4 university)
- Democracy and individual rights became curriculum content

### Language reform:

- 当用漢字 (tōyō kanji) — 1850 kanji limit introduced to simplify literacy
- Vertical writing supplemented by horizontal writing (Western-style)
- Some words and expressions associated with militarism were retired
- This eventually became the 常用漢字 (jōyō kanji) system used today

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## Reconstruction and the Economic Miracle

### 1950s — Survival to Recovery

The Korean War (1950–1953) was a turning point: US military procurement turned Japan into a manufacturing base, pumping money into its devastated economy. The 三種の神器 (sanshu no jingi — "three sacred treasures") — the three appliances every family wanted — became the symbol of postwar aspiration:

- 白黒テレビ (black-and-white TV)
- 洗濯機 (washing machine)
- 冷蔵庫 (refrigerator)

### 1960s — High Growth (高度経済成長)

Japan's GDP grew at ~10% per year throughout the 1960s. This is the 高度経済成長期 (kōdo keizai seichō ki) — the high economic growth period — one of the fastest sustained growth periods in history.

1964 Tokyo Olympics: Japan introduced the 新幹線 (Shinkansen) on the day of the opening ceremony, October 1, 1964. It ran at 210 km/h and arrived to the second on schedule. The message to the world: Japan was back.

Aspirations by decade (家電の象徴):

- 1950s: TV, washing machine, refrigerator (三種の神器)
- 1960s: Color TV, air conditioner, car (新三種の神器 — "3C")
- 1970s+: Everything

1970s–1980s — The Bubble

Japan became an economic giant. By the late 1980s:

- Japan had the world's second-largest GDP
- Tokyo real estate was valued higher than all US real estate combined
- Japanese companies bought iconic American assets (Rockefeller Center, Columbia Pictures)
- Plaza Accord (1985) caused the yen to strengthen dramatically
- Easy money created a バブル経済 (baburu keizai — "bubble economy"): soaring land prices, lavish corporate spending, conspicuous consumption

The バブル期 (baburu ki) — bubble era (roughly 1986–1991) — is remembered with a mix of nostalgia and horror. Corporate expense accounts were legendary. Golf memberships sold for millions. Japanese companies seemed unstoppable.

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## The Bubble Bursts — 1991 and the Lost Decades

Lost Decade(s) (失われた10年/20年/30年)

The bubble collapsed in 1991–1992 when the Bank of Japan raised interest rates to cool overheating. Real estate values crashed. Banks held trillions in bad loans. Unemployment rose. Companies went bankrupt.

失われた10年 (ushinawareta jūnen — "lost decade") became 20 years, then 30 years. Japan entered a period of deflation, stagnation, and restructuring that it hasn't fully emerged from.

Social consequences:

- 就職氷河期 (shūshoku hyōgaki — "employment ice age"): The generation that graduated in the 1990s–2000s couldn't find stable employment. Many became フリーター (furītā) — people cycling through part-time work — and missed the lifetime employment ladder entirely.
- 格差社会 (kakusa shakai — "unequal society"): The gap between winners and losers in the restructured economy grew.
- 引きこもり (hikikomori): Social withdrawal — young people (mostly men) who stopped leaving their homes entirely. Estimated at over 1 million by the 2010s.
- 少子化 (shōshika — declining birthrate): Marriage rates fell. Japan's population peaked around 2008 and has been declining since.

1995: The Double Disaster

1995 was a pivotal year:

- 阪神・淡路大震災 (Great Hanshin Earthquake, January 17): ~6,400 dead. Kobe largely destroyed.
- 地下鉄サリン事件 (Tokyo Subway Sarin Attack, March 20): Aum Shinrikyō cult released sarin gas in Tokyo's subway, killing 13 and injuring thousands. Japan's sense of safety — one of its defining national characteristics — was shattered.

2011: 3.11 (東日本大震災)

The Tōhoku Earthquake and Tsunami (東日本大震災, March 11, 2011) killed ~20,000 people and triggered the Fukushima nuclear disaster. The disaster was devastating — and Japan's response showed extraordi-

nary social cohesion: minimal looting, organized evacuation, remarkable composure.

3.11 is a generation-defining event for modern Japanese people, much as 9/11 is for Americans.

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## American Influence on Modern Japan

Six years of occupation left deep American fingerprints on Japanese culture:

| American import            | Japanese form                              |
|----------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Baseball (野球 — yakyū)      | Japan's most popular sport for 100+ years  |
| Jazz                       | Huge in the 1950s–60s, still thriving      |
| Blue jeans                 | Japan became famous for denim quality      |
| Fast food                  | McDonald's (1971), KFC Christmas tradition |
| Christmas                  | Commercialized celebration (not religious) |
| Valentine's Day (reversed) | Women give chocolate to men                |
| Halloween                  | Massive in the 2010s–2020s                 |
| English loanwords          | Thousands absorbed into everyday Japanese  |

KFC Christmas: In Japan, eating KFC (ケンタッキー) on Christmas Eve is a tradition — the result of a 1974 marketing campaign. Families book their KFC orders months in advance.

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## Japan's Pop Culture Exports

As Japan's economy dominated manufacturing, its culture began dominating soft power:

| Era         | What Japan exported                                           |
|-------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1970s–80s   | Consumer electronics, automobiles                             |
| 1980s–90s   | Video games (Nintendo, Sega, Sony), manga beginning to spread |
| 1990s–2000s | Anime, Pokémon, Dragon Ball, Studio Ghibli worldwide          |
| 2000s–10s   | J-pop (Hamasaki Ayumi, Hikaru Utada), street fashion          |
| 2010s–20s   | Japanese food culture, matcha, anime streaming                |

Japan's クールジャパン (Cool Japan) government initiative (2010s) tried to formalize this soft power — with mixed results. The culture spread organically; the government's help was, charitably, less essential.

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## Modern Japan at a Glance

令和 Japan (2019–present)

- Population declining (~125 million, falling)
- Record number of foreign visitors pre-COVID (2019: ~32 million tourists)
- Growing debate on immigration as solution to labor shortage
- 観光立国 (kankō rikkoku — “tourism nation building”) as economic strategy
- Working to shed “overtime culture” (残業 — zangyō) while maintaining productivity
- Olympic legacy from Tokyo 2020/2021

## Heisei Nostalgia (平成レトロ)

Young Japanese people now look back at the Heisei era (1989–2019) with nostalgia — the way millennials elsewhere nostalgize the 1990s. Platform shoes, vending machine culture, flip phones, early internet — all retrochic.

## The Reiwa Generation

Japan's current young people are Z世代 (Z sedai — Gen Z) — digital natives, globally connected, increasingly bilingual, and pushing back on traditional expectations around gender, work, and marriage.

## Vocabulary of Postwar Japan

| Japanese                       | Meaning                                             |
|--------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| 戦後 (sengo)                     | Postwar (period)                                    |
| 復興 (fukkō)                     | Reconstruction / recovery                           |
| 高度経済成長 (kōdo keizai seichō)    | High economic growth                                |
| バブル経済 (baburu keizai)          | Bubble economy                                      |
| 失われた20年 (ushinawareta nijūnen) | Lost Two Decades                                    |
| 就職氷河期 (shūshoku hyōgaki)       | Employment ice age                                  |
| 引きこもり (hikikomori)             | Social withdrawal                                   |
| 少子化 (shōshika)                 | Declining birthrate                                 |
| 格差社会 (kakusa shakai)           | Unequal society                                     |
| 3.11 (san-ten-ichi-ichi)       | 2011 earthquake / tsunami — shorthand for that date |

Next: Language Evolution →

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## Language Evolution — From Classical Japanese to Emoji

"Modern Japanese is the result of 1,500 years of borrowing, adapting, reforming, and inventing. Understanding how it changed explains why it is the way it is."

Every quirk of Japanese — the three writing systems, the thousands of loanwords, the formal vs. casual divide — has a historical reason. Here's the story.

## 古典日本語 — Classical Japanese (上代・中古語)

The oldest forms of Japanese are preserved in texts from the 7th–8th centuries:

- 『万葉集』 (Man'yōshū, 759 CE): Japan's oldest poetry anthology, using kanji purely phonetically to write Japanese sounds — a system called 万葉仮名 (man'yōgana). This was the precursor to kana.
- 『古事記』 (Kojiki, 712 CE): Japan's oldest chronicle, mixing man'yōgana with classical Chinese.
- 『日本書紀』 (Nihon Shoki, 720 CE): More formal history, written predominantly in classical Chinese.

Classical Japanese (古典語 — kotenggo or 文語 — bungo) has verb forms and vocabulary that look almost nothing like modern Japanese:

| Classical  | Modern             | Meaning           |
|------------|--------------------|-------------------|
| あり (ari)   | ある (aru)           | to exist / be     |
| けり (keri)  | だった (datta)        | past tense marker |
| なり (nari)  | だ / です (da / desu) | copula "is"       |
| べし (beshi) | べきだ (beki da)      | should / must     |
| ず (zu)     | ない (nai)           | negative          |
| ぬ (nu)     | た (ta)             | perfect aspect    |

You'll still encounter classical forms in:

- Poetry (especially haiku and waka)
- Formal speeches and ceremonies
- Some set phrases: 何卒よろしく、ご健勝をお祈りいたします
- Literature studies in Japanese high school

## The Kana Revolution — 9th Century

Before kana, writing Japanese was deeply awkward: Chinese characters were used phonetically (man'yōgana) for Japanese sounds, requiring enormous effort per syllable.

In the early Heian period (794–1185 CE), two phonetic scripts emerged:

### Hiragana

Developed primarily by court women as cursive abbreviations of man'yōgana kanji:

- あ from 安 (an)
- い from 以 (i)
- う from 宇 (u)
- え from 衣 (e)
- お from 於 (o)

Because hiragana was used mainly by women writing in Japanese (men wrote formal texts in Chinese), it was initially called 女手 (onnade — "woman's hand").

The result: The Tale of Genji (源氏物語) — the world's first novel — was written in hiragana by a woman in the 11th century. Without the kana revolution, this would have been impossible.

### Katakana

Developed by male Buddhist monks as shorthand annotations on Chinese texts — a way to mark reading aids alongside kanji. Where hiragana simplified whole kanji characters, katakana extracted partial elements.

## The Kanji-Kana Hybrid System

Japanese settled into its distinctive mixed writing system by the 11th century:

- Kanji for meaning-carrying content words
- Hiragana for grammatical elements (particles, verb endings)
- Katakana for emphasis, foreign words (later)

This system has never been replaced — because it works, and because no reform was ever powerful enough to overcome cultural inertia.

## Chinese Borrowings — On-Yomi Waves

Japanese didn't borrow from Chinese all at once. Different waves of borrowing produced different pronunciation layers:

| Reading type | Origin period     | Region                | Example             |
|--------------|-------------------|-----------------------|---------------------|
| 呉音 (Go-on)   | 5th–6th century   | Southern China (Wu)   | 明 (myō/mō), 行 (gyō) |
| 漢音 (Kan-on)  | 7th–9th century   | Northern China (Tang) | 明 (mei), 行 (kō)     |
| 唐音 (Tō-on)   | 12th–17th century | Song/Ming dynasty     | 明 (min), 行 (hin)    |

This is why many kanji have multiple on-yomi readings — they each come from different periods and different regions of China.

Result: The word 行 (go) has at least three on-yomi:

- ぎょう (gyō) — 行列 (parade)
- こう (kō) — 銀行 (bank)
- あん (an) — rare, Buddhist context

## The Meiji Language Revolution

The Meiji Period (1868–1912) was the most dramatic period of language change since kana was invented.

The Problem: How Do You Modernize a Language?

Japan needed vocabulary for concepts that didn't exist in Japanese: democracy, philosophy, chemistry, electricity, capitalism, liberty, republic, science...

Solution 1: Kanji Compounds (漢語 — kango)

Japanese intellectuals and translators created new compound words from kanji to represent Western concepts:

| Western concept | Japanese creation         | Reading      |
|-----------------|---------------------------|--------------|
| Telephone       | 電話 (electricity + speech) | denwa        |
| Democracy       | 民主主義                      | minshu shugi |
| Science         | 科学                        | kagaku       |
| Philosophy      | 哲学                        | tetsugaku    |
| Economy         | 經濟                        | keizai       |
| Society         | 社会                        | shakai       |
| Individual      | 個人                        | kojin        |
| Liberty         | 自由                        | jiyū         |
| Revolution      | 革命                        | kakumei      |
| Culture         | 文化                        | bunka        |



Many of these compound words were then exported back to China, where they're now standard Chinese vocabulary. Japanese invented the Chinese word for "democracy" (民主主義) and many others. The irony is significant.

## Solution 2: Katakana Loanwords (外来語 — gairaigo)

For words that couldn't be easily translated, especially technology and food, katakana borrowing took over:

| Word             | From               | Era   |
|------------------|--------------------|-------|
| ビール (bīru)       | German Bier        | 1850s |
| パン (pan)         | Portuguese pão     | 1500s |
| コーヒー (kōhī)      | Dutch koffie       | 1700s |
| アルバイト (arubaito) | German Arbeit      | Meiji |
| テレビ (terebi)     | English television | 1950s |
| スマホ (sumaho)     | English smartphone | 2010s |

## Language Standardization

The Meiji government standardized a national language (国語 — kokugo) based on educated Tokyo speech:

- Regional dialects suppressed in schools
- National literacy campaigns raised reading rates dramatically
- Newspapers and novels written in the new standard
- A new style called 言文一致 (genbun-itchi — "unifying written and spoken language") emerged — writing became closer to how people actually spoke

Before Meiji, formal written Japanese and spoken Japanese were completely different languages. After genbun-itchi, they converged.

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## Postwar Language Reform

After WWII, the US Occupation and the Japanese government reformed the writing system:

### 当用漢字 (Tōyō Kanji, 1946)

1850 kanji designated for general use. Simplified forms introduced for some characters. Schools were instructed to teach only these kanji.

### 現代かなづかい (Gendai Kanazukai, 1946)

Kana spelling was reformed to match modern pronunciation. Some historical spellings that no longer matched pronunciation were changed:

- Historical: ゐ (wi), ゑ (we) — these sounds no longer exist; replaced with い, え
- The particle は (wa as topic marker) kept its spelling even though it's pronounced "wa" not "ha"
- ヲ kept as particle を, even though modern pronunciation is "o"

### 常用漢字 (Jōyō Kanji, 1981, revised 2010)

The official list of kanji for general use — currently 2,136 characters. This is the benchmark for "literacy" in Japan.

## The Gairaigo Explosion — Postwar English

After 1945, American English flooded Japanese through occupation, media, and pop culture:

1940s–50s (direct occupation terms): ジープ (jeep), バー (bar), ダンス (dance), デモ (demo/demonstration), ストライキ (strike)

1960s–70s (mass media and consumerism): テレビ (TV), コンピューター (computer), マネージャー (manager), スーパー (supermarket)

1980s–90s (economic boom): リストラ (restructuring — from "restructure"), バブル (bubble), パワーハラスメント → パワハラ (power harassment), セクシャルハラスメント → セクハラ (sexual harassment)

2000s–2010s (internet age): スマホ (smartphone), ツイート (tweet), シェア (share), フォロー (follow), バズる (to go viral, from "buzz")

The rate of loanword adoption has accelerated with the internet. New English terms now enter Japanese within months.

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## Japanese Invented Words That Went Global

It's not all one direction — Japanese contributed words to world English and other languages:

| Japanese word | Entered English as |
|---------------|--------------------|
| 津波 (tsunami)  | tsunami            |
| 台風 (taifū)    | typhoon            |
| 侍 (samurai)   | samurai            |
| 将軍 (shōgun)   | shogun             |
| 禅 (zen)       | Zen                |
| 柔道 (jūdō)     | judo               |
| 空手 (karate)   | karate             |
| 俳句 (haiku)    | haiku              |
| 絵文字 (emoji)   | emoji              |
| 旨味 (umami)    | umami              |
| 盆栽 (bonsai)   | bonsai             |
| 布団 (futon)    | futon              |
| 寿司 (sushi)    | sushi              |
| かわいい (kawaii) | kawaii             |

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## The Emoji Revolution (絵文字)

絵文字 (emoji — "picture character") was invented in Japan in 1999 by NTT DoCoMo engineer Shigetaka Kurita. The first set had 176 characters for mobile phones.

When Apple included emoji support in iOS 5 (2011), they went global — and fundamentally changed digital communication worldwide. The word itself is now in the Oxford English Dictionary.

The name comes from:

- 絵 (e) — picture
  - 文字 (moji) — character / letter
-

## The Future of Japanese

Modern Japanese continues to evolve rapidly:

Gender-neutral language: Traditional gendered speech patterns (see Spoken vs. Written) are fading among younger speakers. Gender-neutral forms are increasingly common.

English influence: Some argue Japanese is being "Anglicized" — more katakana, less classical phrasing. Others see this as natural evolution.

Population decline: With fewer speakers, Japanese may face long-term pressure. But Japanese media, pop culture, and language learning have never been more global.

AI and Japanese: Large language models trained on Japanese data are changing how Japanese is written and processed. Autocorrect and input method editors (IME — 入力メソッドエディタ) have already changed how people choose kanji (type phonetically, select from suggestions).

The language has been changing for 1,500 years. It will keep changing. Your job as a learner is to learn it as it is now — and enjoy the traces of everything it has been.

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## J-Pop — Japan's Soundtrack

"J-pop isn't one genre — it's an entire musical universe. From sugary idol anthems to experimental electronic to deeply literary songwriting, Japanese popular music has something that will stop you mid-sentence and make you want to understand every word."

J-pop (Jポップ) is a broad term for Japanese popular music since roughly the 1990s. Before that, the dominant popular music was 歌謡曲 (kayōkyoku) — a softer, orchestrated style that ruled from the 1960s through the 1980s. The transition to "J-pop" as a category marked Japan's shift toward Western pop structures with distinctly Japanese aesthetics.

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### Why J-Pop Is Great for Language Learning

- Lyrics are in Japanese — obvious, but: you can read them, look them up, and sing along
- Lyrics are often literary — Japanese songwriters frequently use poetic vocabulary, classical references, and emotional depth that textbooks skip
- Repetition — songs drill phrases into your brain more effectively than flashcards
- Emotional engagement — you remember vocabulary tied to feelings
- Cultural window — what songs are popular reveals what Japan is feeling at that moment

Practical tip: Use Uta-Net (うたネット) or J-Lyric for official Japanese lyrics. Use animelyrics.com for anime songs. Use a kanji dictionary alongside — songs often use beautiful but challenging characters.

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## The Eras of Japanese Popular Music

歌謡曲 (Kayōkyoku) Era — 1960s–1980s

The predecessor to J-pop. Lush orchestration, enka influences, melodramatic vocals. This is your parents' and grandparents' Japan:

Key artists:

- 美空ひばり (Misora Hibari, 1937–1989): The greatest singer in Japanese history. Began performing as a child during WWII. Her voice was extraordinary, her emotional range vast. Every Japanese person over 50 has strong feelings about her. A national treasure in every sense.
  - 山口百恵 (Yamaguchi Momoe, 1959–): The ultimate idol of the 1970s. Retired at 21 at the peak of her career to marry actor Miura Tomokazu — one of the most famous career decisions in Japanese entertainment.
  - 沢田研二 (Sawada Kenji / "Julie", 1948–): Japanese glam rock — androgynous, theatrical, wild.
  - キャンディーズ / ピンクレディー: The female idol duo/group template that Jpop still follows.
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## ニューミュージック (New Music) — 1970s–80s

Singer-songwriters and bands who bridged Western rock influences with Japanese pop:

- 荒井由実 / 松任谷由実 (Matsutōya Yumi / "Yuming", 1954–): The queen of Japanese pop for 50 years. Sophisticated, literary, melancholic. Her song 「ルージュの伝言」 (Rouge no Dengon) opens Studio Ghibli's Kiki's Delivery Service.
  - 山下達郎 (Yamashita Tatsurō, 1953–): Japan's master of AOR and city pop. 「クリスマス・イブ」 (Christmas Eve) has been charting every December since 1983.
  - 大滝詠一 (Ōtaki Eiichi, 1948–2013): Pop craftsman extraordinaire, legendary producer.
- 

## City Pop (シティポップ) — Late 1970s–Late 1980s

This is the genre that went globally viral in the 2010s–2020s, 30 years after it was made. Japanese city pop — funky, sophisticated, nostalgic, summer-scented — found an entirely new global audience through YouTube algorithms and lo-fi aesthetic culture.

Essential city pop tracks: | Artist | Song | Year | |---|---|---| | 竹内まりや (Takeuchi Mariya) | Plastic Love | 1984 | | 松原みき (Matsubara Miki) | 真夜中のドア (Stay With Me) | 1979 | | 杏里 (Anri) | Riders in the Sky | 1986 | | 山下達郎 | Sparkle | 1982 | | 菊池桃子 (Kikuchi Momoko) | 卒業 -GRADUATION- | 1985 | | 大貫妙子 (Ōnuki Taeko) | 4:00 AM | 1978 |

「Plastic Love」 by Takeuchi Mariya became a global phenomenon when it suddenly got 40 million+ YouTube views decades after its release. If you haven't heard it, stop reading this and listen now.

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## The J-Pop Golden Age — 1990s

The 1990s were Japan's musical golden era. Economic bubble anxiety met youth culture explosion. Sales figures were astronomical:

Key artists:

宇多田ヒカル (Hikaru Utada, 1983–): Her debut album First Love (1999) remains the best-selling album in Japanese history (~7.65 million copies). Half-Japanese, grew up between Japan and New York, and it shows in her sound — R&B structure with deeply Japanese lyrical soul. Her song 「光」 (Hikari) opens Kingdom Hearts. Her song 「花束を君に」 (Hanataba wo Kimi ni) opens NHK's morning drama. She is the defining voice of J-pop.

浜崎あゆみ (Hamasaki Ayumi, 1978–): The "Empress of J-pop." Dominated the late 1990s–2000s with anthemic pop rock. Best-selling solo female artist in Japan's history. Her lyrics about independence, pain, and identity resonated with a generation.

SPEED: Okinawan teen group. Energetic, catchy, the sound of 1997–98.

globe: Produced by tetsuya komuro (小室哲哉) — the most commercially successful J-pop producer of the 1990s. Also produced TRF, Every Little Thing, and many others.

SMAP: The most famous male idol group in Japanese history. Originally Johnny's entertainment boys-band, became a cultural institution. Their breakup in 2016 was a national event.

Mr. Children (ミスチル, 1988–): Japan's most beloved rock band. Anthemic, melodic, with lyrics of unusual depth. Still active and still selling out stadiums.

B'z (1988–): Japan's best-selling artists of all time. Hard rock duo — extremely polished, enormously popular, zero Western profile. A fascinating example of how different Japan's music market is.

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## 2000s–2010s J-Pop

AKB48 (2005–): Akimoto Yasushi's idol empire changed the music industry: theater-based performances, fan voting, handshake events, massive multi-team structure. The model spread across Asia. Their 選抜総選挙 (senbatsu sōsenkyo — popularity election) was a genuine cultural event.

嵐 (Arashi, 1999–2020): Johnny's group that became one of the most powerful forces in Japanese entertainment. Held the Tokyo Dome for consecutive concerts every year. Hiatus announced in 2020, devastating millions.

きゃりーぱみゅぱみゅ (Kyary Pamyu Pamyu, 1993–): The kawaii art-pop icon. Produced by Nakata Yasutaka, the visuals are hyperreal surreal Harajuku fashion. Globally recognized for her aesthetic.

Perfume (2000–): The electronic trio also produced by Nakata Yasutaka. Precision, technology, and perfectly synchronized choreography. Genuinely innovative live shows using augmented reality.

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## Contemporary J-Pop — 2010s–Present

YOASOBI (2019–): A duo (Ayase + Ikura) who write songs based on short stories. Their debut single 「夜に駆ける」 (Yoru ni Kakeru / Racing Into the Night) became a streaming phenomenon. Lyrics are unusually literary — and useful for advanced reading practice.

Kenshi Yonezu / 米津玄師 (1991–): Started as a Vocaloid (ボカロ) composer, became Japan's biggest solo artist. 「Lemon」 (2018) broke streaming records. 「Pale Blue」, 「KICKBACK」. Writes, produces, illustrates — complete artist.

あいみょん (Aimyon, 1995–): Singer-songwriter with a raw, literary style. Enormous live following. Her lyrics about relationships and daily life are excellent reading practice at intermediate level.

Official髭男dism (Higedan, 2012–): Piano-led pop rock with extraordinary vocal range from vocalist Fujihara. 「Pretender」, 「I LOVE...」. Consistently chart-topping.

King Gnu (2013–): Art rock meets J-pop — more experimental structure, darker themes. 「白日」 (Hakujitsu) is one of the most-streamed Japanese songs ever.

Vaundy (2019–): Gen Z singer-producer who self-produces everything. Multiple viral hits in rapid succession. 「踊り子」, 「おどり場」.

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## Vocaloid (ボーカロイド) — The AI Voice Culture

Vocaloid is a singing synthesizer software. 初音ミク (Hatsune Miku) — the teal-haired virtual singer released in 2007 — became a global pop cultural icon and launched an entire ecosystem:

- Fan-created songs uploaded to ニコニコ動画 (NicoNico Douga) — Japan's YouTube precursor
- ボカロP (Vocaloid Producers) — anonymous composers who became famous through their songs
- Songs then re-recorded by human vocalists and charted commercially
- Major artists including Kenshi Yonezu, YOASOBI's Ayase, Ado, and many others began as Vocaloid composers

ニコニコ動画 (NicoNico Douga): Japan's video platform where Vocaloid culture exploded. Comments scroll across the video in real time — a unique and chaotic viewing experience that influenced Japanese internet culture enormously.

## Anime Music (アニメソング / アニソン)

Anime theme songs (主題歌 — shudaika) are their own genre:

| Era       | Artists                | Notable songs                              |
|-----------|------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| 1960s–70s | Various                | Super Robot genre themes, children's anime |
| 1980s–90s | 水樹奈々, JAM Project      | Dragon Ball Z, Sailor Moon themes          |
| 2000s     | 林原めぐみ, 坂本真綾            | Evangelion, .hack//                        |
| 2010s     | LiSA, Aimer, fripSide  | Demon Slayer, Fate, etc.                   |
| 2020s     | YOASOBI, Ado, King Gnu | One Piece, Jujutsu Kaisen                  |

Aimer (エム): Husky-voiced singer whose anime soundtracks are consistently stunning. 「Ref:rain」, 「Torches」.

LiSA (リサ): The "Queen of Anime Songs." 「紅蓮華」 (Gurenge) from Demon Slayer broke every streaming record in Japan.

Ado (アド, 2002–): Anonymous vocalist who became famous with 「うっせえわ」 (2020) — an anthem of youth frustration. Voice is extraordinary — ranges from delicate to terrifying. Performed all songs for the film One Piece Film: Red.

## Songs for Language Learning

| Level        | Song         | Artist                   | Why                                 |
|--------------|--------------|--------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| Beginner     | さんぽ (Sanpo)  | Studio Ghibli soundtrack | Simple vocabulary, slow             |
| Beginner     | 一番星はどここの星    | Folk song                | Classic children's song             |
| Intermediate | 花束を君に        | Hikaru Utada             | Beautiful, emotional, clear diction |
| Intermediate | Lemon        | Kenshi Yonezu            | Clear lyrics, emotional hook        |
| Intermediate | 夜に駆ける        | YOASOBI                  | Modern language, story-based        |
| Advanced     | 白日           | King Gnu                 | Poetic, harder vocabulary           |
| Advanced     | 春泥棒          | YOASOBI                  | Literary kanji-heavy lyrics         |
| Advanced     | Plastic Love | Takeuchi Mariya          | Nostalgic, nuanced                  |

## Recommended Listening Path

1. Start with Studio Ghibli soundtracks (Joe Hisaishi) — instrumental and vocal, essential cultural context
2. Add Hikaru Utada — the clearest gateway to modern J-pop emotion

3. Try City Pop — Plastic Love, Mariya Takeuchi, Anri — for history and global context
4. Explore YOASOBI and Kenshi Yonezu for contemporary literary J-pop
5. Deep dive into your preferred genre from there

Next up: Traditional Music →

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## Traditional Music — 日本の伝統音楽

“Japanese traditional music doesn't follow Western scales or time signatures. It follows breath, nature, and space. Once you hear it with that context, it becomes something else entirely.”

Japan's traditional music is ancient, diverse, and still alive — performed at shrines, festivals, theaters, and concert halls. Understanding it enriches cultural knowledge, unlocks JLPT reading passages, and helps you appreciate things that are deeply embedded in the Japanese aesthetic.

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### The Aesthetics of Japanese Music

Before jumping into instruments and genres, understand the underlying aesthetic principles:

間 (ma): Silence is music. The pause between notes is deliberate and meaningful. Japanese music breathes.

わびさび (wabi-sabi): Imperfection has beauty. A single quivering flute note, asymmetrical rhythm, a voice that cracks slightly — these aren't failures, they're expression.

自然 (shizen — nature): Japanese music often imitates or evokes natural sounds: rain, wind, flowing water, birds, insects. The shakuhachi (bamboo flute) is specifically designed to produce breath-like, natural tones.

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### 雅楽 — Gagaku (Court Music)

雅楽 (gagaku) is the oldest surviving orchestral music in the world, performed continuously for over 1,300 years. It's the court music of the Japanese imperial household.

#### What It Sounds Like

Slow, spacious, alien to Western ears. The tempo is glacially slow by Western standards — a single phrase can last a minute. But it creates a profound sense of suspended time.

#### Instruments

| Instrument     | Type       | Description                                                                  |
|----------------|------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 笙 (shō)        | Wind       | Mouth organ — cluster of pipes arranged in circle. Creates sustained chords. |
| 篳篥 (hichiriki) | Wind       | Small double-reed pipe — the melodic lead                                    |
| 龍笛 (ryūteki)   | Wind       | Transverse flute                                                             |
| 琵琶 (biwa)      | String     | Short-necked lute                                                            |
| 箏 (koto)       | String     | 13-string zither                                                             |
| 太鼓 (taiko)     | Percussion | Large drum                                                                   |
| 羯鼓 (kakko)     | Percussion | Small barrel drum                                                            |
| 饒鉦 (nōhachi)   | Percussion | Cymbals                                                                      |

## Where to Hear It

- 宮内庁式部職楽部 (Imperial Household Agency Music Department): Performs at imperial ceremonies
  - 春日大社 (Kasuga Grand Shrine), 四天王寺 (Shitennō-ji), 住吉大社 (Sumiyoshi Taisha) — major shrine concerts
- 

## 能楽 — Noh Music (能)

Noh theater (see Traditional Arts) has its own musical tradition:

### Instruments (囃子 — hayashi)

| Instrument     | Reading   | Type                                         |
|----------------|-----------|----------------------------------------------|
| 能管 (nōkan)     | nōkan     | High-pitched flute — eerie, penetrating tone |
| 小鼓 (kotsuzumi) | kotsuzumi | Small hand drum (held at shoulder)           |
| 大鼓 (ōtsuzumi)  | ōtsuzumi  | Larger hand drum (held at hip)               |
| 太鼓 (taiko)     | taiko     | Large barrel drum                            |

### Chanting (謡 — utai)

The vocal style in Noh is 謡 (utai) — a highly stylized chanting between singing and speech. Text is drawn from classical Japanese poetry and literature.

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## 箏 — Koto

The 箏 (koto) is Japan's iconic string instrument — a 13-string (traditionally) zither about 180cm long, played with plectrum picks (爪 — tsume) on the right hand.

Yatsushashi Kengyō (八橋検校, 1614–1685) established the classical koto tradition. His piece 六段の調 (Rokudan no Shirabe) — "Six Sections" — remains a defining work of Japanese music and appears on JLPT cultural reading passages.

### Contemporary koto

Modern composers have extended the koto dramatically:

- 宮城道雄 (Miyagi Michio, 1894–1956): Blind koto master who modernized the instrument and composed 春の海 (Haru no Umi — "Spring Sea") — the piece Japanese people universally associate with New Year's Day (it plays everywhere in January)
  - 沢井忠夫 / 沢井一恵: Contemporary koto composers pushing the instrument into new territory
  - The koto has been played in jazz, pop, and avant-garde contexts
- 

## 三味線 — Shamisen

The 三味線 (shamisen) is a three-stringed banjo-like instrument, played with a large plectrum (撥 — bachi). It arrived from China via the Ryūkyū Kingdom in the 16th century and became central to Edo popular culture.



## Types and Uses

| Type         | Size        | Music style                                      |
|--------------|-------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| 細棹 (hosozaō) | Small neck  | Nagauta (long song), used in kabuki              |
| 中棹 (nakazaō) | Medium neck | Minyo (folk), kouta (short song)                 |
| 太棹 (futozaō) | Thick neck  | Gidayū-bushi (joruri narrative), Tsugaru-jamisen |

### Tsugaru-Jamisen (津軽三味線)

The folk shamisen tradition from Tohoku's Tsugaru region is the most exciting for many modern listeners — rapid, aggressive, improvisational. It sounds more like electric guitar than anything you'd expect from a traditional instrument.

木村大 and 上妻宏光 (Agatsuma Hiromitsu) are contemporary artists who play modern fusions of Tsugaru shamisen.

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### 尺八 — Shakuhachi

The 尺八 (shakuhachi) is an end-blown bamboo flute. The name comes from its standard length (一尺八寸 — one shaku, eight sun = ~54.5cm).

Sound is produced by blowing across the top — similar to blowing across a bottle, requiring significant technique. The resulting sound is breathy, haunting, and deeply human.

Originally used by Buddhist monks of the 普化宗 (Fuke sect) as a meditation practice — playing was called 吹禅 (suizen, "blowing Zen").

The repertoire for solo shakuhachi includes pieces called 本曲 (honkyoku) — original compositions specifically for the instrument, often meditative and deeply slow.

Contemporary shakuhachi: The instrument has been adopted in jazz, ambient music, and global fusion. Riley Lee and Kaoru Kakizakai are internationally recognized performers who play in both classical and contemporary contexts.

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### 演歌 — Enka

演歌 (enka) is Japan's deeply emotional popular ballad genre — often called "Japan's blues" or "Japan's country music." It emerged in the Meiji period from political song forms and became a distinct genre in the 1960s–70s.

#### Characteristics

- Minor keys with pentatonic scales
- こぶし (kobushi): Distinctive vocal ornament — a wavering rise and fall on certain syllables, similar to vibrato but more abrupt
- マイクの持ち方: The distinctive way enka singers hold the microphone (slightly tilted, held close)
- Lyrics about: lost love, the cold north, sake, fishing villages, the loneliness of the road (旅 — tabi), maternal love, stoic endurance
- Visual: Traditional kimono, dramatic stage presence

## Key Artists

| Artist                       | Notes                                            |
|------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| 美空ひばり (Misora Hibari)        | The ultimate. Her songs span kayōkyoku and enka. |
| 北島三郎 (Kitajima Saburō)       | "Saburo" — Japan's most beloved male enka singer |
| 都はるみ (Miyako Harumi)         | Powerful voice, emotional intensity              |
| 細川たかし (Hosokawa Takashi)     | 矢切の渡し — classic                                  |
| 演歌の女王: 天童よしみ (Tendō Yoshimi) | Exceptional voice                                |

Cultural note: Enka is strongly associated with middle-aged and elderly Japanese. Being able to reference an enka song, especially Misora Hibari's, is a meaningful cultural touch when talking to older Japanese people.

## Enka for Language Learning

Enka lyrics are full of rich, sometimes classical vocabulary. Themes of longing, rain, cold nights, and sake make them linguistically rich if emotionally dramatic.

Key vocabulary from enka: | Word | Reading | Meaning | |---|---|---| | 旅 | tabi | journey / travels | | 演歌 | enka | enka (演 = perform, 歌 = song) | | 望郷 | bōkyō | longing for home | | 哀愁 | aishū | pathos / sadness | | 盃 | sakazuki | sake cup | | 涙 | namida | tears | | 故郷 | furusato | hometown / birthplace |

## 民謡 — Minyo (Folk Music)

民謡 (minyo) is Japan's regional folk music — work songs, festival songs, sea shanties, and harvest songs. Every prefecture has distinct minyo traditions:

| Region | Famous minyo           | Notes                                                           |
|--------|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| 沖縄     | 安里屋ユンタ (Asadoya Yunta) | Okinawan folk — distinct scale, sanshin                         |
| 秋田     | 秋田音頭 (Akita Ondo)      | Harvest festival song                                           |
| 北海道    | ソーラン節 (Sōran Bushi)    | Herring fishermen's work song — adopted as school sports anthem |
| 鹿児島    | おはら節 (Ohara Bushi)     | Kagoshima folk                                                  |
| 新潟     | 佐渡おけさ (Sado Okesa)     | Island folk                                                     |

ソーラン節 (Sōran Bushi) has been adopted as an energetic dance performance by school students across Japan — you'll see it performed at sports festivals and school events. The rough fisherman's original has become a national youth anthem.

## 太鼓 — Taiko Drumming

太鼓 (taiko) is Japanese drumming, and it ranges from gentle shrine accompaniment to physically intense full-body performance.

和太鼓 (wadaiko) — traditional Japanese drumming:

- Used at festivals, Noh, gagaku, and religious ceremonies
- The 鼓童 (Kodō) ensemble from Sado Island is the world's most famous taiko group — their performances are extraordinary

Taiko vocabulary: | Japanese | Meaning | |---|---| | 長胴太鼓 (nagado taiko) | Long-bodied barrel drum (the classic big drum) | | 桶胴太鼓 (okedo taiko) | Lightweight bucket drum, portable | | 締太鼓 (shime taiko) | Rope-tensioned small drum | | 鉦 (kane) | Metal gong used with taiko | | バチ (bachi) | Drumstick |

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## Traditional Music and the JLPT

Traditional music appears in JLPT N3–N1 reading and listening sections as cultural knowledge:

- Descriptions of instruments and their use
- Festival music contexts
- Historical descriptions of court or Noh music
- Regional folk culture passages

Key terms to know: 雅楽, 能楽, 歌舞伎, 民謡, 三味線, 箏, 尺八, 演歌, 太鼓

Understanding these terms — even passively — helps with cultural reading passages that trip up learners who've never encountered traditional arts vocabulary.

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## Track: Anime Lover

"Anime got you here. Now let's make sure you actually understand what's happening — not just in subtitles, but in the language itself."

This track is for learners whose primary motivation is anime. Whether you're tired of reading subtitles, want to catch the jokes that don't translate, or simply love the medium — you're in the right place. Anime is one of the most effective immersion tools available, if used correctly.

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## Why Anime Works (and Where It Fails)

### Why It Works

- Massive audio input: Hours of natural-speed Japanese conversation
- Visual context: You understand more than you think from visuals + audio together
- Emotional engagement: High retention of vocabulary you encounter while caring about the story
- Genre variety: Slice-of-life for casual speech, business drama for formal speech, historical fiction for classical Japanese

### Where It Fails

- Shōnen battle anime: Characters speak unnaturally dramatically. No one actually says 「俺は絶対に負けない！」 (I will never lose!) in real conversation.
- Fantasy isekai: Invented vocabulary, medieval speech patterns, demon-lord register. Beautiful, but limited real-world transfer.
- Moe/cute anime: Female characters in moe anime often speak in exaggerated high-pitched styles that are neither natural nor gendered in real life.

Solution: Diversify your diet. Mix your favorites with slice-of-life anime set in modern Japan for real-world vocabulary.

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## Your Learning Path

### Stage 1: Build the Foundation First

Before using anime as a primary learning tool, get to a base level:

- Complete Hiragana and Katakana
- Learn the 500 core vocabulary words
- Understand basic grammar patterns
- Understand casual Japanese — anime is almost entirely casual

Then start using anime as an immersion tool.

### Stage 2: Active Watching

Step 1: Watch with English subtitles (first watch, enjoy the story) Step 2: Watch with Japanese subtitles (Animelon, Kitsunekko subtitles) Step 3: Watch with no subtitles (you'll understand more than you expect) Step 4: Shadow — pause and repeat what characters say, mirroring their intonation

### Stage 3: Mine Your Favorite Shows

Create Anki cards from anime dialogue using tools like:

- Migaku — browser extension that converts subtitles into flash cards
- Animelon — anime with clickable Japanese subtitles
- Kitsunekko — Japanese subtitle files for anime

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## Anime Speech Patterns to Learn

### Common Anime-Specific Speech

| Expression | Context          | Meaning                                        |
|------------|------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| 行くぞ！       | Male protagonist | "Let's go!" / "Here we go!"                    |
| 信じろ！       | Shōnen hero      | "Believe!"                                     |
| 俺に任せろ！     | Male lead        | "Leave it to me!"                              |
| くっ...      | Any character    | Short grunt of pain/frustration                |
| なぜ...！     | Villain reveal   | "Why...!"                                      |
| まさか！       | Shock            | "No way! / Don't tell me...!"                  |
| そんな...！    | Devastation      | "This can't be...!"                            |
| ちくしょう！     | Frustration      | "Damn it!"                                     |
| やれやれ       | Exasperation     | "Good grief..." (classic Shōnen teacher types) |
| 〜だと！？      | Shock/threat     | Assertive "You dare say ~!?"                   |

### Character Speech Types

Different anime character archetypes use different speech patterns:

| Archetype   | Speech style             | Key features                                            |
|-------------|--------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| Shōnen hero | Loud, casual, passionate | 俺 (ore), 〜ぞ、〜だ endings, no keigo                        |
| Tsundere    | Switches cold/flustered  | "べ、別に！" (It's not like I care!), inconsistent register  |
| Kuudere     | Flat, minimal            | Short sentences, no emotion markers, often uses watashi |
| Villain     | Theatrical keigo         | 〜ですわ, archaic forms, elaborate vocabulary               |

| Archetype         | Speech style             | Key features                         |
|-------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| Wise old mentor   | Classical flavor         | 〜じゃ, 〜のう, classical sentence endings |
| Maid character    | Ultra-polite performance | 〜でございます, お嬢様                         |
| Yankii/delinquent | Extra rough masculine    | オレ, 〜じゃねえか, heavy contractions       |

This whole phenomenon — characters speaking as recognizable types rather than as real people — is called 役割語 (role language), and it's one of the highest-leverage things an anime learner can study. It tells you who a character is from their first line, and it warns you which speech patterns not to copy into real life. See the dedicated Role Language page.

## Anime By Difficulty Level

Beginner (Simple vocabulary, slow speech)

| Anime                    | Why                                            |
|--------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| ドラえもん (Doraemon)         | Children's — simple vocab, everyday situations |
| しろくまカフェ (Shirokuma Cafe) | Gentle, clear, animals in a cafe               |
| Chi's Sweet Home         | Daily life of a kitten                         |
| 天才バカボン (Tensai Bakabon)  | Classic comedy, simple language                |
| NHK World (日本語教育)        | Educational content, slow clear speech         |

Intermediate (Modern Japan, everyday conversation)

| Anime                             | Why                                                   |
|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| 日常 (Nichijou)                     | Absurdist slice-of-life — excellent natural speech    |
| 聲の形 (A Silent Voice)              | Emotional, realistic high school Japanese             |
| 夏目友人帳 (Natsume's Book of Friends) | Gentle, slightly literary, beautiful                  |
| とらドラ! (Toradora!)                 | High school romance — extremely natural casual speech |
| アンナチュラル (Unnatural)               | J-drama format, workplace medical Japanese            |

Advanced (Complex language, fast speech, cultural depth)

| Anime                                   | Why                                                                       |
|-----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 鬼滅の刃 (Demon Slayer)                     | Period vocabulary, Taisho-era speech patterns                             |
| もののけ姫 (Princess Mononoke)               | Classical Japanese vocabulary, heavy dialect                              |
| 攻殻機動隊 (Ghost in the Shell)              | Philosophical, technical, extremely complex                               |
| 昭和元禄落語心中 (Shōwa and Genroku Era Rakugo) | Classical rakugo performance speech — extraordinary for advanced learners |
| 平家物語 (The Heike Story)                  | Classical Japanese — genuinely challenging                                |

## The Subtitle Method (Most Effective)

1. First watch: English subs (understand the plot)
2. Second watch: Japanese subs (match sounds to text)

### 3. Third watch: No subs (rely on what you've built)

At intermediate level, flip the order: watch with Japanese subs first, use English subs as backup only.

The shadowing technique: Choose a scene you like. Watch once. Then play and speak along with the character simultaneously — matching speed, intonation, and emotion. This is the fastest path to natural-sounding Japanese.

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## Vocabulary Sets Unique to Anime Genres

### Fantasy/Isekai

| Term  | Reading  | Meaning       |
|-------|----------|---------------|
| 魔法    | mahō     | magic         |
| 勇者    | yūsha    | hero          |
| 魔王    | maō      | demon lord    |
| 冒険者   | bōkensha | adventurer    |
| ギルド   | girudo   | guild         |
| スキル   | sukiru   | skill         |
| レベル   | reberu   | level         |
| ステータス | sutētasu | status/stats  |
| 転生    | tensei   | reincarnation |
| 異世界   | isekai   | other world   |

### School Life

| Term | Reading       | Meaning                  |
|------|---------------|--------------------------|
| 文化祭  | bunkasai      | school cultural festival |
| 体育祭  | taiikusai     | sports day               |
| 部活   | bukatsu       | club activities          |
| 生徒会  | seitokai      | student council          |
| 告白   | kokuhaku      | confession of love       |
| 陰キャ  | inkya         | introvert / quiet type   |
| 陽キャ  | youkya        | extrovert / popular type |
| 修学旅行 | shūgaku ryokō | school trip              |

### Action/Battle

| Term | Reading      | Meaning                                                  |
|------|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| 必殺技  | hissatsuwaza | finishing move                                           |
| 覚醒   | kakusei      | awakening / power-up                                     |
| 限界突破 | genkai toppa | breaking through limits                                  |
| 絆    | kizuna       | bond / connection                                        |
| 仲間   | nakama       | companions / friends (the most important word in shōnen) |

## Recommended Path by Goal

Goal: Understand anime without subtitles in 2 years

1. Learn kana — 2 weeks
2. Core vocab 500 words — 2 months (Anki)
3. N5 grammar — 2 months (Genki I)
4. Anime immersion daily, Japanese subs — ongoing
5. N4 grammar — 3 months (Genki II)
6. Increase anime immersion, mine cards from shows you love
7. N3 grammar — 3 months (Tobira or similar)
8. At this point, you'll understand 70–80% of slice-of-life anime without subtitles

The key variable: Daily input. An hour a day will get you there. Weekends-only won't.

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## The Immersion Community

Join the Japanese learning community:

- [r/LearnJapanese](#) — comprehensive resources and advice
- [Refold](#) — immersion-based learning methodology
- [Matt vs Japan \(YouTube\)](#) — controversial but effective immersion approach
- [JLPT Ninja](#) — JLPT-focused path with immersion elements
- Discord servers: Join "Japanese Language Study Group" servers to find conversation partners

Next tracks: [Manga Reader](#) → | [JLPT N5](#) →

[\newpage](#)

## Track: Manga Reader

"Reading manga is one of the most effective Japanese study methods that also happens to be completely addictive. The furigana is training wheels. The story is what keeps you going."

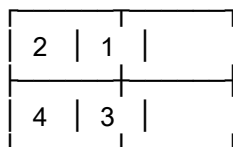
Manga is uniquely suited for language learning: it provides visual context for every panel, furigana (usually) for every kanji, natural dialogue in speech bubbles, and the irresistible pull of "just one more chapter." This track shows you how to use manga as a systematic learning tool.

---

## Reading Direction — The Basics

Manga is read right to left, top to bottom within each panel. If you're reading "normally" (left to right), you're reading the end of the book first.

Panel reading order:



Within each panel, speech bubbles: right to left, top to bottom.

Page direction: Start from what feels like the "back" of a Western book. The spine is on the right.

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## The Anatomy of a Manga Page

| Element             | Japanese       | Meaning                                             |
|---------------------|----------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| コマ (koma)           | Panel          | Each box/image                                      |
| フキダシ (fukidashi)    | Speech bubble  | Dialogue                                            |
| 心の声 (kokoro no koe) | Thought bubble | Internal monologue — usually jagged or cloud-shaped |
| ト書き / ナレーション        | Narration      | Caption boxes — story narration                     |
| 擬音語 (giongo)        | Sound effects  | Written sounds — always katakana                    |
| ふりがな (furigana)     | Furigana       | Small hiragana above kanji — your reading guide     |
| オノマトペ (onomatope)   | Onomatopoeia   | Both sound and state words                          |

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## Your Learning Path

### Stage 1: Essential Prerequisites

Before reading manga in Japanese:

1. Hiragana — must be automatic
2. Katakana — essential for sound effects
3. Kanji basics — ~200 characters gets you through most furigana-covered manga
4. Grammar basics — understand particle roles and verb endings

You don't need to be advanced before reading manga. Start as soon as you can read kana.

### Stage 2: Choose Beginner-Friendly Manga

Look for:

- All furigana — children's manga always has this
- Simple art style — clearer panel flow
- Modern setting — everyday vocabulary transfers to real life
- Short chapters — 20 pages at a time is manageable early on

| Manga                    | Difficulty            | Why it's good for beginners                                            |
|--------------------------|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| よつばと！ (Yotsuba&!)        | Beginner              | Child protagonist, everyday vocabulary, furigana, simple conversations |
| ドラえもん                    | Beginner              | Children's, short stories, 100% furigana                               |
| クレヨンしんちゃん                | Beginner-Intermediate | Everyday life, family vocabulary                                       |
| ARIA                     | Beginner-Intermediate | Gentle, nature-focused, beautiful language                             |
| 名探偵コナン (Detective Conan) | Intermediate          | Mystery vocabulary, consistent storylines                              |
| ワンピース (One Piece)        | Intermediate          | Simple core vocabulary but massive vocab range                         |
| スラムダンク (Slam Dunk)       | Intermediate          | Sports, school, great dialogue                                         |

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## Reading Tools

### Dictionary Apps



| App          | Platform          | Best for                                |
|--------------|-------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| Jisho.org    | Web               | Comprehensive dictionary, kanji lookup  |
| Takoboto     | iOS               | Fast kanji lookup                       |
| Midori       | iOS               | Clean dictionary interface              |
| 広辞苑 (Kōjien) | App               | Japanese-only definition — for advanced |
| Yomitan      | Browser extension | Hover over words for instant definition |

### Physical Manga Reading Tools

- Camera translation (Google Translate, DeepL): Point your phone camera at a page for instant translation. Not perfect but useful for difficult passages.
- Kanji lookup by radical: Learn to look up unknown kanji by counting strokes or identifying the radical using a dictionary app.

### Digital Manga Platforms

| Platform        | Notes                                                        |
|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| BookWalker (JP) | Largest manga digital library, Japan account needed          |
| Kindle (JP)     | Amazon Japan manga — some titles have clickable dictionaries |
| Mangadex        | Fan scanlations — some in original Japanese                  |
| Shonen Jump+    | Official Shueisha app — many series free first chapters      |

## Sound Effects — The Secret Language of Manga

Manga sound effects are not real Japanese vocabulary — but they're everywhere, they enhance meaning visually, and knowing them makes reading smoother.

### Physical Sounds

| Effect | Romaji   | Used for                       |
|--------|----------|--------------------------------|
| ドカン！   | dokan    | Explosion / impact             |
| バン！    | ban      | Bang / gunshot / door slam     |
| ガシャン！  | gashan   | Glass breaking                 |
| ズドン！   | zudon    | Heavy impact                   |
| サクッ    | saku     | Crisp crunch (cutting, biting) |
| ポタポタ   | potapota | Dripping                       |
| ザーザー   | zāzā     | Heavy rain                     |
| ピシャ！   | pisha    | Slap                           |
| ドシン    | doshin   | Heavy thud                     |

### Emotional/State Effects (擬態語 in manga)

| Effect | Used for                            |
|--------|-------------------------------------|
| ドキドキ   | Heart pounding — fear or excitement |
| キラキラ   | Sparkling eyes — wonder, adoration  |

| Effect | Used for                                        |
|--------|-------------------------------------------------|
| ズーン    | Gloom settling in                               |
| ガン !   | Shock/devastation (character looks stunned)     |
| ニヤリ    | Sinister smirk                                  |
| テカテカ   | Shiny / sweating                                |
| フラフラ   | Dizzy / unsteady                                |
| モジモジ   | Fidgeting nervously                             |
| ムカムカ   | Seething / nauseous anger                       |
| メラメラ   | Burning with emotion (usually anger or passion) |

Pro tip: When you see a large katakana effect on the page, look at what's happening in the panel — then you'll permanently remember what that sound describes.

### The Sound of Silence — シーン

The single most famous manga sound effect represents no sound at all: シーン (or 「シーン」). A quiet room, a stunned pause, an awkward silence — Japanese "hears" silence and writes it down. Once you notice it, you'll see it everywhere.

### Furigana Wordplay — Two Meanings at Once

Manga has a trick that doesn't exist in English: making the furigana say something different from the kanji underneath. You read both simultaneously — the kanji gives the literal/written meaning, the small reading gives what's actually spoken or felt.

| Written | Furigana                  | Literal meaning      | The effect                                            |
|---------|---------------------------|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| 本気      | マジ (maji)                 | "seriousness"        | Formal kanji + slangy spoken voice, at once           |
| 機械鎧     | オートメール (Automail)         | "machine armor"      | English ruby names the thing (Fullmetal Alchemist)    |
| 負けて死ぬ   | バイツァ・ダスト (Bites the Dust) | "lose and die"       | Kanji = lethal command; English = the attack's result |
| 親友      | ライバル (rival)              | "close friend"       | A contrasting ruby compresses a whole relationship    |
| 永遠      | とわ                        | "eternity" (vs えいえん) | A softer, more poetic reading                         |

This is the creative extreme of 義訓 (gikun) — improvised, meaning-based readings. Watch for it especially in shōnen battle manga, where technique names get dramatic English or German ruby for a "cool, exotic" feel.

Tip: when the furigana and kanji disagree, that's not a misprint — it's the author handing you two pieces of information. Read the kanji for meaning, the ruby for voice.

### A Note on Character Speech (役割語)

Manga characters don't talk like real people — they talk like types. The wise old master ending sentences in 〜じや, the heiress in 〜ですわ, the tough guy saying 俺 and 〜ぜ: that's role language (役割語), and it's a whole system worth learning. It will tell you who a character is from their first line. See the dedicated Role Language page.

## Grammar Patterns Common in Manga

Manga uses extremely casual Japanese, heavy contractions, and character-specific speech:

### Common Contractions

| Full    | Manga form          | Meaning                      |
|---------|---------------------|------------------------------|
| 〜ている    | 〜てる                 | ongoing action               |
| 〜てしまった  | 〜ちゃった               | accidentally/regrettably did |
| 〜ではない   | 〜じゃない               | isn't                        |
| 〜わけじゃない | 〜わけじゃねえ             | rough masculine negative     |
| 〜から     | 〜から (often dropped) | because                      |
| というか    | っていうか / つか          | I mean / rather              |

### Speech Bubble Cues

| Bubble shape     | Meaning                 |
|------------------|-------------------------|
| Oval/round       | Normal speech           |
| Spiky/jagged     | Shouting, shock, impact |
| Cloud-like       | Thought                 |
| Wavy outline     | Quiet, weak voice       |
| Dark background  | Ominous, serious        |
| Screen tone fill | Internal/emotional      |

## The Mining Method

"Mining" means finding words and grammar in your reading, creating flashcards (Anki), and reviewing them daily. Here's the workflow:

1. Read a page — try without looking things up first
2. Guess from context — the image usually helps
3. Look up unknowns — but only ones that block comprehension
4. Create Anki card — include the sentence from the manga as context
5. Review daily — 10–20 minutes

Sentence mining beats isolated vocab: When you learn 仲間 (nakama — companions) from the panel where Luffy is crying about his crew, you will never forget it.

## Furigana Strategy

Furigana (ふりがな) — the small kana above kanji — is both a gift and a crutch.

Use furigana actively, not passively:

- Cover the furigana with your finger and try to read the kanji first
- Only check the furigana when you're unsure
- When you can read a kanji without needing the furigana, it's in your long-term memory

Many manga aimed at older audiences drop furigana entirely (most seinen, some shōnen after early volumes). This is when your kanji knowledge becomes essential.

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## Manga Vocabulary by Genre

### School Life (学園)

| Vocab           | Meaning                       |
|-----------------|-------------------------------|
| 文化祭 (bunkasai)  | Cultural festival             |
| 体育祭 (taiikusai) | Sports day                    |
| 生徒会 (seitokai)  | Student council               |
| 告白 (kokuhaku)   | Love confession               |
| 部活 (bukatsu)    | Club activity                 |
| 先輩 / 後輩         | Upperclassman / lowerclassman |

### Fantasy/Adventure

| Vocab         | Meaning      |
|---------------|--------------|
| 勇者 (yūsha)    | Hero         |
| 武器 (buki)     | Weapon       |
| 仲間 (nakama)   | Companions   |
| 覚醒 (kakusei)  | Awakening    |
| 魔法陣 (mahōjin) | Magic circle |

### Romance (恋愛)

| Vocab            | Meaning         |
|------------------|-----------------|
| 両思い (ryōomoi)    | Mutual love     |
| 片思い (kataomoi)   | Unrequited love |
| 告白 (kokuhaku)    | Confession      |
| ヤキモチ             | Jealousy        |
| フラれる (fura reru) | To be rejected  |
| 付き合う (tsukiau)   | To date someone |

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## Reading Milestones

| Milestone                                    | What it means |
|----------------------------------------------|---------------|
| Reading a full page without looking up words | N5 territory  |
| Reading a full chapter comfortably           | N4 territory  |
| Reading without furigana (shounen)           | N3 territory  |
| Reading seinen manga without a dictionary    | N2 territory  |
| Reading any manga fluently                   | N1 territory  |

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## Recommended Reading Order

Weeks 1–4: よつばと！ Vol. 1 (Yotsuba) — one chapter per day, look up everything Month 2–3: ドラえもん — 3 short stories per session Month 3–6: Your favorite manga in Japanese — motivation > difficulty Month 6+: Graduate to manga without furigana in familiar genres

The fastest progress comes from reading things you desperately want to understand. Pick the manga you love most and commit to reading it in Japanese.

Next tracks: Anime Lover → | JLPT N4 →

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## Track: Business Japanese

"Japanese business culture is not just 'polite Japanese turned up to 11.' It has its own vocabulary, its own rituals, its own written forms, and its own unspoken rules. Get it right and you open remarkable doors."

This track is for learners headed to Japanese workplaces, dealing with Japanese clients and partners, preparing for Japanese job interviews, or working in international environments with Japanese colleagues. Business Japanese (ビジネス日本語) is a distinct register that requires deliberate study — even fluent speakers of casual Japanese need to learn it separately.

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### Why Business Japanese Is Its Own World

Business Japanese differs from everyday polite Japanese in four key ways:

1. Vocabulary: Entirely different set of phrases, set expressions, and honorific forms
2. Written conventions: Formal email structures, specific opening/closing phrases
3. Implicit rules: What you say and what you mean can be very different
4. Hierarchy encoding: Every communication signals your position and theirs

You cannot just "be polite" your way through a Japanese business setting. Specific formulas are expected and deviating from them reads as inexperienced or disrespectful.

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### Prerequisites

Before this track, make sure you have:

- Polite Japanese — complete
  - Honorific Japanese (Keigo) — complete
  - N3 grammar or higher — needed for professional communication
  - Basic spoken vs. written Japanese understanding
- 

### Business Vocabulary — The Core Set

People and Relationships

| Japanese | Romaji         | Meaning                              |
|----------|----------------|--------------------------------------|
| 御社 / 貴社  | onsha / kisha  | Your company (spoken / written)      |
| 弊社 / 当社  | heisha / tōsha | Our company (humble / neutral)       |
| 担当者      | tantōsha       | Person in charge                     |
| 上司       | jōshi          | Superior / boss                      |
| 部下       | buka           | Subordinate                          |
| 同僚       | dōryō          | Colleague                            |
| 取引先      | torihikisaki   | Business partner / client            |
| 得意先      | tokuisaki      | Regular customer / client            |
| お客様      | okyakusama     | Customer / guest (highest honorific) |
| 先方       | senpō          | The other party                      |

## Meetings and Communication

| Japanese | Romaji     | Meaning                    |
|----------|------------|----------------------------|
| 会議       | kaigi      | Meeting                    |
| 打ち合わせ    | uchiawase  | Briefing / working meeting |
| 資料       | shiryō     | Materials / documents      |
| 議事録      | gijiroku   | Meeting minutes            |
| 報告書      | hōkokusho  | Report                     |
| 提案書      | teiansho   | Proposal                   |
| 見積もり     | mitsumori  | Estimate / quote           |
| 契約書      | keiyakusho | Contract                   |
| 納期       | nōki       | Delivery deadline          |
| 締め切り     | shimekiri  | Deadline                   |

## Business Actions

| Japanese | Romaji             | Meaning                         |
|----------|--------------------|---------------------------------|
| 確認する     | kakunin suru       | To confirm / verify             |
| 共有する     | kyōyū suru         | To share (information)          |
| 対応する     | taio suru          | To respond / handle             |
| 検討する     | kentō suru         | To consider / examine           |
| 調整する     | chōsei suru        | To coordinate / adjust          |
| 承認する     | shōnin suru        | To approve                      |
| 手配する     | tehai suru         | To arrange / coordinate         |
| ご連絡する    | go-renraku suru    | To contact (humble)             |
| ご確認いただく  | go-kakunin itadaku | To have confirmed (by superior) |

## Business Card Etiquette — 名刺交換 (Meishi Kōkan)

The business card exchange is a ritual with specific choreography:

1. Prepare: Cards in your card holder (名刺入れ), never in your pocket or wallet
2. Bow and present: With both hands, card facing them (text toward them), slight bow
3. Receive: With both hands, read it carefully, acknowledge it:  
頂戴いたします。(Chōdai itashimasu.) — "I receive this humbly."
4. Place respectfully: On the table in front of you during a meeting, or in your card holder

5. Never: Write on it, fold it, leave it on the table when you leave, put it in your back pocket

At multi-person meetings, arrange received cards on the table in front of you corresponding to seating positions.

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## Meeting Phrases

### Starting a Meeting

本日はお時間をいただきありがとうございます。(Honjitsu wa ojikan wo itadaki arigatō gozaimasu.) Thank you for taking the time to meet with us today.

早速ですが、本題に入らせていただきます。(Sassoku desu ga, hondai ni irasete itadakimasu.) Shall we get to the main topic?

本日の議題は～です。(Honjitsu no gidai wa ~ desu.) Today's agenda is ~.

### Asking for Clarification

もう少し詳しくお聞かせいただけますか？(Mō sukoshi kuwashiku okikase itadakemasu ka?) Could you elaborate on that a bit more?

おっしゃる意味がよく分かりませんでした。(Ossharu imi ga yoku wakarimasen deshita.) I didn't quite understand what you meant.

### Agreeing and Acknowledging

おっしゃる通りです。(Ossharu tōri desu.) Exactly as you say.

承知いたしました。(Shōchi itashimashita.) Understood. I'll take care of it.

かしこまりました。(Kashikomarimashita.) Certainly. (Extremely formal)

### Politely Declining or Pushing Back

ご提案はごもっともですが、弊社の状況といたしましては... (Go-teian wa gomottomo desu ga, heisha no jōkyō to itashimashite wa...) Your proposal is very reasonable, but given our company's situation...

検討させていただきます。(Kentō sasete itadakimasu.) We will consider it. (Often signals "we'll think of a way to say no")

難しい状況です。(Muzukashii jōkyō desu.) The situation is difficult. (= probably no)

### Closing a Meeting

本日は大変参考になりました。(Honjitsu wa taihen sankō ni narimashita.) Today's meeting was very informative.

それでは、今後ともよろしく願いいたします。(Soredewa, kongotomo yoroshiku onegai itashimasu.) Please continue to treat us well in the future.

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## Business Email — Full Guide

Email (メール) is the primary written communication in Japanese business. The structure is fixed:

## Complete Email Template

件名：〇〇のご確認につきまして

〇〇株式会社  
〇〇部 田中様

お世話になっております。  
株式会社〇〇の山田でございます。

先日はご多忙のところお時間をいただきまして、  
誠にありがとうございました。

早速ではございますが、先日ご相談申し上げた件について  
ご回答をいただきたく、ご連絡差し上げました。

つきましては、下記についてご確認いただけますでしょうか。

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### 【ご確認事項】

- ・ 〇〇について
  - ・ 〇〇について
- 

ご多忙のところ大変恐縮ですが、  
〇月〇日(〇)までにご返答いただけますと幸いです。

何かご不明な点がございましたら、  
お気軽にご連絡くださいませ。

引き続きよろしくお願いいたします。

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山田 太郎 (Yamada Tarō)  
株式会社〇〇 〇〇部  
Tel: 〇〇-〇〇〇〇-〇〇〇〇  
Email: yamada@〇〇.co.jp

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## Key Email Phrases

Openers: | Phrase | When to use | |---|---| | お世話になっております | Standard business opener — always  
| | いつもお世話になっております | Emphasizes ongoing relationship | | ご無沙汰しております | "It's been  
a while" — reconnecting | | 初めてご連絡いたします | First contact | | 突然のご連絡失礼いたします | Cold  
outreach apology |

Body transitions: | Phrase | Meaning | |---|---| | 早速ですが | Getting straight to the point | | つきましては | "In  
light of this..." / "Therefore..." | | なお | "Additionally..." | | また | "Also..." | | ご確認いただきたく... | "I would  
like to ask for your confirmation..." |

Closers: | Phrase | Meaning | |---|---| | よろしく願いいたします | Best regards / Please take care of  
this | | ご確認よろしく願いいたします | Please kindly check | | お返事お待ちしております | I look  
forward to your reply | | 何かご不明な点がございましたらお気軽に | If you have questions, feel free | | ご多忙のところ恐縮ですが | I'm sorry to trouble you when you're busy |



## The 報連相 (Hōrenso) System

報告 (hōkoku) — 連絡 (renraku) — 相談 (sōdan)

This is the fundamental communication framework of Japanese business:

- 報告 (report): Update your superior on the progress/outcome of tasks they assigned
- 連絡 (contact): Share information relevant to others in the team proactively
- 相談 (consult): Bring problems or decisions to your superior before acting unilaterally

The 報連相 system means Japanese workers are expected to over-communicate compared to Western workplaces. Surprises are bad. Proactive communication is good.

Bonus: 確認 (kakunin — confirmation) is sometimes added: 報連相確 (hōrensō-kaku).

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## 根回し (Nemawashi) — The Hidden Meeting Before the Meeting

根回し literally means "going around the roots" — as in, preparing the soil before planting. In business, it refers to informal pre-meeting consensus building.

Before a formal decision is made in a meeting, Japanese professionals typically:

1. Have one-on-one conversations with key stakeholders
2. Share documents and ideas informally beforehand
3. Gauge objections and modify proposals accordingly
4. Arrive at the formal meeting with consensus already built

The formal meeting is then mostly a formality — everyone has already agreed. This explains why Japanese meetings can seem "ceremonial" to Westerners — because they are. The real decisions happened before the meeting.

Understanding nemawashi prevents massive cultural frustration: proposals introduced "cold" in a Japanese meeting without prior consultation will often stall or fail.

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## Job Interview Japanese

Self-Introduction (自己紹介)

私は〇〇大学〇〇学部を卒業し、〇〇株式会社に〇年間勤めておりました。主に〇〇業務を担当し、〇〇の経験を積みました。  
"I graduated from 〇〇 University's School of 〇〇, and worked at 〇〇 Company for ~ years.  
My main responsibilities were 〇〇, and I have accumulated experience in ~."

Common Interview Questions

| Question                                | Japanese         |
|-----------------------------------------|------------------|
| "Tell me about yourself"                | 自己紹介をお願いします      |
| "Why do you want this job?"             | 志望動機をお聞かせください    |
| "What are your strengths?"              | あなたの長所は何ですか？     |
| "What are your weaknesses?"             | 短所についてお聞かせください   |
| "Where do you see yourself in 5 years?" | 5年後のビジョンを教えてください |

## Answer Structure (STAR Method in Japanese)

- 状況 (jōkyō): The situation
  - 課題 (kadai): The challenge/task
  - 行動 (kōdō): The action I took
  - 結果 (kekka): The result
- 

## Salary and Working Conditions

| Japanese  | Meaning        |
|-----------|----------------|
| 給料 / 給与   | kyūryō / kyūyo |
| 基本給       | kihonkyū       |
| 賞与 / ボーナス | shōyo / bōnasu |
| 残業        | zangyō         |
| 有給休暇      | yūkyū kyūka    |
| 社会保険      | shakai hoken   |
| 試用期間      | shiyō kikan    |
| 正社員       | sei-shain      |
| 契約社員      | keiyaku shain  |
| 派遣社員      | haken shain    |
| アルバイト     | arubaito       |

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## Japanese Company Culture to Know

年功序列 (nenkō joretsu): Seniority system — pay and position based largely on years of service. Fading but still influential.

終身雇用 (shūshin koyō): Lifetime employment — one company, one career. Also fading in the modern economy.

飲みケーション (nominication): Communication through drinking (飲む + communication). After-work drinks with colleagues (飲み会 — nomi kai) are semi-mandatory social bonding.

有給が取れない (yūkyū ga torenai): Unable to take paid vacation — common complaint. Japan legally provides vacation but cultural pressure to not use it is strong.

ブラック企業 (burakku kigyō): "Black company" — exploitative employer. Antonym: ホワイト企業 (howaito kigyō).

Next tracks: News Japanese → | JLPT N3 →\*\*

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## Track: News Japanese

"NHK is one of the world's great public broadcasters. Reading it in Japanese — really reading it, not running it through Google Translate — is one of the most satisfying milestones in Japanese learning."

News Japanese (ニュース日本語) is written Japanese at its most formal, dense, and politically neutral. It's the gold standard of standard language — no dialect, no slang, and a very specific set of grammatical

structures and vocabulary that appear nowhere else. This track gets you reading NHK, understanding news broadcasts, and navigating written Japanese media.

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## Why News Japanese Is Different

News Japanese has distinctive features that separate it from everyday speech and even from business writing:

1. Heavy passive voice: Events happen without people being named as agents
  2. Nominalizations: Actions turned into noun phrases
  3. Formal conjunctions: Classical-influenced connectors
  4. Topic-specific vocabulary: Politics, economy, disasters, international affairs
  5. Dense information packing: Japanese news sentences are long and information-rich
  6. Abbreviated forms: Agency names, organization names, and titles compressed
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## Start Here: NHK Web Easy (やさしい日本語)

Before tackling regular news, start with NHK Web Easy (NHKウェブイージー):

- Real NHK news articles rewritten in simpler Japanese
- Furigana on all kanji
- Vocabulary explanations built in
- Free at [www3.nhk.or.jp/news/easy](http://www3.nhk.or.jp/news/easy)

This is the most recommended beginner-to-intermediate reading resource in the Japanese learning community. Read it daily from N4 level onward.

Progression:

1. NHK Web Easy → everyday for 3–6 months
  2. NHK regular news articles → once comfortable with Web Easy
  3. Newspaper articles (朝日新聞、読売新聞、毎日新聞) → advanced
  4. 社説 (shasetsu — editorials) → near-native
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## News Grammar Patterns

These appear constantly in news writing and almost nowhere else:

| Pattern  | Example      | Meaning                                  |
|----------|--------------|------------------------------------------|
| ～によると    | 警察によると...    | "According to ~"                         |
| ～として     | 関係者として...    | "In the capacity of / as ~"              |
| ～をめぐって   | 議論をめぐって...   | "Surrounding the issue of ~"             |
| ～において    | 会議において...    | "At / in the context of ~"               |
| ～に対し     | 政府に対し...     | "Toward / regarding ~"                   |
| ～を受けて    | 批判を受けて...    | "In response to ~"                       |
| ～にもかかわらず | 反対にもかかわらず... | "Despite ~"                              |
| ～に加え     | さらに加え...     | "In addition to ~"                       |
| ～を通じて    | 交渉を通じて...    | "Through ~ / via ~"                      |
| ～とみられる   | 原因とみられる...   | "Is believed to be ~" (journalist hedge) |
| ～もようだ    | 合意もようだ       | "Appears to be ~" (hedge)                |

| Pattern   | Example    | Meaning                               |
|-----------|------------|---------------------------------------|
| ～との見方もある  | 悪化との見方もある  | "There is also a view that ~"         |
| ～が明らかになった | 事実が明らかになった | "It has become clear that ~"          |
| ～とのことだ    | 続けるとのことだ   | "It is said that ~" (reported speech) |

## Passive Voice in News

News Japanese uses passive voice to:

- Avoid naming who did something
- Focus on the event rather than the agent
- Sound neutral and authoritative

| Active (spoken) | Passive (news style) | Meaning                  |
|-----------------|----------------------|--------------------------|
| 首相が発表した         | 発表された                | Was announced            |
| 警察が逮捕した         | 逮捕された                | Was arrested             |
| 政府が決定した         | 決定された                | Was decided              |
| 会社が解雇した         | 解雇された                | Was dismissed            |
| 裁判所が判決を下した      | 判決が下された              | A ruling was handed down |

## News Vocabulary by Topic

Politics (政治)

| Japanese | Romaji        | Meaning                     |
|----------|---------------|-----------------------------|
| 国会       | kokkai        | National Diet (parliament)  |
| 衆議院      | shūgiin       | House of Representatives    |
| 参議院      | sangiin       | House of Councillors        |
| 内閣       | naikaku       | Cabinet                     |
| 首相       | shushō        | Prime Minister              |
| 大臣       | daijin        | Minister                    |
| 選挙       | senkyo        | Election                    |
| 投票率      | tōhyōritsu    | Voter turnout               |
| 与党       | yotō          | Ruling party                |
| 野党       | yatō          | Opposition party            |
| 法案       | hōan          | Bill / legislation          |
| 予算       | yosan         | Budget                      |
| 採決       | saiketsu      | Vote / resolution           |
| 内閣改造     | naikaku kaizō | Cabinet reshuffle           |
| 解散       | kaisan        | Dissolution (of parliament) |

Economy (経済)

| Japanese                    | Meaning                  |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------|
| 景気 (keiki)                  | Economic conditions      |
| 株価 (kabuka)                 | Stock price              |
| 円高 / 円安 (endaka / en'yasu)  | Strong yen / Weak yen    |
| インフレ / デフレ                  | Inflation / Deflation    |
| 利上げ / 利下げ (rigake / risage) | Interest rate hike / cut |
| 物価 (bukka)                  | Prices / cost of living  |
| 賃金 (chingin)                | Wages                    |
| 失業率 (shitsugyōritsu)        | Unemployment rate        |
| 貿易赤字 (bōeki akaji)          | Trade deficit            |
| GDP / 国内総生産                 | GDP                      |
| 財政赤字 (zaisei akaji)         | Fiscal deficit           |

## Disasters (災害)

| Japanese            | Meaning                                |
|---------------------|----------------------------------------|
| 地震 (jishin)         | Earthquake                             |
| 津波 (tsunami)        | Tsunami                                |
| 台風 (taifū)          | Typhoon                                |
| 洪水 (kōzui)          | Flood                                  |
| 土砂崩れ (dosha kuzure) | Landslide                              |
| 震度 (shindo)         | Seismic intensity (Japanese 1–7 scale) |
| 震源地 (shingenchi)    | Epicenter                              |
| 避難指示 (hinan shiji)  | Evacuation order                       |
| 行方不明 (yukue fumei)  | Missing person                         |
| 死者 (shisha)         | Death toll                             |
| 負傷者 (fushōsha)      | Injured persons                        |

## International Affairs (国際)

| Japanese               | Meaning        |
|------------------------|----------------|
| 外交 (gaikō)             | Diplomacy      |
| 首脳会談 (shunō kaidan)    | Summit meeting |
| 条約 (jōyaku)            | Treaty         |
| 制裁 (seisai)            | Sanctions      |
| 国連 (Kokuren)           | United Nations |
| 米国 / 米 (Beikoku / Bei) | United States  |
| 中国 / 中 (Chūgoku / Chū) | China          |
| 韓国 / 韓 (Kankoku / Kan) | South Korea    |
| 北朝鮮 (Kita Chōsen)      | North Korea    |
| EU / 欧州連合              | European Union |

## Country Abbreviations in News

Japanese news often abbreviates country names in headlines:

| Country     | Abbreviation | Full name |
|-------------|--------------|-----------|
| USA         | 米 (bei)      | アメリカ合衆国   |
| China       | 中 (chū)      | 中国        |
| South Korea | 韓 (kan)      | 韓国        |
| Russia      | 露 (ro)       | ロシア       |
| UK          | 英 (ei)       | イギリス      |
| France      | 仏 (futsu)    | フランス      |
| Germany     | 独 (doku)     | ドイツ       |
| Italy       | 伊 (i)        | イタリア      |
| Australia   | 豪 (gō)       | オーストラリア   |
| India       | 印 (in)       | インド       |

## Reading a News Headline

Headlines compress language dramatically. Examples:

Headline: 首相、増税案を撤回へ 野党の反発受け Unpacked: 首相が増税案を撤回する方向へ。野党からの反発を受けた  
Translation: Prime Minister to withdraw tax increase proposal, following opposition pushback.

Headline: 大手企業、賃上げ率過去最高 春闘で妥結 Unpacked: 大手企業が、春季労使交渉 (春闘) において、賃上げ率が  
Translation: Major companies reach wage increase agreement at record rates in spring labor negotiations.

Key headline features:

- Subject often dropped (spring wage negotiation "結果" is implied)
- Particles dropped (〜が, 〜を commonly omitted)
- Verbs often replaced by nouns (〜へ instead of 〜するだろう)
- Abbreviated organization/event names (春闘 = spring labor struggle)

## Reading NHK: Step by Step

Sample Sentence Analysis

Original:

政府は、少子化対策の強化に向けて、来月から新たな支援金制度を導入することを決定したと発表した。

Breaking it down:

- 政府は — As for the government (topic)
- 少子化対策の強化に向けて — toward strengthening measures against the declining birthrate
- 来月から — starting next month
- 新たな支援金制度を — a new financial support system [object]
- 導入することを決定したと — decided to introduce [indirect report]
- 発表した — announced

Translation: "The government announced that it has decided to introduce a new financial support system starting next month, aimed at strengthening measures against the declining birthrate."

## Dates: Reading 元号 (Era Names)

Japanese news constantly mixes the Western calendar (西暦, seireki) with the era-name calendar (和暦, wareki). You must be able to convert on the fly.

The Reiwa formula: 令和 year + 2018 = Western year. So 令和7年 = 2025. (Reverse: 2025 – 2018 = 令和7.)

| Era | Reading | Span      | Formula   | Note                               |
|-----|---------|-----------|-----------|------------------------------------|
| 昭和  | Shōwa   | 1926–1989 | 和暦 + 1925 | Ended at 昭和64年 (just 7 days of it) |
| 平成  | Heisei  | 1989–2019 | 和暦 + 1988 | Ended at 平成31年                     |
| 令和  | Reiwa   | 2019–     | 和暦 + 2018 | 令和元年 = 2019                        |

- 元年 (gannen) = "year 1" of an era. News writes 令和元年, never 令和1年.
- 改元 (kaigen) = changing the era. A transition year splits: 2019 was 平成31年 (Jan–Apr) and 令和元年 (May–Dec).
- Which one news uses: 和暦 for official/domestic/legal matters (budgets, laws); 西暦 for international news, sports, and science. Many outlets print both: 2025年 ( 令和7年 ) .

## Numbers: The Every-Four-Digits System

Japanese groups large numbers by 10,000 (万), not by 1,000 — and each unit is 10,000× the last. This trips up every learner, because printed numerals still use the Western 3-digit comma.

| Unit | Reading | Value                                  |
|------|---------|----------------------------------------|
| 万    | man     | 10,000 (10 <sup>4</sup> )              |
| 億    | oku     | 100 million (10 <sup>8</sup> )         |
| 兆    | chō     | 1 trillion (10 <sup>12</sup> )         |
| 京    | kei     | 10 <sup>16</sup> (national-debt scale) |

To parse a big number: slice into 4-digit blocks from the right.

| Numerals | Reading                   | Value                                     |
|----------|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| 1億2000万人 | ichi-oku nisen-man nin    | 120,000,000 people (≈ Japan's population) |
| 365兆円    | sanbyaku-rokujū-go chō en | 365 trillion yen (national-budget scale)  |

Approximation words (essential for headlines):

| Word      | Reading         | Meaning                                                                  |
|-----------|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 約         | yaku            | "approximately" — goes before: 約3000人                                    |
| 〜余り       | -amari          | "a little more than" — goes after: 100人余り (always more)                  |
| 〜強 / 〜弱   | -kyō / -jaku    | "a bit more than / less than" a round figure: 3割強 ≈ 30–34%, 3割弱 ≈ 26–29% |
| 割 / 分 / 厘 | wari / bu / rin | 1割 = 10%, 1分 = 1%, 1厘 = 0.1% (3割2分 = 32%)                                |
| ポイント      | pointo          | percentage point: 「2ポイント増」 = up 2 points, not 2%                         |
| 年度        | nendo           | fiscal/academic year — April 1 to March 31. 2024年度 = Apr 2024–Mar 2025   |

Drift note: a 2024 NHK survey found ~19% of people in their 20s now read 「7割弱」 as more than 70% — the reverse of the traditional sense. Writers still use 弱 = less; learn the traditional rule but know the confusion exists.

## Names: Crime-Reporting Honorifics

Japanese media follow strict conventions for how they refer to people in criminal cases — and dropping the honorific itself signals legal status.

| Term      | Reading                 | Meaning                                                                     |
|-----------|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 容疑者       | yōgisha                 | Suspect — name + 容疑者 after arrest. A media-coined word that replaced the    |
| 被告        | hikoku                  | Defendant — name + 被告 after indictment (起訴)                                 |
| 〜の疑い      | ...no utagai            | "on suspicion of ~" — the standard hedge before guilt is proven             |
| 自称        | jishō                   | "self-described" — prefixed when police couldn't verify identity/job: 自称・会社 |
| 実名 / 匿名報道 | jitsumei / tokumei hōdō | Named vs. anonymous reporting. Adults are usually named; minors (少年法) a     |
| 呼び捨て      | yobisute                | Using a bare name with no honorific. Media switched to 容疑者/被告 partly to a   |

The 逮捕 → 判決 vocabulary chain:

| Japanese  | Reading              | Meaning                                 |
|-----------|----------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| 逮捕        | taiho                | arrest                                  |
| 送検        | sōken                | referral from police to prosecutors     |
| 起訴 / 不起訴  | kiso / fukiso        | indictment / decision not to prosecute  |
| 求刑        | kyūkei               | the sentence the prosecution asks for   |
| 判決        | hanketsu             | the verdict/sentence handed down        |
| 実刑 / 執行猶予 | jikkei / shikkō-yūyo | actual prison term / suspended sentence |
| 控訴 / 上告   | kōso / jōkoku        | appeal to high court / to Supreme Court |

Fresh change: as of 2024 the 法務省 directs prisons to address inmates as ーさん by default — a human-rights-driven shift away from 呼び捨て.

## Weather: Forecast Register (気象)

Weather is on every broadcast, and it has its own set phrases beyond 晴れ / 曇り / 雨.

| Japanese  | Reading                   | Meaning                                                                     |
|-----------|---------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 前線        | zensen                    | weather front (寒冷前線 cold, 温暖前線 warm, 梅雨前線 rainy-season)                     |
| 気圧の谷      | kiatsu no tani            | a trough of low pressure — brings unsettled weather                         |
| 大気の状態が不安定 | taiki no jōtai ga fuantei | "the atmosphere is unstable" — set warning for thunder, squalls, downpour   |
| 〜のおそれ     | ...no osore               | "risk of ~": 大雨のおそれ                                                         |
| ところにより    | tokoro ni yori            | "in places" — patchy, not widespread                                        |
| 線状降水帯     | senjō kōsuitai            | "linear rainband" — stalled storms dumping intense rain (official JMA term) |

The 3-tier alert system (low → high): 注意報 (advisory) → 警報 (warning) → 特別警報 (emergency, "protect your life now").

A new 危険警報 tier is being inserted between 警報 and 特別警報, but only from May 2026 — not in use yet.

Heat thresholds (by the day's maximum, except 熱帯夜):



| Japanese | Reading   | Threshold                                  |
|----------|-----------|--------------------------------------------|
| 夏日       | natsubi   | ≥ 25°C                                     |
| 真夏日      | manatsubi | ≥ 30°C                                     |
| 猛暑日      | mōshobi   | ≥ 35°C (the highest official term for now) |
| 熱帯夜      | nettaiya  | overnight minimum ≥ 25°C                   |

Plus 熱中症警戒アラート (heatstroke alert), nationwide since 2021, with a higher 特別警戒 tier added in 2024.

## Sports: Headline Shorthand

Sports headlines have their own punchy vocabulary, much of it borrowed from sumo.

| Japanese | Reading                | Meaning                                                               |
|----------|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 制す       | seisu                  | to win / take (a title or match): 決勝を制す                               |
| 完封       | kanpū                  | a shutout (pitcher allows no runs)                                    |
| 連覇       | renpa                  | consecutive titles: 3連覇 = three-peat                                  |
| V        | bui                    | = 優勝 (championship). V奪回 = recapture the crown; V逸 = narrowly miss it |
| 逆転       | gyakuten               | comeback/reversal: 逆転サヨナラ = walk-off comeback                         |
| 〜が〜を下す   | ...o kudasu            | A defeats B (formal headline verb)                                    |
| 白星 / 黒星  | shiroboshi / kuroboshi | a win / a loss (from sumo's open/filled circles)                      |
| 番狂わせ     | bankuruwase            | an upset — the underdog wins                                          |

## Listening: NHK Radio and Television

### NHK Radio Japanese

- NHKラジオニュース — formal news broadcasts, excellent for pitch accent study
- Newscasters speak at ~280 characters per minute — fast, clear, standard accent
- Available as podcast and streaming at [nhk.or.jp](https://www.nhk.or.jp)

### NHK Television

- NHKニュース7 (7pm) — main evening news
- おはよう日本 — morning news program
- クローズアップ現代 — documentary news program
- 日曜討論 — political debate program (extremely difficult, very rewarding)

### NHK for School (NHK for School)

Educational content for school children — accessible, well-produced, good intermediate listening.

## Recommended News Reading Path

| Level | Resource                         | What to do                                 |
|-------|----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| N4    | NHK Web Easy                     | Read 1 article per day, look up everything |
| N3    | NHK Web Easy + easy NHK articles | Read 2 articles per day                    |
| N3-N2 | Regular NHK articles             | Read 1 article per day, mine vocabulary    |
| N2    | Multiple news sources            | Cross-reference, build genre vocabulary    |
| N1    | 朝日新聞、読売新聞                        | Read editorials (社説), long-form pieces     |

## The News Learner's Toolkit

| Tool                        | Purpose                   |
|-----------------------------|---------------------------|
| NHK Web Easy                | Gateway news reading      |
| Jisho.org                   | Dictionary                |
| Yomitan (browser extension) | Instant hover definitions |
| Google News (Japanese)      | Japanese news aggregator  |
| 朝日新聞デジタル                    | Subscription newspaper    |
| NHK Radio                   | Listening practice        |
| Anki + news sentences       | Vocabulary mining         |

The habit that makes this work: Read one news article every single day. It doesn't matter if you don't understand everything. Over 6 months, the vocabulary will compound.

Next tracks: Business Japanese → | JLPT N2 →

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## JLPT — The Japanese Language Proficiency Test

"The JLPT won't make you fluent. But it gives you a roadmap, a milestone, and a certificate that Japan actually recognizes. That combination is hard to beat."

The 日本語能力試験 (Nihongo Nōryoku Shiken — Japanese Language Proficiency Test) is the world's most widely taken Japanese certification exam, administered by the Japan Foundation and Japan Educational Exchanges and Services (JEES). It's held twice a year — July and December — at locations worldwide.

## The Five Levels

| Level | Label              | Vocabulary     | Kanji   | Study hours (est.) |
|-------|--------------------|----------------|---------|--------------------|
| N5    | Beginner           | ~800 words     | ~100    | 150–200 hours      |
| N4    | Elementary         | ~1,500 words   | ~300    | 300–500 hours      |
| N3    | Intermediate       | ~3,750 words   | ~650    | 600–900 hours      |
| N2    | Upper-Intermediate | ~6,000 words   | ~1,000  | 1,000–1,500 hours  |
| N1    | Advanced           | ~10,000+ words | ~2,000+ | 2,000–4,000 hours  |

"Study hours" are rough estimates assuming you're starting from zero. Prior exposure to kanji (through Chinese or Korean), immersion, or related languages affects these significantly.

## Test Format

All JLPT levels test three areas:

| Section                   | Content                        |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------|
| 言語知識 (Language Knowledge) | Vocabulary, kanji, grammar     |
| 読解 (Reading)              | Reading comprehension passages |
| 聴解 (Listening)            | Audio tracks with questions    |

No speaking. No writing. The JLPT is entirely multiple-choice (4 options). This is both its limitation and its accessibility.

Scoring: Each section is scored separately. You must pass each section individually — you can't compensate a failed section with a perfect score elsewhere. Sections are curved (scaled scores).

| Level | Total score | Passing score per section                        |
|-------|-------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| N5    | 180         | 38 (vocab/grammar), 19 (reading), 19 (listening) |
| N4    | 180         | 38, 19, 19                                       |
| N3    | 180         | 19, 19, 19                                       |
| N2    | 180         | 19, 19, 19                                       |
| N1    | 180         | 19, 19, 19                                       |

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## When and Where

Exam dates: First Sunday of July / First Sunday of December (most locations)

Registration: Opens approximately 3–4 months before the exam. Register at [jlpt.jp](http://jlpt.jp) or through your country's local partner organization.

Locations: 47 countries/regions. Major cities worldwide. In Japan, dozens of cities.

Cost: ~¥5,500–6,000 in Japan. Varies internationally.

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## What the JLPT Proves

Officially recognized by:

- Japanese immigration for visa applications (especially engineer/specialist visas)
- Many Japanese companies for hiring non-Japanese staff
- Some university admissions in Japan
- Professional certification bodies

N1 specific value:

- Required or preferred for many professional positions in Japan
- Often a requirement for Japanese government positions
- Demonstrates near-native reading ability

What it doesn't prove:

- Speaking ability
- Writing ability

- The ability to function naturally in conversation

Many people with N2 or N1 struggle with everyday conversation — the JLPT doesn't test production. Plan your study to include speaking and writing alongside JLPT prep.

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## Study Strategy Principles

### 1. Grammar Before Vocab (at N5–N3)

Grammar structures are finite. Vocabulary is infinite. Learn grammar first — it gives you a scaffold that makes vocabulary stick.

### 2. Spaced Repetition for Vocabulary

Anki or a similar SRS tool is essential for the vocabulary load. N2 requires you to actively know 6,000 words — passive recognition isn't enough.

### 3. Past Papers Are the Best Practice

The JLPT has a consistent format. After studying the content, past papers are your best preparation tool. JLPT Sensei has free resources. Official practice tests are sold at bookstores.

### 4. Reading Every Day

Reading Japanese at your level daily is the single highest-leverage activity for the reading section. Use NHK Web Easy for N4+.

### 5. Listening Requires Deliberate Practice

The listening section trips up many learners who study only from textbooks. Listen to Japanese content at your target level daily. For N3+, NHK news radio, anime, or drama at appropriate speed.

### 6. Take Full Mock Exams

Time pressure is real. Practice under timed conditions at least 3–4 times before the real exam.

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## Study Resources by Level

| Resource                     | Best for              | Notes                                                 |
|------------------------------|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| Genki I                      | N5–N4 grammar         | Standard university textbook                          |
| Genki II                     | N4–N3 grammar         |                                                       |
| Tobira                       | N3–N2                 | Excellent intermediate bridge                         |
| 新完全マスター (Shin Kanzen Master) | N3–N1                 | Each section (grammar, reading, listening) separately |
| 日本語総まとめ (So-matome)          | N5–N1                 | 6-week crash course format                            |
| WaniKani                     | Kanji N5–N2           | Subscription SRS                                      |
| Anki                         | Vocabulary all levels | Free SRS                                              |
| JLPT Sensei                  | Practice questions    | Free web resource                                     |
| 日本語能力試験公式問題集                 | Practice tests        | Official materials — essential                        |

## Choosing Your Level

| If you...                     | Start at                        |
|-------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| Know nothing                  | N5                              |
| Completed Genki I             | N4–N5                           |
| Completed Genki II            | N3–N4                           |
| Have 1+ years of study        | Take a practice N3 test and see |
| Read manga comfortably        | N3–N2                           |
| Watch anime without subtitles | N2–N1                           |
| Work or study in Japanese     | N2–N1                           |

Take a practice test before committing. Don't sandbag (taking N5 when you're clearly N3 level) — it wastes time and money. The JLPT doesn't give "credit" for exceeding the level you tested at.

## The Real Goal

The JLPT is a tool, not a destination. Passing N1 with a score of 100/180 while struggling to hold a conversation is less useful than having natural conversations at N3 grammar level with a rich vocabulary.

Use the JLPT to:

- Identify specific weak areas (grammar, vocabulary, reading speed, listening)
- Set concrete milestones
- Get a certificate that matters to Japanese employers and immigration

Don't use the JLPT to:

- Measure your "real" Japanese ability
- Replace actual communication practice

The best Japanese learners do both: Study systematically for the JLPT and immerse themselves in real Japanese media and conversation.

Choose your level: N5 → | N4 → | N3 → | N2 → | N1 →

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## JLPT N5 — The Starting Line

"N5 is where every journey begins. Don't underestimate it — it requires real study. But you'll be surprised how much Japanese you can communicate with N5 knowledge."

N5 is the entry-level JLPT certification. Passing it proves basic understanding of foundational Japanese. It's achievable in 3–6 months of consistent study from zero, and it builds the foundation for everything above.

## What N5 Covers

| Area       | Target          |
|------------|-----------------|
| Vocabulary | ~800 words      |
| Kanji      | ~100 characters |

| Area      | Target                                |
|-----------|---------------------------------------|
| Grammar   | ~100 patterns                         |
| Reading   | Simple texts, short sentences         |
| Listening | Slow, clear speech about daily topics |

## N5 Kanji List (Core 100)

These are the kanji you must be able to read and recognize at N5:

Numbers & Counting: 一 二 三 四 五 六 七 八 九 十 百 千 万

Time: 年 月 日 時 分 今 毎 週 曜

People & Family: 人 父 母 兄 姉 弟 妹 子 女 男

Nature: 山 川 海 空 木 花 雨 水 火 土 石

Places: 国 学 校 駅 店 会 社 図 書 館

Actions (used in verbs): 行 来 食 飲 見 聞 話 読 書 買 入 出 上 下

Descriptors: 大 小 高 安 新 古 長 白 黒 赤 青

Other Essentials: 電 車 何 本 口 手 目 耳 生 先 右 左 中 外 前 後

## N5 Grammar Patterns

### Sentence Structure

- A は B です。 — A is B.
- A は B じゃないです。 — A is not B.
- A は B でした。 — A was B.
- これ / それ / あれ / どれ — this/that/that over there/which
- ここ / そこ / あそこ / どこ — here/there/over there/where

### Particles

| Particle | Function                 | Example  |
|----------|--------------------------|----------|
| は        | Topic                    | 私は学生です。  |
| が        | Subject                  | 猫がいます。   |
| を        | Object                   | 水を飲みます。  |
| に        | Direction/time/location  | 学校に行きます。 |
| で        | Location of action/means | 電車で来ました。 |
| と        | And/with                 | 友達に行きます。 |
| も        | Also                     | 私もです。    |
| の        | Possession               | 私の本。     |
| か        | Question                 | ですか？     |
| ね        | Confirmation             | そうですね。   |
| よ        | Assertion                | 分かりますよ。  |

## Verbs

- ーます / ーません / ーました / ーませんでした — polite present/negative/past/past negative
- ーてください — Please do ~
- ーたいです — I want to do ~
- ーています — ongoing action
- ーてもいいですか — May I ~?
- ーてはいけません — You must not ~
- ーことができます — I can / am able to ~

## Adjectives

- 大きい → 大きくない → 大きかった (い-adjective conjugation)
- きれい → きれいじゃない → きれいでした (な-adjective conjugation)
- Adjective + noun: 大きい犬, きれいな花

## Common Expressions

| Pattern       | Example     | Meaning             |
|---------------|-------------|---------------------|
| ーはどこですか       | 駅はどこですか？    | Where is ~?         |
| ーはいくらですか      | これはいくらですか？  | How much is ~?      |
| ーをください        | 水をください。     | Please give me ~.   |
| ーがほしいです       | 新しい本がほしいです。 | I want ~.           |
| ーが好きです / 嫌いです | 猫が好きです。     | I like / dislike ~. |
| ーが上手です        | 日本語が上手です。   | Is good at ~.       |
| ーがわかります       | 英語がわかります。   | Understand ~.       |

## N5 Vocabulary — 100 Essential Words

### Daily Life

食べ物 (food) / 飲み物 (drink) / 朝ごはん (breakfast) / 昼ごはん (lunch) / 晩ごはん (dinner) / 水 (water) / お茶 (tea) / ジュース (juice) / ご飯 (rice/meal) / パン (bread) / 魚 (fish) / 肉 (meat) / 野菜 (vegetables) / 卵 (egg)

### People

人 (person) / 友達 (friend) / 先生 (teacher) / 学生 (student) / 会社員 (company worker) / 家族 (family) / 父 (father/my) / 母 (mother/my) / 兄 (older brother) / 姉 (older sister)

### Places

家 (home) / 学校 (school) / 会社 (company) / 駅 (station) / 銀行 (bank) / コンビニ (convenience store) / レストラン (restaurant) / 病院 (hospital) / 図書館 (library)

### Time Words

今日 (today) / 明日 (tomorrow) / 昨日 (yesterday) / 今週 (this week) / 今月 (this month) / 今年 (this year) / 朝 (morning) / 昼 (noon) / 夜 (night)

## Adjectives (most useful)

大きい/小さい (big/small) / 高い/安い (expensive/cheap) / 新しい/古い (new/old) / 良い/悪い (good/bad) / 多い/少ない (many/few) / 難しい/易しい (difficult/easy) / 楽しい (fun) / きれい (pretty/clean) / 暑い/寒い (hot/cold weather)

## Verbs

行く (go) / 来る (come) / 帰る (return home) / 食べる (eat) / 飲む (drink) / 見る (see) / 聞く (listen/ask) / 話す (speak) / 読む (read) / 書く (write) / 買う (buy) / 使う (use) / 起きる (wake up) / 寝る (sleep) / 待つ (wait) / 分かる (understand) / ある/いる (exist) / する (do) / 入る (enter) / 出る (exit)

## N5 Practice Questions (Sample)

### Vocabulary:

田中さんは まいにち がっこうに ( )。 a. いきます b. きます c. かえります d. おきます Answer: a (goes to school every day)

### Grammar:

これは だれ ( ) かばんですか。 a. が b. の c. を d. に Answer: b (whose bag is this?)

### Reading (short sentence):

「私の名前は田中です。毎朝、7時に起きます。朝ごはんはパンを食べます。」 Question: 田中さんは何時に起きますか? Answer: 7時 (7 o'clock)

## 6-Week N5 Study Plan

| Week | Focus                                        | Daily Activity                       |
|------|----------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| 1    | Hiragana + Katakana                          | 30 min kana drill + writing          |
| 2    | Core vocabulary (200 words) + Numbers        | Anki 20 new cards/day                |
| 3    | Grammar 1: です/ます, particles, basic sentences | Genki Chapter 1–4                    |
| 4    | Grammar 2: Verbs, adjectives, questions      | Genki Chapter 5–8                    |
| 5    | Kanji 100 + vocabulary review                | WaniKani levels 1–3, Anki review     |
| 6    | Practice tests + weak areas                  | 2 full practice tests, review errors |

Daily minimum: 45 minutes Optimal: 1.5 hours

## Recommended Resources

| Resource                       | What                          |
|--------------------------------|-------------------------------|
| Genki I (Chapters 1–12)        | Primary grammar textbook      |
| Anki + N5 deck                 | Vocabulary SRS                |
| Tae Kim's Grammar Guide (free) | Alternative grammar reference |
| JLPT Sensei N5 section         | Free practice questions       |



| Resource          | What                                   |
|-------------------|----------------------------------------|
| 日本語総まとめN5         | Focused test prep book                 |
| 公式問題集N5           | Official practice test                 |
| Duolingo Japanese | Supplementary (limited but accessible) |

## After N5: What's Next?

N5 gives you:

- The ability to understand basic Japanese in everyday situations
- ~800 words — enough for survival conversation
- ~100 kanji — enough to read children's texts with furigana

You can now:

- Start reading beginner manga (よつぱと！) with a dictionary
- Watch Doraemon and catch many sentences
- Navigate Japan with confidence
- Start basic Japanese conversations

Aim for N4 next. With the N5 foundation, N4 study time is typically 3–4 months at the same intensity.

Next level: N4 →

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## JLPT N4 — Building Confidence

"N4 is where Japanese starts to feel real. You can hold a conversation. You can watch simple anime and follow along. You can read children's manga. You're not just studying — you're communicating."

N4 represents elementary proficiency — the ability to understand basic Japanese in familiar everyday situations. It's the second rung, and a significant step up from N5.

### What N4 Covers

| Area       | Target                                         |
|------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Vocabulary | ~1,500 words                                   |
| Kanji      | ~300 characters                                |
| Grammar    | ~150 patterns                                  |
| Reading    | Simple notices, short articles, everyday texts |
| Listening  | Short conversations at near-natural speed      |

### New Grammar at N4 Level

N4 introduces several important grammar patterns not covered at N5:

## Conditional Forms

| Pattern | Meaning                         | Example       |
|---------|---------------------------------|---------------|
| ～たら     | If/when ~ (past conditional)    | 着いたら連絡してね。    |
| ～ば      | If ~ (hypothetical)             | 行けばよかった。      |
| ～と      | When/if ~ (natural consequence) | 右に曲がると駅があります。 |
| ～なら     | If ~ (given that)               | 行くななら早く言って。   |

## て-form Extensions

| Pattern       | Meaning               | Example   |
|---------------|-----------------------|-----------|
| ～てから          | After doing ~         | 食べてから行く。  |
| ～ても           | Even if ~             | 雨が降っても行く。 |
| ～てみる          | Try doing ~           | 食べてみる。    |
| ～ておく          | Do in advance         | 予約しておく。   |
| ～てしまう         | End up doing (regret) | 食べてしまった。  |
| ～てあげる/くれる/もらう | Give/receive favor    | 教えてあげる。   |

## Verb Forms

| Pattern   | Meaning                       | Example       |
|-----------|-------------------------------|---------------|
| ～ことができる   | Can / able to                 | 泳ぐことができます。    |
| ～ことがある    | Have had the experience of    | 日本に行ったことがある。  |
| ～ようになる    | Come to be (change over time) | 話せるようになった。    |
| ～ようにする    | Try to / make it so that      | 早く寝るようにしている。  |
| ～なければならない | Must do / have to             | 宿題をしなければならない。 |
| ～はずだ      | Should be / expected to be    | 来るはずです。       |
| ～つもりだ     | Intend to                     | 行くつもりです。      |
| ～そうだ      | Looks like / seems            | 雨が降りそうだ。      |

## Noun Modification

| Pattern         | Meaning                   | Example      |
|-----------------|---------------------------|--------------|
| Plain verb + 前に | Before doing              | 食べる前に手を洗う。   |
| た form + あとで    | After doing               | 食べたあとで、歯を磨く。 |
| ～ので             | Because (reason, polite)  | 忙しいので行けません。  |
| ～のに             | Despite / even though     | 頑張ったのに失敗した。  |
| ～だけ             | Only / just               | これだけでいい。     |
| ～しか～ない          | Only (exclusive/limiting) | 100円しかない。    |

## N4 Vocabulary: 200 Key Words (Beyond N5)

### Time and Frequency

いつも (always) / たいてい (usually) / よく (often) / ときどき (sometimes) / あまり～ない (not often) / 全然～ない (not at all) / もう (already) / まだ (still/not yet) / もうすぐ (soon) / もうちょっと (a little more) / すぐ (immediately)

## Emotions and States

嬉しい (happy) / 悲しい (sad) / 怖い (scary) / 恥ずかしい (embarrassed) / びっくりする (be surprised) / 心配する (worry) / 疲れる (get tired) / 元気 (healthy/energetic) / 大丈夫 (fine/okay) / 残念 (unfortunate/disappointing)

## Actions and Verbs

説明する (explain) / 紹介する (introduce) / 確認する (confirm) / 準備する (prepare) / 決める (decide) / 続ける (continue) / 終わる/終える (end) / 始まる/始める (begin) / 選ぶ (choose) / 渡す (pass/hand over) / 受け取る (receive) / 送る (send) / 調べる (research/look up) / 比べる (compare) / 変える (change something)

## Adjectives (new at N4)

親切 (kind/na-adj) / 丁寧 (polite/careful) / 便利 (convenient) / 不便 (inconvenient) / 大切 / 大事 (important) / 有名 (famous) / 必要 (necessary) / 特別 (special) / 複雑 (complex) / 簡単 (simple/easy) / 正しい (correct) / 間違い (mistake)

## Abstract Nouns

理由 (reason) / 目的 (purpose) / 方法 (method) / 機会 (opportunity) / 経験 (experience) / 関係 (relationship/connection) / 意味 (meaning) / 例 (example) / 気持ち (feeling) / 様子 (state/situation)

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## N4 Kanji — Additional 200

The N4 adds ~200 kanji to the N5 base:

Body and Health: 体 顔 頭 心 足 手 指 声 病 医 薬 元

Actions: 会 使 教 知 持 働 泳 走 歩 遊 作 切 洗 着

Time and Society: 午 夜 週 間 期 代 昔 今 最 次 後 先

Nature and Environment: 地 風 空 星 雲 雪 冬 春 夏 秋 野 森 林 葉

Buildings and Places: 室 部 面 所 場 院 館 堂 台 庭

Descriptors: 重 軽 強 弱 深 浅 広 狭 明 暗 早 遅

People and Social: 友 親 仲 様 者 方 位 番 号 度 回

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## Reading at N4 Level

At N4, you should be able to read:

- Short notices and announcements
- Simple letters and emails
- Basic explanations and instructions
- Short news articles (NHK Web Easy)
- Children's manga with furigana (よつばと！ Vol. 1)

Key reading skills for N4:

- Identifying the main topic of a short passage
- Understanding the gist of a 150–300 character text
- Answering simple comprehension questions

## Sample N4 Reading Passage

田中さんは週に三回、スポーツジムに行っています。最近、太ってしまったので、ダイエットを始めることにしました。

Questions:

- 田中さんは週に何回ジムに行きますか？ (3回)
  - なぜダイエットを始めましたか？ (太ってしまったから)
  - 来年の目標は何ですか？ (マラソン大会に出ること)
- 

## Listening at N4 Level

At N4, you should understand:

- Slow, clear conversation about daily topics
- Simple instructions and directions
- Basic announcements
- Short dialogues between two people

Key listening skills:

- Understanding the topic and key information
  - Catching numbers, times, and quantities
  - Following a simple narrative
- 

## 8-Week N4 Study Plan

| Week | Focus                                                 |
|------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| 1–2  | N4 grammar patterns (Genki II Ch. 13–18)              |
| 3    | N4 vocabulary set 1 (500 new words via Anki)          |
| 4    | N4 kanji (Anki + writing practice)                    |
| 5    | N4 vocabulary set 2 + reading practice (NHK Web Easy) |
| 6    | Listening practice (JLPT listening tracks, anime)     |
| 7    | Grammar review + practice test 1                      |
| 8    | Full practice test 2 + targeted review                |

---

## After N4: What's Changed?

With N4 you can:

- Hold simple conversations about familiar topics
- Read most menus and basic signs without a dictionary
- Watch simple anime and understand the main plot
- Write basic emails and texts in Japanese
- Navigate Japan independently with confidence

N4 is often described as "survival Japanese" — you can function in Japan, though complex situations remain challenging.

Next level: N3 →

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## JLPT N3 — The Great Leap

"N3 is the hardest single step in the JLPT journey. Below N3, everything is foundational. Above N3, you're building fluency. N3 is the bridge — and it's a long one."

N3 sits between beginner and intermediate. It represents the ability to understand everyday Japanese in a variety of contexts — not just simple daily situations but also media, nuanced conversation, and moderately complex written text. This is the level where Japanese starts to feel like a usable skill.

### What N3 Covers

| Area       | Target                                           |
|------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| Vocabulary | ~3,750 words                                     |
| Kanji      | ~650 characters                                  |
| Grammar    | ~200+ patterns                                   |
| Reading    | Articles, letters, explanations, simple opinions |
| Listening  | Natural-speed conversation, variety of topics    |

N3 has the largest vocabulary jump of any level transition — from ~1,500 (N4) to ~3,750. This is where systematic vocabulary study becomes non-negotiable.

### Key Grammar at N3

#### Expressing Reason and Cause

| Pattern | Meaning                         | Example             |
|---------|---------------------------------|---------------------|
| ～ために    | For the purpose of / because of | 試験のために勉強する。         |
| ～せいで    | Because of (negative cause)     | 雨のせいで遅れた。           |
| ～おかげで   | Thanks to (positive cause)      | 君のおかげで合格した。         |
| ～によって   | Depending on / due to           | 人によって違う。            |
| ～わけだ    | That's why / naturally          | 疲れているわけだ。           |
| ～からといって | Just because ~ (doesn't mean)   | 金持ちだからといって幸せとは限らない。 |

#### Expressing Change

| Pattern | Meaning                    | Example    |
|---------|----------------------------|------------|
| ～ていく    | Continuing into the future | 変わっていく。    |
| ～てくる    | Coming to pass / emerging  | 分かってきた。    |
| ～ようになる  | Come to be able to         | 泳げるようになった。 |
| ～なくなる   | Stop doing / cease         | 痛くなくなった。   |
| ～に変わる   | Change to ~                | 晴れに変わる。    |

#### Limiting and Restricting

| Pattern  | Meaning                               | Example         |
|----------|---------------------------------------|-----------------|
| ～だけでなく～も | Not only ~ but also                   | 英語だけでなく日本語も話せる。 |
| ～ばかり     | Nothing but / just ~                  | 遊んでばかりいる。       |
| ～さえ～ば    | If only ~                             | 時間さえあれば行ける。     |
| ～くらい/ぐらい | About / approximately / to the extent | 3日くらいかかる。       |
| ～について    | About / concerning                    | 日本語について話す。      |

### Expressing Condition and State

| Pattern | Meaning                           | Example    |
|---------|-----------------------------------|------------|
| ～はずがない  | Can't possibly be                 | そんなはずがない。  |
| ～にちがいない | Must certainly be                 | 彼に違いない。    |
| ～らしい    | Apparently / seems like (hearsay) | 雨が降るらしい。   |
| ～ようだ    | Seems like (observation)          | 疲れているようだ。  |
| ～みたいだ   | Looks like (casual らしい)           | 知っているみたいだ。 |
| ～かもしれない | Might be / perhaps                | 来るかもしれない。  |
| ～と思われる  | It is thought that                | 原因と思われる。   |

### Advanced て-form Uses

| Pattern  | Meaning                               |
|----------|---------------------------------------|
| ～てはじめて   | Only after doing ~ do you realize/can |
| ～てしょうがない | Can't help but ~ / extremely          |
| ～てたまらない  | Unbearably ~ / can't stand            |
| ～てならない   | Can't help but ~                      |
| ～ていられない  | Can't afford to keep doing ~          |

## N3 Vocabulary Strategy

At N3, you're memorizing ~2,000 new words beyond N4. This requires:

1. Daily Anki reviews: 20 new cards/day, 20 min review minimum
2. Reading real Japanese: Vocabulary encountered in context sticks far better
3. Word families: Learn 悲しい (sad) → 悲しむ (feel sad) → 悲しみ (sadness) together
4. Compound recognition: ○○的 (systematic-ally), ○○化 (-ization), ○○者 (-person) patterns

### Key Vocabulary Categories for N3

Abstract and Academic: 理解 (understanding) / 判断 (judgment) / 影響 (influence) / 状況 (situation) / 原因 (cause) / 結果 (result) / 可能性 (possibility) / 必要性 (necessity) / 効果 (effect)

Emotions and Psychology: 感動 (being moved emotionally) / 不安 (anxiety) / 安心 (relief) / 失望 (disappointment) / 期待 (expectation) / 後悔 (regret) / 満足 (satisfaction) / 我慢 (endurance/putting up with)

Society and Relationships: 社会 (society) / 文化 (culture) / 伝統 (tradition) / 習慣 (custom/habit) / 礼儀 (manners) / 差別 (discrimination) / 平等 (equality) / 協力 (cooperation) / 競争 (competition)

## N3 Kanji — Additional ~350

At N3, you add approximately 350 kanji to your N4 base. Themes include:

Body and Health: 頭 腹 腰 肩 骨 血 薬 治 痛 苦

Economy and Business: 給 払 貯 費 税 価 値 産 業 商

Society: 法 律 政 選 議 府 都 庁 県 市

Communication: 連 絡 報 告 相 談 知 伝 説 記

Nature and Science: 気 温 湿 乾 電 化 物 質 量 力

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## Reading at N3

N3 reading passages are significantly more complex than N4:

- 300–600 character passages (up from ~150–300)
- Multiple paragraphs with a clear argument or narrative
- Inference questions (not directly stated in the text)
- Understanding the writer's opinion or intent

Sample N3 Reading Passage Topic: Passages about: health habits, travel experiences, technology changes, social customs, advice columns, short opinion pieces.

Reading Strategy for N3:

1. Read the questions FIRST — know what to look for
  2. Skim the passage for the main idea
  3. Read carefully for sections relevant to the questions
  4. For inference questions, look for language like: ーといえる、ーと考えられる、ーようだ
- 

## Listening at N3

Natural-speed conversation about daily and social topics. You'll hear:

- Two people discussing plans or making decisions
- Short announcements and instructions
- Questions about a story you've heard
- Conversations where you must infer intent or feeling

Listening strategy:

- Note the setting first (where? who?)
  - Listen for the main point, not every word
  - Recognize key vocabulary even in fast speech
  - Practice with anime, NHK Web Easy audio, and JLPT practice materials
- 

## 12-Week N3 Study Plan

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| Weeks | Focus                                 |
|-------|---------------------------------------|
| 1–3   | Vocabulary (Anki, So-matome N3 vocab) |
| 4–5   | Grammar (新完全マスター N3 文法)               |

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| Weeks | Focus                                                  |
|-------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| 6–7   | Kanji (新完全マスター N3 漢字, 20/day)                          |
| 8     | Reading practice (NHK Web Easy → regular NHK articles) |
| 9     | Listening practice (JLPT audio, anime, NHK)            |
| 10    | Full practice test 1 + weakness analysis               |
| 11    | Targeted review of weak sections                       |
| 12    | Full practice test 2 + final review                    |

## Real-World Ability at N3

With N3 you can:

- Have conversations about most daily topics
- Read NHK Web Easy comfortably
- Watch slice-of-life anime and understand most of it
- Read manga aimed at older teens (some without furigana)
- Write clear emails and messages
- Understand news broadcasts partially (with effort)
- Travel Japan independently, including reading signs and asking for help

Famous N3 challenge: N3 grammar appears in Tobira (the main intermediate textbook). Many learners describe Tobira as the hardest textbook in their journey — not because N3 is hardest, but because it's the transition from structured beginner learning to open-ended intermediate.

Next level: N2 →

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## JLPT N2 — Near Fluent

"N2 is where Japanese becomes useful in the real world. It's required for many university programs in Japan, preferred or required for many professional positions, and the level where you can watch the news and mostly understand it."

N2 represents upper-intermediate proficiency. You can understand Japanese used in a wide variety of situations — not just everyday casual contexts, but also moderately complex media, professional situations, and extended written texts. This is a genuinely significant milestone.

### What N2 Covers

| Area       | Target                                                     |
|------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Vocabulary | ~6,000 words                                               |
| Kanji      | ~1,000 characters                                          |
| Grammar    | ~200+ patterns (more complex)                              |
| Reading    | Newspaper articles, formal letters, complex explanations   |
| Listening  | Near-natural speed, news broadcasts, complex conversations |

The vocabulary jump from N3 (~3,750) to N2 (~6,000) is large — over 2,000 new words, many of them abstract, technical, or classical in origin.



## N2 Grammar — Selected Key Patterns

### Formal Written Expressions

| Pattern     | Meaning                       | Example        |
|-------------|-------------------------------|----------------|
| ～において/～における | At / in (formal location)     | 会議において決定された。   |
| ～に関して/～に関する | Regarding / concerning        | この問題に関して意見がある。 |
| ～に対して/～に対する | Toward / against              | 批判に対して反論した。    |
| ～を通じて/～を通して | Through / via                 | 交渉を通じて解決した。    |
| ～として        | As / in the role of           | 代表として参加する。     |
| ～にわたって      | Over a period of / throughout | 3年にわたって研究した。   |
| ～をはじめ(として)  | Starting with / including     | 東京をはじめ各地で。     |
| ～に伴って       | Along with / as ~ happens     | 高齢化に伴って問題が増える。 |

### Expressing Degree and Limit

| Pattern  | Meaning                         | Example       |
|----------|---------------------------------|---------------|
| ～にすぎない   | Nothing more than / merely      | 噂にすぎない。       |
| ～にほかならない | Is nothing other than           | これは詐欺にほかならない。 |
| ～に過ぎる    | Too ~                           | 難しすぎる。        |
| ～こそ      | Precisely / exactly (emphasis)  | 今こそチャンスだ。     |
| ～さえ      | Even / even if                  | 子供でさえ知っている。   |
| ～ほど～ない   | Not as ~ as                     | 思ったほど難しくない。   |
| ～に至っては   | When it comes to (extreme case) | 彼に至っては全く知らない。 |

### Expressing Stance and Opinion

| Pattern   | Meaning                            | Example      |
|-----------|------------------------------------|--------------|
| ～に違いない    | Must be (strong certainty)         | 彼が犯人に違いない。   |
| ～はずがない    | Cannot possibly be                 | そんなはずがない。    |
| ～わけがない    | There's no reason that ~           | できるわけがない。    |
| ～わけにはいかない | Can't afford to / must not         | 諦めるわけにはいかない。 |
| ～ものだ      | Naturally is / used to (nostalgic) | 昔はよく遊んだものだ。  |
| ～ものではない   | Is not something that should be    | 嘘をつくものではない。  |

### Concessive and Adversative

| Pattern  | Meaning                    | Example         |
|----------|----------------------------|-----------------|
| ～ものの     | Although / even though     | 行ったものの何もできなかった。 |
| ～にもかかわらず | Despite / regardless of    | 反対にもかかわらず実行した。  |
| ～とはいえ    | Even so / having said that | 忙しいとはいえ連絡できる。   |
| ～ながら(も)  | While ~ / even though      | 知りながら黙っていた。     |
| ～からには    | Since / now that           | 決めたからには頑張る。     |

## N2 Vocabulary: Key Domains

### News and Current Affairs

報道 (coverage/reporting) / 政策 (policy) / 経済 (economy) / 予算 (budget) / 外交 (diplomacy) / 条約 (treaty) / 制裁 (sanctions) / 議会 (parliament) / 改革 (reform) / 批判 (criticism) / 支持 (support) / 反対 (opposition)

### Academic and Abstract

論理 (logic) / 証明 (proof) / 仮説 (hypothesis) / 根拠 (basis/grounds) / 矛盾 (contradiction) / 概念 (concept) / 傾向 (tendency) / 観点 (perspective) / 前提 (premise) / 結論 (conclusion) / 比較 (comparison) / 検討 (examination)

### Formal Written Japanese

以上 (above / the above) / 以下 (below / the following) / 一方 (on the other hand) / また (also / in addition) / なお (furthermore) / ただし (however / provided that) / これに対し (in contrast to this) / したがって (therefore) / よって (thus)

### Classical and Literary

〜しかるべき (as appropriate) / 〜にかんする (concerning) / 〜たる (being ~, formal) / 〜べき (should / ought to) / 〜べからず (must not, classical) / 〜にして (while being)

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## N2 Kanji — The Second 700

At N2, you should know approximately 1,000 kanji in total. The additional ~350 from N3 level gives you access to:

News/Politics: 政 法 選 議 府 庁 省 裁 判 罪 刑 律

Science and Technology: 科 技 術 研 究 実 験 証 測 量 機 器

Economics: 経 済 税 率 株 投 資 産 負 債 利 益

Formal Writing: 論 述 析 察 観 点 念 理 義 則 規 制

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## Reading at N2

N2 reading tests your ability to:

- Understand newspaper and magazine articles
- Follow editorial opinions and arguments
- Read formal notices, official letters
- Understand long-form explanations (600–1,000 characters)
- Identify implicit meaning and writer's intent

Reading strategies for N2:

1. Build speed — N2 passages are longer, time is tight
  2. Practice identifying paragraph structure (main claim → support → conclusion)
  3. Study how Japanese writers signal concession (〜ものの, 〜とはいえ)
  4. Practice with real newspaper editorials (朝日新聞 社説)
-

## Listening at N2

N2 listening includes:

- News-style announcements at near-broadcast speed
- Complex conversations between multiple speakers
- Lectures and extended monologues
- Passages where you must infer the speaker's attitude or intent

Key skill: Not just comprehension, but inference. "What does this person actually think?" when they're being polite about disagreeing.

---

## 16-Week N2 Study Plan

| Phase          | Weeks | Focus                                          |
|----------------|-------|------------------------------------------------|
| Vocabulary     | 1–4   | 2,000+ new words (Anki + So-matome N2)         |
| Grammar        | 5–8   | 新完全マスター N2 文法 (all patterns)                   |
| Kanji          | 9–10  | ~350 new kanji + compounds                     |
| Reading        | 11–12 | Newspaper articles, NHK, practice passages     |
| Listening      | 13–14 | NHK radio, JLPT audio, drama without subtitles |
| Practice Tests | 15–16 | 3+ full practice tests, targeted review        |

Daily commitment: 2+ hours. N2 is not part-time — treat it like a course.

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## What N2 Opens

Career:

- Many Japanese companies list N2 as a hiring requirement for non-Japanese applicants
- Graduate school applications in Japan often require N2
- Professional visa applications may accept N2

Real-world ability:

- Read most newspaper articles with a dictionary
- Watch news broadcasts and understand ~80%
- Read most manga without furigana
- Participate in most workplace conversations
- Write professional emails and reports

Immersion: At N2 level, you can consume most Japanese media without subtitles and extract enough meaning to enjoy it. This is the point where immersion truly accelerates.

Next level: N1 →

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## JLPT N1 — The Summit

"N1 is not the end of Japanese learning — it's the point where you finally have enough tools to learn everything else from the language itself. Most N1 holders will tell you they learned more Japanese after N1 than before."

N1 represents advanced proficiency — the ability to understand Japanese at the level needed for most professional, academic, and social contexts. Only a fraction of non-native learners reach N1. Those who do can genuinely participate in Japanese society at a sophisticated level.

## What N1 Covers

| Area       | Target                                                        |
|------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|
| Vocabulary | ~10,000+ words                                                |
| Kanji      | ~2,000 characters (full Jōyō list + beyond)                   |
| Grammar    | Complex, classical-influenced, nuanced patterns               |
| Reading    | Essays, editorials, literary texts, legal/technical documents |
| Listening  | Full-speed natural speech, complex discussion, subtle nuance  |

The vocabulary at N1 includes:

- Classical Japanese vocabulary surviving in formal writing
- Technical vocabulary across multiple domains
- Literary and archaic expressions
- Subtle distinctions between near-synonyms

## N1 Grammar — Advanced Patterns

N1 grammar is dense with formal, written, and classical-influenced patterns:

### Classical and Literary Forms

| Pattern    | Meaning                                  | Example       |
|------------|------------------------------------------|---------------|
| 〜ごとし/ごとく   | Like ~ / as if ~ (classical)             | 嵐のごとく突撃した。    |
| 〜べく        | In order to / should (classical て-form)  | 解決すべく努力する。    |
| 〜たる        | Being ~ / as (formal attributive copula) | 国家たる責任がある。    |
| 〜しかるべき     | As appropriate / proper                  | しかるべき対応をとる。   |
| 〜にして       | While being / as well as                 | 天才にして努力家でもある。 |
| 〜いかん       | Depending on / according to              | 結果いかんでは再考する。  |
| 〜といわず〜といわず | Not just ~ but also ~                    | 昼といわず夜といわず働く。 |

### Expressing Conditions and Nuance

| Pattern   | Meaning                           | Example           |
|-----------|-----------------------------------|-------------------|
| 〜をよそに     | Heedless of / indifferent to      | 周囲の心配をよそに出発した。    |
| 〜もさることながら | Not only ~ but also               | 技術もさることながら経験も必要だ。 |
| 〜に至るまで    | To the extent of / up to          | 細部に至るまで確認した。      |
| 〜ならではの    | Unique to / only possible with    | 京都ならではの景色。        |
| 〜にたえる     | Worthy of / can bear/endure       | 読むにたえる文章。         |
| 〜に即して     | In accordance with / in line with | 実態に即して考える。        |
| 〜をもって     | By means of / with                | 実力をもって示した。        |

## Concession and Contrast (Advanced)

| Pattern   | Meaning                            | Example       |
|-----------|------------------------------------|---------------|
| ～ではあるまいか  | Might it not be that / I wonder if | 誤りではあるまいか。    |
| ～ずにはいられない | Can't help but do                  | 笑わずにはいられない。   |
| ～を余儀なくされる | Be forced to / have no choice but  | 中止を余儀なくされた。   |
| ～ならいざしらず  | I don't know about ~ but...        | 昔ならいざしらず今は違う。 |
| ～はさておき    | Setting ~ aside                    | 冗談はさておき。      |

## N1 Vocabulary: What's Different

At N1, vocabulary is less about quantity and more about nuance:

### Near-Synonyms That Must Be Distinguished

Japanese has many near-synonyms with subtle usage differences:

| Pair              | Distinction                                               |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| 見る / 見える / 目にする   | Active looking / passive seeing / happen to see           |
| 思う / 考える / 信じる    | Casual opinion / deliberate reasoning / believe firmly    |
| 言う / 述べる / 語る     | Say casually / state formally / narrate/tell              |
| 変わる / 変化する / 変容する | Change (general) / change (scientific/formal) / transform |
| 行う / 実施する / 遂行する  | Carry out (general) / implement / execute/accomplish      |
| 始まる / 開始する / 着手する | Begin (general) / begin (formal) / start work on          |

## Classical and Literary Vocabulary

| Japanese | Reading    | Meaning                          |
|----------|------------|----------------------------------|
| 由来       | yurai      | Origin / derivation              |
| 趣        | omomuki    | Taste / atmosphere / gist        |
| 様相       | yōsō       | Aspect / appearance              |
| 所以       | yuen       | Reason / cause (literary)        |
| 齟齬       | sogo       | Discord / mismatch               |
| 辻褄       | tsujitsuma | Consistency (辻褄が合う = consistent) |
| 見識       | kenshiki   | Discernment / insight            |
| 蔑ろ       | naigashiro | Disregard / neglect              |
| 弊害       | heigai     | Harmful effects / evil           |
| 妥当       | datō       | Appropriate / valid              |

## 四字熟語 (Yojijukugo) at N1

N1 tests yojijukugo (four-character idioms) in depth:

| Idiom             | Meaning                                 |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| 五里霧中 (gorimitchū) | Completely at a loss / in thick fog     |
| 孤軍奮闘 (kogunfuntō) | Fighting alone / single-handed struggle |

| Idiom                  | Meaning                                                 |
|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| 試行錯誤 (shikōsakugo)     | Trial and error                                         |
| 前途多難 (zentotanan)      | Many difficulties ahead                                 |
| 一石二鳥 (isseki nichō)    | Kill two birds with one stone                           |
| 針小棒大 (shinshōbōdai)    | Making a mountain out of a molehill                     |
| 朝令暮改 (chōreib ōkai)    | Policy that changes morning and evening — inconsistency |
| 玉石混淆 (gyokuseki konko) | Good mixed with bad                                     |
| 本末顛倒 (honmattentō)     | Putting the cart before the horse                       |
| 換骨奪胎 (kankondattai)    | Imitation that replaces the original's spirit           |

## N1 Reading

N1 reading includes:

- Editorial columns and opinion essays (800–1,000 characters)
- Literary excerpts with classical language features
- Technical articles from specific fields
- Multiple connected passages (comparing different texts on the same topic)
- Inference and critical reading questions

What makes N1 reading hard:

1. Speed: passages are long, time is short
2. Subtlety: answer choices are close; you must find the precise best answer
3. Classical grammar: some passages use pre-modern language features
4. Inference: the correct answer is often not directly stated

N1 Reading Strategy:

- Read widely in Japanese literature and editorials from months before the exam
- Practice reading at 500+ characters per minute
- Study classical grammar features (〜べし, 〜ず, 〜ごとし) separately
- For comparison passages (comparing two or more texts), map out author positions before answering

## N1 Listening

N1 listening tests:

- Extended monologues (lectures, talks, explanations)
- Nuanced conversation where speaker intent must be inferred
- Multiple-choice questions requiring comparison of multiple statements
- Integrated understanding (combine information from different parts of audio)

The difficulty: speakers at N1 level speak naturally, with all the contractions, hedging, and implied meaning of real Japanese conversation. You must understand both what is said and what is meant.

## Study Plan for N1

N1 preparation is typically 6–12 months from N2 level, depending on your reading and listening habits.

#### Phase 1 (Months 1–3): Build the vocabulary base

- Learn remaining kanji to full Jōyō + 200 extras
- 新完全マスター N1 語彙 (vocabulary)
- Anki mining from reading

#### Phase 2 (Months 3–5): Grammar and expression

- 新完全マスター N1 文法
- 新完全マスター N1 表現 (expressions — yojijukugo, idioms)
- Classical Japanese grammar basics (classical verb forms)

#### Phase 3 (Months 5–8): Immersion-intensive reading

- Read 1–2 newspaper articles daily (朝日新聞、読売新聞、毎日新聞 社説)
- Read short stories and literary prose
- Read technical articles in your field
- Mine vocabulary from everything

#### Phase 4 (Months 8–10): Listening intensive

- NHK news radio
- Japanese political discussion programs
- Drama without subtitles (complex plots, varied register)
- JLPT N1 practice listening tracks

#### Phase 5 (Months 10–12): Test preparation

- 3+ full official-level practice tests
  - Detailed error analysis
  - Targeted vocabulary and grammar review
  - Timed reading practice
- 

### The N1 Mindset

N1 isn't won in the last few months of cramming. It's built over years:

Years 1–2: N5 → N3 foundation Years 2–3: N3 → N2 breadth Years 3–5: N2 → N1 depth

Successful N1 candidates almost universally describe the same key habit: reading and listening to Japanese every single day, not just studying it. The vocabulary and nuance required at N1 is too large to memorize — it must be absorbed through sustained exposure.

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### After N1: What Comes Next?

N1 holders often describe the same experience: Japanese becomes a tool, not a subject. You stop thinking about Japanese and start thinking in it, with it, through it.

What N1 opens:

- Most Japanese university and graduate school admissions
- Professional positions requiring Japanese literacy
- Legal, medical, and academic translation work

- Full enjoyment of Japanese literature, film, and media without subtitles or aids
- The ability to continue learning Japanese entirely from Japanese

What remains after N1:

- 地方語 (dialect) — You still may struggle in Osaka or Tohoku
- 文語 (classical Japanese) — University-level study is a separate discipline
- 専門語 (technical vocabulary) — Law, medicine, engineering each have their own deep vocabulary
- 生きた日本語 (living Japanese) — Slang, generational expression, internet language — these never stop evolving

N1 is not the end. It is the beginning of reading the room.

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「千里の道も一歩から。」 (Senri no michi mo ippo kara.) Even a journey of a thousand miles begins with a single step.

You started with hiragana. This is where that step leads.

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